

The background is a dark, textured collage. It features several large, vibrant purple flowers with delicate petals. Interspersed among the flowers are translucent, segmented worm-like creatures, possibly hydras, which have a white, ribbed appearance. A magnifying glass with a silver rim is positioned in the lower center, its lens reflecting the surrounding elements. The overall aesthetic is mysterious and scientific.

VOWS
AND
VENOM

N. SLATER

Vows and Venom

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Thank You!

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Author's Note

Thank you so much for taking a chance on Elliot and Malakai's story. This is an MM medium-burn dark romance with high heat scenes, focusing primarily on themes of control, submission, and the complexities of forbidden love.

This book can be read as a complete standalone and is part of the ***Forbidden*** series, a collection of taboo romances united by theme rather than characters.

Please protect your mental health. While not all of the following themes are present at the same intensity, they do appear throughout this novel.

Reader discretion is advised.

Content warnings: Incest/twincest, past domestic abuse, past abusive relationship, possessive/controlling behavior, power exchange/BDSM dynamics, dub-con elements, emotional manipulation,

degradation/humiliation, praise kink, orgasm denial/edging, cock cages/chastity, plugs, public/semi-public sexual situations, marking/bruising, subspace, jealousy-driven violence, on-page violence, parental neglect/emotional abuse, disordered eating, anxiety/trauma responses, low self-worth/self-esteem issues, emotional breakdown/crying during scenes, references to past physical assault, victim-blaming, codependency, isolation from outside relationships.

If any of these themes are harmful to your wellbeing, please take care of yourself first. There will always be other books.

For those who choose to stay, thank you for trusting me with this story. I hope you find something meaningful in these pages.

~

When you finish, please consider rating the book with stars or leaving a review. As an indie author, every review helps to get my books in front of the readers who love them, and I appreciate you taking the time to give me feedback!

If you'd like to keep up with new releases, personal updates, and exclusive content, you can sign up for my weekly newsletter/blog!

Newsletter ~ Welcome to the Madness

All my love,

N. Slater

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Elliot

The Ashford estate rises from the October mist like a ghost of better times. I watch it materialize through the rain-streaked window of my Uber, my fingers digging into the worn fabric of my hoodie sleeves. *God, I fucking hate this place.*

Three stories of pale Georgian stone, windows dark except for the warm glow of the entrance hall stare back at me. The grounds stretch endlessly on either side of the winding drive, manicured lawns giving way to ancient oaks that have witnessed generations of Ashford secrets.

Home. The word sits heavy in my chest, more burden than comfort. Most people dream of wanting to visit or live in a place like this but for me, it's just a reminder of the love and attention I grew up without. I even share the same face as my twin and yet, *I'm* the problem because I chose to stand on my two feet.

Well, I tried and now, I'm back.

"Hell of a place," the driver says, leaning forward to peer through the windshield. "You grow up here?"

"Something like that."

The car rolls to a stop at the foot of the wide stone steps. I fumble with my wallet, pulling out too many bills because my hands won't stop trembling, and I can't bear to sit here a moment longer or deal with the driver's curious eyes or the looming facade of everything I tried to escape.

"Keep it." I grab my single duffel bag and push open the door before he can respond.

The October air hits me like a slap. It's cold, damp, and carries the scent of wet leaves and woodsmoke from someone's bonfire, probably the neighbors just behind us. I pause on the gravel drive as the Uber pulls away, and for a long moment, I can't make myself move.

Six months. I made it six months before I came running back home with my tail between my legs. Apparently, having a lot of money doesn't do shit when you get tangled up with the wrong people.

The front door opens before I reach the steps, warm light spilling across the stone, Mrs. Callahan's familiar silhouette appearing in the gap. She's worked for the family since before my brother and I were born, bandaged our scraped knees, and snuck us cookies when our mother wasn't looking. She's more parent to us than Victoria has ever bothered to be.

"Elliot." She says my name like a prayer and a worry all at once, her weathered face creasing with concern. Her eyes sweep over me in a single glance, cataloging every detail like she always does.

I'm sure I look a mess, too. Six months ago, I left in a fitted, tailored suit worth most people's salaries but time and circumstance have destroyed my

self-confidence. Now, I find comfort in my loose sweaters and pants one size too big so that I can hide in the fabric. Sleep no longer comes easily, nightmares replaying in my head because of the very reason I returned home.

She just offers me a small smile but doesn't comment on my appearance or why I'm here. That's one of the things I've always loved about her.

"Mrs. Callahan." I manage something that might be a smile. "I wasn't sure anyone would be up."

"I've had your room ready for three days." She steps back to let me enter, and the heat of the house presses against my cold skin, a stark contrast to the emptiness these walls have always held. "Your mother called ahead."

Of course she did. Victoria Ashford might not bother to be present for her son's return, but she'd never miss an opportunity to manage appearances from a distance.

"Where are they?" I glance around the entrance, surprised that my mother's heels clicking against the wood isn't echoing through the place.

"Monaco. They send their regards." Mrs. Callahan's tone is carefully neutral, but I catch the slight tightening around her eyes. "Some charity event, I believe. They'll be back next week, perhaps."

Perhaps. Always perhaps with my parents. Perhaps they'll make my birthday. Perhaps they'll attend my graduation. Perhaps they'll notice I exist at all.

"And Malakai?"

The question slips out before I can stop it, and I hate myself for asking. I hate the way my pulse quickens and the way my body coils tight, caught between the urge to flee and the inability to move.

Mrs. Callahan's expression flickers with confusion before settling back to the neutral one she usually wears. "In the city for business. He should return early tomorrow morning."

Which means he'll show up around 1 or 2 am. *Fuck*. "Right." I hitch my duffel higher on my shoulder, ignoring the way the motion pulls at bruises hidden beneath layers of fabric. "I'll just head up, then. It was a long flight."

"I'll have something sent up. You look like you haven't eaten properly in months."

I probably haven't. Food became an afterthought somewhere along the way, one more thing that required energy I didn't have. "Thank you, Mrs. Callahan."

She reaches out as I pass, her hand hovering near my arm, as if she senses I might flinch from the contact. I used to run to her for hugs growing up and now I can't even imagine anything more than curling up in my bed and hiding beneath the covers, hoping that tomorrow will be better than today.

"It's good to have you home, Elliot. Truly."

I can't bring myself to agree as I climb the stairs, making my way to the room at the end of the hall. It's directly across from Malakai's but as I step inside, my childhood bedroom is exactly as I remember it and entirely wrong.

It's the same pale blue walls, the same heavy oak furniture, and the same view of the south gardens through tall windows now streaked with rain. My books still line the shelves in alphabetical order, my desk sitting beneath the window where I spent countless hours studying, trying to be good enough, smart enough, and present enough to earn a fraction of the attention my parents lavished on my brother.

But someone has been in here.

Standing in the doorway, my duffel bag slipping from numb fingers, I catalog each of the small violations. The book on my nightstand, the one I left open to mark my place, now lies closed with a leather bookmark tucked between its pages. My desk chair is angled differently, pushed in too neatly and the drawer of my nightstand isn't quite flush with its frame.

Malakai.

I don't need to see the evidence to know. My brother has always treated my boundaries as suggestions at best, obstacles to be dismissed at worst. Even six months and three thousand miles weren't enough distance to escape his reach.

A bitter laugh catches in my throat. Did I really think running would change anything? Malakai probably knew where I was every moment of every day. He probably tracked my phone, monitored my accounts, and kept tabs through channels I can't begin to imagine.

The thought should make me angry. It should spark some defiant flame in my chest.

Instead, I just feel tired.

I drop the duffel at the foot of the bed and make my way to the bathroom, peeling off layers as I go. The hoodie first, then the t-shirt beneath it, each movement calculated to minimize the pull of damaged tissue.

However, the mirror shows me what I can't truly hide.

I look like hell. My frame has crossed the line from slender to gaunt, my cheekbones sharpened beneath skin that hasn't seen proper sunlight in weeks. There's even dark circles around my eyes in purple-brown smudges that make me look haunted.

And then there are the bruises.

They map my torso like a constellation of violence. The oldest ones have faded to a sickly yellow-green, barely visible unless you know where to look, while the newer ones still carry hints of purple and blue. Fingerprints wrap around my upper arms, and a larger bloom spreads across my ribs where I was shoved into a doorframe.

I trace my fingers over the marks, pressing just hard enough to feel the dull ache beneath my skin. It's a reminder that it was real, that Marcus was real, even if some days the memories feel like nightmares I invented to explain why I can't breathe.

Why did you let it get so bad? I ask myself but I don't have an answer. I'm not even sure there is an explanation other than the fact that I was being stubborn. I should have left a long fucking time ago.

Blowing out a heavy breath, I switch on the shower, glad for real pressure from the showerhead for once. The water runs hot enough to turn my skin pink, steam filling the bathroom until the mirror fogs over. I stand under the spray until the water starts to cool, letting it wash away the grime of travel if not the memories beneath.

When I finally emerge, wrapped in the softest clothes I packed, the room is shrouded in darkness. A tray waits on my desk with something that smells like Mrs. Callahan's chicken soup, but my stomach turns at the thought of eating.

I climb into bed instead, pulling the covers up to my chin but sleep refuses to come no matter how tightly I close my eyes. I knew it wouldn't, but I hoped anyway. I hoped that being back in my childhood bed, surrounded by the ghosts of a simpler time, might somehow quiet the noise in my head. Instead, my thoughts chase just themselves in endless circles, spiraling through memories I'd rather forget.

Marcus's hands on my throat. The sound of my own voice begging. The slow, sickening realization that the man who claimed to love me wanted nothing more than to break me down into something small and manageable.

And beneath all of it, threaded through like poison in my bloodstream, sits the knowledge that some sick part of me liked it.

Not the violence, but the structure. The control. The way it felt to have someone else make all the decisions as I surrendered the exhausting weight of choice.

What does that say about me? What kind of person craves the cage even as they fight against the bars?

I flop onto my side, frustrated with myself, the clock on my nightstand reading 11:47 when the air in the room seems to change. I feel it before I hear anything, a shift in pressure like the moment before a storm breaks. The fine hairs on my arms stand at attention as my body recognizes danger before my mind catches up.

My whole body tenses up as I force my eyes closed and try not to breathe. Maybe if I stay perfectly still, if I pretend to be asleep, Malakai will leave and give me one more night of peace before everything becomes complicated again.

"I know you're awake, little brother."

The smooth voice comes from the doorway, rolling over my skin like a physical touch and raising goosebumps in its wake.

I didn't hear the door open or footsteps in the hall, but Malakai has always moved like a predator. He won't go away, though. Slowly, I open my eyes and tilt my gaze toward the door.

My brother stands framed just inside my room, looking just as imposing as he always does. Those broad shoulders of his are covered in a fitted

black shirt with the sleeves rolled up to expose the intricate tattoo sleeve that wraps his left forearm. His dark hair is slightly disheveled, like he's been running his hands through it, his jaw carrying the shadow of a day's growth.

No doubt Mom told him I was coming back. He's going to be mad I didn't say anything.

We have the same face, the same sharp cheekbones and strong jaw, the same gray-green eyes that can look silver in certain light. But where my features have softened into something almost delicate, Malakai's have hardened into edges sharp enough to cut. Where I make myself small and try to disappear, Malakai commands every room he enters simply by existing in it.

"You're back." Two words carry the weight of six months of silence.

"Malakai." I push myself up against the headboard, pulling the covers with me like they might offer some kind of protection. "I didn't think you'd be home until later."

"I changed my plans." He steps into the room, my heart rate spiking despite my best efforts to stay calm. "Six months without a word, and you didn't think I'd want to see my brother the moment he deigned to return?"

"I needed space." *Lies.* It's just that Malakai is so intense and I needed to collect my thoughts before I faced my brother.

"You needed to run, and you've always been good at that. Running from anything that makes you feel something."

His words hit a little too close to the truth but I refuse to acknowledge it. "That's not fair."

"No?" He reaches the bed and stands there, looking down at me with an expression that reveals nothing and everything all at once. "You

disappeared in the middle of the night. Left a note with three sentences on it. Then you blocked my number for the first two months. And now you show up out of nowhere, looking like death warmed over, and you want to talk about *fair*?"

My jaw tightens as I press my back against the wood. "I'm an adult. I don't need your permission to live my own life." My words come out weak, wobbling toward the end, a whine at the back of my throat. There's no doubt in my mind that Malakai can see beneath my façade.

"Clearly." His gaze sweeps over me, cataloging every detail the way he always does and missing nothing. "You've done such an excellent job of it." There's a flicker of concern there, but it quickly disappears.

"What do you want, Malakai? It's late, I'm tired, and whatever lecture you've got prepared can wait until morning."

For a long moment, he doesn't respond. He just stands there studying me with those unreadable eyes, the silence stretching until my nerves feel like they might snap.

And then, in the next second, his hand shoots out and closes around my chin before I can flinch away, Malakai tilting my face up toward him.

"Look at you." His voice has gone soft, almost gentle, and somehow that's worse than the sharpness. "You're a mess, little doe. When's the last time you ate? Slept properly? Did anything besides whatever self-destructive spiral you've been drowning in?"

I try to pull away, but his grip only tightens. *Little doe*. He hasn't called me that in ages and the way it makes me feel, the heat that builds in my lower belly and starts to move down... Nothing good can come from it.

"Let go of me." My words contrast my actions as I shuffle forward a little, now fully resting on my knees, my hands fisted at my sides.

"No." He shifts his thumb, brushing it across my cheekbone in a gesture that shouldn't feel as intimate as it does. "You don't get to vanish for half a year and then act as if nothing happened. You don't get to shut me out."

"I... I wasn't shutting you out. I was trying to figure out who I am without everyone else's expectations suffocating me."

"And? Did you find your answers?"

The question hits too close to the truth, and my eyes burn even as I refuse to cry. Not here, not in front of him. "I found out I'm really good at making terrible decisions," I whisper, the laugh that escapes after hollow and broken. "Is that what you wanted to hear?"

Something shifts in his expression, the cold assessment giving way to something rawer and more dangerous. He releases my chin only to reach for my arm instead, fingers wrapping around my wrist with the same rigid grip. I realize what's happening a second too late.

"Don't."

But Malakai is already pushing up the sleeve of my hoodie, shoving the soft fabric past my elbow to expose the skin beneath. The bruises there are older, but the fingerprints left by someone who grabbed me hard enough to leave marks that lasted are unmistakable.

He goes very still.

The silence that follows is worse than shouting or the accusations. It's the kind of quiet that precedes violence, my heart beating a little faster as I brace myself for his anger.

"Malakai." My voice breaks on his name but I don't try to pull back. "It's not what you think."

"What I *think* is that someone put their hands on you." His voice is terrifyingly calm, the kind of calm that precedes an ultimatum. "What I

think is that someone hurt you badly enough to leave marks I can still see after god knows how long."

"It was nothing. He didn't mean to; it was just a stupid fight." The lies taste like ash on my tongue, but I can't stop them from coming because I can't bear to see the look on my brother's face if I tell the truth.

"He." His thumb presses into one of the bruises, hard enough to make me hiss. "Who is he?"

"It doesn't matter. It's over, I left, I came home, and it's done."

"That's not what I asked." He hisses as he leans closer until his face is inches from mine, the scent of his cologne wrapping around us both. "I asked who did this to you."

"Why does it matter? What are you going to do, track him down and beat him up?" I try for dismissive and land somewhere closer to desperate. My breathing quickens as I tug back a little, regretting it when his hand tightens around my arm. "I handled it. I don't need you to fight my battles."

"You handled it." The words drip with contempt. "Is that why you're skin and bones? Why you look like you haven't slept in weeks? Why you tried to hide from me? Why you flinch when someone gets too close?"

My brows furrow in confusion. "I—I don't flinch."

"You did when I reached for you." His grip on my wrist shifts and gentles slightly, his thumb tracing absent patterns over my racing pulse. "You've never flinched away from me before."

It's true. Despite everything, despite the complicated tangle of our relationship, Malakai has never hurt me. He's never raised a hand or left bruises, because that's always been everyone else's job.

"I'm just tired." The excuse is weak, and we both know it. "I wasn't expecting you tonight, and you startled me."

"Elliot." My name comes out as a command and a warning and a plea all wrapped into one. "Tell me who did this."

"Why? So you can ride in like some kind of avenging angel? I don't need saving, Malakai. I'm not a damsel in distress."

"No." His free hand comes up to grip my jaw again, holding me in place and forcing eye contact while his touch burns against my skin. "You're my brother. You're mine to protect, whether you want to admit it or not, and someone put their hands on what belongs to me."

The words send heat curling through my belly, a small gasp pulling from my lips as my pulse pounds a little harder beneath his grip on my wrist.

What belongs to me.

It's possessive and controlling, everything I should be trying to escape, so why does part of me want to lean into it?

"I'm not yours." The protest comes out weaker than I intend. "I'm not anyone's."

"Keep telling yourself that." His thumb presses against my pulse point, and I know he can feel how fast my heart is racing. "Your body knows the truth even if your mouth won't admit it."

"You're impossible."

"And you're deflecting." He releases my jaw but doesn't move away, his body still close enough that his warmth bleeds into my skin. "I'm going to ask you one more time, *Elliot*, and you're going to give me an answer."

My throat tightens. There's steel in his eyes, an absolute certainty that he'll get what he wants because he always does. I could lie again, spin another deflection or make up another excuse designed to make him go away and leave me to lick my wounds in peace. But he would see through it, because he always does, and maybe I'm just tired of carrying this alone.

"His name is Marcus." I stumble over the name, hating how it tastes like ash on my tongue. "We were together for four months, and I really don't want to talk about it."

Malakai absorbs the information without any visible reaction, his expression giving nothing away. Then he pushes my sleeve up further, exposing more skin and more evidence of Marcus' destruction, my brother's jaw tightening further as his eyes go nearly black. "These are old." It isn't a question.

"The relationship ended a few weeks ago," I mutter.

"And the newer ones?" His eyes meet mine. "The ones you're hiding under all those layers?"

My blood runs cold. "I don't know what you're talking about."

"Little doe." The nickname drags up memories of our childhood, of whispered secrets and shared glances and a bond that always felt like more than brotherhood should. "I know when you're lying. I've always known."

I want to deny it, to pull away and rebuild my walls and pretend I'm fine. Instead, I hear myself say, "He didn't take the breakup well."

Something shifts in my brother's eyes. It's not quite anger, but it's something far worse. "I see." Those two words terrify me more than any threat could have.

I tug back against his grip again, to no avail, a small pleading whine falling from my lips. "Malakai, whatever you're thinking, don't." My voice wavers as I reach for his arm, my fingers curling into the fabric of his sleeve. "It's over. He's in another state. I just want to forget it happened and move on with my life. *Please.*"

"Of course." He releases my wrist and smooths my sleeve back down with a gentleness that doesn't usually match him. "You should get some rest. You

look exhausted."

The sudden shift in his demeanor makes my head spin. "That's it? You're not going to lecture me? Demand details? Tell me how stupid I was to get involved with someone like that?"

"Would it help if I did?"

"No."

"Then what would be the point?" He stands up straighter, and I suddenly feel small in my childhood bed, looking up at my brother like he's something I'll never fully understand. "Get some sleep, Elliot. We'll talk more in the morning." He gives me one more once over before turning toward the door.

"Malakai."

He pauses but doesn't turn around.

"What are you going to do?"

Silence stretches between us, the muscles in his shoulders tensing before relaxing completely. When he finally speaks, his voice comes out softer than I've ever heard it, but there's still an undercurrent of rage beneath it. "Whatever needs to be done."



Elliot

Malakai walks out without looking back, and I should feel relieved. I should feel grateful for the reprieve, but instead a different kind of fear creeps through my veins as I stare at the empty doorway.

Whatever needs to be done.

The words echo in my head as I sink back against the headboard, my heart still pounding from the encounter. My wrist tingles where he gripped it as I press my thumb against the spot without thinking, chasing the ghost of his touch like some kind of masochist. Heat flickers low in my belly at the memory of his fingers wrapped around me, my cock twitching in my pants at the idea of *more* and I hate myself for it.

What the hell is wrong with me?

How can someone want his brother? His twin? A man who has such a similar face to mine that it's nearly like looking in a mirror?

I barely have time to catch my breath before footsteps sound in the hallway again. Malakai reappears in my doorway, but this time he doesn't hover on the threshold. He walks straight into my room, shuts the door behind him with a soft click, and leans against it with his arms crossed over his chest. "I changed my mind." His voice is deceptively casual, but I can see the tension coiled in his shoulders. "We're going to talk about this now."

My stomach drops even as something else stirs beneath the anxiety. "Malakai, it's almost midnight." I pull the covers higher, as if the thin fabric could somehow protect me from whatever is about to happen. "I told you everything you need to know."

"You told me a name and a timeline. That's not everything." He pushes off the door and moves toward my bed with predatory grace, my breath catching in my throat. "That's barely anything at all."

"What more do you want from me?" The question comes out breathless, the heat creeping up my neck at how desperate I sound. My fingers twist in the comforter, my knuckles going white. *Fuck.*

"The truth." He stops at the foot of my bed, towering over me once again. "All of it. Starting with how long this was actually going on."

"I told you." My voice wavers despite my best efforts to keep it steady. "Four months."

"Four months of what, exactly?" He tilts his head, studying me. "Four months of him hitting you? Four months of you hiding it? Four months of you convincing yourself it wasn't that bad?"

Each question lands like a blow, and I flinch before I can stop myself. The movement makes something flicker in Malakai's expression, a darkness I'm all too familiar with, a darkness that has me shifting my thighs together as fantasies creep into my head.

"How long, Elliot?"

"The relationship was four months." I drop my gaze to the loose thread I've been picking at, unable to hold his stare any longer. "The other stuff started about six weeks in."

"Six weeks." He repeats the words slowly, letting each syllable hang in the air between us like a blade. "So for two and a half months, you let someone use you as a punching bag, and you didn't think to call me?"

The accusation cuts deep, my eyes burning with the threat of tears I refuse to shed. "It wasn't like that." Even I can hear how weak the defense sounds. "It didn't start out violent. He was just intense. Possessive. I thought it meant he cared about me."

"Possessive how?"

I don't want to answer that. The shame of that relationship sits heavy in my chest, making it hard to breathe. Admitting the truth means admitting how pathetic I've been, how easily I let myself be manipulated by someone who saw my need for structure and exploited it for his own sick purposes.

"Elliot." My name snaps through the air like a whip, my head jerking up instinctively. The command in his voice sends a shiver racing down my spine, my traitorous cock twitching in my pants again. "I asked you a question."

I bite down on my bottom lip, teasing at broken skin there before answering. "He wanted to know where I was all the time." The words start slow, but the thought of Malakai saying my name in that stern way again has the explanation coming out a little bit easier. My heart pounds as I speak, each confession peeling back another layer of the shame I've been carrying for months. "Who I was talking to? Why I didn't answer his texts

fast enough? At first I thought it was sweet, you know? Like he was just really into me."

Malakai's jaw tightens, but he doesn't interrupt. His silence is somehow worse than any response would be, heavy with judgment I can feel even if I can't see it on his face.

"Then he started showing up places." My voice drops to a whisper as I have to force each word past the tightness in my throat. "My classes, the library, the coffee shop where I liked to study. He'd just appear and act like it was a coincidence, but it happened too often to be random." A bitter laugh escapes me, scraping against my throat. "I should have seen the red flags. They were everywhere. But I was so desperate to feel like someone actually wanted me that I ignored every single one."

"What else?"

The question comes out almost soft, and somehow that makes it harder to answer. I swallow back a gasp when his hand drops to mine, his thumb running over my knuckles. Anyone else would think it was just a sweet gesture but I can feel my brother's control straining. My fingers twist tighter in the comforter as I force myself to continue.

"He started isolating me from my friends. He said they were bad influences, that they didn't understand our relationship, that they were trying to come between us." My breath hitches, and I have to pause to steady myself. Malakai's thumb stops running over my knuckles, the absence of that touch almost like an incentive to keep going. The moment I start talking again, the movement continues. "I believed him. I cut people off because he asked me to, and by the time I realized what was happening, I had no one left."

The silence that follows is suffocating. Malakai removes his hand and stands motionless at the foot of my bed, his expression carved from stone. I find myself searching his face for any hint of what he's thinking. Anger? Disappointment? Disgust?

Part of me wishes he would just yell at me. That would be easier than this weighted quiet, this sense of standing on the edge of a cliff and waiting for the ground to crumble beneath my feet.

"When did he first hit you?"

The question comes out almost like a hiss, just barely above a whisper. This is the Malakai that other people fear, the one who built a reputation on being ruthless and untouchable. The one who would burn the world down if someone crossed him.

I should be afraid. Instead, something warm unfurls in my chest at the evidence of his protectiveness, and the reaction confuses me so much that I stumble over my answer.

"A—about six weeks in." I make myself keep talking even though every instinct screams at me to stop, to hide, to protect myself from the vulnerability of being truly seen. "We got into an argument about something stupid. I don't even remember what it was anymore. He grabbed my arm and shoved me into a wall, and I hit my head hard enough to see stars."

"And you stayed."

It's not a question, but I answer anyway. "He apologized. Cried. Promised it would never happen again. Said he just loved me so much that he lost control." The excuses taste like poison on my tongue, all the lies I told myself to justify staying with someone who was slowly destroying me. "I wanted to believe him. I needed to believe him, because if I admitted what

was really happening, I'd have to admit that I was stupid enough to fall for it in the first place."

Malakai moves, circling around to the side of my bed slowly, my pulse kicking up a notch because I have no idea what he's doing. When he sits down on the edge of the mattress, close enough that I can feel the heat radiating from his body, I freeze.

He reaches for my hand, and I let him take it without resistance. Malakai pushes up my sleeve again, exposing the faded bruises that Marcus left behind. I watch his face as he traces the outline of a fingerprint with his thumb, the tenderness of the touch making my heart flutter a little.

"How many times?" His voice comes out rough, like he's holding back the emotions he really wants to release by sheer force of will.

"I don't know." The admission burns with shame, tears pricking at the corners of my eyes. "I lost count after a while. It became normal, I guess. Part of the routine. He'd get angry, he'd hurt me, he'd apologize, and then everything would be fine for a few days until it happened again."

"And the newer bruises?" His thumb stills against my wrist, the tension thrumming through his body like a live wire. "The ones you're hiding under your clothes?"

My throat constricts so tight I can barely breathe. I knew this question was coming, but that doesn't make it any easier to answer. The memory surfaces and even closing my eyes does nothing to stop it from hitting me all at once. "He showed up at my apartment about a week after I ended things." My voice comes out thin, barely recognizable as my own. "I thought I'd gotten away clean. I changed my number, blocked him on everything, and even moved to a different building. But he found me anyway."

Malakai's grip on my hand tightens, not enough to hurt, but enough to ground me in the present when the past threatens to pull me under.

"He was waiting inside when I got home from class. I don't know how he got in. Maybe he had a key copied, or maybe he just charmed his way past the building manager." A hysterical edge creeps into my laugh, unable to suppress the tremor in my voice. "He was always good at that. Making people trust him."

"What did he do, Elliot?"

"He wanted me to come back. He said he'd changed, that he'd gotten help, that he couldn't live without me." My eyes sting, but I refuse to let the tears fall. Not yet. Not until I've said everything that needs to be said. "When I told him no, he didn't take it well."

"Show me."

The command is soft but leaves no room for disobedience, and I find myself complying before I can think better of it. My hands shake as I reach for the hem of my hoodie, pulling it up and over my head to reveal the damage underneath. The cool air hits my bare skin, a shiver running down my spine, feeling exposed in more ways than one.

The bruises across my ribs are the worst, still vivid in shades of purple and green. There are more on my stomach, my chest, and my shoulders, a roadmap of violence written across my skin in colors that shouldn't exist on a human body.

Malakai makes a sound low in his throat, something between a growl and a curse, the raw fury in it making heat spike through my body despite the circumstances. "He did this because you told him no?"

I nod, unable to form words around the lump in my throat. My skin prickles beneath his gaze, and I resist the urge to cover myself, to hide from

the intensity of his scrutiny.

"And then?"

"And then I packed a bag and bought a plane ticket and came home." I pull the hoodie back down, desperate to put some barrier between myself and his penetrating stare. "I didn't know where else to go. I don't have anyone else."

I chose to come back here, to this house that never felt like home, to the brother whose intensity I spent six months trying to escape because even with all of that, Malakai is still the safest option I have. The realization settles in my chest and I find myself leaning toward him without meaning to, drawn by some gravity I can't resist.

"Is he still contacting you?" Malakai's voice cuts through my spiraling thoughts.

"Yeah. He keeps finding ways around the blocks. New numbers, fake accounts, emails from random addresses." I wrap my arms around myself, trying to hide maybe, I'm not sure. "I've gotten thirty-seven messages in the past week alone. Some of them are apologies. Some of them are threats. I never know which version of him I'm going to get."

"Do you have these messages?"

"On my phone." I nod toward the nightstand where my phone is, the screen dark and silent for now, surprisingly enough. "I screenshot everything, just in case I need proof someday." Fuck, I shouldn't have said that.

Rage flashes in Malakai's eyes, mixed with something that's dangerously close to protection. He's always been fiercely protective of me and my safety. Running from him kept Malakai from doing any of that properly.

He stands abruptly, and for a moment I think he's going to leave again. Instead, he begins pacing the length of my room, his movements strained as the muscles in his shoulders and arms flex and loosen. "You should have fucking called me the first time he touched you." Each word comes out clipped, each one a small explosion of suppressed fury that I can feel vibrating in the air between us. "You should have fucking called me and I would have been on the first flight out. I would have made sure he never came near you again."

"I couldn't." My voice breaks, and the tears I've been fighting finally spill over. "You don't understand, Malakai. I couldn't call you because calling you would mean admitting that I failed. That I ran away from home to prove I could take care of myself and instead I walked straight into something worse."

He stops pacing and turns to face me, the dark look in his eyes mixed with a softness that isn't usually there. "Do you think I would have judged you for being hurt?"

"I think you would have said I told you so." The confession pours out of me in a rush, words tumbling over each other in their haste to escape. "I think you would have reminded me that you warned me about leaving, that you said something bad would happen if I tried to make it on my own. I couldn't stand the thought of you looking at me and seeing exactly what I see when I look in the mirror."

"And what is that?"

I chew on my bottom lip, more tears spilling down my cheeks. I don't want him to know how I see myself.

"Elliot, tell me. What do you see when you look in the mirror?"

"Someone weak." My voice drops to a whisper, thick with self-loathing. "Someone pathetic. Someone who can't survive without someone else calling the shots."

Malakai crosses the room in three strides. His hands cup my face, thumbs brushing away the tears that won't stop falling, and when he speaks, his voice is a few octaves deeper.

"You are not weak." His tone leaves no room for argument. "You survived something that would have broken most people. You got yourself out. You came home. That takes more strength than you give yourself credit for."

"Then why do I feel so broken?" I hate how vulnerable I sound. I hate how much I want him to have an answer that will make everything okay.

"Because he made you feel that way. Because he spent months tearing you down and convincing you that you were nothing without him." Malakai's grip on my face tightens just slightly, the pressure sending a confusing wave of calm through my body. "But you're not nothing, Elliot. You're mine to protect, and I don't protect things that are worthless."

The words hit me all at once, knocking the air from my lungs and sending heat flooding through my veins. My cock stirs despite the tears still wet on my cheeks, and the shame of my body's reaction wars with something deeper, something that feels dangerously like hope.

"I don't know what to do," I confess. "He keeps finding me and contacting me, and I don't know how to make it stop. I can't go to the police because he hasn't technically done anything illegal since I left, and even if I did, he's charming and well-connected and they'd probably believe him over me."

My breathing hitches as I lean into Malakai's touch despite every rational thought screaming at me to pull away. His thumbs are still stroking slow,

soothing circles on my cheeks that make my thoughts go fuzzy around the edges.

"I'm so tired, Malakai. I'm so tired of being scared all the time. I need someone to make it stop. I need..."

I can't finish the sentence. The words lodge in my throat, because what I was about to say is too close to the truth I've been running from for years.

But Malakai knows. *He always knows.*

"You need someone to take care of it." His voice drops lower, wrapping around me like velvet and making my skin prickle with awareness. "You need someone to make the decisions you can't make. To handle the problems you can't solve." His thumbs stroke across my jaw before his fingers trail down to my neck, gently squeezing just beneath my chin, a shiver running down my spine. "You need someone to take control so you can finally stop fighting."

Yes. The word echoes through my mind even though I can't bring myself to say it out loud. That's exactly what I need, and hearing his name it makes something inside me crack wide open.

"I can do that for you, little doe." The nickname sends a bolt of heat straight to my core, a gasp tearing from my throat before I can stop myself. "I can make Marcus disappear. I can make sure he never comes near you again. I can give you the safety and structure you're so desperate for."

"How?" The question comes out breathless, my pulse pounding through every inch of my body.

"That's not something you need to worry about." He releases my face and takes a step back, the loss of his touch bringing me back to reality. My body sways toward him instinctively, chasing the contact he's withdrawn. "All you need to do is ask me properly."

"What do you mean, properly?" My voice sounds strange to my own ears.

His eyes bore into mine, a smirk pulling at his lips as his eyes darken with the desire I remember from before I left. "I mean on your knees."

My heart stops. The world narrows down to nothing but Malakai's face and the impossible words that just came out of his mouth. Heat floods through me, my cock stiffening further until it's almost uncomfortable. I shift onto my knees, trying to relieve the ache but that just makes it worse, Malakai's raised brow telling me he knows exactly what those words did to me.

God, he looks so dangerous in this moment, my own brother demanding my submission, the dim light in the room hitting the ring just above his left brow that I didn't notice before.

"You want me to kneel?" My face burns with a combination of shame and anticipation.

"I want you to show me that you understand what you're asking for. I want you to prove that you're willing to do what it takes to get what you need."

I should say no. The thought filters through the haze clouding my mind. I should tell him to go to hell, that I'm not going to debase myself by kneeling at my brother's feet like some kind of submissive. This is *insane*. This is crossing a line we can never uncross.

But my body is already moving, responding to his command before my brain can catch up because some part of me wants this.

I slowly slide off the bed, my heart pounding so hard I can hear it in my ears. The hardwood floor is cold against my knees when I settle onto it, the shock of it sending a jolt up my spine that draws a gasp from my lips. I keep my eyes down, unable to look at my own brother, my face burning

with shame and confusion and a terrible, aching need that I don't know how to process.

This is wrong. I know it's wrong. Malakai is my brother, my twin, and I'm kneeling at his feet like he owns me.

But it doesn't feel wrong. It feels like the first thing that's made sense in months. Like something inside me that's been wound too tight is finally starting to loosen.

I shift, trying to ease the ache between my legs before pressing against the tent in my pants, Malakai's hiss making me freeze. *Shit.*

"Look at me."

The command sends a shiver through my entire body, and I raise my eyes, almost afraid of what I'll see. Malakai is staring down at me like I'm something precious, something valuable, something worth protecting. No one has ever looked at me like that before.

"Now ask me."

My lips part, but for a moment no sound comes out. My throat is tight with emotion, my chest aching with the weight of everything I've been carrying for so long. The tears start falling again, but I don't try to stop them. There's no point in pretending anymore. Not when I'm already on my knees.

"Please." The word cracks in the middle, full of desperation. "Please, Malakai. Help me. I can't do this on my own anymore." A sob escapes me, and I let it, too exhausted to hold anything back. "I need you."

He moves closer, his hand moving to gently cup my jaw. His thumb traces the line of my cheekbone, wiping away tears with a tenderness that seems at odds with the darkness I glimpsed in his eyes earlier. "Good boy."

The praise washes over me, an embarrassing sound escaping me, something between a sob and a moan. Despite that, I lean into his touch without thinking, desperate for more.

His fingers tighten slightly on my jaw, tilting my face up further until I have no choice but to meet his eyes. The look in them makes my whole body tremble, a combination of possession and tenderness that I don't know how to reconcile.

"Was that so hard, little doe?"

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Malakai

I've been awake for hours, watching the sun rise through the windows of my study while I plan exactly how this day will unfold.

Sleep didn't come last night, not after seeing Elliot on his knees with tears streaming down his face and my name breaking apart on his lips. The image burned itself into my brain, playing on repeat every time I closed my eyes until I gave up on rest entirely and turned my attention to more productive pursuits.

Marcus Vance. Graduate student at UCLA, twenty-eight years old, comes from money but not enough to matter. I found everything I needed within the first hour of searching, his address, his class schedule, the names of his friends and family members, and the location of the gym where he works out every Tuesday and Thursday morning. By the time dawn started

painting the sky in shades of pink and gold, I had a complete picture of the man who dared to put his hands on my brother.

He'll regret it. I'll make sure of that personally.

But first, there's the matter of Elliot himself.

I leave a note on his nightstand while he sleeps, his face slack and peaceful in a way I haven't seen since he walked through the door last night. The bruises on his arms are visible above the blanket he's clutching like a lifeline, and the sight of them makes my jaw clench so tight my teeth ache.

Breakfast. 8am. Don't be late.

The words are simple, a command wrapped in the guise of an invitation, but I know he'll understand the subtext. After last night, after the way he knelt for me so sweetly and begged for my help, there's no going back to the way things were before. We've crossed a line that can't be uncrossed, and now it's time to establish exactly what that means.

I make my way to the formal dining room and instruct the kitchen staff to prepare all of Elliot's favorites. Blueberry pancakes with real maple syrup, scrambled eggs with chives, fresh-squeezed orange juice, and the specific brand of Earl Grey tea that he used to drink by the potful when we were teenagers. It's a test of sorts, a way to show him that I've been paying attention all these years even when he thought I wasn't looking.

The table is set for two by the time I settle into my chair at the head, my tablet propped against a water glass as I scroll through emails I have no intention of actually reading. The words blur together on the screen while my mind runs through the conversation ahead, anticipating his objections and planning my responses. I run my tongue over the metal barbell pierced through it, a habit I've never been able to break when I'm thinking, and let my mind run through the conversation ahead.

Elliot will fight me on this. He'll tell me I'm insane, that what I'm proposing is impossible, that we're brothers and this crosses every line that exists between siblings. But I saw the truth last night when he sank to his knees without me having to ask twice. I saw the relief that washed over his face when I took control, the way his whole body softened when I called him a good boy.

He needs this. He's needed it his whole life, and I'm done pretending I'm not the one who should give it to him.

The clock on the wall reads 7:58 when I hear footsteps in the hallway, hurried but trying not to sound rushed. A small smile tugs at the corner of my mouth as I keep my eyes fixed on the tablet screen. He's punctual, at least. That's a good sign.

Elliot appears in the doorway looking like he barely slept, his hair damp from a hasty shower and his clothes rumpled in a way that suggests he grabbed the first things he could find. He's wearing another oversized sweater that swallows his frame, and the sight of it makes something possessive curl tight in my chest. I want to see him in clothes that actually fit, clothes that show off the body he's been hiding beneath layers of fabric like armor.

Soon enough, I'll have him in whatever I want. Or nothing at all.

"Sit." I gesture to the chair at my right without looking up from my tablet, keeping my tone casual even as I track his every movement from the corner of my eye.

He hesitates for just a moment before crossing the room and lowering himself into the indicated seat. His movements are almost delicate, and I catch the slight wince he tries to hide when his weight settles onto the chair.

"You found my note." I set the tablet aside and reach for my coffee, taking a slow sip while I study his face over the rim of the cup.

"I found it." His voice is rough, scratchy with sleep and nerves that he's trying desperately to hide. "You could have just knocked on my door like a normal person."

"I could have." I set the cup down and let my gaze drift over the spread of food between us. "But I thought you might appreciate a few minutes to compose yourself before we had the harder part of this conversation."

His eyes dart to the platters arranged across the table, recognition flickering across his features as he takes in the food I had prepared specially for him. His lips part slightly, surprise softening the tension around his eyes. "You remembered."

"I remember everything about you, Elliot." I keep my tone even, but I make sure he hears the weight beneath the words. "I always have."

He swallows hard, his Adam's apple bobbing in his throat, and reaches for the teapot with trembling hands. I let him pour his cup and take a fortifying sip before I speak again, giving him a moment to settle into the strangeness of this situation.

"Eat something." It's not a request.

He picks up his fork and pushes the eggs around his plate, taking a small bite that he chews mechanically. His appetite is clearly nonexistent, which doesn't surprise me given the state he was in last night, but I need him to build his strength back up. The next few weeks are going to be demanding, and I won't have him collapsing because he's too anxious to eat properly.

"More than that." I nod toward the pancakes. "You need actual food, not just a few bites to appease me."

His jaw tightens with a flash of the defiance I remember from our childhood, that stubborn streak that always made him dig in his heels when he felt cornered. But he pulls the plate of pancakes toward him and cuts off a piece without argument. He reaches for the syrup, drowning his plate in it before cutting off another small piece and lifting it to his mouth.

I can't help but watch his throat work as he swallows, the gauntness of his features hiding the true beauty he possesses.

We eat in silence for several minutes, the only sounds are the clink of silverware against porcelain and the distant ticking of the grandfather clock in the hallway. Elliot manages about half a pancake and a few more bites of eggs before setting his fork down with a sigh that tells me he's reached his limit.

"I can't." He shakes his head when I raise an eyebrow. "My stomach is in knots. I'll try to eat more later, I promise, but right now I just need to know what's going to happen. I need to know what you meant last night when you said you'd help me."

I lean back in my chair and take another sip of coffee, letting the silence stretch between us until his fingers start tapping nervously against the table. He's anxious, practically vibrating with it, and the urge to reach over and still his hand with my own pulls at me.

Not yet. First we establish the rules.

"Let me be clear about what I'm offering." I set the cup down and fold my hands on the table in front of me, giving him my full attention. "I will handle Marcus. You don't need to know how and you won't ask. By the end of the week, he will no longer be a problem."

Elliot's fingers stop their tapping, curling into a loose fist instead. "What does that mean, handle him? Malakai, if you're planning to do something

illegal, I don't want to be responsible for you ending up in prison."

"Your concern is touching, but unnecessary." I allow a small smile to curve my lips. "I have no intention of going to prison. I have resources, Elliot. Legal and otherwise. Marcus Vance will be dealt with in a way that ensures he never comes near you again, and that's all you need to know about it."

He looks like he wants to argue, to demand more details, but something in my expression must convince him to let it go because he just nods tightly and reaches for his tea again. His fingers wrap around the delicate cup like he's seeking warmth or maybe comfort, and I file away that observation for later.

"And in return?" The question is barely above a whisper, his eyes fixed on the amber liquid in his cup like he can't bear to look at me while he asks.

"In return, you stay here at the estate. You finish your degree online, which I've already arranged with the university. You'll join Ashford Holdings in a junior analyst position that reports directly to my department." I pause, letting each piece of information sink in before I deliver the final term. "And you belong to me."

His head snaps up, eyes wide with shock. "Belong to you?"

"*Completely.*" I hold his gaze without flinching, letting him see that I'm absolutely serious about every word coming out of my mouth. "Your body. Your time. Your obedience. You will ask permission for everything, from what you eat to when you sleep to where you go. Everything you are, everything you do, belongs to me."

The color drains from his face, then rushes back in a flush that spreads from his cheeks down to his neck and disappears beneath the collar of his sweater. His breathing shallows, coming out in short pants, his pupils

dilating as his body responds to my words even while his mind struggles to process them.

"That's insane." His voice cracks on the last word. "I'm your brother. You can't just own me like some kind of possession."

"Can't I?" I tilt my head, studying him with the same careful attention I use when evaluating a business proposal. "You came to *me* last night, Elliot. You got on your knees and begged me to help you, to take control, to make the decisions you can't make for yourself. I'm simply offering to give you exactly what you asked for."

"That was different. I was upset, I wasn't thinking clearly, I didn't mean for you to take it literally."

I click my tongue ring against my teeth, watching the way Elliot's gaze drops to my mouth. His flush deepens, spreading down his neck, before he looks away quickly like he's been caught doing something he shouldn't.

"Didn't you?" I lean forward, close enough to see the way his breath catches when I invade his space. "Tell me you didn't feel relief when you knelt for me. Tell me your whole body didn't relax when I called you a good boy. Tell me you haven't spent your entire life searching for someone who could give you the structure and control you so desperately crave."

His mouth opens and closes several times, but no words come out. The flush on his cheeks has deepened to a dark rose, his pulse jumping wildly in the hollow of his throat.

"You can say no." I sit back, giving him room to breathe again. "You can walk out of this room, pack your bag, and leave. Handle Marcus on your own. Continue pretending you're something you're not." I let the words hang in the air between us, heavy with implication. "But we both know how that worked out for you last time."

"That's not fair." His voice is thick, trembling with emotions he's trying desperately to suppress. "You can't use what happened with Marcus as leverage to make me agree to this."

"I'm not using it as leverage. I'm pointing out a pattern." I keep my tone as gentle as I can despite how much I just want to see him kneeling for me again, submitting to what I'm demanding of him. "You left home because you wanted independence, and you ended up with a man who controlled you through violence and fear. That's not what you actually need, Elliot. It's a twisted version of it, offered by someone who didn't have your best interests at heart."

"And you do?" The question comes out sharp, almost bitter. "You think you know what's best for me better than I do?"

"I know that you probably haven't been able to sleep properly in months. I know that you've barely eaten just by looking at you, that you flinch at sudden movements, and that you curl in on yourself like you're trying to disappear." I hold his gaze steadily, willing him to see the truth in my words. "So yes, Elliot. I think I know what you need better than you're willing to admit to yourself."

Silence stretches between us, thick with tension and the weight of everything I've just laid bare. Elliot's hands are shaking where they rest on the table, his eyes bright with unshed tears. Beneath all of that, though, I know he's considering my proposal, partly because he needs this but also because he wants this.

"Why?" His voice wobbles as he draws his hands into his lap, his chest visibly rising and falling with the confusion of my words. "Why would you want this? I'm your brother, Malakai. Your twin. This is wrong on so many levels I can't even begin to count them."

"Wrong by whose standards?" I ask the question without judgment, genuinely curious about his answer. "Society's? Our parents', who couldn't be bothered to show up for your homecoming? The world that taught you to be ashamed of what you need?"

"Wrong by any standard." But his voice wavers on the words, uncertainty creeping into the cracks of his conviction.

"Let me tell you what I see when I look at you, Elliot." I rise from my chair and move around the table, stopping beside him so I can look down at his upturned face. "I see someone who has spent his entire life trying to fit into a mold that was never meant for him. Someone who has been neglected by parents who should have treasured him, overlooked by a world that couldn't see his value, and brutalized by a man who exploited his needs for his own sick gratification."

I reach down and cup his jaw in my hand, tilting his face up toward mine. His breath catches at the contact, and I feel the slight tremor that runs through his body at my touch.

"I see someone who deserves to be taken care of. Protected. Cherished." My thumb strokes across his cheekbone, wiping away a tear that has escaped despite his best efforts to hold them back. "I see someone who belongs to me, whether either of us wants to admit it or not. I've seen it since we were children, Elliot. I've just been waiting for you to see it too."

His eyes fall closed as he leans into my touch with a shuddering breath that speaks louder than any words could. The fight is draining out of him, I can see it in the way his shoulders slump and his hands unclench on the table.

"What happens if I say yes?"

"Then you're mine." I let the words settle over him. "You'll follow my rules, accept my decisions, and trust me to take care of you in ways no one else ever has. In return, I'll give you everything you need. Safety. Structure. A place where you finally belong."

"And if I say no?"

"Then I'll still deal with Marcus, because I refuse to let him continue terrorizing you. But you'll walk out of this house and out of my life, and we'll both spend the rest of our days knowing that you were too afraid to take what we both want."

His eyes open, and the conflict I see there makes my chest tight. He's teetering on the edge, caught between the conditioning of a lifetime and the truth of his own desires, and I can almost see the scales tipping back and forth as he weighs his options.

"I need time to think." There's a desperation to the need in his voice and I know he'll break sooner, rather than later. "This is too much, Malakai. You're asking me to hand over my entire life."

"I'm asking you to let me carry the weight you've been struggling under alone." I release his jaw and step back, giving him space even as everything in me screams to pull him closer. "But I understand that this is a significant decision. You have until the end of breakfast to give me your answer."

His eyes widen with alarm. "That's not enough time."

"It's more than enough." I return to my seat and pick up my coffee, taking a calm sip while he stares at me in disbelief. "You already know what you want, Elliot. You've known since you knelt for me last night. All I'm asking is for you to stop fighting it and say yes."

The silence that follows is deafening. Elliot's gaze drops to his plate, to his hands, and then to the window where morning light is coming through

the crack of the curtains. I can practically see the war raging inside him, duty and desire locked in a battle that only one can win.

I wait. I've learned patience over the years, cultivated it like a skill until I can outlast almost anyone in a negotiation. And this is a negotiation, perhaps the most important one of my life. The stakes couldn't be higher, and I refuse to lose.

Minutes tick by as Elliot's breathing gradually slows, the tension in his shoulders easing by degrees as he works through whatever internal debate is consuming him. Finally, after what feels like an eternity, he raises his eyes to mine.

"Yes."

The word is quiet, barely more than a breath, but it hits me, triumph surging through my veins. However, I keep my expression neutral through sheer force of will. "Yes what?" I need to hear him say it properly and know he understands exactly what he's agreeing to.

He swallows hard, his throat working around the words. "Yes, I'll belong to you. I'll follow your rules and accept your decisions and trust you to take care of me." A shaky breath escapes him. "I'm yours, Malakai."

The satisfaction that unfurls in my chest is unlike anything I've ever experienced. *He's mine.* After years of watching and wanting and waiting, Elliot is finally, irrevocably mine. "Good boy." I let the praise wash over him, his eyes fluttering closed, his whole body seeming to melt at the words. "Now, before we go any further, there's something we need to establish. When we're in private, when it's just the two of us, you will address me as 'sir.' Is that understood?"

His eyes fly open, a fresh wave of color flooding his cheeks. "Sir?"

"Yes." I hold his gaze, letting him see that this isn't negotiable. "It's a sign of respect, Elliot. A reminder of your position and mine. We've danced around this dynamic our whole lives, and now it's time to formalize it."

He's quiet for a long moment, processing this new requirement, and I can see the internal struggle playing out across his features. But then he nods slowly, his tongue darting out to wet his lips in a nervous gesture that makes heat coil low in my belly.

"Yes, sir." The words come out tentative, the undercurrent of a new emotion beneath them. Relief. Rightness. Like a key sliding into a lock it was always meant to open.

"Good boy," I say again, loving how easily it makes my brother melt. "And Elliot? If you ever disobey me, if you break my rules or defy my instructions, I won't call you 'little doe.' I'll use your full name. Elliot Aurelius." I let each syllable land, a name rarely used by anyone in the house. "When you hear that, you'll know you're in trouble. Do you understand?"

His breath hitches at the sound of his middle name on my lips, a name I doubt he's heard spoken aloud since our grandmother's funeral years ago. The intimacy of it isn't lost on him, I can tell by the way his pupils dilate and his hands grip the edge of the table.

"Yes, sir. I understand."

"Good." I push back from the table and rise to my feet. "Then let's begin. Come here and kneel."

He stands on unsteady legs, his chair scraping against the hardwood floor as he pushes it back. For a moment he just hovers there, uncertainty written across his features, the last vestiges of resistance clinging to his pride.

I point to the floor in front of my chair. "Here. Now."

The command cuts through his hesitation, and he moves to stand before me with his head slightly bowed.

"Knees apart." I keep my voice calm, trying to hide the excitement bleeding through me. "Hands on your thighs, palms up. Back straight. Eyes down." Mom and Dad won't be home any time soon and I ordered the staff to clear out until we were finished with breakfast, not that they would say anything if they saw. I'd make sure of it.

He sinks to the floor slowly, his movements awkward and unpracticed as he tries to arrange his body according to my directions. His knees spread wider than is strictly comfortable, his hands settling on his thighs with the palms facing the ceiling, his spine straightening as he drops his gaze to the floor.

It's not perfect. His posture is slightly off, his shoulders too tense, and his breathing too shallow. But seeing him kneeling at my feet sends a rush of possessive heat through my body that demands acknowledgment.

"Wider." I tap the inside of his knee with my foot, and he shifts to spread his legs further apart. "Better. Now relax your shoulders. You're not being punished, Elliot. This position is meant to help you find peace, not cause you discomfort."

He makes a visible effort to comply, rolling his shoulders back and letting some of the tension drain from his muscles. His breathing evens out slightly, though I can still see the rapid flutter of his pulse in his throat.

"Good." I reach down and adjust the angle of his chin with two fingers, tilting his head to a more neutral position. "When you kneel for me, this is the position you'll take unless I tell you otherwise. It's called a presentation position, and it's designed to show your submission and your trust."

"Yes, sir."

"When I give you an instruction, you respond with 'yes, sir.' When I ask you a question, you answer honestly and completely. When I praise you, you thank me." I release his chin and step back to survey my work. "Is that understood?"

"Yes, sir."

"Good boy." I settle back in my chair and pick up my tablet, scrolling through emails with deliberate casualness. "You'll hold this position while I finish my morning correspondence. Don't speak unless spoken to, and don't move unless given permission. If you need something urgently, you may say 'sir' to get my attention. Otherwise, I expect silence."

He lets out a soft sound, something between a moan and a gasp, his eyes on me, wide with disbelief that I'm actually going to make him kneel here while I work. But he doesn't protest or argue, just settles deeper into the position while trying to find some equilibrium.

I never realized how much I love the image of my brother on his knees for me. However, the fantasy I've been warring with for years, of those perfect lips parted, begging me for something else are exacerbating the situation. He's not ready for that but he will be.

The minutes stretch out, marked only by the soft sounds of my fingers against the tablet screen and Elliot's carefully controlled breathing. I'm not actually reading my emails, my attention is fixed entirely on him, but he doesn't need to know that. This exercise is about more than just teaching him a position. It's about showing him that I'm serious, that my control extends to every aspect of his life now, that he will wait for my attention rather than demanding it.

Ten minutes pass. Then fifteen. I watch from the corner of my eye as his thighs begin to tremble, the muscles protesting the unfamiliar strain. His

breathing has gone deeper and slower, the tension that has been living in his shoulders since he arrived finally starting to fade.

This is what he needs. Structure. Boundaries. Someone to hold the reins so he doesn't have to carry that weight alone.

Twenty minutes. His head has drooped slightly, his eyes half-closed in something that looks almost like a trance. Peace has settled over his features, a stark contrast to the hunted, haunted expression he wore when I walked through his door last night.

I set aside my tablet and lean forward, reaching out to card my fingers through his hair in a gentle stroke that makes him shiver. "You did well for your first time, little doe."

His eyes flutter open, hazy and unfocused, the look he gives me so open and trusting. It only reinforces the fact that this deal is perfect.

"Thank you, sir." The words come out soft and dreamy, like he's speaking from very far away.

"How do you feel?"

He takes a moment to consider the question, his brow furrowing slightly as he searches for the right words. "Quiet," he finally says. "My head feels quiet. It hasn't felt like that in a long time."

"That's the point." I continue stroking his hair, watching the way his eyes drift closed again at the sensation. "This is what submission can give you, Elliot. Peace. Clarity. A break from the constant noise of trying to control everything on your own."

"I didn't know it could feel like this." His voice is barely above a whisper. "I thought it would be scary or humiliating, but it just feels safe."

"Because you're with someone who has your best interests at heart." I cup his jaw and tilt his face up toward mine, waiting until his eyes focus on me

before I continue. "What Marcus did to you wasn't submission. It was abuse dressed up in control. There's a difference, and I'm going to teach you what that difference looks like."

He nods slowly, leaning into my touch with a trust that makes my chest ache with satisfaction.

"Now." I release his jaw and let my hand fall away from his hair. "We have a lot of work to do, and this is only the beginning."

His eyes meet mine, clearer now. The haze of subspace he slipped into is fading, but the peace remains, settled into his bones like it belongs there.

"Yes, sir. I'm ready."



Malakai

The first day of Elliot's new life begins at precisely 7:00 AM when my phone buzzes with a text message.

I'm awake, sir.

Three words. Simple, obedient, exactly as instructed. I stare at the screen for a long moment, letting the satisfaction of it wash through me before I type my response.

Good boy. You may shower and dress. Report to the dining room for breakfast at 7:30.

I set the phone aside and return my attention to the research I started last night, the financial reports long forgotten in favor of more pressing matters.

Marcus Vance. I expected to find him still in California, still teaching his pathetic graduate seminars three thousand miles away from my brother.

Elliot said he was in another state, said that's why he felt safe coming home, and I let him believe that was true.

It isn't.

The fucker's apartment lease is dated two weeks ago, a sublet in Hartford signed under his mother's maiden name like that would be enough to hide him. He even managed to pick up a new adjunct position at a community college forty minutes from the Ashford estate and started just days before Elliot arrived on our doorstep covered in bruises.

He followed him. The sick fuck actually followed him across the country.

My hands curl into fists as I stare at the screen, rage building behind my ribs. Elliot thought he was running to safety. He had no idea the monster was already here, circling closer, waiting for the right moment to strike.

I close the laptop and lean back in my chair, forcing my breathing to steady. Elliot doesn't need to know about this. He's already terrified, and telling him that Marcus is forty minutes away instead of three thousand miles would shatter whatever fragile sense of security he's managed to find.

No. I'll handle this myself, tonight, and Elliot will never have to know how close the danger actually was.

My mind drifts back to the image of him waking up in his childhood bedroom, reaching for his phone before he even gets out of bed because I told him to. The reality of it still hasn't fully sunk in, even after watching him kneel at my feet yesterday morning, even after hearing him whisper "yes, sir" in that broken, beautiful voice.

Elliot Aurelius Ashford belongs to me now, and I intend to make sure neither of us ever forgets it.

Breakfast is a quiet affair, Elliot eating his toast and eggs while I review emails on my tablet. He asks permission before pouring himself a second

cup of tea, his cheeks flushing pink at the words, and the sight of that color spreading across his skin makes me want to do awful, nasty things to him.

"You may have more tea," I tell him without looking up as I hear the soft clink of porcelain when he complies.

This is how it will be from now on. Every meal, every movement, every decision filtered through me first. Some might call it excessive, but I know what Elliot needs even better than he does. He's spent his whole life drowning in choices, paralyzed by the weight of his own freedom, and I'm going to strip all of that away until the only thing left is the peace of absolute surrender.

After breakfast, I walk him through the rules in more detail. His door stays open at all times unless I give him explicit permission to close it. He reports to me when he wakes up and before he goes to sleep. He asks permission before eating, before leaving any room, and before doing anything that isn't specifically outlined in the schedule I've prepared for him.

When he starts his position at the office, it'll be even easier to watch over him but that's an issue for later.

"What if you're busy?" he asks, his brow furrowed with concern. "What if I text you and you don't respond right away?"

"Then you wait." I keep my voice calm, even as I enjoy the way his eyes widen at the implication. "You wait until I give you an answer, Elliot. That's the point. You don't make decisions on your own anymore. You trust me to make them for you."

He swallows hard, his throat working around whatever protest he's trying to suppress, but he nods. "Right. I mean, yes, sir."

"Good boy."

The praise makes him shiver, and I file that reaction away with all the others, not even mad that he forgot to thank me. He's so responsive, so hungry for approval, and I'm going to use that hunger to reshape him into exactly what I need him to be.

The morning passes in a haze of small surrenders. Elliot asks permission to use the bathroom, his face burning with humiliation, and I grant it with a casual nod that belies the satisfaction thrumming through my veins. He asks permission to get a glass of water, to sit on the couch in the study, and to retrieve a book from the shelf. Each request chips away at his pride, and each granted permission reinforces my authority over him.

By midafternoon, he's settled into the rhythm of it, the tension in his shoulders easing as he stops fighting the structure I've imposed. Honestly, I thought it would take him longer but he's been the same since we were kids, always looking to me for approval of his actions.

I watch him from across the study while pretending to focus on work, tracking the way his breathing has slowed, the way his movements have become more fluid and less guarded. Submission looks good on him. It's beautiful.

Around four o'clock, I rise from my desk and stretch, rolling the stiffness out of my shoulders. I have business to attend to this evening, business that Elliot doesn't need to know about, and I need to start preparing.

"I'm going out tonight." I keep my tone casual as I shrug off my shirt and reach for the crisp white button-down I had pressed this morning. "I have some matters to take care of in the city. You'll stay here, follow the schedule I've laid out, and be in bed by eleven."

Elliot looks up from the book he's been reading, his eyes tracking my movements as I work the buttons up my chest. "Where are you going?"

"That's not something you need to concern yourself with." I tuck the shirt into my trousers and reach for my suit jacket, sliding my arms into the sleeves and adjusting the lapels barely thinking about the motion. "Your only job is to obey the rules I've given you and wait for me to return."

He's staring at me now, his lips parted slightly and his cheeks flushed with color that has nothing to do with embarrassment. I recognize that look and the heat building behind his eyes as he watches me dress, a dark thrill running through me when I see his hand drift down to press against the front of his pants.

He catches himself almost immediately, jerking his hand away like he's been burned, but it's too late. I've already seen.

"Elliot Aurelius."

His head snaps up at the sound of his full name, his face draining of color as he registers the tight, controlled edge in my voice. Good. He should recognize that tone. He should know exactly what it means.

I cross the room in three strides, and before he can react, my hand is around his throat, lightly squeezing, as I pin him against the wall behind his chair. He lets out a sharp, startled gasp, his hands coming up to grip my wrist, but he doesn't try to pull away.

"When I said that you ask permission for everything," I murmur, my face inches from his, "I meant everything. Do you understand me?"

"I wasn't... I didn't mean to..." His voice comes out strangled, his pupils blown wide with arousal and fear and something else I can't quite name.

"You touched yourself." I press closer, letting him feel the heat of my body against his. "You were watching me get dressed and you got hard and you reached down to touch what belongs to me without asking permission first."

A desperate whimper escapes his throat. "I'm sorry, sir. I wasn't thinking."

"No, you weren't." My free hand slides down his chest, over his stomach, until I'm cupping him through the thin fabric of his pants. He's hard, straining against my palm, and the sound he makes when I squeeze is almost enough to undo my own self-control. "Is this what you need, little doe? You need me to take care of this for you?"

"Please." The word comes out broken, barely audible. "Please, sir."

I start to massage him through the fabric, watching his face as his eyes flutter closed and his hips rock forward into my touch. He's so responsive, so desperate for contact, and the power of having him like this, pinned against the wall and begging for my hand on his cock, makes my own arousal pulse with urgency.

"Even this belongs to me now." I tighten my grip on his throat just slightly, enough to remind him of my control. "Even when you want to come, you ask me first. You don't touch yourself without permission. You don't find release unless I decide you've earned it."

"Yes, sir." He's trembling now, his whole body shaking as I work him closer and closer to the edge. "I understand, I'm sorry, please don't stop, please..."

His hips move faster, grinding against my palm with increasing desperation as his breath comes in short, sharp gasps, his hands fisting in my jacket, his head thrown back against the wall as he chases the pleasure I'm giving him.

And then, just as he's about to fall apart, I pull my hand away.

The sound he makes is almost wounded, a broken cry of denial that echoes through the study. His eyes fly open, wild and unfocused, his hips

still rocking forward into empty air like his body hasn't caught up with the loss of sensation.

"Good boys get to come, Elliot." I release his throat and take a step back, straightening my jacket. "Bad ones suffer the consequences."

"Please." Tears gather in the corners of his eyes, his voice cracking with despair. "Please, I'll be good, I'll ask next time, I promise."

"I know you will." I reach out and cup his jaw, tilting his face up toward mine. "Because every part of you is mine now. You agreed to it. Even that thing between your legs." I let my thumb trace across his lower lip, watching him shiver at the contact. "Maybe if you're a good boy, I'll even get on my knees for you someday. But that's a privilege you haven't earned yet."

I release him and turn away, leaving him slumped against the wall with his chest heaving and his erection straining against his pants. The sight of him like that, wrecked and wanting and completely at my mercy, makes me want to forget about my plans for the evening and spend the rest of the night taking him apart piece by piece.

But Marcus Vance is waiting, and I have a promise to keep.

"I expect you to follow your schedule while I'm gone." I pause at the door, looking back over my shoulder at the beautiful mess I've made of my brother. "And Elliot? If I find out you touched yourself while I was away, the consequences will be severe. Is that understood?"

He nods, his voice too wrecked to form words.

"I need to hear you say it."

"Yes, sir." The words come out hoarse, barely more than a whisper. "I understand."

"Good boy."

“Thank you, sir.”

I leave him there, trembling against the wall, and make my way out of the estate with a smile curving my lips. Tonight, Marcus Vance will learn exactly what happens to people who hurt what belongs to me. And tomorrow, Elliot will learn what it means to be rewarded for his obedience.

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Malakai

Stopping by my bedroom, I pause by the small table just beside the bed, staring at the bottom drawer. The one I keep locked. The one I've never let anyone see inside, not even Mrs. Callahan, or the cleaning staff. Not a single soul in the years has been in that drawer since I put what's inside there.

But the way Elliot looked at me just now... the way he knelt for me earlier... *It's time.*

My fingers find the small key I keep on my keyring, the one that looks like it belongs to a safety deposit box, and I slide it into the lock. The drawer opens smoothly, revealing the black velvet box nestled among papers I'll never need to reference.

I bought the collar in Rome three years ago from a small shop near the Piazza Navona, tucked down an alley that most tourists would never find,

run by an old man whose family had been crafting leather goods for five generations. I told myself it was an impulse purchase, merely a curiosity, something that caught my eye and nothing more.

That was a lie, and I knew it even then.

I knew exactly whose throat this collar was meant for. I knew the precise measurement because I'd memorized the circumference of Elliot's neck years before and filed it away in the part of my brain that catalogs everything about him. I knew the way the black leather would contrast against his pale skin, the way the small silver buckle would catch the dim light of my room when he tilted his head, and the way his pulse would flutter beneath the supple band when I fastened it into place.

I've imagined it more times than I should admit. Late at night, alone in my bed, I've pictured Elliot kneeling at my feet with this collar around his throat and my name on his lips. I've stroked myself to the fantasy of him wearing nothing but this strip of leather, his eyes soft and hazy with submission, his body offered up to me without reservation.

Three years I've waited. Three years of watching him date other people, knowing none of them could give him what he needed. Three years of biding my time, keeping this collar locked away like a promise I wasn't sure I'd ever get to keep.

Now he's home. Now he's agreed to be mine. Now there's nothing standing between us except the few hours it will take me to deal with Marcus Vance.

I lift the box from the drawer and flip it open, running my thumb across the inside of the leather. It's still as soft as the day I bought it, preserved perfectly in the darkness, waiting for its owner.

Tonight, Elliot will wear my collar.

And nothing will ever be the same.

I slip the box into my jacket pocket and head out the door.



The drive to Hartford takes forty minutes, giving me plenty of time to review what I know about Marcus Vance's new routine. He's been in Connecticut for two weeks now, settling into his sublet apartment and his adjunct position like he's planning to stay a while. Like he's waiting for something.

Or someone.

He spends most of his evenings at a dive bar three blocks from his building, a shabby little place called The Rusty Nail that caters to locals and college kids looking for cheap beer. Not exactly the sophisticated Manhattan scene he was used to, but I suppose stalking your ex-boyfriend across the country requires certain sacrifices.

Which is exactly where I find him, nursing a whiskey at the end of the bar like he doesn't have a care in the world. Like he didn't spend months terrorizing my brother, leaving bruises on his skin and scars on his psyche. Like he didn't show up at Elliot's apartment and beat him badly enough to send him fleeing across the country.

I take a seat two stools down and order a bourbon I have no intention of drinking. Marcus doesn't even glance in my direction, too absorbed in his phone to notice the predator that's just walked into his territory.

I study him while I wait, cataloging his features with a sort of detachment I've perfected over the years. He's handsome enough, I suppose, with dark hair and a sharp jaw and the kind of easy confidence that comes from never having faced real consequences for his actions. I can see why Elliot was

drawn to him initially. There's a charm beneath the cruelty, and that makes me hate him even more.

"Marcus Vance?"

He looks up at the sound of his name, his brow furrowing with confusion.

"Do I know you?"

"No." I smile, though it doesn't reach my eyes. "But you know my brother."

The color drains from his face as recognition dawns on him. I still look enough like Elliot even if I am a bit taller, and more filled out. Though, if Marcus is as obsessed with Elliot as I think he is, then he's seen pictures by stalking Elliot's social media the way bastards like him do, cataloging every detail of his life including the twin brother who looks just like him but carries himself like a completely different species.

"I don't want any trouble." He slides off his barstool, his eyes darting toward the exit. "Look, whatever Elliot told you, it wasn't like that. He's unstable, he exaggerates everything, and you can't believe what he says."

"I believe him." I stand as well, blocking his path to the door. "I believe the bruises I saw on his body. I believe the fear in his eyes when he talks about you. I believe every word he told me about the way you isolated him, controlled him, and beat him when he didn't comply with your demands."

"That's bullshit." His voice rises, drawing glances from the other patrons. "I never laid a hand on him. He's lying. He's a fucking liar! And if you believe his sob story then you're as crazy as he is."

My smile widens. "I was hoping you'd say something like that."

Marcus tries to run the moment he realizes I'm not here to make nice and the fact that I am *not* anything like my brother, shoving past me toward the exit with a desperation that tells me everything I need to know about his

guilt. I let him get three steps before my hand closes around the back of his neck, fingers digging into the soft flesh hard enough to bruise.

"We're going to have a conversation." I keep my voice as pleasant as I can with the kind of tone that makes the bartender glance over and then quickly look away. "You can walk out of here with me like a civilized person, or I can drag you out. Your choice."

He struggles for a moment, his hands coming up to claw at my grip, but I've got six inches and forty pounds of muscle on him. When I steer him toward the back exit, he stumbles along without further protest, his breath coming in sharp, panicked gasps.

The alley behind the bar is dark and narrow, reeking of garbage and stale beer. A single flickering light illuminates the space near the dumpster, casting long shadows across the cracked concrete. I shove Marcus forward, watching him stumble and catch himself against the grimy brick wall.

"Please." He turns to face me, his hands raised in supplication. "Whatever Elliot told you, it's not true. Your brother really is fucking crazy. He probably hurt himself just to get attention and blame it on me."

The words barely register before my fist connects with his jaw.

The impact sends him reeling, his head snapping to the side with a satisfying crack. He crashes into the wall and slides down, his legs giving out beneath him. I'm on him before he can recover. My hand fists in the front of his shirt, hauling him up just enough that I can see the terror blooming in his eyes.

"That's for calling him a liar." I hit him again, this time in the stomach, and he doubles over with a retching gasp. "And that's for every time you made him think he was crazy."

"Stop, please, I'm sorry, I'm sorry—"

"You're sorry?" I release his shirt and let him crumple to the ground, watching him curl in on himself like the pathetic creature he is. "You spent months isolating him from everyone who cared about him. You convinced him that he was worthless, that no one would believe him, that he deserved everything you did to him. And now you're sorry?"

I crouch down beside him, grabbing a fistful of his hair and wrenching his head back so he's forced to look at me. Blood is already streaming from his nose, painting his lips and chin in crimson streaks, tears gathering in the corners of his eyes.

"I saw the bruises." My voice comes out deadly calm, which seems to frighten him more than shouting would. "I saw the fingerprints on his arms where you grabbed him. I saw the marks on his ribs where you hurt him. I saw every single piece of evidence that you left on his body, and I memorized it, because I wanted to make sure I returned the favor."

My fist connects with his ribs in the same spot where Elliot's bruises were darkest. He screams, the sound echoing off the alley walls, and then I clamp my hand over his mouth to muffle it.

"Quiet." I wait until his screaming subsides into muffled whimpers before I continue. "You're going to listen to me very carefully, Marcus, because I'm only going to say this once."

He nods frantically, his eyes wide and wet above my hand.

"Elliot Ashford is *mine*." I let the words sink in, watching comprehension flicker through the pain in his expression. "He belongs to me. Not to you, not to anyone else. *Mine*. And I protect what's mine. Touch him again and I'll make tonight feel like a warm-up. "

I release his mouth and stand, looking down at the broken mess of a man huddled at my feet. He's shaking uncontrollably, his breath coming in

hitching sobs, a wet stain spreading across the front of his pants that tells me I've made my point.

"You're a sick fuck." The words come out garbled through the blood in his mouth, but I hear them clearly enough. "He's your brother. Your own fucking brother. You're disgusting, you know that? You're worse than I ever was."

My foot connects with his stomach before he can say another word, the air rushing out of him in a satisfying whoosh. He curls in on himself, gagging and retching, and I wait until he's finished before I crouch down and grab his jaw, forcing his face toward mine.

"I might be a sick fuck." My voice comes out raw, shaking with a rage I'm no longer trying to contain. "But at least I don't hurt what's mine."

I release him and straighten up, brushing off my hands as he continues to gasp and choke at my feet.

"You followed him here." I continue as I examine my bloody knuckles. "You thought you could keep stalking him and terrorizing him, and no one would stop you. But I'm not no one, Marcus. I'm the person who will end your miserable existence if you ever come near my brother again."

"I won't." The words tumble out of him in a desperate rush, slurred by the blood filling his mouth. "I swear, I won't, I'll leave him alone, I'll go back to California, I'll never contact him again, please just let me go."

"You'll do more than that." I crouch down again, getting right in his face so he can see the absolute sincerity in my eyes. "You're going to delete every photo you have of him, every text message, every email. You're going to block his number and forget it exists. You're going to pretend that Elliot Ashford was nothing more than a fever dream, and if his name ever so

much as crosses your mind, you're going to remember this moment and think better of it."

He nods so hard I'm surprised his neck doesn't snap. I know he'll try something stupid in the next week or so, just to test the waters but I'll end him when he does.

"And if I ever find out you've tried to contact him, if I hear so much as a whisper that you've been asking about him or looking for him or thinking about trying your luck again, I will come back." I grip his chin, forcing his battered face toward mine. "And next time, they won't find enough of you to identify."

The threat hangs in the air between us, Marcus' loud sobs, tears and blood and snot mixing together on his ruined face, filling me with a satisfaction so profound it borders on euphoric. This is what happens to people who hurt what belongs to me. This is the price of touching my brother.

I stand for the final time, managing a smile despite how much I want to just stomp his face right here and now. But what fun is it to completely end a man who I can have a little deadly fun with later? "Have a nice evening, Marcus."

He doesn't say anything as I climb back into my car and head back home, realizing just how bad this could have gone had I not entered Elliot's room the other night.

Forty minutes. That's how close Marcus was to Elliot this whole time. Forty minutes and a monster's worth of obsession. He won't be a problem anymore.

My knuckles ache where they split against Marcus's face, but it's a good kind of pain. The kind that reminds me I did something worthwhile.

I pull into the garage just before midnight and make my way inside, my footsteps echoing through the silent halls. The house is dark except for a single light glowing from Elliot's room, and I feel a surge of satisfaction knowing he's still awake, waiting for me, just like I told him to.

He's sitting up in bed when I appear in his doorway, his eyes going wide as he takes in my appearance. I probably look a mess, my jacket rumpled and my hair disheveled and my knuckles crusted with blood that isn't mine.

"It's done." I push out as his gaze drops to my hands. "He won't bother you again."

"What did you do?" The question comes out breathless, his eyes fixed on the evidence of violence painted across my skin.

"What I said I would." I examine my knuckles with distant interest, flexing my fingers to test the damage. "You don't need the details."

I watch the emotions play across his face, fear and relief and something else that makes my blood run hot. He's not horrified by what I've done. He's grateful. Maybe even aroused, if the way his breathing has quickened is any indication.

Good. He should understand exactly what I'm capable of when it comes to protecting him.

I cross the room and stop at the edge of his bed, reaching down to run the back of my hand across his face. The blood on my knuckles smears across his cheek, but neither of us moves to wipe it away.

"You're mine to protect." My voice drops lower, a register meant only for him. "Mine to keep safe. Do you understand?"

"Yes, sir." The words come out shaky, his eyes glistening with unshed tears. "I understand."

I reach into my jacket pocket and my fingers close around the velvet box that's been burning a hole against my chest all evening. "I have something for you."

Elliot's eyes track my movements as I pull out the box and hold it between us. His brow furrows slightly, confusion flickering across his features, and I have to fight to keep my expression neutral even as my heart pounds against my ribs. Three years I've waited for this moment. Three years of imagining his face when he sees what I've kept hidden away for him.

I flip open the lid.

The collar sits nestled in black tissue paper, and I watch Elliot's face as recognition dawns. His lips part, his breath catching audibly in the quiet room as his eyes go wide, darting from the collar to my face and back again.

"Malakai, that's a..." He trails off, unable or unwilling to finish the sentence.

"A collar. Yes." I keep my voice steady even as arousal pulses hot through my veins, my cock already stirring at the sight of him staring at the leather that will soon circle his throat. "You'll wear this when we're alone. A reminder of who you belong to."

"I don't..." He shakes his head, pulling back slightly against the headboard. "That's not something I've ever done before. I'm not sure I can —"

"You can." I cut him off gently but there's an undercurrent of need that moves through my tone against my permission. "You knelt for me, Elliot. You begged me for help. You agreed to follow my rules, to let me make decisions for you, to belong to me completely." I lift the collar from the

box, letting him see the full thing in all its glory. "This is simply an extension of that agreement. A physical symbol of your submission."

"But wearing a collar makes it so..." He swallows hard, his throat bobbing. "Real. *Permanent*."

"It is real. It is permanent." I set the box aside and move closer to the bed, the collar dangling from my fingers. "At least, it will be for as long as you're mine. And you are mine, little doe. This just makes it visible."

He's trembling now, his chest rising and falling with shallow breaths, and I can see the war playing out behind his eyes. Part of him wants to refuse, to cling to whatever shred of independence he thinks he has left. But another part, the part that knelt for me so sweetly last night and melted beneath my hands this afternoon, that part wants this as badly as I do.

I just need to give him permission to accept it.

"The collar stays between us." I lower myself to sit on the edge of the bed, close enough that my thigh presses against his hip through the blankets. "You'll wear it when we're alone in this house, and you'll remove it when we're around others. No one else needs to know what happens within these walls."

"And if I say no?" His voice comes out thin, wavering. "If I tell you I can't do this?"

"Then you say no, and I put the collar away." I hold his gaze, letting him see that I mean every word even as my blood burns with the need to fasten the leather around his throat right now, to see my fantasy finally made flesh. "I told you before, Elliot. You can always refuse. But I think we both know that's not what you want."

The silence stretches between us, thick with tension and unspoken desires. I watch him wrestle with himself, his fingers twisting in the sheets, his

lower lip caught between his teeth. My cock throbs in my pants, painfully hard at the anticipation of what's about to happen, but I force myself to wait. This has to be his choice. It won't mean anything if I don't let him come to it on his own.

"Okay." The word comes out barely above a whisper, so quiet I almost miss it.

"Okay what?" I need to hear him say it properly. I need the words to carry me through every moment that comes after.

"Okay, I'll..." He takes a shaky breath, his eyes dropping to the collar in my hands. "I'll wear it. I want to wear it."

The relief that floods through me is staggering, followed immediately by a wave of possessive triumph so intense it takes everything I have not to pin him to the bed and claim him in every way possible. Instead, I hold onto my self-control, savoring every second of this moment I've imagined countless times.

"Look at me."

His eyes lift to mine, wide and vulnerable and so fucking beautiful.

"Tilt your head back."

He obeys, his chin lifting to expose the long pale column of his throat, and the trust in that gesture nearly undoes me. My hands shake slightly as I reach for him, and I have to pause for a moment to steady myself. I've waited three years for this. I can wait three more seconds to make sure I do it right.

Elliot shivers as the leather makes contact with his skin. I wrap it around his throat slowly, letting my fingers brush against his pulse point and feeling the way his heart races beneath my touch. The buckle fastens at the back with a soft click, sending a soft echo through the silence.

I pull back to look at him, and the sight steals the breath from my lungs.

The collar is snug against his throat, not tight enough to restrict but firm enough that he'll feel it with every swallow, every breath, and every turn of his head. The black leather stands out against his pale skin as I twist it around, the small silver buckle shining in the low light like a secret meant only for us.

He looks exactly like I imagined. Better than I imagined. I reach down to adjust myself, giving my cock a squeeze to keep from doing anything stupid. Elliot lets out a soft sound, his eyes hazing over a little as he meets my gaze, those gorgeous lips parted for me. It's almost as if this moment has unlocked another step for the both of us, my need for his submission and his need to let go.

Jesus Christ, I could come right fucking now just staring at his face.

"How does it feel?" My voice comes out rougher than I intend, betraying more of my arousal than I'd like.

His hand drifts up slowly, fingers trembling as they brush against the leather. He softly traces the edge of it, his expression shifting from uncertainty to wonder to something that looks almost like peace.

"It feels..." He swallows, the collar moving with the motion of his throat. "It feels like it belongs there. Like I've been waiting for it without knowing what I was waiting for."

"You have been waiting, doe." I reach out and cup his jaw, tilting his face up toward mine. The blood from my knuckles has started drying to a rusty brown, and I smear a fresh streak across his cheekbone without thinking, marking him in yet another way. "You've been waiting your whole life, little doe. And now the wait is over."

"Thank you, sir." The words catch in his throat, thick with emotion.
"Thank you."

I lean back and survey my work, drinking in the sight of him. Collared and marked and trembling with a need that mirrors my own. The fantasy I've carried for three years made real in this bedroom. My hand travels down to the silver buckle, pulling the small ring that was flipped up before. I slip a finger through the loop and gently tug forward, Elliot letting out a soft moan of need.

God, he's fucking perfect.

"Thank you, sir."

I raise an eyebrow, realizing I said that last part aloud, a deviant grin sliding over my lips. "Don't thank me yet, little doe. You haven't started paying your debt."



Elliot

The first thing I do when I wake up the next morning is reach for my phone. It's a barely conscious movement, my fingers closing around the device before my eyes are fully open. The screen glows too bright in the darkness of my room as I squint at the time. 6:47 AM.

Thirteen minutes before my alarm would have gone off, but my body seems to somehow have internalized the new schedule already, dragging me from sleep with an urgency that has nothing to do with rest. I type out the message with clumsy fingers, my heart already beating faster than it should.

I'm awake, sir.

The response comes within seconds, as if Malakai was waiting for it. As if he's been lying in his own bed, phone in hand, counting the minutes until I checked in.

Good boy. Collar on, then kneel for five minutes. You may shower and dress after. Breakfast at 7:30.

Good boy. Two words, and my whole body flushes with warmth. I hate how much I like hearing that. I hate how much I've come to crave it in just two days.

I push myself out of bed and pad across the cold hardwood to my dresser, where the collar sits waiting on top for me. The leather is still as soft beneath my fingers as it was yesterday, supple from the oils Malakai used to treat it. I still remember the way his hands looked when he fastened it around my throat for the first time, the barely contained hunger in his eyes while blood was still drying on his knuckles from whatever he did to Marcus.

I shouldn't find that memory comforting. I shouldn't feel safer knowing my brother beat a man bloody for me.

But I do.

Blowing out a small breath, I wrap the leather around my neck and reach back to fasten it. It takes a few tries, frustrating me every time the clasp slips until I swivel around and do it up beneath my chin. It's snug but not tight, just present enough that I feel it with every swallow, every breath, a constant reminder of who I now belong to.

I'm not even sure *why* I'm doing all of this. A few days ago, I was running home, terrified of what I found and now I'm here, willingly giving into my brother. Like, I could just... *not* but the absolute peace I get from following his commands and the giddiness that follows when I please him... it's not normal, I'm aware.

But fuck, it feels so good.

I sink to my knees beside my bed, positioning myself the way Malakai taught me. Knees apart, hands on my thighs with the palms facing up, back straight, eyes down. The posture felt awkward and uncomfortable the first time I tried it, my muscles protesting the unfamiliar position, but now my body slides into it almost automatically.

Five minutes. That's all I have to do. Five minutes of stillness, of silence, of letting my mind settle before the day begins.

The first minute is the hardest. My thoughts race, cataloging everything I need to do, everything I'm afraid of, everything that could go wrong. But somewhere around the third minute, the chaos starts to quiet. By the fifth minute, there's nothing but the sound of my own breathing and the steady pressure of the collar against my throat.

When my phone buzzes with the timer I set, I almost don't want to get up, some part of me imagining Malakai caressing my jaw. He would tell me how good I am and I would thank him, the fantasy slowly morphing into something else as my lips part in anticipation of...

Fuck. No. Shit.

The shower is hot and quick as I try to stuff that fantasy back where it fucking came from, my gaze tracking to a new pair of dress clothes neatly folded by the door. That wasn't there ten minutes ago which means Malakai has been in here, no doubt ensuring that I was following his rules.

"Did he see me in the shower?" I ask myself, twisting back to look at the open bathroom door and then back at the clothing. Heat creeps up my neck, the collar suddenly feeling a little too tight as my cock stiffens beneath the towel. *Shit. Shit. Shit! Spiders. Grandma. Marcus.*

That has the opposite reaction I want, the peace from kneeling for five minutes completely dashed by the memories of that man's hands on me.

"Well, that sucks," I mutter before pulling on the clothes left for me, surprised how well they fit. They're still a little too big but it shows off my body shape, revealing more of me than I'd like. The gray trousers are soft and the fitted black sweater is nicer than anything I would have chosen for myself. I run my fingers over the fabric, wondering why he picked these specific pieces, what statement he's trying to make by dressing me like a doll he's preparing to display.

I make my way downstairs at exactly 7:28, giving myself two minutes to settle into my seat before Malakai arrives. But when I reach the dining room, he's already there, seated at the head of the table with a cup of coffee and his tablet, looking like he's been awake for hours.

Is he ever not awake before me?

"Good morning, little doe." He doesn't look up from his screen, but I can feel his attention on me. "Sit."

I take my place at his right and stare at the spread of food in front of me. Toast, eggs, fresh fruit, and a pot of tea already steeping. My stomach growls, reminding me that I barely ate dinner last night, too nervous and unsettled to manage more than a few bites.

But I don't reach for anything. I wait.

The silence stretches, Malakai's gaze shifting to me even though I'm not looking at his face. He's testing me, I realize. Seeing if I'll remember the rules without being prompted.

"May I eat, sir?"

"You may."

The permission settles over me like a balm as I reach for the toast. The first bite is almost painful, my stomach clenching around the food like it's

forgotten how to process sustenance, but I force myself to chew and swallow.

"All of it." Malakai's voice cuts through my thoughts. "You need to rebuild your strength. I won't have you collapsing because you're too anxious to feed yourself properly."

"Yes, sir."

I eat mechanically, working my way through the eggs and toast and fruit until my plate is clean. It's more food than I've consumed in a single sitting in weeks. My stomach protests the sudden abundance, but I don't complain. The thought of disappointing him makes my stomach clench harder than the food does.

When I'm finished, I set down my fork and wait.

"Good boy." The praise washes over me, my shoulders relaxing slightly. "Now tell me what you ate."

The command seems weird but I comply anyway. "Toast with butter. Scrambled eggs. Strawberries and melon. Two cups of tea."

"How do you feel?"

The question catches me off guard. I expected him to move on, to dismiss me or give me my next instruction, but instead he's watching me with those gray-green eyes that miss nothing.

"Full," I admit. "A little nauseous. But better than yesterday."

"The nausea will pass as your body adjusts to eating regularly again." He sets aside his tablet and gives me his full attention, the weight of his focus causing my breath to catch in my throat. "Today we're going to work on establishing your routine. I have meetings this morning, but I expect you to follow the schedule I've prepared. We'll reconvene for lunch at noon."

"Yes, sir." I hesitate, the question I've been wanting to ask burning on my tongue. "Malakai, I was wondering about the job. The position at Ashford Holdings you mentioned."

His expression doesn't change, but I sense a shift in the air between us. "What about it?"

"When do I start? I know you said you arranged something, and I'd like to know what to expect. I want to be useful and contribute, not just sit around the house all day waiting for you to tell me what to do."

The words come out harsher than I meant to, a flash of the old defiance surfacing before I can suppress it. Malakai's eyes narrow slightly as I brace myself for his withdrawal. But instead, he leans forward and rests his forearms on the table, bringing his face closer to mine.

"You're not ready."

"What do you mean I'm not ready? I was getting my degree, I have skills, I can—"

"Elliot." My name cuts through my protests, and I fall silent immediately. "You came home days ago covered in bruises, barely able to eat or sleep, and flinching at every sudden movement. You're in no condition to handle the pressure of a corporate environment, and I won't set you up to fail by throwing you into work before you've had time to heal."

"But I feel fine. I feel better than I have in months."

"Because I'm taking care of you." His voice softens slightly, but the steel beneath it remains. "Because you're following my rules and letting me carry the weight you've been struggling under alone. That's not the same as being healed, little doe. That's just the beginning."

I want to argue and tell him he's wrong, that I'm capable of more than he thinks, and that I don't need to be coddled and protected and managed like a

child. But the words die in my throat because some part of me knows he's right.

I'm barely holding myself together, and the only reason I've managed even that much is because Malakai has been there to catch me every time I start to fall.

"When will I be ready?" My voice comes out just above a whisper.

"When I say you are." He reaches across the table and cups my jaw in his hand, tilting my face up toward his. "Trust me, Elliot. I know what you need better than you do right now. The job will be there when you're strong enough to handle it. Until then, your only responsibility is to follow my rules and let me take care of you."

"Yes, sir." The words come out automatically, some of the tension draining from my body at the familiar surrender.

"Good boy." His thumb strokes across my cheekbone, and I lean into the touch without meaning to. "Now go to the study and wait for me. Kneel by my desk. I'll join you after my first meeting."

I stand on unsteady legs and make my way out of the dining room, hyperaware of the collar around my throat and the lingering warmth of Malakai's hand on my face. The study is quiet when I enter, the heavy curtains still drawn against the morning light as I cross to his desk and lower myself to my knees without hesitation.

The moment I hit the floor, it's almost as if my body immediately accepts what I'm trying to push back against. *Malakai knows me*. That familiar peace washes over me as I wait, though my mind drifts a little. My phone buzzes in my pocket but I hesitate to pull it out.

Malakai didn't say I could, and even though checking the time seems harmless enough, I find myself unwilling to risk his disapproval over

something so small.

When did that happen? When did his opinion start mattering more than my own comfort?

The question circles through my mind as I continue to kneel, my knees beginning to ache against the hard floor. I try to remember what I was like before Marcus, before the relationship that broke me down into something so desperate. I try to remember a time when I didn't crave structure and rules and someone else's hand on the reins of my life.

I can't.

Maybe Malakai is right. Maybe I was made for this. Maybe the only thing that's been wrong all along is my insistence on fighting against my own nature.

Footsteps in the hallway pull me from my thoughts, and I straighten my spine as the door opens. Malakai enters the study, and even though I can't see his face from my position on the floor, I feel his gaze sweep over me. "Look at you being such a good boy for me in that position," he purrs, the note of approval making my chest bloom with warmth.

He crosses to the desk and settles into his chair, close enough that his knee brushes against my shoulder. The contact sends a jolt through my body, and I have to fight to keep my breathing steady.

"You may relax your posture while I work." His hand drops to the back of my neck, fingers curling around the back of my collar as his fingers brush the hair just hanging over the leather. "But you stay here, at my feet, until I tell you otherwise."

"Yes, sir."

I let my spine curve slightly, easing the strain in my lower back, but I don't move away from the warmth of his leg against my shoulder. The

sound of his fingers on the keyboard fills the silence, punctuated by the occasional rustle of papers, and I find myself drifting into a strange, peaceful state that hovers somewhere between sleep and wakefulness.

Time loses meaning. There's only the rhythm of Malakai's work, the steady pressure of his hand on my neck, and the quiet of my own mind.

At some point, his hand moves from my collar to my hair, fingers carding through the strands in slow, repetitive strokes that make my eyes flutter closed. The touch is gentle, almost absent-minded, like he's petting a cat curled at his feet.

I should be humiliated by that comparison. Instead, I arch into his hand, chasing the sensation, wanting more.

"You're doing so well." His voice comes out soft, barely above a murmur. "So much better than I expected for your first real day."

"Thank you, sir." The words slur slightly, my tongue thick and clumsy in my mouth.

"How does it feel? Being here, like this?"

I consider the question, searching for the right words through the haze that's settled over my thoughts. "Quiet," I finally say. "My head feels quiet. It's never quiet, not usually. There's always noise and worrying, always what if what if what if. But right now there's just this. Just you."

His hand stills in my hair, and I feel him shift above me. When I open my eyes and tilt my head back, he's looking down at me with an expression I don't really know how to process. It's full of hunger, yes, the same hunger I've seen since the first night I came home. But beneath it, there's something softer. Something that looks almost like wonder.

"That's what submission can give you." His thumb traces along my hairline, a shiver running down my spine at the sensation. "Silence. Peace.

A place where you don't have to think, don't have to decide, and don't have to be anything except mine."

The word settles into my bones, my cock stirring against my thigh in response. *Not now*, I think desperately. *Please not now*.

But my body doesn't listen. The arousal builds with every stroke of Malakai's fingers through my hair, every brush of his knee against my shoulder, every soft word of praise that falls from his lips. By the time he returns his attention to his work, I'm half-hard and praying he doesn't notice.

Of course he notices.

"Elliot." His voice is calm, almost casual. "Are you hard right now?"

My face flames. "I'm sorry, sir. I didn't mean to, I can't help it, I—"

"I didn't ask for an apology. I asked a question."

I swallow hard, my throat working against the collar. "Yes, sir. I'm hard."

"Because of this?" His hand tightens in my hair, pulling my head back further until I'm forced to look directly up at him. "Because of kneeling at my feet while I work? Because of my hand in your hair?"

"Yes, sir." The admission burns, but I can't lie to him. I've never been able to lie to him, even before all of this.

"Good." He releases my hair and turns back to his computer, the loss of contact feeling almost like dismissal. I hate it. "That's exactly how it should be."

I wait for him to do something, to acknowledge my arousal, to give me permission to touch myself or tell me to make it go away. But he just keeps typing, his attention fixed on the screen like I'm not kneeling beside him with my cock straining against my pants.

The waiting is its own kind of torture.

Minutes pass. My erection doesn't flag, fed by the constant awareness of Malakai's presence, the leather around my throat, and the lingering sensation of his fingers in my hair. I shift slightly, trying to find a position that doesn't press my pants so tightly against my aching flesh, Malakai making a small sound of amusement.

"Uncomfortable?"

"Yes, sir."

"Good." He still doesn't look at me. "That discomfort is a reminder. Your pleasure belongs to me now, Elliot. You don't get to come or touch yourself or even get to seek relief without my explicit permission. The sooner you accept that, the easier this will be."

My cock stiffens a little more, my mind intrigued that I don't even have control over my own pleasure.

Fucking hell.

I like belonging to my brother, and I don't know what that makes me.

The morning stretches on, Malakai working while I kneel beside him, my arousal ebbing and flowing with the rhythm of his attention. When he ignores me, the absence of his focus makes me ache in ways that have nothing to do with my cock. When he reaches down to stroke my hair or squeeze the back of my neck, each touch sends sparks cascading through my body until I'm trembling with the effort of holding still.

Eventually, he pushes back from the desk and looks down at me. "It's time for lunch."

I blink, disoriented. The morning has vanished, swallowed whole by the strange timeless space of kneeling at his feet.

"You did well this morning." He rises from his chair and offers me his hand, helping me to my feet on legs that have gone stiff and numb. "I'm

proud of you, little doe."

The praise hits me like a drug, rushing through my bloodstream until I feel dizzy with it. I sway toward him without meaning to as he catches me with a hand on my hip, steadying me. For a moment we just stand there, his body warm and solid against mine, his hand burning against my flesh where his fingers have slipped beneath my shirt along my waist.

"Thank you, sir." My voice comes out hoarse. "Thank you."

"Come." He releases me and steps back. "Let's get some food in you. You'll need your strength for this afternoon."

I follow him to the dining room, my mind still floating somewhere outside my body. Lunch passes in a blur of asking permission, eating what I'm told, and reporting what I've consumed. The routine is a little easier the second time, the questions and answers falling into a rhythm that requires less and less conscious thought.

After we eat, Malakai leads me to the library, where he settles into an armchair with a stack of papers and gestures for me to kneel beside him. I sink down without hesitation, my body remembering the position even as my knees protest the return to hard floor.

"May I ask you something, sir?"

He glances down at me, one eyebrow raised. "You may."

"When you're not here, when you're in your meetings or working somewhere else in the house, what am I supposed to do?"

"Follow the schedule I gave you." His attention returns to his papers. "There's a list of approved activities on my desk. Reading, exercise, rest. You'll find ways to occupy yourself."

"But I have to ask permission before I do any of them?"

"Yes."

"Even if you're busy? Even if I have to wait for you to respond?"

"Yes." He sets down his papers and looks at me fully, the weight of his gaze pinning me in place. "That's the point, Elliot. You wait for me. You depend on me. You learn that your time, your activities, and your very existence revolves around my decisions. Is that a problem?"

I should tell him this is too much, too controlling, or maybe too extreme. But the words won't come, because some treacherous part of me doesn't want to say them.

"No, sir." I force the words out. "It's not a problem."

"Mmmm, you're perfect for me, aren't you, little doe?"

The afternoon unfolds slowly, each moment bleeding into the next. I kneel while Malakai reads. I ask permission to use the bathroom and wait, my bladder aching, until he looks up from his papers and grants it. I ask permission to stretch my legs when the cramping becomes unbearable, and he makes me wait five more minutes before he allows me to stand.

Each request chips away at my pride. Each granted permission fills the hollow space left behind with something warmer.

By the time evening arrives, I'm exhausted in a way that has nothing to do with physical exertion. My mind feels scraped raw, exposed, all my defenses worn away by hours of constant vigilance. When Malakai leads me to his study and points to the floor beside his chair, I sink to my knees with something that feels dangerously close to gratitude.

"You've been fighting yourself all day." His hand finds its place on the back of my neck along my collar as I melt into the touch. "I can see it. The tension in your shoulders, the way you hesitate before each request. You're still resisting, even as you obey."

"I'm trying, sir. I'm trying not to fight, but it's hard. I keep thinking about how wrong this is, how I shouldn't want it, and how there must be something broken in me to need this so badly."

"There's nothing broken in you." His grip tightens around my neck, a gasp falling from my lips at the sudden pressure. "You were made for this, Elliot. Made to serve, to submit, and to find peace in surrender. The only thing that's broken is the world that taught you to be ashamed of who you are."

I want to believe him and let go of the shame and the guilt and the constant voice in my head telling me I'm sick, and perverted, and wrong for craving my brother's control.

"Let go." His voice drops to a murmur. "Stop fighting. Just for tonight, let yourself have what you need."

And maybe it's the exhaustion, or the hours of submission wearing away my resistance, or simply the undeniable truth that I'm tired of fighting a battle I was never going to win. But something inside me finally, finally gives way.

I slump against his leg, my forehead pressing against his thigh, let out a breath I feel like I've been holding for years.

"Good boy." His hand strokes through my hair, gentle and reverent. "That's it, little doe. That's exactly right."

Kneeling at his feet, the collar warm around my throat and his hand in my hair and his praise washing over me, something shifts. For the first time since I can remember, I don't want to be anywhere else.



Malakai

The house settles into silence around midnight, the old bones of the estate creaking and groaning as they always do when the temperature drops. I'm still tucked away in my study, reviewing quarterly reports that don't require my attention but provide a convenient excuse to stay awake, when I hear it.

Footsteps. Soft, hesitant, padding down the hallway toward the kitchen.

I set aside my tablet and listen, tracking the sound as it moves through the house. Elliot's room is directly above mine, and I've memorized the particular rhythm of his movements over the past few days. The way he paces when he can't sleep. The creak of his mattress when he tosses and turns. The soft thud of his feet hitting the floor when he wakes up in the morning.

He's been doing well today. Better than I expected, honestly. The way he surrendered at my feet this evening, slumping against my leg, told me

something fundamental had shifted inside him. He's starting to accept what he is, what he needs, what I can give him.

But old habits die hard, and Elliot has spent a lifetime fighting against his own nature.

I wait until I hear the kitchen faucet turn on before I move, rising from my chair with the silent grace that years of martial arts training have instilled in me. The hallway is dark, lit only by the faint glow of moon through the windows as I navigate it from memory rather than sight.

The kitchen door is open, spilling a wedge of light across the hardwood floor. I pause just outside, letting my eyes adjust, taking in the scene before me.

Elliot is standing at the sink with his back to me, wearing nothing but a thin t-shirt and sleep pants that hang low on his hips. His hair is mussed from tossing in bed, and even from here I can see the tension in his shoulders, the rigid line of his spine. His hands are tightly wound around a glass of water as he takes large gulps, completely unaware of my presence.

He didn't ask permission.

The realization sends a pulse of something through my veins. Not anger, exactly. Something closer to anticipation. He's given me an opening, a reason to push him further, and I intend to take full advantage of it.

"Did you forget something, Elliot Aurelis?"

The glass slips from his fingers and shatters against the sink, water and shards of crystal spraying across the counter. Elliot whirls around, his eyes widening, his chest heaving as he sputters his next words.

"Malakai." My name comes out strangled, caught somewhere between relief and terror. "I didn't hear you."

"Clearly." I step into the kitchen, letting the door swing shut behind me with a soft click that. "Answer my question. Did you forget something?"

He stares at me for a long moment, realization dawning across his features. The color drains from his face, then rushes back in a flood of crimson that spreads from his cheeks down to his neck.

"I was just getting water." His voice comes out thin. "It's just water. I didn't think I needed to—"

"You didn't think." I close the distance between us with slow, measured steps, enjoying the way he shrinks back against the counter with each one. "That's the problem, isn't it, Elliot? You didn't think. You just acted, based on what you wanted, without considering the rules we established."

"It was one glass of water." A flash of defiance sparks in his eyes, the old stubbornness rearing its head. "I was thirsty. I couldn't sleep. I didn't want to wake you up over something so small."

"The size of the request is irrelevant." I stop directly in front of him, close enough that I can feel the heat radiating from his body, close enough to see his pulse jumping frantically in his throat. "The rules exist for a reason. You ask permission before you do anything. *Anything*. That includes getting out of bed in the middle of the night to get water."

"That's ridiculous." The words come out before he can stop them, instant regret flashing across his face. "I mean, I just... it seems excessive, don't you think?"

"I think you're standing in my kitchen at midnight, having broken one of my rules, and now you're arguing with me about whether or not those rules are fair." I lean in closer, bracing one hand on the counter beside his hip, caging him in. It's not even *my* kitchen but it might as well be for how often

Mom and Dad are away. "Does that seem like the behavior of someone who's learned their lesson?"

His breath catches, his throat working as he swallows. "No, sir."

"No. It doesn't." I straighten and take a step back, putting space between us that I can see he doesn't want. "On your knees."

He hesitates, glancing down at the floor. The kitchen tile is annoyingly cold this time of night, far colder than the hardwood in the study where he was kneeling all day. I see the calculation in his eyes, the brief flare of resistance as he continues to hesitate and some part of that pisses me off. We were doing so well earlier.

"Elliot." I let his name hang in the air, heavy with warning. "Don't make me repeat myself."

He drops to his knees.

The sound he makes when he hits the tile is somewhere between a gasp and a whimper, his whole body jerking at the shock of the cold. Ever so slowly, he settles into position, knees apart, hands on thighs, spine straight, satisfaction curling through me at how automatically he assumes the posture now.

"You know the rules." I move to lean against the opposite counter, crossing my arms over my chest as I look down at him. "Recite them for me."

His jaw tightens, but he complies. "I report to you when I wake up."

"And?"

"I put on the collar."

"And?"

"I kneel for five minutes before starting my day."

This continues for several minutes, each rule dragged out of him one by one while the cold of the tile seeps into his bones. The rules are new but he's completely memorized them, to my surprise. I can also see him starting to shiver, tiny tremors running through his frame that he's trying desperately to suppress. His knees must be aching by now, the hard ceramic unforgiving against his joints.

Good. Pain is an excellent teacher.

"What rule did you break tonight?" I ask when he's finished reciting.

"I left my room without permission." His voice has gone rough, stripped of the earlier defiance. "I got water without asking."

"And why is that a problem?"

He's quiet for a moment, his brow furrowing as he considers the question. "Because you told me to ask permission for everything."

"That's not why." I push off from the counter and cross the kitchen to stand over him, forcing him to crane his neck back to meet my eyes. "Try again."

"I don't understand." Frustration bleeds into his tone. "You told me to ask, and I didn't ask. Isn't that enough?"

"No." I crouch down so we're at eye level, a small gasp falling from his lips at my sudden proximity. "The rules aren't arbitrary, Elliot. They're not about control for the sake of control. They exist because you need them. Because your mind is too loud, too chaotic, and too full of anxiety and fear and second-guessing. The rules give you structure. They give you peace. And when you break them, you're not just disobeying me. You're denying yourself the very thing you came home looking for."

His eyes go wide, and I see the moment my words land. The moment understanding clicks into place behind those gray-green irises that mirror

my own.

"I broke the rules because I thought I knew better." His voice comes out barely above a whisper. "Because I decided what was important and what wasn't, instead of trusting you to make that decision for me."

"Yes." I reach out and cup his jaw in my hand, tilting his face up further. His skin is cold against my palm, chilled from the air and the fear that's been running through his system since I caught him. "And what does that tell you?"

"That I'm not as far along as I thought I was." A shudder runs through him. "That I'm still fighting, even when I think I've stopped."

For a moment, I just stand there looking into my brother's eyes. I had no idea he would submit so easily or that he would even want to. For sure, I thought there would be more back and forth, a little bit of shouting, lots of slamming doors, maybe even just general push back. But he just... melts so easily.

"Very good." I stroke my thumb across his cheekbone as he leans into the touch with a desperation that makes heat pulse through my cock. "Now. You're going to kneel here and recite the rules again. All of them. From the beginning. And you're going to keep reciting them until I tell you to stop."

"Yes, sir."

I release his jaw and straighten, turning my back on him to busy myself with making a pot of tea. I don't even really fucking like tea but the patience that comes with waiting for the water to boil and steeping the loose leaves in the cup make it worth it. That and the fact that having a cup of coffee this late will ruin my nonexistent sleep schedule.

The broken glass still glitters in the sink, shards scattered across the counter, but I leave it for now. Let him kneel there surrounded by the

evidence of his mistake while I go about mundane tasks, showing him that his punishment is secondary to my own comfort.

The kettle fills with water. The burner clicks on. And behind me, Elliot's voice rises and falls in a steady rhythm.

"I report to you when I wake up. I put on the collar. I kneel for five minutes before starting my day. I ask permission before eating. I report what I ate when I'm finished..."

The list goes on, the soothing cadence of my brother's voice falling into the background. My tea steeps while he recites, a smile creeping onto my lips as the kettle begins to whistle. *He's still going?* Surely, I thought he would stop or at least ask if he could be done. After all, he only came down here for a glass of water.

But no, Elliot obeys so perfectly. He really is a dream come true.

I ready the several parts to my tea including a spoonful of honey before turning back around to lean against the counter, sipping the Earl Grey as I watch my brother. His voice grows hoarse as the minutes stretch on, cracking on certain words, but he doesn't stop. He doesn't beg for mercy or try to argue. He just keeps going, over and over, the rules becoming a kind of meditation.

The tension drains from his shoulders as the repetition does its work. His breathing slows and deepens, his body relaxing into the position despite the cold and the ache. I suspected this might have that effect but I wasn't entirely sure. Elliot doesn't need gentleness or coddling, but the firm hand of discipline showing him exactly where the boundaries lie.

It's beautiful.

Fifteen minutes pass. Then twenty. I'm on my second cup of tea when the shift in his posture becomes apparent, the way his hips have started to cant

forward slightly, his thighs pressing together in a way that speaks to a very specific kind of discomfort.

He's hard.

The realization sends a bolt of arousal through my own body, my cock stirring in my pants at the sight of my brother on his knees, shivering and aching and rock hard from nothing more than reciting rules in my kitchen.

I set down my tea and cross to stand in front of him, looking down at the obvious bulge tenting his thin sleep pants. He's stopped reciting, his voice trailing off mid-sentence as he registers my proximity, his face flushing an even deeper shade of crimson.

"Don't stop on my account." I let my voice drop a few octaves. "You were doing so well."

"I..." He swallows hard, his eyes fixed on the floor. "I can't concentrate."

"Because of this?" I nudge his knee with my foot, and he whimpers at even that slight contact. "Because you're hard?"

"Yes, sir." Humiliation coats those two words, sending a thrill through me.

"Look at me."

He raises his eyes slowly, and the desperation there makes my cock twitch. His pupils are blown wide, his lips parted and trembling, his whole body vibrating with a need he doesn't know how to process.

"Did I give you permission to get aroused?"

"No, sir."

"Did I give you permission to stop reciting your rules?"

"No, sir."

"Then why did you stop?"

He doesn't have an answer. He just stares up at me with those wide, pleading eyes, silently begging for something he can't bring himself to ask

for.

I crouch down again, bringing my face level with his, and grip his chin. "You're beautiful like this, you know. You're desperate and needy and completely at my mercy." I turn his face from side to side, inspecting him like a prize I've won. "I could keep you here all night. Make you recite those rules until you're sobbing. Until your knees are bruised and your voice is gone and you can't think about anything except how badly you need to come."

A choked sound escapes his throat, somewhere between a moan and a sob.

"Would you like that?" I tighten my grip, forcing his chin up higher. "Would you like me to use you until you break?"

"I don't know." The words come out ragged, torn from somewhere deep inside him. "I don't know what I want. I just... I need..."

"You need what? Tell me."

His hand moves before I can stop it, reaching down toward his straining cock like it has a will of its own. He catches himself at the last second, fingers hovering just above the fabric, before looking up at me with an expression of pure torment.

"Please," he whispers. "Please, I need to touch myself. I can't stand it."

A slow smile spreads across my face, his eyes widening at whatever he sees in my expression. "You want to touch yourself, little doe? You want to make yourself come right here on my kitchen floor?"

"Yes." The word comes out as a plea. "Please, sir. Please let me."

I consider him for a long moment as he squirms under my gaze. Then I release his chin and stand, my eyes flicking to the broken glass still scattered in the sink.

"Alright." I turn and walk toward the cabinet where we keep the cleaning supplies. "You have two minutes. I need to clean up the mess you made. By the time I'm finished, you either come, or you don't come at all."

His face goes slack with shock. "Two minutes? That's not enough time. I can't possibly—"

"Then I suggest you stop wasting it by arguing with me." I pull open the cabinet door, keeping my back to him. "Clock's ticking, Elliot."

I hear the rustle of fabric, followed by a sharp intake of breath.

"No." I don't turn around. "If you're going to fall apart, I want you to make a mess of yourself. Keep your pants on."

A whimper escapes him, but then I hear the sound of his hand working himself through his pants, the ragged gasps of someone chasing pleasure with desperate urgency.

"That's it." I keep my voice calm, even as my own cock strains against my zipper. "Show me how badly you need it."

The gasps and whispers intensify as I risk a glance over my shoulder and nearly lose my composure.

Elliot has braced one hand on the cold tile, his body pitched forward so he's almost on all fours. His other hand is buried in his sleep pants, his back is arched in a way that pushes his ass up into the air. His head hangs low, hair falling into his face, but I can still see the desperate tears streaming down his cheeks.

He's the most beautiful thing I've ever seen.

I force myself to turn back to the task at hand, finding the dustpan and locating the small broom. I move slowly, drawing out every second as I begin to sweep up the shards of glass from the counter.

"Please." The word comes out between gasps. "Please, I'm so close, please let me—"

"Thirty seconds." I don't turn around. "Better hurry."

The sounds behind me grow more frantic, filled with whimpers and moans and choked-off sobs as he chases his release with everything he has. I count the seconds in my head, each one stretching into an eternity.

Twenty. Fifteen. Ten.

His breath hitches behind me, the telltale sounds of someone right on the edge filling the kitchen, and I turn around just in time to see him arch his back even further, his whole body going taut with impending release.

"Stop."

The word cracks through the kitchen, Elliot's hand pulling from his pants and bracing on the tile floor. He collapses back onto his heels, his cock still straining visibly against the wet patch that's formed on the front of his pants. Tears stream down his face as he stares up at me with an expression of utter devastation.

"Please." The word comes out as a sob. "Please, I was so close, please let me finish, please—"

I cross the kitchen, gripping his jaw firmly as I force him to meet my eyes. His whole body is shaking with denied release, the sight of him like this making something possessive and primal roar to life in my chest.

"I told you once before that only good boys get to come." I purr, letting the words run off my tongue. "And you've been anything but good tonight, Elliot Aurelius."

He flinches at the use of his full name, fresh tears spilling down his cheeks. "I'm sorry. I'm sorry, I'll be good, I promise I'll be good, just please —"

"You'll be good?" I tilt his face up further, inspecting the damage. His lips are swollen from biting them, his cheeks streaked with tears, his eyes red-rimmed. "You broke my rules. You argued with me about whether those rules were fair. You got yourself so worked up that you almost came without permission. And now you're telling me you'll be good?"

"I will." His voice cracks on the words. "I swear I will. Please, Malakai. Please, sir. I'll do anything."

"Anything?" I let the word hang in the air between us, wondering if he'll bite.

"Anything." He nods frantically, willing to promise me the world if it means I'll let him come.

I lean in close, my lips brushing against his ear as I speak. "Then go back to bed. Don't touch yourself. And when you wake up tomorrow, hard and aching and desperate, you're going to come to me and beg for permission to find release. And maybe, if you're very, *very* good, I'll consider granting it."

The sound he makes is somewhere between a sob and a scream, muffled against his own fist as he struggles to contain his anguish. I release his jaw, looking down at the wreck I've made of my brother with a satisfaction so intense it borders on euphoric.

"Do you understand, little doe?"

It takes him a long moment to find his voice. When he does, it comes out barely audible. "Yes, sir. I understand."

"Good." I reach down and card my fingers through his hair, a gentle gesture that seems almost cruel in the context of what I've just denied him. "Now get up. Clean yourself up. And go to bed. You may close the door tonight."

He rises on shaky legs, his hand bracing against the counter for support. His sleep pants are still tented, the wet spot at the front a testament to how close he came, and every line of his body speaks to the agony of unfulfilled need.

"And Elliot?"

He pauses at the kitchen door, looking back at me with those devastated eyes.

"If I find out you touched yourself tonight, the consequences will be far worse than anything you experienced here. Do you understand?"

"Yes, sir."

"Good boy."

He flinches at the praise, as if it wounds him to hear it now, and disappears through the door without another word. I listen to his footsteps retreat down the hallway, up the stairs, and back to his room where no doubt he'll lie awake all night, throbbing and desperate and utterly forbidden from seeking relief.

I wait until I hear his door close before I let out a breath, my own arousal pulsing insistently in my pants. It would be so easy to follow him, to push open his door and take what we both want. But that's not how this works. That's not how you train someone to submit.

You make them wait. You make them want. You make them need you so badly that the thought of disobeying becomes unthinkable.

I finish cleaning up the broken glass and return to my study, but I don't touch myself either. If Elliot has to suffer through the night, then so do I. We're in this together, after all.

We're brothers. Twins. Two halves of the same whole.

And soon, he'll understand that completely.



The next morning, I'm already in the dining room when my phone buzzes with his text.

I'm awake, sir.

I smile at the screen, imagining him lying in his bed, still hard and aching for the release I denied him last night.

Good boy. Report to my study before breakfast. We need to discuss last night.

The three dots appear, disappear, appear again. Finally:

Yes, sir.

I set down my phone and lean back in my chair, anticipation thrumming through my veins. Last night was a test, and Elliot passed. He passed not by obeying perfectly, but by accepting the consequences when he failed. He let me punish him, deny him, and reduce him to tears without fighting back.

He's learning slowly and painfully, but he's learning.

And today, I'm going to reward him for it.



Elliot

I wake with my cock aching and my sheets damp with sweat, the remnants of a dream I can't quite remember clinging to the edges of my consciousness. My hand moves instinctively toward my groin before I catch myself, freezing with my fingers hovering just above the fabric of my sleep pants.

I wasn't given permission.

The thought hits me like a splash of cold water, and I pull my hand back to rest on my stomach instead, staring up at the ceiling as my heart pounds against my ribs. My body throbs with need, the denied release from last night still coiled tight and desperate in my belly, but I don't touch myself.

I won't touch myself.

The realization settles over me with a weight that should feel oppressive but instead feels almost peaceful. I don't have to make the decision. I don't

have to weigh the consequences or argue with myself about what I should or shouldn't do. Malakai already made the choice for me, and all I have to do is obey.

It's terrifying how much relief that brings me.

I reach for my phone and type out the message before I can second-guess myself.

I'm awake, sir.

The response comes almost immediately, and I wonder if he slept at all last night or if he spent the hours the same way I did, lying awake in the dark with his body burning and his mind racing.

Good boy. Report to my study before breakfast. We need to discuss last night.

My stomach clenches at the words, a mixture of anxiety and anticipation swirling together until I can't tell where one ends and the other begins. I swing my legs out of bed and pad across the cold floor to my dresser, reaching for the collar that sits waiting for me.

The leather is warm from being left in a patch of early morning sun, and it slides around my throat like it belongs there. My fingers fumble with the buckle just like the day before a moment before it catches, and I let out a slow breath as the familiar pressure settles against my pulse point.

I kneel beside my bed without being told, sinking into the position that's becoming more natural with each passing time I do it. Knees apart, hands on thighs, palms up, spine straight. I set a timer on my phone and close my eyes, letting the quiet wash over me.

Five minutes. Five minutes of stillness before I have to face whatever comes next.

By the time the timer buzzes, my mind is calmer than it has any right to be. I dress quickly in the clothes Malakai left for me, before making my way downstairs to his study.

The door is open, and I pause on the threshold, my heart climbing into my throat at the sight of him.

Malakai is sitting behind his desk, dressed in a charcoal suit that fits him like it was made for his body because it probably was. His dark hair is slightly damp from a recent shower, his jaw freshly shaved. He's reading something on his tablet, but his eyes flick up to meet mine the moment I appear, a small smile curving his lips.

"Good morning, Elliot. Come in. Close the door behind you."

I obey, my pulse quickening as the latch clicks shut.

"Kneel." He gestures to the spot beside his chair, the same place I've been kneeling for the past two days. I cross the room and lower myself to the floor, waiting for the conversation he mentioned we were going to have. "Look at me."

I raise my eyes to find him watching me with an expression I can't quite read. There's approval there, satisfaction, even, but underneath it all is something darker, something hungry that makes heat pool in my belly despite my best efforts to stay calm.

"You did well last night." He speaks slowly, letting each word land before moving to the next. "You accepted your punishment without complaint. You obeyed when I told you to stop, even though you were right on the edge." His hand reaches out to cup my jaw, tilting my face up further. "I'm proud of you, little doe."

The praise hits me like a drug, spreading through my chest until I feel almost dizzy with it. "Thank you, sir."

"I hope you learned from it." His thumb strokes across my cheekbone as I lean further into the touch. "The rules exist for a reason. When you break them, there are consequences. But when you follow them, when you trust me to guide you, there are rewards as well."

"I understand, sir."

"Do you?" His eyes search my face, looking for something I'm not sure I know how to give. "Tell me what you learned."

I consider the question carefully, sorting through the tangle of emotions and sensations that last night left behind. "I learned that the rules aren't about control for the sake of control. They're about structure. About giving me something solid to hold onto when everything else feels like chaos." I pause, swallowing hard. "And I learned that disappointing you feels worse than any punishment you could give me."

His hand stills on my face, something shifting in his expression. It's subtle, barely perceptible, but I catch the way his jaw tightens and the way his eyes darken with an emotion I don't have a name for.

"Good boy." The words come out rough, almost hoarse, and he clears his throat before continuing. "Now. Are you hungry?"

My stomach growls in response, my cheeks heating with embarrassment. "Yes, sir."

"Good. We're going to eat breakfast."

Relief floods through me at the prospect of food, but it's short-lived because Malakai doesn't move toward the door. Instead, he reaches for a covered tray I hadn't noticed sitting on the corner of his desk and sets it in front of him.

"Sir?" I frown, confused. "Aren't we going to the dining room?"

"No." He lifts the cover to reveal a spread of fresh fruit, crispy bacon, buttered toast, and a small pot of tea. "I'm going to feed you."

My face flames hotter. "I'm not a kid, Malakai. I can feed myself."

"I know you're not a kid." His voice drops lower, taking on a silky quality that makes my spine tingle. "But I want to know if those pretty lips are just for show." He picks up a strawberry and holds it out toward me, his eyes never leaving mine. "I'm going to make sure you're full today, little doe. Now open your mouth."

I stare at the strawberry, my heart pounding so hard I can feel it in my throat. This is humiliating. This is degrading. This is everything I should be fighting against.

But the slight thrill running through me at the idea of my brother making sure I'm fed? Fuck it. I open my mouth

The strawberry touches my lips, and I bite down, the sweet juice flooding my tongue as Malakai watches with an intensity that makes me harder than I've been since I woke up. He waits until I've chewed and swallowed before selecting another piece of fruit, this time a slice of melon, and offering it to me with the same patient expectation.

We continue like this for what feels like hours, Malakai alternating between fruit and bacon and bites of toast, his fingers occasionally brushing against my lips in a way that feels like he's teasing me on purpose. Each touch sends sparks cascading through my nervous system, and by the time he pours me a cup of tea and holds it to my mouth so I can drink, I'm trembling with the effort of holding still.

"Such a good boy." He sets the empty cup aside and strokes his hand through my hair. "You took everything I gave you without complaint. I knew you would."

"Thank you, sir." My voice comes out wrecked, my cock straining against my slacks all over again. If I'm going to be in a permanent state of arousal, I think I might die.

Malakai returns his attention to his tablet, scrolling through emails with one hand while the other continues to card through my hair. I kneel beside him, trying to focus on anything other than the persistent ache between my legs, but it's impossible. Every brush of his fingers against my scalp sends another wave of arousal through my body, and soon I'm shifting restlessly, trying to find a position that doesn't press my pants so tightly against my flesh.

"Something wrong, little doe?"

"No, sir."

"Elliot." The warning in his voice makes me shiver. "Don't lie to me."

I swallow hard, my eyes fixed on the floor. "I'm aroused, sir. I'm sorry. I can't help it."

"I know you can't." His hand tightens in my hair, pulling my head back so I'm forced to look up at him. "That's the point. Your body responds to me whether you want it to or not. Whether you think it should or not." His eyes bore into mine. "That's how I know you were made for this."

I don't know what to say to that, so I don't say anything. I just kneel there, trembling, as he releases my hair and returns to his work.

Minutes pass. The ache in my cock doesn't fade. If anything, it gets worse, fed by the constant awareness of Malakai's presence, the leather around my throat, and the memory of last night when he made me touch myself and then told me to stop right before I fell apart.

I shift again, just as my eyes catch on something that makes my breath stutter in my chest.

My brother's hard too

The bulge is unmistakable, thick against the fine fabric of his trousers, my mouth watering at the sight. He's sitting there, working on his tablet, acting like nothing is happening, but he's just as affected as I am.

The knowledge sends a rush of heat through my body that's almost painful in its intensity. I want to touch him. I want to taste him. I want to make him feel as desperate and needy as he's made me feel. I don't even know where these thoughts are coming from but I fucking need it like I needed that water last night.

But I can't. Not without permission.

The wanting becomes unbearable, a living thing coiling tight in my belly and demanding satisfaction. I try to focus on something else, once again, but my eyes keep drifting back to the bulge in his trousers, and every time they do, another wave of arousal crashes through me.

Finally, I can't take it anymore.

"Sir?" My voice comes out thin as I swallow back the moan sitting on the edge of my tongue.

"Yes?"

"May I..." I have to stop and swallow a second time, my throat suddenly dry. "May I take care of that for you?"

Malakai sets aside his tablet and looks down at me, one eyebrow raised. "Take care of what?"

He's going to make me say it. Of course he is.

"You're hard, sir." The words burn on their way out, shame and desire tangling together until I can't tell them apart. "I want to help. I want to make you feel good. Please."

"You want to suck my cock." It's not a question, and the bluntness of it makes my face flame even hotter. "You want to put your mouth on me like a good little whore. Is that it, little doe?" His words come out almost as a growl, his need bleeding through his tone.

I should be offended or even disgusted by the way he's talking to me. Instead, my cock thickens between my legs, a little sound at the back of my throat making an appearance. Fuck, everything about this is *so wrong*.

"Yes, sir." The admission tears itself from my throat. "Please. I need it."

"Need what? Tell me exactly what you need, Elliot."

"I need your cock in my mouth." The words spill out of me in a rush, shame flooding my chest but it's like I can't stop the words from coming. "I need to taste you, feel you, make you come. Please, sir. Please let me suck your cock."

His eyes darken, and I see the moment his control wavers. It's brief, barely a flicker, but it's there, and knowing that I can affect him that way sends a thrill of power through my veins.

"You beg so prettily." His voice has gone rough. "But I don't think you've earned it yet."

My heart sinks. "Please, sir. I'll do anything."

"Anything?" He considers me for a long moment, and I can see him weighing his options, deciding how far to push. "Alright. You can have what you want. But you're going to wait fifteen more minutes first."

"Fifteen minutes?" I can't keep the desperation out of my voice. "Sir, please, I don't know if I can—"

"You can." His hand returns to my hair, stroking through the strands with deceptive gentleness. "You will. Because I'm telling you to."

The next fifteen minutes are the longest of my life.

Malakai returns to his work, scrolling through his tablet and occasionally making notes on a pad of paper beside him, acting for all the world like I'm not kneeling at his feet, trembling with need, my eyes fixed on the bulge that never quite fades from his trousers.

I count the seconds in my head, each one stretching into an eternity. My cock throbs in time with my heartbeat, leaking steadily into my underwear until I can feel the wet patch spreading against my skin. I want to touch myself so badly it hurts, but I keep my hands flat on my thighs, palms up, exactly where they're supposed to be.

Finally, *finally*, Malakai sets aside his tablet, swiveling his chair around to face me fully.

"Time's up." His hand cups my jaw, tilting my face up. "Are you ready to show me what those pretty lips can do?"

"Yes, sir." The words come out barely above a whisper. "Please."

He spreads his legs wider, making room for me between them, and reaches for his belt. The clink of the buckle sounds impossibly loud in the quiet study, and I watch with rapt attention as he unfastens his trousers and frees his cock.

He's bigger than I expected, thick and flushed and already leaking at the tip. My mouth waters at the sight as I lean forward instinctively before catching myself and looking up for permission.

"Go ahead." His voice is strained with the same need that's been building in me all morning. "Show me what you can do."

I lean forward and wrap my lips around the head of his cock, and the sound Malakai makes nearly undoes me on the spot. It's a low, guttural groan, torn from somewhere deep in his chest. His hand fists in my hair, not guiding, just holding, and I take that as encouragement to take him deeper.

The taste of him floods my senses, salt and musk and something uniquely Malakai that I know I'll be craving for the rest of my life. I hollow my cheeks and suck him in deeper, bobbing my head in a rhythm that makes his grip tighten, the slight sting of pain only adding to the pleasure building in my own body.

"That's it." He breathes out. "Just like that, little doe. You take me so well."

I moan around his cock, the praise washing over me like warm honey, and redouble my efforts. I want to make him lose control. I want to see him fall apart the same way he's made me fall apart. I want to be good for him in a way that no one else ever has.

His hips start to move forward, shallow thrusts that push him deeper into my throat as I relax my jaw to take more of him. Tears prick at the corners of my eyes from the stretch, but I don't pull back. I want this. *I need this*. I need him to use me, to take what he wants, and to make me his in every way that matters.

"Fuck." The curse falls from his lips like a prayer. "Elliot. I'm close."

I suck harder, my tongue swirling around the head every time I pull back, his whole body tensing beneath me. His hand tightens in my hair further, pulling almost painfully, and then he comes with a groan that reverberates through my entire body.

I swallow everything he gives me, the taste of him flooding my mouth and sliding down my throat. The intimacy of it, the wrongness of it, the sheer overwhelming rightness of having my brother's cock in my mouth while I swallow his release, pushes me over an edge I didn't even realize I was standing on.

My orgasm crashes through me without warning, ripping a moan from my throat that vibrates against Malakai's softening cock. Pleasure explodes through my body in wave after wave, my cock pulsing and spilling into my pants without a single touch. I didn't ask permission. I didn't even realize I was close. But it's too late now, the release tearing through me with an intensity that leaves me shaking and gasping for air.

When it's over, I pull back and look up at Malakai with wide, horrified eyes.

"I'm sorry." The words tumble out of me in a rush. "I didn't mean to, I didn't know I was going to, I'm sorry, I'm so sorry—"

"Shh." His hand cups my face, his thumb brushing away tears I didn't realize I'd shed. "Look at me, Elliot."

I force myself to meet his eyes, bracing for the anger, the disappointment, or even the cold withdrawal I've been dreading since I got home.

Instead, I find wonder.

He's looking at me like I'm something precious, his eyes softer than I've ever seen them, and there's a tenderness in his touch that makes my chest ache. "You came untouched," He whispers, awe tinting his words. "Just from sucking my cock. Just from being good for me."

"I didn't mean to." My voice cracks. "I'm sorry. I know I should have asked permission. I know I broke the rules. I just couldn't help it. You were making those sounds and I was so full of you and I just—"

He silences me with a kiss.

It's soft at first, barely a brush of lips against mine, but then his hand slides to the back of my neck, playing with the edge of my collar and he deepens it, his tongue sweeping into my mouth to taste himself on my lips. I melt into him, all the tension and fear and shame draining from my body as

he claims my mouth with the same thorough possession he's used to claim everything else.

When he finally pulls back, we're both breathing hard.

"You were perfect." He presses his forehead to mine, his breath warm against my lips. "Do you understand me? You were absolutely perfect."

I don't know what to say. I don't know how to process any of this. My brother just kissed me. My brother's taste is still on my tongue. And now, my brother is looking at me like I hung the moon.

"I don't..." I shake my head, struggling to form coherent thoughts. "I don't understand. I broke the rules. I came without permission."

"You did." His thumb strokes along my jaw. "And normally, there would be consequences for that. But this time, I'm going to let it go. Do you know why?"

I shake my head.

"Because watching you fall apart like that was the most beautiful thing I've ever seen." His eyes bore into mine. "Because you didn't come from touching yourself. You came from pleasing me. From being so deep in your submission that your body couldn't hold back anymore." He kisses me again, much quicker this time. "That's not a failure, little doe. That's everything I've ever wanted from you."

Tears spill down my cheeks, but I don't try to stop them. I'm overwhelmed, overloaded, my emotions too big for my body to contain. Malakai stuffs himself back into his pants before pulling me up from the floor and into his lap, cradling me against his chest while I shake and sob and try to make sense of what just happened.

"I've got you." His voice is a low murmur against my hair. "I've got you, little doe. You're safe. You're mine. Everything is going to be okay."

I don't know how long we stay like that, wrapped around each other in his study while the morning sun climbs higher in the sky. Eventually, my tears dry and my breathing steadies, and I become aware of the sticky mess in my pants, the ache in my knees, and the rawness of my throat.

"Sir?"

"Yes?"

"May I take a shower? I'm... I made a mess of myself."

His chest rumbles with a low laugh. "No, you may not take a shower."

My heart sinks. "Sir, please. I feel disgusting."

"I said no shower." He tips my chin up so I'm forced to meet his eyes, the smile on his lips still soft. "I'm going to give you a bath."

Before I can respond, he lifts me off his lap and sets me on my feet. My legs wobble beneath me, still unsteady from kneeling for so long, as he steadies me with a hand on my hip before guiding me out of the study and up the stairs.

I've never been in Malakai's room before. Even as children, it was always off-limits, a private sanctuary that I knew better than to invade. But now he leads me through the door without hesitation, and I take in the space with wide eyes.

It's masculine and elegant, all dark wood and rich fabrics, with a king-sized bed that dominates one wall and floor-to-ceiling windows that overlook the estate's gardens. The bathroom is through a door on the far side, and when Malakai pushes it open, I catch a glimpse of marble and chrome before he pulls me inside.

The tub is massive, big enough for two people, Malakai turning on the faucets before reaching for a bottle of something that smells like eucalyptus

and mint. Steam rises from the water as it fills, the scent helping clear some of the fog from my head.

"Strip."

My fingers fumble with the buttons of my shirt, still clumsy from the aftershocks of my orgasm, but I manage to work them free and shrug the fabric off my shoulders. My pants follow, then my underwear, until I'm standing naked before my brother in the middle of his bathroom.

I feel vulnerable. *Exposed*. Especially with the bruises littering my arms and torso. Out of habit, I go to wrap my arms around my chest, Malakai shooting me a strange look. Confused, I drop my hands back to my side, the smile of approval on my brother's lips giving me the confidence to remain in that position. It feels so revealing but it's like I've already surrendered the parts of myself that would have cared about modesty.

"Get in."

I step into the tub and lower myself into the water, hissing slightly at the heat. It's just on the edge of too hot, enough to make my skin flush pink, but the warmth seeps into my aching muscles and loosens the tension I didn't realize I was carrying.

Malakai kneels beside the tub, rolling his sleeves up to his elbows, and reaches for a washcloth. He dips it into the water and begins to clean me, starting with my shoulders and working his way down. When the cloth passes over the fading bruises on my ribs, his hand stills.

"These are healing," He pushes out. "Another week and they'll be gone."

I look down at the marks Marcus left behind, the yellowing evidence of a life I'm trying desperately to leave behind. "Yes, sir."

"You will never have to hurt again." His fingers trace the outline of the largest bruise. "Do you understand me, Elliot? As long as you're mine, no

one will ever lay a hand on you. No one will ever make you feel small or scared or worthless. I won't allow it."

The words hit me somewhere deep, cracking open a part of myself I've been trying to keep protected. "Malakai..."

"I mean it." His eyes meet mine, a fierceness there that I'm beginning to realize is just for me. "You're mine to protect. Mine to care for. Mine to cherish." His hand slides lower, beneath the water, and wraps around my soft cock. "Mine to play with."

I gasp, my hips jerking involuntarily at the contact. I'm too sensitive and wrung out from my earlier orgasm, but my body responds anyway, blood rushing south as he strokes me with agonizingly slow movements.

"Sir..."

His hand releases my cock and travels lower, sliding between my thighs and further back until his fingers brush against my ass. I tense instinctively, but he doesn't push inside, just traces the sensitive skin with a touch so light it makes me shiver.

"All of this is mine." His voice drops a few octaves, dark with want. "Every inch of you. Mine to have, to use, to worship." His fingers spread through my cheeks, brushing against my hole, a moan escaping my throat before I can stop it. "Do you have any idea how close I am to the edge of my control right now?"

"Then use me." The words spill out before I can think better of them. "I want you to. Please, Malakai. Use me."

His hand stills, his eyes meeting mine with an intensity that steals my breath.

"You have absolutely no idea what you're asking." His voice is strained, tight with the effort of holding himself back. "The things I want to do to

you, Elliot. The ways I want to take you apart and put you back together. You're not ready for any of it."

"I could be." I'm trembling now, my whole body vibrating with a need I don't fully understand. "I want to be. I want you to show me."

He leans in close, his lips brushing against my ear. "You will be. I promise you that. But not yet. Not until I've taught you everything you need to know. Not until you can take everything I want to give you without breaking."

His fingers withdraw from between my cheeks, and I let out a whimper of protest that makes him chuckle.

"Patience, little doe." He presses a kiss to my forehead. "We have all the time in the world."

He finishes bathing me in silence, his hands gentle as they clean every inch of my body. When the water starts to cool, he helps me out of the tub and wraps me in a towel so soft it feels like a cloud against my skin. He dries me thoroughly, and then leads me back into his bedroom.

"Get into bed."

I blink at him, surprised. "Your bed?"

"My bed." He pulls back the covers and gestures for me to climb in. "You're going to rest for a while. You've had a long morning."

I crawl between the sheets, surrounded by his scent, and watch as he strips off his own clothes and joins me. He doesn't try to touch me, just pulls me against his chest and wraps his arms around me. The position feels oddly like safety, like I could stay here and Malakai could protect me against the world.

It doesn't even feel sexual... it just feels... *perfect*.

“Wait! What about work?” I press a hand against his chest, but he just tightens his arms around me, a chuckle rumbling through him.

“Elliot, Mom and Dad own the fucking company and I run it. They can deal with not having their boss breathing down their necks for a few hours. Now, sleep. I’ll be here when you wake up.”

I do as I’m told, curling in closer to the warmth he’s providing, ignoring that awful voice that tells me this is wrong. Malakai said it was right. He said I’m allowed to want what I need. And I need this. I need to submit.

I need my brother.



Elliot

I wake up surrounded by warmth and the scent of eucalyptus, my body still loose and heavy from sleep. It takes me a moment to remember where I am, my mind processing the unfamiliar softness of the sheets and the solid weight of an arm draped across my waist.

Malakai's bed. Malakai's arm. Malakai's breath warm against the back of my neck.

The memories of yesterday flood back in a rush, my face heating in response. *Holy shit*. No one has ever taken care of me the way Malakai did. I blink a few times, still trying to gather my bearings before I realize we somehow slept through the entire day. Or I did. There's no doubt in my mind Malakai must have slipped away to work and then came back.

I shift slightly, testing whether he's awake, his arm tightening around me almost immediately.

"Stay." The word comes out rough with sleep, a command even in its softness.

"I wasn't going anywhere." My voice sounds foreign to my own ears, a bit scratchier than usual. "What time is it?"

"Early. I didn't want to wake you. It seemed you really needed the sleep." His lips brush against the nape of my neck, just below where the collar sits. I never took it off last night, and neither did he. "We have time."

"Time for what?"

He doesn't answer, just pulls me closer until my back is flush against his chest and his hips press against my ass. He's hard, I realize with a jolt that sends heat flooding through my belly. Hard and hot and pressed right against the cleft of my—

"Sir." The word comes out strangled.

"Shh." His hand slides up my chest, fingers splaying over my heart. "Just feel. Don't think."

We lie there for what feels like hours, his body wrapped around mine, his arousal a constant presence against my skin. He doesn't do anything about it, doesn't grind against me or reach for my own hardening cock. He just holds me until the tension in my muscles melts away and I sink back into that floaty, peaceful space I'm starting to associate with his presence.

Eventually, he presses a kiss to my shoulder and pulls away.

"Time to get up." His voice shifts back to that authoritative tone that makes my spine straighten instinctively. "Today is your first day at Ashford Holdings."

The words hit me like a bucket of cold water. I'd almost forgotten, lost in the haze of the past few days, that a world exists outside of this house. That

I'm supposed to have a job, a life, and responsibilities beyond kneeling at my brother's feet and learning how to fall apart on command.

"I thought you said I wasn't ready." I sit up slowly, the sheets pooling around my waist. "You said I needed more time to heal."

"I said you'd be ready when I decided you were ready." He's already out of bed, moving toward the bathroom with the easy grace of someone who's been awake for hours despite the evidence to the contrary. "And I've decided. You're ready."

I want to argue and tell him that I don't feel ready, that the thought of walking into a corporate office and pretending to be a functional human being makes me anxious. But the words die in my throat because I know, on some level, that it doesn't matter what I feel. Malakai has made the decision, and my only job is to follow.

"Yes, sir."

"Good boy." He pauses in the bathroom doorway and looks back at me over his shoulder. "Shower and meet me in my study. I'll have your clothes laid out."

I do as I'm told, washing quickly under water that's too hot, trying to scrub away the lingering fog of sleep and arousal that clings to my skin. By the time I make it to the study, wrapped in a towel and still dripping slightly, Malakai is seated behind his desk with a garment bag draped over the chair beside him.

"Come here."

I cross the room and stop in front of the desk, hyperaware of my near-nakedness and the way his intense gaze tracks over my body, which makes my cock twitch beneath the towel. My eyes dart to the entrance of the study and then back to him, realizing I haven't seen the staff since I arrived.

Malakai snorts. "I told them to make themselves scarce until Mom and Dad return. I didn't want them intruding on these moments as you find yourself. Now," He points to the chair. "Today, you represent me." He unzips the garment bag and pulls out a set of clothes that don't look like anything I've ever worn or even thought about dressing in. The soft navy trousers and pale gray sweater are beautiful... but they also look *fitted*. It takes me a moment to understand that's exactly what Malakai wants. *He wants to show me off*. "You'll dress accordingly."

"These are..." I reach out to touch the sweater, marveling at the quality. "These must have cost a fortune."

Another chuckle rumbles through his chest. "Sometimes I wonder if you forget how much money our family has, Elliot. Besides, this outfit is appropriate for a junior analyst at Ashford Holdings." He sets the clothes aside and reaches into his desk drawer, pulling out something that makes my heart stutter. "And so is this."

It's a metal plug, from the look of it, with a flared base and a tapered tip that is so shiny I can almost see my face in it. It's smaller than I expected, but substantial enough that I know I'll feel every inch of it. "Sir?"

"You can't wear the collar in public." His voice carries a note of regret that surprises me. "People would talk or speculate about things they don't know and don't understand." He leans forward, his fingers brushing against my throat, tracing the leather one last time before he reaches around to unfasten the buckle. The collar slides free, the absence of it almost overwhelming. "But you'll still wear something of mine. Something that reminds you who you belong to, even when no one else can see."

He sets the collar aside, then shows me the plug again as he holds it between us.

"You'll wear this today." His voice drops low enough that I have to strain to hear. "A reminder that even when I'm not next to you, you're mine."

My mouth goes dry. "All day?"

"All day." He sets the plug on the desk and leans back in his chair, watching me with those gray-green eyes that miss nothing. "Unless it becomes too much. In which case, you'll text me, and we'll figure something out."

"And if I can handle it?"

"Then you'll prove to both of us that you're stronger than you think you are." He gestures toward the bathroom connected to his study. "Go. I'll prepare you."

My legs feel unsteady as I walk to the bathroom, my heart pounding so hard I can feel it in my throat. This is insane. This is crossing every line of professionalism that exists. I'm about to go to my first day at a new job with a plug in my ass and my brother's fingerprints all over my skin.

And God help me, I want it.

The bathroom is smaller than the one attached to his bedroom, but still just as luxurious. I wonder how I missed the grandeur of the life we grew up in and then remember I spent most of my time in my bedroom or anywhere outside the house I could find to hang. My only good memories were with Malakai and I was never focused on the luxuries, just him.

Malakai follows me in and closes the door, then turns me to face the counter. "Hands flat. Eyes forward."

I comply, bracing myself against the cool marble as I stare at my reflection in the mirror. My face is flushed, my eyes bright with a mixture of fear and anticipation. Behind me, Malakai reaches for a bottle of lubricant just at the edge of the counter, almost as if he prepared for this.

My breath catches in my throat as he tugs at the towel, the fabric slipping to the floor, my brother's eyes meeting mine in the mirror. For a moment, he just stares and then I hear the click of the cap and my body tenses at the first cool touch of his slicked fingers against my entrance. My lips part as my back arches, a small gasp falling from me. Malakai's eyes darken with interest, his other hand moving to set the lube back down and then grip my waist.

"Breathe, little doe. This will be easier if you relax."

He pauses his movements, waiting for me to comply but I can't. I'm on edge, hard, and completely exposed to a man I shouldn't have feelings for. I don't even know if that's what this is, if that's why I'm so conflicted or if it's just because my brother is touching me...

Malakai removes his fingers and steps closer, his back covering mine as he presses a kiss to my shoulder. "Elliot, look at me." My grip tightens on the counter as a strange sound tears from my throat, Malakai slowly twisting me around so that I'm actually looking at him. "Hey, *hey*, is this too much? I need your words, Elliot. Talk to me."

I shake my head and then nod before shaking it again. "I don't know. It's... I... you keep saying this is okay but I just..."

"We can try something else," Malakai purrs as his lips ghost over mine. "It's okay."

My heart sinks into my stomach at the thought of disappointing him. Honestly, it's not even about the plug. It's about how fast all this is progressing, how I so easily melt at my brother's feet without so much as a second thought. It's about the fact that a few days in and I might be falling for him...

“No, I want to do this,” I push out, gently curling my fingers into his shirt. “Please, sir. I want to wear your plug.”

This time Malakai hesitates before pressing a feather-light kiss to my lips. “Okay. But you’ll tell me when it’s too much?” His fingers move to gently cup my chin, his thumb now running across my lips. “I want to see how strong you are but I don’t want you to break yourself. I’ll push your limits but the end goal is not to see you fail, Elliot.”

Every time he says my name, it feels like a burn. I nod enthusiastically, practically forcing his hand off my chin so I can turn around again, letting him know that I want this. I’ll deal with my wretched feelings later.

Malakai grants me another chuckle before fingering my hole again and then pressing inside. “Relax for me. That’s it.” His other hand strokes down my spine in a soothing motion. “You’re doing so well, little doe.”

A second finger soon joins the first, scissoring gently to stretch me wider. I bite my lip against the sounds that want to escape, watching in the mirror as my brother prepares me to wear his claim all day. My cock strains against the cabinet, threatening to unload all over the marble and porcelain but I breathe through it, intent on making my brother proud.

By the time he inserts a third finger, I’m actively trying not to come but the desire etched in every line of my brother’s face has me holding back. “God, you’re perfect, little doe. I’m going to insert the plug now.” Malakai withdraws his fingers, the cool press of metal against my entrance replacing it. “Push back against it. Let it in.”

I obey, and the plug slides inside me with a stretch that tears a gasp from my throat. It’s cold at first, a shock against my heated flesh, but it warms quickly as it settles into place. The flared base nestles between my cheeks, a constant pressure that I know I’ll feel with every step.

"How does it feel?"

"Full." The word comes out strangled. "I feel full."

"Good." He turns me around and cups my face in his hands, tilting my head up so our eyes meet. "You're going to feel me all day, Elliot. Every time you shift in your chair, every time you walk down a hallway, you'll remember who you belong to."

"Yes, sir."

A warm smile spreads across his lips, the approval making my heart soar as he dips his head to kiss me, his tongue tracing the seam of my lips until I open for him. *I'm so fucked, aren't I?*

When he pulls back, his eyes are dark with want. "Get dressed. We leave in twenty minutes."



The drive to Ashford Holdings is torture.

Every bump in the road shifts the plug inside me, sending sparks of sensation up my spine that make it impossible to sit still. Malakai drives with one hand on the wheel, the other resting casually on my thigh, his fingers tracing idle patterns on the fabric of my trousers like he isn't perfectly aware of what he's doing to me.

"Stop squirming." There's amusement in his voice that makes me want to punch him and kiss him all at the same time.

"I can't help it." I grit my teeth as we hit another pothole. "Every time the car moves, it moves."

"That's the point." His hand slides higher on my thigh, fingers brushing dangerously close to where my cock is already starting to stiffen. "You'll learn to control your reactions. By the end of the day, you'll be able to sit in

a meeting with a plug in your ass and no one will know except you and me."

"You're a sadist."

"Perhaps." He pulls into the parking garage beneath Ashford Holdings, a sleek glass tower that dominates the downtown skyline. "But you love it."

I don't have a response to that, mostly because he's right. He takes up a spot marked with his name and cuts the engine, before turning to face me, his expression shifting into something more serious.

"A few rules for today." His hand finds the back of my neck, squeezing gently. "You will address me as Mr. Ashford in public. You will not give any indication that our relationship is anything other than professional, despite the fact that we are brothers. However, using my name is okay during informal meetings. If you need me, text. If it becomes too much, text. And Elliot?"

"Yes?"

"If anyone touches you inappropriately, you tell me immediately. Understood?"

The possessiveness in his voice sends a shiver down my spine. "Yes, sir."

"Good boy." He releases my neck and opens his door. "Now. Walk normally. No one needs to know you're stuffed full and desperate for me."

"Fuck you," I breathe as I climb out of the car, my legs almost giving out when my feet hit the pavement.

His laugh follows me across the parking garage. "Later, little doe. Be good."



Elliot

Ashford Holdings is everything I expected and nothing I was prepared for. The lobby is a cathedral of glass and steel, all soaring ceilings and polished floors, very similar to our estate. I managed to avoid coming here after the age of five or six because I threw such temper tantrums that Dad chose to leave me at home with the nanny. Only Malakai was ever good enough for them but I can see why now. He embodies everything this place seems to boast.

And it looks like a place he would thrive. I was picturing something a little less chaotic but there's bustles of people in expensive suits, clutching coffee cups and tablets, their faces set in expressions of determined productivity. The energy is overwhelming, a stark contrast to the quiet intimacy of the estate.

I am so not ready for this.

Malakai walks beside me, close enough that I can feel the heat of his body but not close enough to touch. He's transformed from the man who held me all night into something harder, a predator in a tailored suit who commands respect with every step.

"Mr. Ashford." A woman in a crisp blazer falls into step beside us, her stilettos clicking against the marble floor. "Your nine o'clock is waiting in conference room B. And the quarterly reports came in last night. I left them on your desk."

"Thank you, Sarah." He doesn't break his stride. "This is my brother, Elliot. He's starting today as a junior analyst in the finance department."

Sarah's gaze flicks to me with professional curiosity. "Of course. HR has his paperwork ready. I'll make sure he's settled before your meeting."

And then he's gone, striding toward the elevator without a backward glance, leaving me alone in the lobby with Sarah and the constant pressure of the plug reminding me that I'm not nearly as alone as I feel.

"So," Sarah teases, a smile curling her lips upward as she leads me toward the elevator bank. "You're the mysterious twin. We've all been curious about you."

"Curious?" I fall into step beside her, trying to ignore the way the plug shifts with every stride. Jesus Christ, I'm going to come. I can't stop thinking about it.

"Mr. Ashford never talks about his personal life." She presses the button for the twelfth floor and gives me a sideways glance. "Most of us didn't even know he had a brother until HR sent out the memo about your start date. Which is weird considering you two are twins and your parents own the company. It's almost like you just... didn't exist."

"We're not that close." The lie tastes bitter on my tongue. "Different paths, you know."

"Mmm." She doesn't sound convinced, but she doesn't push either. "Well, the finance department is a good place to start. Low pressure, steady work. You'll have time to find your footing."

The elevator doors open onto a bustling floor filled with cubicles and glass-walled offices. *What the fuck is with all the glass?* I hate how revealing it is, how everything is so open. It feels... vulnerable. Heads turn as we pass, curious eyes tracking my progress through the main area, my face heating beneath the scrutiny.

"Everyone, this is Elliot Ashford." Sarah's voice carries across the open floor. "He's starting as a junior analyst today. Please make him feel welcome."

A chorus of murmured greetings follows, but it's the whispers underneath that make my skin prickle.

"That's his brother? They look nothing alike."

"I heard they're twins. Fraternal, right."

"Nah, identical. Elliot just looks softer."

"Wonder if he's as intense as Mr. Ashford."

A woman with bright red hair and a friendly smile appears at my elbow. "Don't mind them. New blood is always exciting around here. I'm Paulina. You're going to be two desks down from mine."

"Thanks." I try to return her smile, but it feels stiff on my face. "It's nice to meet you."

"You're nothing like we imagined, you know." A man with wire-rimmed glasses leans against a nearby cubicle wall, his arms crossed over his chest. "Mr. Ashford is so..."

"Terrifying?" someone supplies from across the aisle. Laughter follows the question.

"I was going to say commanding." Wire-rimmed glasses grins. I should probably learn names but this is all terribly overwhelming. I thought when I'd start working here, I would be across the hall from Malakai or at the very least much closer to him and out of the public eye. "But terrifying works too. You seem more..."

"Normal?" I offer.

"Approachable." He extends his hand. "I'm Greg. Welcome to the pit."

More people drift over, drawn by the novelty of fresh gossip, and soon I'm surrounded by a small crowd of analysts all vying for my attention. The questions are all rapid-fire, each one more invasive than the last.

"So what's he like at home?"

"Does he ever smile?"

"Is it true he fired someone for making eye contact in the elevator?"

"I heard he once made a VP cry in a board meeting."

"Okay, okay, that's enough." Paulina steps between me and the growing mob, her hands raised in a placating gesture. "Leave him alone. It's his first day, for God's sake."

"We're just curious," Greg protests. "It's not every day we get insider information on the boss."

"And if Mr. Ashford finds out we're interrogating his brother on day one, we might be the next ones out on the street." Paulina's voice carries a warning that makes the crowd shift uncomfortably. "Remember what happened to Patterson?"

The name sends a ripple of unease through the group, people immediately dispersing, muttering excuses about deadlines and meetings. I exhale

slowly, my shoulders dropping with relief.

"Thank you," I mumble to Paulina. "I wasn't expecting..."

"The Spanish Inquisition?" She laughs and pats my arm. "Don't worry about it. They'll lose interest in a week or two if you don't feed into it. Come on, I'll show you to your desk." She waves to Sarah, the first woman offering a small nod before disappearing back into the hallway.

My workspace is modest but functional, a standard cubicle with a computer, a phone, and a small potted succulent that someone has placed in the corner with a card that reads "Welcome to the team!"

"That's from me," Paulina admits. "Figured you could use something green to look at. This place can feel pretty sterile."

"It's perfect. Thank you."

She leaves me to settle in and I lower myself into my chair, promptly biting back the gasp that threatens to escape as the plug shifts and presses deeper. My fingers grip the armrests, my knuckles going white, and I have to close my eyes for a moment to collect myself.

"You okay?" Greg has paused by my cubicle, his brow furrowed with concern. "You look a little pale."

"Fine." The word comes out strained, but I clear my throat to cover it. "Just nervous. First day jitters."

"Ah." He nods knowingly. "The coffee here is terrible, but it helps. Break room is down the hall to the left."

"Thanks."

He moves on, and I slump back in my chair, wincing as the movement sends another jolt of sensation through my body. I'm not going to fucking survive but the thought of texting Malakai, telling him that I can't handle this simple task keeps me from pulling out my phone.

Unfortunately, I can't focus on anything. Every time I sit down, I have to bite back a gasp. Every time I stand up, my legs tremble slightly from the stimulation. The plug is a constant presence, impossible to ignore, a tether connecting me to Malakai even though he's somewhere else in the building, probably running meetings and making deals and absolutely not thinking about me.

Except I know that's not true. I know he's thinking about me. I can feel it.

I see him twice during the morning. Once in the elevator, when I'm heading down to grab paperwork from HR and he's coming up from the parking garage. Our eyes meet through the closing doors but his expression doesn't change or give any indication that he knows me at all. However, his mouth twitches, just slightly, which just has me thinking about his fingers in my ass this morning.

The second time is across the bullpen, when I look up from my computer to find him standing outside a conference room on the other side of the floor. He's talking to someone, his posture more relaxed than outside the elevator, but his eyes are fixed on me. Even from this distance, I can feel the weight of his gaze, pinning me to my chair and making me hyperaware of every inch of my body.

When I squirm in my seat, I swear I see him smile.

"You must be the new guy."

I look up to find a man leaning against the edge of my cubicle, a charming smile plastered across his face. He's handsome in a conventional way, tall with sandy hair and blue eyes that crinkle at the corners when he grins. His suit is expensive but not quite as tailored as Malakai's, and there's something about the way he carries himself that puts me slightly on edge.

I immediately put him in a Marcus-type category, reminding myself that while most everyone in the office seems nice, I will not be falling for anything this charming guy tries to pull. My first instinct is to text my brother and alert him of the guy but this isn't like at the estate. This is Malakai's career, his legacy, and a business in my own family name.

I can handle this, I tell myself.

"Elliot Ashford." I extend my hand, trying to ignore the way the movement shifts the plug inside me. "Just started today."

"Connor Webb." His handshake lingers a beat too long, his fingers squeezing mine with unnecessary pressure. "Senior analyst. I'm in the office next to Sarah's if you ever need anything."

"Thanks." I pull my hand back as subtly as I can manage. "I'm still getting my bearings, so I'll probably take you up on that." *I probably won't.*

"Please do." His eyes drift down my body in a way that makes my skin crawl, a little too slow and too appreciative to be just professional curiosity. "It's nice to have some fresh blood around here. Things were getting a bit stale."

Before I can respond, my phone buzzes with a text.

My office. Now.

No greeting, no explanation, just the command that makes my heart rate spike.

"Sorry." I stand, my legs unsteady. "I have to go. Meeting with Mr. Ashford."

Connor's eyebrows rise slightly. "Already? I know he's your brother, but most of us don't get summoned to the top floor on day one. Must be nice having family in high places."

I duck my head to hide the rising color to my cheeks and dash toward the elevator, my phone clutched in my hand. Anxiety zips through me as I fall against the wall the moment the doors slide closed, a moan falling from my lips as I press my ass back against nothing. I feel so fucking full and I need to come.

I'm not going to survive until lunch but I have to. Maybe Malakai will take it out when I get upstairs? I'm not sure how long I stand there, pressing myself against the cool surface, relishing in the relief before the doors open again to the top floor. I manage a smile to the receptionist while trying to do my best and not waddle to Malakai's corner office.

The blinds are drawn when I arrive, casting the room in a dim, intimate light that makes my pulse quicken.

"Lock the door."

His voice comes from behind the desk, where he's seated with his jacket off and his sleeves rolled up to his elbows. He looks relaxed, but I can see the tension in his shoulders and the darkness in his eyes that tells me he's anything but.

I turn the lock and cross the room to stand in front of his desk, my hands clasped behind my back.

"Come here." He pushes his chair back and pats his thigh. "Show me."

My face flames with understanding. "Sir, we're at work. Someone could —"

"The door is locked. The blinds are closed. No one is going to interrupt us." He leans forward, his eyes boring into mine. "Now come here and show me."

I move around the desk on trembling legs and stop in front of him, close enough to touch. He doesn't touch me, though. He just waits patiently, one

of his eyebrows raised, until I understand what he wants.

I turn around and bend over the desk, my hands bracing against the polished wood as I present myself to him. The position shifts the plug, pressing it deeper, and I have to bite my lip against the moan that wants to escape.

"Good boy." His hand lands on my lower back. "Let's see how you've been doing."

He tugs my trousers down just enough to expose the base of the plug, his fingers tracing the flared edge where it nestles between my cheeks. The touch isn't meant to be sensual, but my body doesn't care about the distinction. Heat floods through me, pooling in my groin and making my cock throb against the desk.

"You've been so good this morning, little doe." His finger circles the base of the plug, teasing where it sits inside of me. "I've been watching you squirm from across the floor. Watching you try to sit still while this pretty thing reminds you who you belong to."

"Sir, please." I don't even know what I'm asking for. More? Less? Just something to break the unbearable tension that's been building all morning.

"Please what?" He presses the plug deeper, just slightly, and I have to muffle my moan against my forearm. "Tell me what you need."

"I need to come." The words spill out before I can stop them. "Please, sir. I've been on edge all morning. I can't think. I can't concentrate. All I can feel is you."

"It's only been a few hours, Elliot." He chuckles, his hand smoothing down my hip. "But you don't get to come. Not yet. I just wanted to see you." He adjusts my pants, pulling them back up and fastening them. When he turns me around to face him, his expression soft, just like it was this

morning. "You're doing so well." He cups my face in his hands, his thumbs stroking across my cheekbones. "I know today is hard. I know the plug is distracting. But you're handling it beautifully."

"It doesn't feel like I'm handling it." My voice cracks. "It feels like I'm falling apart."

"Falling apart for me is handling it." He presses a kiss to my forehead, lingering. "Now go back to your desk. Finish your day. And when we get home, I'll take care of you properly."

That promise is all I need to obey, yet, some part of me wonders if my brother's urgent request to see him in his office was because of Connor. I don't like the guy's vibes either but he didn't do anything other than shake my hand.

Right?

The afternoon is somehow worse than the morning. Every minute drags like an hour, each second marked by the relentless pressure of the plug and the memory of Malakai's hands on my body. Connor stops by my desk twice more, his smiles too friendly and his touches a little too familiar, and by the time five o'clock arrives, I'm ready to crawl out of my skin.

I know I should say something to Malakai but it also feels like I might just be reading into things. Paulina stopped through several times too, granted she was bringing me reports and showing me which excel files I needed for the quarterly reports.

Something tells me it's not the same but I brush it aside, rushing off to the car the moment Malakai sends a text to be waiting for him. I can barely contain the need thrumming through me as we head home, both of his hands on the steering wheel, all of his focus on the road rather than on me.

Does he know? Did I disobey him again? Is he angry?

The thoughts run through my head as I try to recreate my kneeling in the car, stiffening my back and placing my hands palm up on my thighs. It doesn't do much, that plug nestled in my ass constantly dragging along my inner walls every time we hit a bump in the road.

A needy whine tears from my lips just as Malakai pulls into the drive, the two of us barely making it through the front door. He crowds me against the foyer wall the moment we're inside, his body pressing against mine from chest to thigh. His hand fists in my hair, pulling my head back to expose my throat, his mouth descending on my pulse point with a hunger that makes me cry out.

"You were perfect today." The words are growled against my skin. "So good for me. So desperate and needy and mine."

"Please." The word is a sob, a prayer. "Please, sir, I need—"

"I know what you need." His hands are everywhere, tugging at my clothes, pulling the sweater over my head and working open the buttons of my trousers. "I'm going to give it to you. Right here. Right now."

He spins me around and pushes me face-first against the wall, his hand pressing between my shoulder blades to hold me in place. I hear the clink of his belt, the rustle of fabric, and then his fingers are finding the plug and pulling it free with a slick sound that makes me whimper.

"So open for me." His voice is rough with want. "So ready. You've been waiting all day for this, haven't you?"

"Yes." I push back against him, desperate for more. "Please, Malakai. Please, I can't wait anymore."

His fingers replace the plug, two of them sliding into me with an ease that speaks to how thoroughly he prepared me this morning. He works me open

further, adding a third finger, stretching me until I'm gasping and trembling against the wall.

"Not yet." He pulls his fingers free and wraps his hand around my cock instead, stroking a few times. "I want you to come just like this. From my hand. From the memory of being stuffed full all day. Can you do that for me?"

"Yes." I'm nodding frantically, pushing into his grip. "Yes, sir, please, I'm so close, please let me—"

"Come. Come for me now, little doe."

My orgasm crashes through me like a wave, pulling me under until I can't breathe, think, or do anything but shake and moan as Malakai strokes me through it. His other arm wraps around my chest, holding me upright when my legs threaten to give out, his lips pressing soft kisses to my shoulder as I fall apart in his arms.

When it's over, I'm trembling so hard I can barely stand. He turns me around and pulls me against his chest, cradling me like something precious as I come back to myself.

"I've got you." His voice is soft against my hair. "I've got you, little doe. You did so well. I'm so proud of you."

I cling to him, my face buried in his neck, and let the tears come. They're not sad tears, just the overwhelming release of a day spent on the edge, a day of constant stimulation and control and the strange, terrifying intimacy of belonging to someone so completely.

"This is what it means to be mine." He strokes my back in long, soothing motions. "I push you all day, make you desperate and needy, and then I take care of you. I'll always take care of you, Elliot. Do you understand?"

"Yes, sir." The words come out muffled against his skin. "I understand."

He holds me until my trembling stops, before carrying me upstairs to his bathroom, where he runs another bath and cleans me with the same tender attention he showed me yesterday. By the time he tucks me into his bed, my body is heavy with exhaustion and my mind is finally, blissfully quiet.

“Sir, can I wear my collar?” The words sound foreign coming from my mouth but it’s a comfort I’ve grown used to in the past few days. Malakia just hums his response, the leather wrapping around my neck a few seconds later, the sound of the clasp echoing in the darkness.

"Sleep. I'll bring dinner up in a bit. Tomorrow will be easier. I promise." He ruffles my hair a little and then moves toward the door, anxiety racing through my chest. He catches my expression, his smile softening a little. “Elliot, the work day is never over. I still have a few things to wrap up but I was not going to make you wait any longer. I’ll be back with dinner and then I’ll stay. I promise.”

I manage a small nod and curl tighter beneath the covers as he leaves. *I promise.* I’m getting dangerously close to truly believing those words.



Elliot

I'm still floating in that hazy post-bath warmth when I hear the front door open downstairs.

At first, I don't think anything of it. Mrs. Callahan comes and goes at odd hours, and the staff have their own schedules that I've never bothered to learn. But then I hear voices and one of them is unfortunately really, *really* familiar.

Mother.

I sit up so fast the room spins, my heart hammering against my ribs as I strain to hear the conversation drifting up from the foyer. I can't make out the words, but I don't need to. That laugh, that precise, practiced trill that she uses at charity events and dinner parties, is unmistakable.

The bedroom door opens, Malakai stepping inside with an expression that tells me everything I need to know.

"Our parents are here." His voice is carefully neutral. "They stopped by on their way from Monaco to some event in the city. They're staying for dinner."

"Dinner?" My throat chokes around the word, the beautiful world I've been in for the past few days shattering. Some part of me never really wanted them to come back. "They're staying for dinner."

"Just dinner. They'll be gone by nine."

I should be relieved. A few hours, that's all. A few hours of pretending to be the son they never wanted, the twin who never quite measured up, the disappointment they shipped off to boarding school at thirteen because they didn't know what else to do with me.

Instead, I feel sick.

Malakai crosses to the bed and sits beside me, his hand finding the back of my neck in that familiar grip that always settles something inside me. "I need you to take off the collar."

My hand flies to my throat, fingers curling around the leather that's become as essential as breathing over the past few days.

"I know." His thumb strokes along my hairline. "I know it's hard. But they can't see it, Elliot. No one can know what happens between us."

"I understand." I do understand. That doesn't make it any easier.

His fingers find the buckle at the back of my neck, and I hold my breath as he unfastens it. The leather slides away from my skin and I feel naked without it. The comforting attachment has given me peace, knowing that Malakai is control. Without it...

"It's just for a few hours." He sets the collar on the nightstand, within sight but out of reach. "I'll put it back on the moment they leave. I promise."

"I know." I force myself to stand, moving across the hall to my room so I can pull out clothes that are appropriate for a family dinner I never wanted to attend. "I'll be fine."

I'm not sure either of us believes that.



I'm going to die tonight, mostly because the panic of hearing Mom in the foyer has only heightened. Will they catch on about what's happening? Will they be able to see something on my face? Will Malakai protect me if something happens? Why are they back anyway?

The few times I came back from boarding school, they never tried to be around or cared. It was always Mrs. Callahan who was there to greet me and hear about school life, my troubles, or boyfriends who never seemed to stick around.

Something about their presence here feels... off.

I slip into my usual seat when the four of us are sharing dinner, my father at the head, Mom seated along the side next to him, Malakai across from her, and my seat the farthest away, on the other side of Malakai. It's like they're the perfect trio of family and I was somehow the afterthought. The silence is broken only by the clink of silverware against porcelain and my mother's endless stream of chatter once everyone is settled.

"The charity gala in Monaco was simply divine. You should have seen the Rothschilds' yacht, Richard. Absolutely stunning. Three decks, a helipad, the works." She takes a delicate sip of wine, her eyes sweeping over the table without ever quite landing on me. "And the Hendersons asked after you, Malakai. Their daughter is still single, you know. Lovely girl. Very accomplished."

"I'm not interested." Malakai's voice comes out flat, a final edge to it. He's never been interested in whoever they've tried to pair him up with and I've never cared. Tonight, though, a pang of jealousy hits me square in the chest at the idea of someone else having Malakai the way I want him.

The way I want him.

Fuck.

Not good.

"You're never interested." She sighs dramatically. "At some point, you'll need to think about the family legacy. An heir. Someone to carry on the Ashford name."

"The Ashford name is doing fine."

I keep my eyes fixed on my plate, pushing roasted vegetables around with my fork while I try to make myself as small as possible. It's a skill I perfected years ago, the art of disappearing in plain sight. If I'm quiet enough, maybe they'll forget I'm here entirely. I also didn't ask for permission to eat so I'm not sure if I should.

My disappearing act almost works.

"And how are you settling in, Elliot?" My mother's attention shifts to me so suddenly I nearly choke on my own spit. "Malakai mentioned you've taken a position at the company."

"Yes." I clear my throat, forcing my voice to stay steady. "Junior analyst in the finance department. I started today, actually."

"That's nice, dear." She's already turning away, her interest exhausted by the single sentence I've managed to provide. "Richard, did you speak with Harrison about the security contracts? Malakai mentioned there might be some concerns about the overseas expansion."

And just like that, I cease to exist.

My father hasn't looked at me once since we sat down. He's been glued to his phone through the entire meal, occasionally grunting responses to my mother's questions but otherwise existing in his own world. A world that apparently doesn't include his younger son.

Not that this is new. Richard Ashford has never known what to do with me. I'm too soft, too quiet, and too unlike the golden child seated across the table. Where Malakai has a commanding presence that aligns with the family name, I'm all awkward angles and uncomfortable silences. Where Malakai thrived under their demanding expectations, I crumbled.

They sent me away because it was easier than trying to understand me. And now that I'm back, nothing has changed.

Under the table, Malakai's hand finds my thigh.

The touch brings me down from the panic swirling in my chest, a silent reminder that I'm not as alone as I feel. His fingers press into my muscle with just enough pressure to keep me from spiraling into the familiar pit of worthlessness that my parents' presence always seems to dig.

"The security division has exceeded projections by fifteen percent this quarter," Malakai explains, the professional edge to his tone giving nothing away regarding his current hand placement. "The overseas expansion is on track for Q3."

"Excellent." My father finally looks up from his phone, the pride in his eyes making something twist painfully in my chest. What I wouldn't give for that look to be focused on me even just once. "I knew putting you in charge was the right decision. You've always had a head for this business."

"Unlike some people," my mother adds with a light laugh that's probably meant to be teasing but lands rather harshly. "Not everyone is meant for leadership, dear. There's no shame in supporting roles."

Malakai's hand clamps down on my thigh so hard I have to bite back a gasp. "Elliot is probably one of the best analysts on my floor. His work today was excellent."

My mother looks genuinely surprised. "Oh. Well. That's lovely."

She turns to my father to discuss something about their upcoming trip to Milan as I cease to exist again. The conversation flows around me, and I sit there in silence, feeling the phantom weight of the collar I'm not wearing and the very real weight of Malakai's hand on my leg. I nearly gather up the courage to whisper if I can eat before I'm cut off.

"Maybe all you needed was to let your brother look after you." My mother's voice cuts through my thoughts, my mother watching me with an expression that might almost be fond. "You always did better when you had someone to guide you. Remember how lost you were after boarding school? You ended up running off to California, getting mixed up with that awful boyfriend." She shakes her head. "I'm glad you're home, dear. Malakai will take good care of you."

She means it lightly but she has no idea how close it lands.

I push back from the table, my chair scraping against the hardwood floor with a sound that makes everyone look up. "Excuse me." My voice comes out steadier than I feel. "I'm not feeling well. I think I'll lie down." Malakai is going to punish me for this but I don't care. I can't stay here anymore.

"Oh." My mother's brow furrows with something that might be concern if I didn't know better. "Well. Feel better, dear."

My father doesn't even look up from his phone.

I make it to the hallway before the first tear falls, my feet taking me to my room without thinking about it. My childhood bedroom feels foreign now, like a museum exhibit of a life I no longer live. The posters on the walls, the

books on the shelves, the trophies from sports I quit years ago, they all belong to someone else. Someone I used to be before Marcus, before California, before I came home and let my brother take me apart piece by piece.

I plop down on the edge of the bed and stare at nothing, that familiar numbness spreading through my chest. *Invisible. Worthless. Tolerated rather than loved.* The feelings are so old, so deeply ingrained, that they fit like a second skin. Everything Malakai worked so hard for over the last few days, all those fuzzy feelings and the quietness in my head starts to crack and fall away.

I don't know how long I sit there before the door opens. Malakai doesn't knock. He just walks in like he owns the place, taking in the scene before saying anything. "They're gone." He closes the door behind him with a soft click before setting something on my dresser. "Their car came early. Something about the event starting sooner than expected, I believe but I'm sure they were just done with what they came for."

I don't respond. I can't find the words through the fog that's settled over my brain.

He crosses the room and stops in front of me, close enough that I have to tilt my head back to meet his eyes. Whatever he sees in my face makes his expression soften in a way that hurts almost as much as my parents' indifference.

"On your knees, little doe."

The command cuts through the numbness like a blade, and I slide off the bed and onto the floor without conscious thought. The position is automatic now, my body knowing what to do even when my mind has checked out.

"Good boy." His hand cups my jaw, tilting my face up toward his. "You're spiraling. I can see it."

"I'm fine." The lie tastes like ash on my tongue.

"You're not fine. And that's okay." He strokes his thumb across my cheekbone, wiping away the tears from earlier. "That's why I'm here."

He releases my jaw and steps back, and for a moment I think he's going to leave. Instead, he helps me stand and then reaches for the hem of my sweater and pulls it over my head in one smooth motion. The cool air hits my bare skin as he continues to undress me like a doll, his fingers ghosting over newly bared skin each time. My pants follow, then my socks, until he has me kneeling again only in nothing but my boxers.

"This isn't punishment." He circles behind me, his footsteps soft against the carpet. "This is reclamation. You went somewhere dark, and I'm going to bring you back." His hands land on my shoulders, my body sagging a bit as I let out a heavy breath. "Focus on me." His voice drops into a lower register. "There's nothing else. Just my hands. Just my voice. Let everything else fall away."

He starts to touch me.

At first, it isn't even sexual. Just long, sweeping strokes down my back, across my shoulders, along my arms. His fingers trace patterns on my skin that I can't decipher, and I feel myself sinking deeper into that floaty space where nothing exists except sensation.

"That's it." His breath is warm against my ear. "Just feel. Don't think."

He drops to his knees in front of me, his hands moving to my chest, palms flat against my skin, fingers brushing over my nipples just lightly enough to make me gasp. The touch sends sparks cascading through my nervous

system, my cock starting to stir despite the emotional turmoil of the evening.

"Your body knows what it needs." He pinches one nipple, then the other, and I have to bite back a moan. "Even when your mind is too tangled up to understand."

He spends what feels like hours touching me everywhere, his hands mapping every inch of my skin like he's memorizing the territory. My neck, my arms, my stomach, my thighs. He traces the fading bruises Marcus left behind with a tenderness that makes my eyes burn. He circles my nipples until they're peaked and sensitive. He runs his nails down my back just hard enough to leave trails of fire in their wake.

And through it all, he talks.

"You're not invisible." His voice is steady, almost taking on a hypnotic nature. "You've never been invisible to me. From the moment we were born, I've seen you. Every part of you. The parts you try to hide, the parts you're ashamed of, and the parts you think make you weak. I see all of it, Elliot. And I want all of it."

I'm trembling now, my body strung tight with a need that has nothing to do with the numbness that brought me here. His hands dip lower, skimming along the waistband of my boxers, a whimper tearing from the back of my throat.

"Please." The word tears itself from my throat. "Please, sir."

"Please what?" His fingers trace the outline of my cock through the thin cotton. "Tell me what you need."

"I need to come." The admission comes raw, my voice hoarse with need. "I need you to make me come. Please. I can't think about anything else

when you touch me. I can't feel anything except you." Tears run down my cheeks at the intensity of the emotion coursing through me.

"That's the point." He finally wraps his hand around me through the fabric, and I cry out at the contact. "When they make you feel small, I'm going to make you feel everything. When they make you feel worthless, I'm going to show you exactly how much you're worth."

He strokes me slowly, building the pleasure with a patience that borders on cruelty. Every time I get close, every time I feel that familiar tightening at the base of my spine, he backs off, changes the rhythm, or denies me the release I'm begging for.

"Not yet." His own voice is rough now, strained with his own arousal. "You don't come until I say you can."

"Please." Tears are streaming down my face, and I don't know if they're from the edging or the emotions or some combination of both. "Please, Malakai. I can't take it anymore. I need it. I need you."

"You have me." He pulls down my boxers and wraps his bare hand around my cock, the skin-on-skin contact makes me sob. "You've always had me, little doe. Even when you didn't know it. Even when you ran away. I was always here, waiting for you to come home."

He strokes me faster now, his grip tightening around my length, my body hurtling toward the edge with a speed that leaves me breathless.

"Come for me."

My orgasm crashes through me, whiting out my vision and tearing a scream from my throat. Pleasure explodes through every nerve ending, so intense it borders on pain, my body shaking as Malakai strokes me through it.

When the aftershocks subside, I collapse against him, my brother catching me easily, pulling me into his lap and cradling me against his chest while I sob into his neck. "I've got you." His hand strokes through my hair. "I've got you, little doe. You did so well."

"They don't see me." The words come out broken, muffled against his skin. "They've never seen me."

"I know." His arms tighten around me. "That's their failure, not yours."

"It still hurts."

"I know it does." He presses his lips to my temple. "But you're not invisible. Not to me. Never to me."

He holds me while I cry, but they're different tears this time. They aren't the numb, hopeless tears of before, but something more pure, something that feels almost like release.

Eventually, the tears slow and my breathing steadies. Malakai shifts beneath me, reaching for what he left on my dresser, producing a small plate of food. He hands me the plate, the roasted vegetables softly decorated with cheese. "When it's not just the two of us, you do not have to ask for permission if it deals with your well-being. This isn't just when Mom and Dad come home but at the office, too. You aren't to skip meals or avoid the bathroom."

I offer him a meager nod, letting him feed me the few bites before setting the plate down on the floor. Then he reaches for the dresser again, producing my collar.

"May I?"

I nod, unable to form words, and tilt my chin up to give him access to my throat. The leather settles against my skin like it was meant to be there, and I let out a shaky breath as he fastens the buckle.

"There." His fingers trace the edge of the collar. "That's better, isn't it?"

"Yes, sir." My voice comes out a little hoarse. "Thank you."

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Malakai

The morning starts like clockwork. My phone buzzes at 6:47, Elliot's text appearing on the screen like a small act of devotion.

I'm awake, sir.

I smile at the message and type my response.

Good boy. Collar on. Kneel. I'm coming to watch.

The three dots appear, then disappear. Then:

Yes, sir.

I find him in his bedroom, already sinking to his knees beside his bed, the collar fastened around his throat as I lean against the doorframe to observe.

He's beautiful like this. Eyes closed, spine straight, hands resting palm-up on his thighs. The tension that lived in his shoulders when he first came home has started to fade, replaced by something softer, more settled. He's

learning to let go and learning to trust me. The small act of devotion fills in a piece of me I didn't even know I was missing.

For as much as I've loved being the golden boy of the family, the one who will carry on the legacy of the Ashford name, I've loved the idea of someone depending on me even more. And now I have it.

I watch the slow rise and fall of his chest as he breathes, my mind wandering to darker places.

What would it be like to stand over him right now, my cock in my hand, stroking myself while he kneels in perfect submission? What sounds would he make if I painted his face with my release, marking him in the most primal way possible? Would he open his mouth and beg for it, or would those pretty eyes go wide with shock before melting into acceptance?

My cock stirs at the thought, pressing insistently against my zipper. I could do it. I could walk over there right now, pull myself free, and use him exactly the way my body is demanding. He would let me. He would thank me for it.

But not yet. Not this morning.

I file the fantasy away for later and force my attention back to the present. His timer goes off, a soft chime that breaks the silence, and his eyes flutter open. When he sees me standing in the doorway, color floods his cheeks.

"Sir." His voice is rough with a mixture of sleep and desire. "I didn't notice you actually came."

"I told you I was going to." I push off the doorframe and cross to him, my fingers finding their familiar place at the back of his neck. "You did well. How do you feel?"

"Quiet." The word comes out soft, almost reverent. "My head feels quiet. I really like this part of the morning."

"Good." I squeeze his neck once before releasing him. "Get dressed. Breakfast is in thirty minutes."

The day unfolds in its familiar rhythm. Breakfast, where he asks permission before eating and reports what he consumed. Morning kneeling in my study while I handle correspondence. Lunch, where he feeds himself now but still waits for my nod before picking up his fork.

He's been mostly good since the incident with our parents. There's been a few minor slip-ups, quickly corrected, but nothing that required more than a sharp word or a pointed look. The structure seems to be settling into his bones, becoming less of a cage and more of a framework that holds him together.

But I can see the chafing too.

The slight tightening around his eyes when I make him wait for permission to use the bathroom. The barely suppressed sigh when I deny his request to stretch his legs during a long kneeling session. The way his jaw sets when he has to ask for something he considers trivial.

He needs the rules. We both know that. But accepting that need and embracing it are two different things, and Elliot is still fighting the latter.

After lunch, I have a conference call with our overseas partners that will take at least two hours. I leave Elliot in the library with instructions to read and rest, then head to my study and close the door.

The call drags on, filled with the kind of tedious negotiations that make me wish I'd gone into literally any other profession. By the time we're wrapping up, nearly three hours have passed, and my patience is worn thin.

I check my phone. No messages from Elliot. Good. He's following instructions.

Except something feels off.

I can't explain it or point to any concrete evidence, but instinct prickles at the back of my neck as I make my way downstairs. The library is empty. His book sits abandoned on the side table, the spine cracked to mark his place.

I check the kitchen. The study. The sitting room. *Nothing*.

Then I hear the front door open.

I'm in the foyer before he's fully through the entrance, my arms crossed over my chest as I watch him freeze in the doorway. He's holding a small pharmacy bag, his face flushed from the cold outside, and the moment our eyes meet, I see the realization crash through him.

He didn't ask.

"Did you forget something, Elliot Aurelis?"

His throat bobs as he swallows. "Malakai, I can explain—"

"Can you?" I keep my voice perfectly level, which seems to frighten him more than shouting would. "Please. I'm fascinated to hear your explanation for why you left the house without permission while I was in a meeting."

"I needed something from the pharmacy." He holds up the bag like it's evidence in his defense. "It was just ten minutes. I didn't want to interrupt your call for something so small."

"So you decided the rules didn't apply."

"No, that's not—" He cuts himself off, his eyes dropping to the floor. "I didn't think it was a big deal."

"You didn't think." I let the words hang in the air between us, watching him shrink beneath their weight. "That's exactly the problem, Elliot. You didn't think. You decided, on your own, that your judgment was better than mine. That some rules are more important than others. That you get to choose when to obey and when to do whatever you want."

"I'm sorry." His voice comes out small. "I should have texted you. I should have waited."

"Yes. You should have." I uncross my arms and gesture toward the stairs. "Upstairs. My room. Now."

He moves past me without another word, his shoulders hunched and his head bowed. I follow at a distance, giving him time to stew in the anticipation of what's coming. A thousand ideas run through my head regarding what I want to do to my brother and how I want him to understand his punishment but there's also some part of me that wants to make sure he falls apart.

I don't bother turning on the lights once we get into my room. The shadows seem appropriate for what I have planned.

"Strip."

He hesitates for just a moment before he drops his bag, his hands then moving to the hem of his sweater. I watch as he pulls it over his head, revealing the lean lines of his torso, the sweater falling to the floor in a soft heap. His fingers tremble slightly as they move to his belt, fumbling with the buckle before finally working it free. His pants follow, sliding down his legs and pooling at his ankles before he steps out of them.

He pauses there, standing in just his underwear, his cock already beginning to tent the thin fabric.

"I said strip." My voice carries no room for negotiation. "All of it."

His cheeks flush darker as he hooks his thumbs into the waistband and pushes the last barrier down his legs. When he straightens, he's completely bare before me, his cock half-hard and curving slightly toward his stomach. His hands twitch at his sides like he wants to cover himself but knows better than to try.

"On the bed. On your back."

He complies, climbing onto the mattress and settling against the pillows with his arms at his sides. His breathing has quickened, his chest rising and falling with shallow anticipation. I let myself take an extra few seconds, drinking in every inch of exposed skin, every tremor of nervous energy, and every sign of the arousal he's unable to hide no matter how hard he tries.

I shed my jacket and roll up my sleeves, taking my time, letting the silence stretch and grow heavy between us. His eyes track my movements with barely concealed desperation, his tongue darting out to wet his lips when I finally move toward the bed.

When I join him on the mattress, kneeling beside his hip, he's trembling.

"Do you know why you're being punished?"

"Because I left without permission." His voice wavers, catching on the last word.

"Because you decided the rules only apply when it's convenient for you." I trail my fingers down his chest, watching goosebumps rise in their wake. His nipples peak as my touch passes near them, and I file that reaction away for later use. "Because you thought a trip to the pharmacy was too small to matter. Because you still don't understand that every rule, every requirement, and every moment of obedience exists for a reason."

My hand wraps around his cock, and he gasps at the contact. He's fully hard now, his length hot and heavy against my palm as I stroke him slowly, letting him feel every callus on my fingers.

"The rules aren't arbitrary, Elliot. They're not about controlling you for the sake of control." I twist my wrist on the upstroke, his hips jerking involuntarily. "They're about teaching you to surrender. To trust. To let go of the part of your brain that's always second-guessing, always rationalizing,

always looking for loopholes." I tighten my grip and stroke faster, watching his chest heave with ragged breaths. "When you decide which rules to follow, you're not submitting. You're just playing pretend."

"I understand." The words come out breathless, broken by a moan he can't quite suppress. "I'm sorry. I won't do it again."

"I know you won't." I bring him to the edge in under a minute, his body so responsive, so attuned to my touch, that it takes almost nothing to get him there. He's gasping, his hands fisting in the sheets, his cock leaking against his stomach, the head flushed an angry red. "Because I'm going to make sure you remember this lesson for a very long time."

And then I let go.

The sound he makes is somewhere between a whine and a sob, his hips bucking into empty air as his approaching orgasm recedes. I watch his cock twitch uselessly, a bead of precum sliding down the shaft as his body screams for contact that isn't coming.

I wait and let him come down, the desperation building until he's squirming against the sheets, his eyes wild and pleading.

"Malakai, please—"

"Please *what*?" I wrap my hand around him again, stroking with the same maddening rhythm. "Please let you come? After you disobeyed me?"

"I said I was sorry." He's panting now, sweat beginning to bead along his hairline. "I won't do it again, I promise."

"I know you're sorry." I bring him to the edge again, feeling his cock pulse against my palm, his balls drawing tight against his body. His thighs are trembling, his stomach muscles clenching with every stroke, and I can tell by the way his breath catches that he's right there, right on the precipice. "But sorry isn't enough."

I let go.

His cry echoes off the walls, the rawness of it hitting me square in the chest. He throws his head back against the pillows, tears gathering in the corners of his eyes as his body writhes with denied release. His cock bobs against his stomach, leaving wet trails across his skin.

"You want to come?" I grip his jaw with my free hand, forcing him to look at me. His pupils are blown so wide his eyes look almost black, and the tears have started to spill down his temples. "Then you should have asked permission before leaving the house."

The third edge is worse than the first two. I draw it out, keeping him hovering on the precipice for what feels like an eternity. I'm hard as well, the little control I have left keeping me from stroking myself to completion. My hand moves in slow, measured strokes, building the pressure with excruciating patience. His face contorts with pleasure and frustration, his hands still clawing at the sheets until his knuckles go white, his hips canting upward in desperate little thrusts that he can't seem to control.

"Please." The word comes out broken, barely recognizable. "Please, I'm so close, please don't stop, please—"

I stop.

The sob that tears from his throat is the most beautiful sound I've ever heard. His whole body convulses, back arching off the mattress as he chases a release that keeps slipping away. By now, tears are streaming down his face in earnest, and his pleas have devolved into incoherent begging.

"Please, please, I can't, I need it, please Malakai please—"

"What do you need?"

"I need to come." The words come out shattered, scattered across ragged breaths. "Please, sir. Please let me come. I'll ask permission for everything.

I'll never leave without telling you again. I'll do anything, anything you want, just please—"

"Anything?"

"Anything." He's nodding frantically, his eyes wild with desperation. "I'm yours. All of me. Every part. I'll be good, I promise I'll be good, please—"

I wrap my hand around him again, and his moan is almost a scream. I stroke him slowly, watching his face crumble with each pass of my fist. "You want to come so badly, don't you?" I run my thumb over the head of his cock, smearing the precum that's been leaking steadily. "Look at you. Crying and begging like this is the only thing that matters in the world."

"It is." His voice cracks. "Right now it is. Please, sir. I'll do anything. I'll be anything you want. Just let me come."

"Not yet."

The fourth denial breaks something in him.

The scream he releases is hoarse, his throat already raw from begging. His body goes rigid, every muscle locked tight as his orgasm crests and then crashes back down without release. I can feel his cock throbbing in my grip and I can see the way his balls draw up tight like his body is trying desperately to come even without my permission.

But he doesn't. He can't. Because I won't let him.

When the wave passes, he collapses against the mattress. He doesn't beg this time. He just lies there, tears sliding silently down his temples as his cock throbs uselessly against his stomach. The fight has gone out of him completely, replaced by a surrender so complete it takes my breath away.

"I asked for one thing." I lean down, my lips brushing against his ear. My voice comes out rougher than I intended, my own arousal threatening to

undo this moment. "One thing, Elliot. Obedience. Not some of the time. Not when it's convenient. Always. Is that so much to ask?"

"No, sir." His voice is barely a whisper, cracked and ruined. "It's not."

"Then you understand why I had to do this?"

"Yes, sir." A shudder runs through him, his body still twitching with aftershocks of denied pleasure. "I understand."

I stroke him again, and the sound he makes is almost inhuman. His back arches off the bed, his hands scrabbling at the sheets, at my arms, at anything he can reach. He's beyond words now, reduced to pure sensation and desperate need.

The fifth edge has him sobbing openly, his body arching off the bed as I bring him right to the brink and hold him there. His pulse pounds against my palm and I can feel the way his cock twitches with every heartbeat, begging for a release I haven't decided to grant.

"I need to hear you say it." My voice comes out rough, strained with my own arousal that I've been ignoring for the past several minutes. "Tell me you need the rules. Tell me you need me to control you."

"I need it." The words spill out between sobs, barely coherent. "I need the rules. I need you to control me. I need you, Malakai. Please. I can't do this without you. I can't be anything without you telling me what to be."

"Good boy."

I stroke him hard and fast, finally giving him what he's been begging for, as his orgasm tears through him. His back arches again, a scream ripping from his throat as he spills over my fist and across his stomach. The first pulse is so strong it hits his chin, and I stroke him through it, wringing every last drop of pleasure from his trembling body.

The sight of him like this, utterly destroyed and completely surrendered, undoes something in me I wasn't prepared for. My free hand moves without conscious thought, pressing against my own aching cock through my pants, the pressure alone enough to push me over an edge I didn't realize I was standing on.

I unload in my pants, my release spilling hot and wet against the inside of my boxers as I watch Elliot shake apart beneath me. The orgasm rips through me with a ferocity that steals my breath, my hand tightening involuntarily around his cock as my own pleasure crashes through me in waves I can't control.

I've been holding off for days, telling myself I was building toward the moment I could finally sink inside him and claim him completely. But this, watching him break and beg and finally shatter at my command, has undone every shred of my carefully maintained control.

It reveals something I hadn't been ready to admit, even to myself. I need him just as desperately as he needs me. This isn't just about power or control or teaching him to submit. This is about a hunger that's lived in my bones since long before he came home, a craving that's only grown sharper with every day he's spent on his knees at my feet.

Elliot doesn't notice. He's too far gone, his eyes unfocused and glazed, his body still twitching with the aftershocks of his own release. His orgasm seems to last forever, wave after wave crashing through him until he's nothing but a shaking, sobbing mess beneath my hands. When it finally subsides, he collapses against the mattress so completely that I briefly wonder if he's passed out.

He hasn't, though. His eyes are open, staring at nothing, tears still tracking down his cheeks. His chest heaves with ragged breaths as his cock twitches

weakly against his thigh.

I take a moment to collect myself, to steady my breathing and push down the vulnerability that my unexpected release has exposed. Then I disappear into the attached bathroom for a warm cloth, cleaning him up first, taking my time, being gentle with his abused flesh. He whimpers when I wipe down his cock, his hips jerking away from the contact, and I murmur soothing words until he settles.

I clean myself discreetly while he floats in the aftermath, wiping away the evidence of my own loss of control before he can notice. This moment isn't about me. It's about him learning what he needs, accepting what he is.

But later, when I'm alone, I'll sit with what just happened. I'll examine the way my body betrayed me, the way watching him come apart was enough to make me lose myself completely. For now, I gather him into my arms and pull him against my chest.

"You needed that." I press my lips to his temple, tasting the salt of his tears. "You needed to be reminded."

"I know." His voice is wrecked, barely audible, scraped raw from screaming. "I know."

"You like this." I stroke my hand through his sweat-damp hair. "You need the rules. The structure. It's not weakness, little doe. It's who you are."

He's quiet for a long moment, his breath slowly steadying against my neck. His fingers curl into my shirt like he's afraid I might disappear, and I tighten my arms around him in silent reassurance.

When he finally speaks, the words come out soft but certain. "I know," he whispers. "I finally know."

I hold him until his trembling stops, until his breathing evens out into something close to normal, until the tears have dried on his cheeks and his

body has gone heavy with exhaustion.

"Sleep." I press a kiss to his forehead. "I'll wake you for dinner."

His eyes are already drifting closed, exhaustion pulling him under. "Yes, sir."

I watch him for a moment longer, this beautiful, broken boy who has given himself to me so completely. Then I rise from the bed and leave him to rest, the dampness in my trousers a reminder of how thoroughly he's gotten under my skin.

He's learning. Slowly, painfully, but he's learning.

And so, it seems, am I.



Elliot

The past week has settled into something more than a routine. It's become comfortable, something I almost look forward to. Not having to think and just follow rules has given me a peace of mind I've been craving and Malakai is everything I've been looking for. I wish I had figured that out *before* I ran off looking for answers.

Now? It's just perfection.

I wake up, text Malakai, put on my collar, and kneel for five minutes. Breakfast follows, then kneeling in the study while he works, then lunch, then more kneeling or reading or whatever task he assigns me. The routine has become second nature, the rules are no longer something I fight against but something I lean into, a framework that holds me together when everything else feels uncertain.

I've only worn the plug twice more since that first day at work. The second time was uneventful, just another day of squirming in my desk chair while trying to focus on spreadsheets. But the third time was different.

The third time, Malakai caught Connor standing a little too close to me during lunch. I hadn't thought much of it at the time, just Connor being Connor with his too-friendly smiles and his lingering glances. But Malakai had seen, and within the hour, I was summoned to his office with that familiar text that made my heart rate spike.

My office. Now.

What happened next still makes my face heat when I think about it.

He didn't say a word about Connor. My brother just locked the door, bent me over his desk, and worked the plug in and out of me until I was sobbing and begging for release. Then he lifted me onto his desk, spread my legs, and took me into his mouth like he was trying to consume me whole.

I came so hard I saw stars. And then I couldn't function for the rest of the day.

Every time I tried to focus on work, all I could think about was his mouth, his hands, and the way he'd looked up at me from between my thighs with those dark, possessive eyes. By the time we got home that evening, I was already half-hard again, desperate for more of whatever he wanted to give me.

I've been more careful around Connor since then. Not because Malakai told me to, but because I physically cannot handle the consequences of making my brother jealous. My brain turns to mush when he touches me, and I need at least some cognitive function to do my job.

The initial passion of this arrangement has evolved into something deeper, the frantic desperation of those first few days giving way to a quieter kind

of intimacy, one built on routine and trust and the growing certainty that I am exactly where I belong.

Malakai has started touching me more, too. Not just sexually, but in small ways throughout the day that make my chest ache with something I'm afraid to name. A hand on my hip while we're standing in the kitchen. Fingers brushing against my throat when he adjusts my collar. His palm cupping my cheek when he tells me I've been good.

In the evenings, we've moved from the study to the lounge. He'll sit on one end of the sofa with a book or his tablet, and I'll lie down with my head in his lap, his fingers carding through my hair while I drift in and out of sleep. Sometimes we talk. Sometimes we don't. Either way, I always wake up feeling more rested than I have in years.

It's comfortable. Safe. Everything I never knew I needed.

Which is why I'm caught off guard when Malakai produces a velvet box at breakfast and sets it on the table between us.

"I want to try something new."

I set down my fork, my appetite suddenly forgotten. There's something different in his expression, a careful intensity that puts me on alert. "Okay." I draw the word out slowly. "What kind of something?"

"Before I show you, I want to establish some new rules." He folds his hands on the table, his gaze holding mine with that focused attention that always makes me feel like the only person in the world. "A color system. For communication."

I frown, confusion creasing my brow. "A color system?"

"Green means you're okay, you want to continue. Yellow means you need to slow down, you need a moment to process. Red means everything stops

immediately, no questions asked." He holds my gaze. "If you say red, we stop. Completely. I don't care what we're in the middle of."

"We've never needed that before." The words come out before I can stop them. "You've always just known when to push and when to back off."

"This is different." He pauses, his jaw tightening slightly. "What I want to try is more intense than anything we've done before. I want to push you, but I don't want to push too hard."

"Because I need this?" I search his face, looking for something to answer my question but don't find it. "Because this is what's good for me?"

He hesitates. Just for a second, but I catch it. A flicker of uncertainty that cracks through his carefully maintained composure. And suddenly I see it. The veil lifting on something I should have recognized weeks ago. This isn't just about what I need. It's about what he wants.

All of it, the rules, the control, the constant touching and the possessive looks and the way he watches me like I'm the only thing in the world worth seeing. It's not just an arrangement designed to help me heal. It's his desire, raw and real and just as desperate as my own.

Instead of pushing back, though, I find that I love the idea someone wants me for more than just to help me with my needs. He wants me for *me*. "I want to please you." The words come out soft but with a confidence I'm slowly learning to lean into. "Whatever you want to do, whatever you need from me, I want to give it to you."

His eyes darken, his throat working as he swallows. "Elliot..."

"I mean it." I reach across the table and take his hand, something I've never initiated before. "Tell me the colors again."

He's quiet for a long moment, his fingers tightening around mine. When he finally speaks, his voice is rougher than usual. "Green means good.

Yellow means slow down. Red means stop."

"Green means good. Yellow means slow down. Red means stop." I repeat them back, holding his gaze. "I understand. Now show me what you want to try."

He releases my hand and reaches beneath the table, producing a velvet box that he sets between us.

"What is it?"

"Open it."

I reach for the box with trembling fingers, my heart already beating faster than it should. The lid lifts smoothly, revealing a bed of black silk and something metal nestled in its center. It takes me a moment to understand what I'm looking at.

It's a cage. A delicate lattice of polished steel designed to fit around a cock, with a small ring at the base and a tiny lock at the front. The craftsmanship is beautiful, but the implication makes my heart drop into my stomach.

"Malakai..." My voice comes out strangled. "Is this what I think it is?"

"Your pleasure belongs to me now." He reaches across the table and plucks the cage from the box, turning it over in his fingers so I can see every angle. "This will ensure you remember that even when I'm not with you."

"I don't understand." But I do. God help me, I do. "You want me to wear this?"

"It fits around your cock." He speaks matter-of-factly, like he's explaining a new piece of office equipment. I'm not that much of a prude I don't know what it is but I've also never really gone down *that* road either. "Once it's on, you won't be able to get hard. The cage prevents an erection entirely."

He holds up a small silver key that was hidden beneath the silk. "Only removed with this. Which I keep."

I stare at the cage, then at the key, then at Malakai's face. He watches me with that careful intensity he gets when he's trying to read my reaction, to gauge whether he's pushed too far. He sets the cage down between us. "Now, tell me the colors again, little doe." His voice has gone all husky, one quick look between his thighs telling me that this might be something he's been fantasizing about.

"Green means good. Yellow means slow down. Red means stop."

"Good boy." He picks up the cage again. "Now. I'm going to put this on you. But first, I'm going to make you come. It's easier to fit when you're soft, and I want you to start this experience from a place of satisfaction, not desperation."

My cock twitches at the words, already interested despite the anxiety coiling in my stomach. "Here? At the breakfast table?"

"Does that bother you?"

It should. But nothing about my life with Malakai follows the rules of what should and shouldn't be anymore. "No, sir."

"Then stand up and push your pants down. Let me see you."

I obey, rising from my chair and unfastening my pants. The fabric pools at my ankles, followed by my underwear, and I stand there half-naked, my cock already beginning to fill under Malakai's hungry gaze.

"Beautiful." He rises from his own chair and circles around the table to stand in front of me. His hand wraps around my length, a gasp tearing from my throat in response. "I'm going to miss seeing you hard for me. But watching you strain against the cage, desperate and denied, might be even better."

He steps up behind me, his chest pressing against my back, the hard line of his cock through his pants grinding against my bare ass. His hand wraps around my length again while the other grips my hip, pulling me back against him.

"I've been thinking about this all morning." His voice is rough against my ear as he starts to move, his hips rolling forward in slow, measured thrusts that have nothing to do with the hand working my cock and everything to do with something far more primal. "About having you like this. About being inside you."

I whimper at the words, at the image they bring into my head. His clothed cock slides along the seam of my ass, the friction of expensive fabric against my bare skin making me shudder. His hand strokes me in time with his thrusts, and my mind fractures, unable to tell the difference between what's happening and what I desperately want to happen.

"Is this what you think about?" His teeth graze my earlobe. "When you're kneeling for me? When you're lying in my lap? Do you imagine me taking you properly?"

"Yes." The shameless confession falls from my lips as I arch back against him, my hands braced on the table. "All the time. I think about it all the time."

He groans against my neck, his hips snapping forward harder, and I can feel how hard he is, how much he wants this too. His hand tightens on my hip, fingers digging in hard enough to bruise as he continues grinding against me.

"One day." The words come out fractured, his control slipping. "One day I'm going to bend you over this table and fuck you until you can't remember your own name."

The image fills my thoughts: Malakai behind me, inside me, filling me up while his hand pins me down and his voice tells me what a good boy I am. I can almost feel it, the stretch, the burn, the overwhelming fullness of having him claim me completely.

"Please." I'm pushing back against him now, chasing the phantom sensation of something that isn't there yet. "Malakai, please, I want—"

"I know what you want." His hand speeds up on my cock while his hips maintain that maddening rhythm, mimicking the act we haven't committed to yet. "And you'll have it. When you're ready. When I've prepared you properly." His thumb swipes over the head of my cock, spreading the precum that's leaking. "But for now, this is what you get. My hand. My body against yours. The promise of what's coming."

It's too much. The stimulation, the words, the relentless grinding of his cock against my ass. I can feel my orgasm building at the base of my spine, coiling tighter with every thrust.

"Come whenever you're ready." His voice drops lower, rough with his own arousal. "This is the last time you'll be able to for a while. Make it count."

The permission shatters something inside me. My orgasm crashes through me without warning, spilling over his fist and onto the hardwood floor as I cry out his name. My knees buckle, but he holds me up, his arm wrapping around my chest while his hand works me through every pulse and spasm.

Behind me, I feel his hips stutter, hear his breath catch, and for a moment I think he might follow me over the edge. But he doesn't. He just holds me there, grinding slowly against my ass as the aftershocks fade, until I'm soft and trembling and completely wrung out.

"Good boy." He presses a kiss to my temple, his breathing ragged against my hair. "Such a good boy for me." He helps me back into my seat, his gaze roaming up and down my body before landing on my cock. It twitches beneath his attention before he walks into the kitchen. "Now relax. This might be uncomfortable at first."

He returns, a warm cloth dragging down my length, Malakai taking care to clean me up before grabbing my present. The cage is cold when it touches my skin, and I hiss at the sensation. Malakai works carefully, fitting the ring around the base of my cock and balls before sliding the cage itself into place. His fingers are gentle as he adjusts the fit, making sure nothing is pinched or positioned incorrectly.

When he finally clicks the tiny lock closed, the sound echoes through the dining room like a death bell.

"How does it feel?"

I look down at myself, at the metal encasing my cock, and feel a rush of emotions so complex I can't begin to untangle them. Vulnerability. Fear. Arousal that has nowhere to go. And underneath it all, a deep, perverse satisfaction.

"Strange." The word comes out hoarse. "I can feel it." I shift a little to sit up better, the metal moving with me. "Every time I move, I feel it." I don't exactly know how to feel about this. Looking up at my brother, the feral grin on his face has me desperately thinking about spiders but it doesn't work. My cock swells a little, the slight pressure of the cage making it impossible to fully harden.

A little whine tears from the back of my throat as I kneed my knuckles on my bare thighs, trying to stave off the sudden need running through me.

"I see that it's working." Malakai smirks, holding up the key, before slipping it onto a chain around his neck. "You'll feel me all day. Every shift, every step, every breath will remind you who you belong to."

Every day? I don't think I'll be able to do this for more than an hour.

"Color?"

I take a moment to actually assess, the way he's taught me. My body is humming with sensation, my mind spinning with implications, but underneath it all is a bedrock of trust that is keeping me rooted in reality.

"Green."

A slow, satisfied smile spreads across my brother's face. "Good boy." He leans down to help me back into my pants, even going so far as to fasten my belt. "Now finish your breakfast. We leave for the office in an hour."



Elliot

By noon, I'm going insane.

Every thought of Malakai makes my cock try to harden, which means every thought of Malakai is accompanied by a sharp reminder that I can't. The cage prevents any real swelling, but the sensation of trying and failing is maddening. Like an itch I can't scratch. Like a sneeze that won't come.

I shift in my desk chair for the hundredth time, Paulina glancing over with a concerned expression.

"You okay? You've been fidgety all morning."

"Fine." The word comes out strained. "Just drank too much coffee."

She doesn't look convinced, but she lets it go. Thank God for small mercies. My phone buzzes with a text, and I grab it so fast I nearly knock over my actual coffee.

How does it feel?

I glare at the screen, then type my response with more force than necessary.

I hate you.

My brother's reply comes almost instantly.

That's not an answer.

I take a deep breath, trying to find words for the chaos happening inside my body.

It feels like I'm going insane. I can't stop thinking about you and every time I do, the cage reminds me that I can't do anything about it. I'm going to die.

Good.

I stare at that single word, torn between the urge to scream and the urge to laugh. He's enjoying this. The sadistic bastard is sitting in his corner office, probably smirking at his phone, completely aware of the torment he's putting me through.

And the worst part is, some twisted part of me loves it too.

The afternoon drags by in a haze of frustration and distraction. Every time I manage to focus on work, something triggers a thought of Malakai and the cycle starts all over again. The cage rattles against my skin when I walk to the bathroom. It presses against my thigh when I sit back down. It's a constant, inescapable reminder of his control, and by the time the workday ends, I'm ready to crawl out of my skin.

I'm at the coffee machine, desperately needing caffeine to survive the drive home, when Connor Webb appears at my elbow.

"Elliot." The warmth in his voice and the way he says my name always makes me uncomfortable. "You look good today."

"Thanks." I keep my eyes fixed on the pot, willing it to brew faster. "I need to get back to my desk."

"What's the rush?" He steps closer, close enough that I can smell his cologne. It's too strong and aggressive, nothing like Malakai's subtle sandalwood. "We never got that drink."

"I've been busy."

"You're *always* busy." He throws out an exaggerated sigh as he leans against the counter, positioning himself so I'd have to push past him to leave. "Starting to think you're avoiding me."

I *am* avoiding him. Very deliberately, ever since Malakai took me apart in his office for letting Connor stand too close during lunch. But I can't exactly say that. "It's not personal." I finally look at him, hoping my expression conveys how much I want this conversation to end. "I'm just settling into the new job. It takes a lot of focus."

"All work and no play." He shakes his head with exaggerated disappointment. "That's no way to live, Elliot. You need to loosen up. Have some fun."

"I have plenty of fun."

"Do you?" He tilts his head, studying me with an intensity that makes my skin crawl. "Because from where I'm standing, it looks like you spend all your time working and none of your time actually enjoying yourself. Do you even do anything when you get home, or do you just work more?" His smile twists into something that might be teasing if it didn't feel so predatory. "Does our boss play boss at home too? Just telling you what to do all the time?"

The words hit too close to something true, heat flooding my cheeks before I can stop it. My eyes dart away from his face, fixing on the coffee pot like

it holds the answers to every question I've ever had, but I know he's seen the blush. I know he's cataloging it, filing it away as evidence of something I can't let him understand.

"That's none of your business." My voice comes out weaker than I want it to, thin and reedy in the quiet break room.

"Touched a nerve, did I?" He laughs, but there's no warmth in it. "*Relax*, Elliot. I'm just making conversation. Trying to get to know my coworker a little better. Is that such a crime?"

His hand lands on my waist.

The touch is light, almost casual, as if he's done it a thousand times before and has every right to do it again. But it sends a spike of ice through my veins, freezing me in place as every muscle in my body locks up. I can't move or speak or do anything but stand there with another man's hand on my body, my breath coming in shallow little gasps that I desperately hope he can't hear. This is what Marcus taught me to do.

Freeze. Submit. Wait for it to be over.

I hate that my body still defaults to this, that months of conditioning carved these pathways into my nervous system so deeply that I can't seem to override them no matter how hard I try. Everything Malakai has done over the past week falls to the wayside, fear inserting itself in my head rather than rational thought.

"Please stop." The words scrape out of my throat. "I don't like being touched."

"You don't like being touched by me, you mean." Connor's fingers press into my hip, hard enough to make his point. "What's the deal with you and your brother anyway? He's got you on a pretty tight leash, doesn't he? Can't go anywhere without his permission, can't talk to anyone he doesn't approve

of." He shakes his head with mock sympathy. "Must be exhausting, having someone control every aspect of your life like that."

The words hit too close to something true, but not in the way he thinks. My stomach turns at the irony of it, at how right and how wrong he is all at once. He sees the control but misunderstands its nature entirely, thinking it's oppression when it's actually the only thing holding me together.

"That's not how it is," I push out.

"No?" Connor's eyebrow arches with exaggerated skepticism. "Because from where I'm standing, it looks like you can't take a piss without big brother signing off on it. That's not healthy, Elliot. You're a grown man. You should be able to make your own choices, live your own life." His grip tightens on my hip. "Spend time with whoever you want."

I press my hands against his chest and push, trying to create space between us. "I said stop. I'm not interested. I will never be interested. Please just leave me alone."

He doesn't budge. If anything, he leans in closer, his body crowding mine against the counter until I have nowhere left to go. Tears are threatening to spill over now, my composure cracking under the weight of his unwanted attention and my own helpless fear. I feel small and trapped. Just like I felt with Marcus, all those nights when he wouldn't take no for an answer, when my protests fell on deaf ears and my body became something that didn't belong to me anymore.

"Connor, please." My voice breaks on his name. "Please, I can't—"

Movement across the bullpen catches my eye. Malakai is standing outside one of the conference rooms, coffee cup in hand, staring at us with an expression that makes my blood run cold. His face is completely blank, wiped clean of any emotion I might use to gauge his reaction, but his eyes

are burning with something that looks a lot like murder. The stillness of him is somehow more terrifying than any outburst could be, a predator assessing the situation before he strikes, calculating exactly how much damage he wants to inflict.

When the coffee cup shatters in his grip, I know things are about to make a turn for the worst.

Ceramic and hot liquid spray across the floor, splattering against his expensive shoes and the tile, but Malakai doesn't seem to notice. He stares for one moment longer before cutting across the hallway toward us.

Connor follows my gaze and steps back, his hand finally falling away from my waist as he registers the approaching threat. The cocky confidence drains from his face, replaced by something that looks a lot like fear. *Good.* He should be afraid.

"Mr. Ashford." Connor's voice comes out higher than usual. "I was just—"

"Conference room." Malakai's voice is terrifyingly calm. "Now."

Connor hesitates for just a moment, clearly weighing his options, and calculating whether defiance or compliance will serve him better. Whatever he sees in Malakai's face must convince him, because he ducks his head and slinks off across the hallway without another word, his shoulders hunched in defeat.

Malakai watches him go, tracking his progress. Only when Connor disappears into the conference room, does my brother turn that burning gaze on me, my knees threatening to buckle under the weight of his stare.

"Go to the car." The words come out clipped, his control on edge, each syllable bitten off like he's afraid of what might escape if he opens his mouth too wide. "Wait for me there."

"Malakai, I didn't—" The words tumble out in a rush as I desperately try to explain, apologize, or even make him understand that I didn't want this and didn't do anything to encourage Connor's attention.

"I know." Something in his expression softens, just for a moment. His hand lifts like he wants to touch me, but he catches himself at the last second, remembering where we are. "This isn't about you. Go to the car. I'll be down soon."

I rush back to my desk, grab my bag and flee, my heart pounding so hard I can feel it in the cage.



Malakai

I watch Elliot flee toward the elevator, his shoulders hunched and his bag clutched against his chest like a shield. Every instinct in my body screams at me to follow him, to pull him into my arms and hold him until the trembling stops, to kiss away the tears I saw threatening to spill down his cheeks.

But I have something else to handle first.

I take a moment to collect myself, trying to calm my breathing. Connor should understand what happens when someone touches what belongs to me. Except Elliot doesn't belong to me. Not really. Not in any way I can claim publicly.

This is just an arrangement. Just a way to play out my desires while giving him what he needs. At some point it will stop, Elliot will be comfortable in his own skin, and we'll go back to being strangers who share

the same blood. That's what I've been telling myself since the moment he knelt at my feet for the first time.

I don't believe it anymore. Maybe I never did.

The conference room door looms ahead of me, Connor's silhouette obvious through the frosted glass. I pause outside, my hand on the handle, and force myself to take three deep breaths. In. Out. In. Out. In. Out. The rage is still there, coiled tight in my chest, but I've controlled it for now. The way I do with everything.

The way I control Elliot.

I push open the door and step inside, letting it swing shut behind me with a soft click. Connor is standing by the window, his beaten puppy expression evaporating the moment we're alone. His spine straightens, his jaw sets, and when he turns to face me, there's defiance burning in his eyes. *Typical asshole.*

"You can't keep him locked up like that." The accusation in Connor's voice is clear. "He's a grown man, Malakai. He should be able to talk to whoever he wants, go wherever he wants, without you hovering over him like some kind of prison warden. Hell, no one even knew that you had a fucking brother before he literally showed up."

I don't respond and just stand there, watching him, letting the silence stretch until it becomes uncomfortable.

"I'm *serious*." Connor takes a step toward me, emboldened by my lack of reaction. "The way you control him isn't healthy. He jumps every time you walk into a room. He can't make a single decision without looking to you for approval first. That's not normal sibling behavior. That's abuse."

My control wavers at the newest accusation. He has no idea what abuse looks like. He has no idea what Elliot looked like when he came home,

covered in bruises and flinching at shadows, so broken that he couldn't eat or sleep without someone telling him it was okay.

But this conversation isn't about Elliot. Not really. It's about Connor.

"Are you finished?" My voice comes out flat, devoid of any emotion. I roll my shoulders, assuming more of that *Mr. Ashford* persona I usually reserve for speaking with investors.

"No, I'm not finished!" Connor's face reddens with anger. "Someone needs to stand up for him since he clearly can't stand up for himself. You've got him so beaten down that he can't even—"

"I asked if you were finished." I take a step closer, something in my expression making him falter. "Because if you are, I'd like to discuss something else entirely."

"What else is there to discuss? This is about Elliot. This is about the way you treat him."

"No." I pull a folder from the conference table, one I'd placed there earlier in anticipation of this conversation. I had already been planning to speak with him this afternoon, so it's perfect timing. "This is about the five complaints that have crossed my desk in the past week. All of them about you."

Connor's face goes pale. "What complaints?"

"Unwanted advances. Inappropriate touching. Making an employee uncomfortable with your persistent attention." I flip open the folder and spread the papers across the table. "Sarah reported seeing you corner Elliot by the elevators on Tuesday. Riley documented an incident in the break room on Wednesday. Delia filed a formal complaint after watching you put your hands on him during the quarterly meeting. James submitted a written statement about the way you've been lingering at his desk." I look up,

holding his gaze. "Five separate employees, all reporting the same pattern of behavior toward the same person. That's quite damning, Connor."

"That's bullshit." His voice rises, panic bleeding through the bravado. "They're lying. All of them. I was just being friendly. Elliot's new, he looked lost, and I was trying to help him settle in."

"Five *separate* people, all lying about the same behavior toward the same target?" I shake my head slowly. I hate calling my brother a target but distancing myself from my emotions right now is important. Connor can't know how much Elliot means to me. "That seems statistically unlikely."

"This is about you being overprotective." Connor jabs a finger in my direction. "You can't stand the idea of anyone else getting close to him. These complaints are probably fabricated, people trying to get on the boss' good side by reporting exactly what they think you want to hear."

"This *should* be an HR matter." I continue as if he hasn't spoken. "Targeted harassment, hostile work environment, potential grounds for immediate termination. But I told Belinda I'd handle it personally, because surely one of my senior analysts wouldn't be doing something like this to my own brother right under my nose." I close the folder with a sharp snap. "Clearly, I was wrong."

Connor grabs a binder from the table and hurls it across the room. It crashes against the wall, papers exploding in a chaotic flutter as he stands there breathing hard, his chest heaving with impotent rage.

"Are you done?"

"I didn't do anything wrong." His voice has gone hoarse. "I was just trying to be nice to Elliot. He looked lonely, alright? I thought maybe he needed a friend who wasn't his overbearing control freak of a brother."

"A friend." The word tastes bitter on my tongue. "Is that what you call cornering someone at the coffee machine? Putting your hands on them after they've asked you to stop? Making them cry?"

"He wasn't crying."

"He was about to." I take another step forward as Connor takes one back. "I saw his face, Connor. I saw the fear in his eyes. And you want to stand here and tell me you were just being friendly?"

"You're overreacting. You always overreact when it comes to him."

Something in me snaps. I move before I can think, crossing the distance between us in two strides and slamming my palm against the wall beside Connor's head. He flinches, pressing back against the glass, and for the first time I see real fear in his eyes.

"Do you want to know why I'm protective of my brother?" My voice comes out a few octaves deeper. "Do you want to hear that his last boyfriend hurt him? That Elliot felt he had no way out, so he stayed with a man who used him as a punching bag? Do you want to hear that he was terrified to leave, terrified that no one would believe him, terrified that he deserved what was happening to him?"

Connor's face goes gray. "I didn't know—"

"Of course you didn't know." I lean closer, close enough to see the sweat beading on his forehead. "You didn't bother to know. You saw someone vulnerable and you decided to push, because that's what men like you do. You push and push until you get what you want, and you don't give a damn about who you hurt in the process."

"I'm not like that." His voice comes out thin. "I would never—"

"You already did." I pull back slightly, giving him room to breathe. "You put your hands on him after he asked you to stop. You made him feel

trapped and scared and helpless. Do you have any idea what that does to someone who's already been through what he's been through?"

Connor shakes his head.

"Seeing him come home broken, with bruises on his arms and that hurt, hollow look in his eyes—" I have to stop and swallow against the tightness in my throat. "That broke something in me. As his brother, I should have been there for him. I should have protected him. And I wasn't. He didn't feel like he could come to me, and I have to live with that failure every single day."

The confession surprises me as much as it seems to surprise Connor. I don't talk about my feelings. I don't explain myself. But something about this moment, about the rage and the fear and the desperate need to make him understand, has cracked me open in ways I wasn't prepared for.

I need Elliot. More than anything. More than this company, more than my reputation, more than the careful control I've built my entire life around. I need him like I need air, and watching someone else try to take him from me has stripped away every pretense I've been hiding behind.

"Here's what's going to happen." I step back, straightening my jacket, reassembling my composure piece by piece. "You're going to attend mandatory sensitivity training. You're going to stay away from Elliot, not because he's my brother, but because he's asked you to leave him alone and you're going to respect that. And if I hear even a whisper of you pulling this shit with anyone else, I will personally ensure that you never work in this industry again."

Connor swallows hard. "And if I don't?"

"Then I'll have HR proceed with the formal investigation." I smile, and it's not a pleasant expression. "Five complaints, Connor. Five witnesses willing

to testify about your behavior. How do you think that's going to look in court? How do you think your next employer is going to react when they call for references and hear about the sexual harassment lawsuit you settled out of court?"

The color drains from his face. "You wouldn't."

"Try me."

I turn and walk toward the door, my hand on the handle before I pause and look back over my shoulder.

"I know I'm your boss, and everything I just said was in that capacity. But I'm telling you this as Elliot's brother." I hold his gaze, letting him see every ounce of the rage I've been containing. "Don't fuck with him. Because if you do, you're going to see a very different side of me. And I promise you, Connor, you don't want that."



The drive home is silent, Elliot sitting in the passenger seat with his hands folded in his lap, his eyes fixed on the passing scenery. He hasn't asked what happened with Connor or if he's in trouble. He just sits there, waiting for me to set the tone.

But I'm too jostled to speak. The confrontation with Connor has left me raw and exposed, all my carefully constructed walls crumbling around me. Every time I look at Elliot, I see him pressed against the counter with another man's hands on his body, and the rage threatens to swallow me whole.

But underneath the rage is something else. Something that scares me far more than anger ever could.

I need him. Not just his submission, not just his obedience, but *him*. Every stubborn, broken, beautiful piece of him. I've been telling myself this is just an arrangement, just a temporary solution to a temporary problem, but that's a lie I can't maintain anymore.

I'm in love with my brother.

Or something close to it. Maybe love is the wrong word. Maybe obsession is more accurate, this consuming need to possess him completely, to claim every inch of his body and soul until there's nothing left that doesn't belong to me. Whatever it is, it's not going away. It's only getting stronger, and I don't know how much longer I can pretend otherwise.

We pull into the garage, and I cut the engine, sitting there for a moment in the darkness, trying to find the words.

"Malakai?" Elliot's voice is smaller than usual. "Are you okay?"

I turn to look at him, a small gasp falling from his lips. "Inside." The word comes out rougher than I intended. "My room. Now."

He doesn't argue. He just unbuckles his seatbelt and follows me into the house, up the stairs, and into the bedroom that's become as much his as it is mine over the past week. I close the door behind us and lean against it, watching him stand in the middle of the room, uncertain what to do with himself.

"I need this." The confession tears out of me before I can stop it. "I need to know you're mine."

"I am yours." He says it without hesitation. "Malakai, I've been yours since the moment I came home."

"Say it again."

"I'm yours." He takes a step toward me. "Only yours. No one else."

I cross the room and pull him into my arms, my hands fisting in his shirt as I crush my mouth against his. The kiss is desperate, nothing like the controlled exchanges we've shared before. When my tongue sweeps against his, he gasps into my mouth, and I feel the exact moment he registers the barbell. All of our kisses have been softer and sweeter and while I know he's seen the metal through my tongue, he's never fully acknowledged it.

His whole body shudders, a moan vibrating against my lips as the metal drags across his tongue. He pulls back just enough to stare at me, his eyes wide and dark with want.

"You have a—" He can't even finish the sentence, his breath coming in ragged bursts. "How did I not feel it before? You've... sucked me off before. You..."

"I do." I drag my tongue slowly across my lower lip, letting him watch the glint of metal. I've perfected speaking with it hidden so that no one at work can see anything other than the metal through my brow. It's already bad enough they can see the edges of my tattoos peeking out from the cuffs of my suit. "Problem?"

"No." The word comes out strangled. "God, no."

I pull him back in, kissing him deeper this time, deliberately letting him feel every slide of the barbell against his tongue. He whimpers into my mouth, his knees buckling slightly, and I have to wrap an arm around his waist to keep him upright. I've imagined this moment for years, wondering what sounds he would make and how he would react to the unexpected sensation. God, I'm falling apart, and he's the only thing holding me together.

"I need to touch you." I'm already pulling at his clothes, yanking his shirt over his head and fumbling with his belt. "I need to feel you."

"Yes." He helps me, his own hands working at buttons and zippers. "Whatever you need. I'm here."

I strip him slowly once the initial frenzy passes, my hands mapping every inch of skin as it's revealed. The cage glints between his legs, a reminder of my control, but tonight it feels less like a symbol of power and more like a barrier between us.

When he's finally naked, I step back and reach for my own shirt. Elliot's eyes go wide. I've never undressed in front of him before. Every encounter, every scene, every moment of intimacy has happened with me fully clothed, maintaining that barrier between us. But tonight I need more. Tonight I need everything.

I pull my shirt over my head and let it fall to the floor. My pants follow, then my underwear, until I'm standing before him as bare as he is.

"You're beautiful." The words fall from his lips like a prayer. "God, Malakai, you're so beautiful."

"Say it." I close the distance between us, my hands cupping his face. "Tell me who you belong to."

"I'm yours." His voice breaks on the words. "I'm yours, Malakai. All of me."

"And I'm yours." The confession surprises us both. "No one else touches you, little doe. No one except me."

"What happened?" His hand comes up to touch my face, concern flickering through his expression. "What did you do?"

I grab the lube from the nightstand, my hands shaking slightly. "What had to be done. I need to be inside you, Elliot. I need—" I stop, forcing myself to slow down, to check in the way I've taught him to expect. "Color?"

His eyes drop to the cage still locked around his cock, then rise to meet mine. "Green. So green."

I kiss him again, softer this time, letting myself sink into the sensation. Then I turn him around and press him down onto the bed, his chest against the mattress and his ass in the air.

I prepare him slowly, thoroughly, one finger at a time. He's tight and I have to remind myself to be patient even as every cell in my body screams for more. I kiss down his spine as I work him open, tracing the knobs of his vertebrae with my lips, tasting the salt of his skin.

"Please." He pushes back against my fingers, desperation coating his words. "Malakai, please, I need you."

I slick myself with lube and press the head of my cock against his entrance. "Tell me if it's too much."

"It won't be." He looks back at me over his shoulder, and the trust in his eyes nearly undoes me. "I want this. I've wanted this since the beginning."

I push inside and fuck, the feeling is indescribable. Tight heat surrounds me, gripping my cock like he was made for this, made for me. I have to stop, buried halfway inside him, just to remember how to breathe.

"Malakai." His voice is strained, overwhelmed. "Oh God, Malakai."

"I know." I press forward, sinking deeper, until I'm fully seated inside him. "I know, little doe. I feel it too."

I start to move, slow at first, letting him adjust to the intrusion. But the need is too great, the desperation too overwhelming, and soon I'm thrusting harder and faster, chasing a release that feels like it might break us both.

"Sir, please." Elliot's voice cracks as he slips into the scene we usually play. "I need to come. Please, I need—"

The cage. Fuck, the cage is still on.

I pull out, ignoring his whimper of protest, and flip him onto his back. My fingers fumble with the lock, finally freeing him from the metal prison, and his cock springs free, flushed and leaking.

"Better?" I line myself up and push back inside, groaning at the sensation.

"Yes." He wraps his legs around my waist, pulling me deeper. "Yes, yes, please, don't stop."

I don't stop. I make love to him with everything I have, every thrust a declaration of ownership, every kiss a promise I don't have words for. His hand wraps around his own cock, stroking in time with my movements, and I watch his face as the pleasure builds. Some part of me wants to make him ask for permission but this moment is for both of us.

"Come for me." The words are a growl against my throat. "Fall apart for me, little doe."

His back arches off the bed, his cock pulsing between us, his cry of release swallowed by my mouth as I kiss him through it. The clench of his body around mine pushes me over the edge, and I follow him into oblivion, spilling inside him with a groan that feels like it's ripped from my very soul.

We collapse together, tangled and sweating, my cock still twitching inside of him. "Color?" The question comes out a little hoarse.

Elliot smiles up at me, his face flushed. "So green." His fingers trace my jawline with a tenderness that doesn't feel possible. "I've been dreaming about this. But I kept fighting with myself, telling myself it was wrong." He shakes his head slowly. "How could something that feels so right be wrong?"

"It's not wrong." I press my forehead to his. "It's perfect, little doe. You're perfect for me."

His stomach chooses that moment to growl, both of us falling into laughter. "Alright." I press a kiss to his lips, still chuckling. "Let's get some food in you."

"I don't really want to move." He tightens his legs around me, keeping me inside him. "Can't we just stay like this?"

"We could." I kiss him again, lingering there for a few seconds. "But if you're a good boy for me, I promise we'll do this again. Maybe I'll even leave my cock inside you as you fall asleep, so you can feel me when you wake up." I watch his eyes darken at the suggestion. "How does that sound?"

A whimper escapes his throat, and he nods frantically.

"Good." I smile, reluctantly pulling out of him. "Now let's see what the staff prepared while we were out, yes?"



Elliot

I wake up full. Not full in the way I've grown accustomed to over the past week, with the plug nestled between my cheeks as a constant reminder of Malakai's claim. This is different. This is deeper, more intimate, more overwhelming in every way that matters because Malakai's cock is still inside me.

The realization hits me slowly, filtering through the haze of sleep. We didn't separate after the second time last night, after he took me apart on the bed and then again after dinner, his hands tracing every inch of my skin like he was memorizing me. He just wrapped his arms around me, pulled me back against his chest, and held on. Neither of us moved. Neither of us wanted to.

And now I'm waking up with him still buried inside me, a connection that feels more intimate than anything we've done before.

It feels fantastic. It feels like everything I never knew I needed. But it also feels like torture, because I'm hard as a rock and there's no way to find relief without his permission.

Searching for a distraction, I reach for my phone on the nightstand, careful not to jostle too much, and pull up an Excel spreadsheet from work. The quarterly projections blur before my eyes as I scroll through the numbers, trying desperately to focus on anything other than the ache between my legs and the fullness in my ass.

It's not working.

Behind me, Malakai shifts in his sleep. His hips rock forward, just slightly, a barely conscious movement that sends sparks cascading through my nervous system. I bite my lip to keep from moaning, my fingers tightening around my phone until the case creaks in protest.

He does it again. A slow, lazy thrust that presses him deeper, and I feel him starting to harden inside me. My body responds without my permission, clenching around him, trying to draw him in even further. The sensation is maddening, pleasure and frustration tangling together until I can't tell where one ends and the other begins.

His hips pick up a rhythm, still slow, still half-asleep, but more purposeful. I can feel him growing harder with every thrust, filling me more completely, stretching me in ways that make my eyes roll back. I abandon the spreadsheet entirely, my phone slipping from my fingers as I grip the pillow instead.

"Malakai." His name comes out as a plea.

He doesn't respond, my brother still moving, his breath warm against the back of my neck, his arm tightening around my waist. I don't know if he's

awake or still dreaming, but his body knows exactly what it wants, and it's taking it with a single-minded focus that leaves me trembling.

The pace increases as his thrusts grow deeper and more urgent, and I feel him pulse inside me, the heat of his release flooding my insides. I gasp at the sensation, my own cock throbbing painfully against my thigh, desperate for attention it's not going to receive.

"Good morning, baby."

The words are murmured against my ear, rough with sleep and satisfaction, but I freeze.

Baby. He called me *baby*.

It's different from little doe, different from good boy, different from any of the names he's used before. It's softer. More affectionate. More like something a lover would say than something a dom would say to his submissive.

But Malakai doesn't seem to notice the weight of what he's just said. He's already pulling out of me, the loss of him leaving me feeling empty in a way that borders on unbearable.

"I think I could wake up like that forever." His voice is still lazy and satisfied, as he rolls onto his back and stretches. "Watching my come trickle out of you is probably the most beautiful thing I've ever seen."

I twist around to look at him, the question on my lips dying before it can form. Because that controlled look is back, settling over his features like a mask sliding into place. Even as I stare at the tattoos decorating his arms, at the way his muscles shift as he stretches, I can see the looseness in his shoulders fading, replaced by the careful composure he wears like armor.

He's back. The Malakai who requires permission for everything. The Malakai who holds all the power. The brief glimpse of something softer,

something more vulnerable, is gone.

He yawns, and I catch the glint of metal in his mouth, a shiver running down my spine at the memory of that same tongue ring that made me gasp and shudder last night when he kissed me and when he dragged it across my tongue until I forgot my own name.

How did I not truly register it before? He's had my cock in his mouth. He's kissed me countless times. I should have felt it or at least noticed, but somehow it never clicked until last night when the sensation shocked me into awareness.

There's so much I don't know about my brother. So many secrets hiding beneath the surface. And I'm only just beginning to scratch it.

"Let's get you prepped for the day, alright?" Malakai sits up, the sheets pooling around his waist. "Wash up, put the cage back on, and then kneel. I'll make sure breakfast is ready."

"Yes, sir." The words come out automatically, and I scramble out of bed before he can see the desperate need still etched across my face.

The bathroom is a sanctuary from the heat of his presence. I turn on the shower and step under the spray, letting the water cascade over my skin as I try to bring my body back under control. Unfortunately, I'm still hard and aching, desperate for a release I know I won't get. Once the cage is on, there's no relief. No escape. Just hours of torment while I try to function like a normal human being.

Maybe Malakai won't know.

The thought slithers through my mind before I can stop it. He's probably downstairs, dealing with breakfast. I have a few minutes alone. And I need this so badly, something to take the edge off before I lose my mind entirely.

My hand drifts lower, past my straining cock, to the slick mess Malakai left behind. I'm still open from last night, wet with his release, and when I press a finger inside of my ass, the sensation makes me cry out.

I clap my other hand over my mouth, my eyes darting to the bathroom door. It's closed. He's downstairs. He won't know.

I add a second finger, fucking myself on my own hand while the water beats down on my shoulders. It's not enough, nowhere close to what I really need, but it's something. The pleasure builds slowly, coiling tight in my belly, and I'm so close, so fucking close—

And then the door opens.

I yank my hand away, but it's too late. Malakai is standing in the doorway, still naked, his expression unreadable as he takes in the scene before him. "You naughty, naughty boy." His voice is soft, almost gentle, which somehow makes it worse. "*Elliot Aurelius*."

Fuck, I'm in trouble.

"I feel like I was too lenient with you yesterday." He steps into the bathroom, closing the door behind him. "But it's okay. We all learn lessons, right?"

"I'm sorry." The words tumble out in a rush. "I'm sorry, sir, I just needed—I couldn't—"

"Shh." He reaches past me to turn off the water, then grabs a towel and begins drying me off with brisk swipes across my skin. "You're going to learn. That's what today is for."

He dries every inch of me, thoroughly, then leads me out of the shower and positions me in front of the mirror. The cage goes on first as he fits the metal around my still-hard cock. The sensation of being contained, trapped, and denied, makes me whimper.

But he's not done.

He reaches into the drawer beneath the sink and produces a small bottle of lube. My heart rate spikes as I watch him coat his fingers, but instead of reaching for me, he rummages through the drawer again and pulls out something else.

Shit. It's a smaller plug than the one I wore to work that first day, but no less intimidating because it means I'm going to be feeling Malakai *everywhere*.

"Since you want to be stuffed so badly," his voice is a low rumble against my ear, "I'll help you."

The plug slides into me easily, my body still loose and slick from last night. It settles into place with a pressure that makes me gasp, smaller than his cock but a persistent sensation that's impossible to ignore in conjunction with the cage.

"I can't walk around like this all day!" I push out, desperation coating my words.

"You should have thought about that." He meets my eyes in the mirror, and the smile that curves his lips is pure wickedness. "I hope you're ready for the nine o'clock conference meeting to present the financial reports. I'm going to love watching you squirm."

He directs me back into the bedroom to dress, selecting my clothes with the same care he always does. Fitted pants that will show every shift and fidget and a soft sweater that will do nothing to hide the flush I know will be coloring my cheeks and neck all day.

"Kneel." He points to the spot beside the bed. "I'll let you know when breakfast is ready."

I sink to my knees, the movement shifting the plug inside me and sending a fresh wave of sensation through my body, my cock trying to stir and failing. The double sensation is maddening. Malakai disappears through the door, leaving me alone with my thoughts and the constant pressure of being filled.

Does he know he called me baby? Does he know there's a different side to him, softer and more affectionate, that slips through when his guard is down?

Is something different happening between us?

I've been trying so hard to keep my feelings contained, to convince myself that this is just an arrangement, just a mutually beneficial exchange of control and submission. But last night changed something. Feeling him inside me, hearing him say I'm yours, watching his composure crack as he fell apart above me—

I think I'm falling in love with my brother.

I love him. Not just as a brother, not just as a dom, but as something more. Something I can never speak aloud, acknowledge, or allow to see the light of day.

No one can ever know that.



Elliot

The whole day is torture. Malakai insists we drive together, since my car is still at the office from yesterday, which means I'm trapped in the passenger seat with the plug shifting inside me every time we hit a bump. By the time we arrive at Ashford Holdings, I'm already on the verge of tears, my body strung so tight I feel like I might snap at any moment.

However, the conference meeting is worse. I have to stand at the front of the room, presenting financial reports to a table full of executives, while the plug presses against spots inside me that make my voice waver and my hands shake. In contrast, my cock tries to thicken, the pressure of the cage flagging it but the arousal doesn't die. It just... simmers. Malakai sits at the head of the table, his expression perfectly neutral, but I can see the gleam of amusement in his eyes every time I shift my weight or pause to collect myself.

He's enjoying this. By the time the meeting ends, I'm drenched in sweat and my underwear is sticky with precum that's been leaking steadily for the past hour. I make it back to my desk on trembling legs and collapse into my chair, biting back the moan that wants to escape when the plug drives deeper inside of me.

"You okay?" Paulina leans over the partition, her brow furrowed with concern. "You look like you're running a fever."

"Fine." The word comes out strangled. "Just tired. Didn't sleep well."

"You sure? You've been fidgeting all morning. If you're sick, you should go home."

"I'm fine." I force a smile. "Really. Just need some water."

She doesn't look convinced, but she lets it go. Greg stops by twenty minutes later to ask if I need anything, then Dana from accounting, then Wilson from IT. Everyone seems to have noticed that something is wrong, and their concern only makes the humiliation worse.

I can't tell them the truth. I can't explain that I'm falling apart because my brother fucked me twice last night and once this morning, then stuffed me with a plug and caged my cock before sending me to work like this is all perfectly normal.

Tears keep threatening to well up, my whole body on fire with a need I can't satisfy. Every time I move, the plug shifts. Every time I think about Malakai, my cock strains against the cage. Every time someone asks if I'm okay, I have to swallow down the scream building in my throat.

By lunchtime, I can't take it anymore.

I grab my keys and escape to my car, locking myself inside and adjusting my seat until I'm practically horizontal. The new position takes some of the

pressure off the plug, giving me just enough relief that I can finally breathe without wanting to sob.

I eat my sandwich in silence, staring at the ceiling, counting down the hours until this day is over. By four o'clock, I'm about ready to burst, the numbers blurring on my screen. A phone call saves me but realizing that it's Malakai might be a blessing or a curse.

"My office. Now."

The walk to the elevator feels like a death march. Every step jostles the plug, every breath reminds me of the cage, and by the time I reach the top floor, I'm barely holding myself together. Malakai's door is open when I get there, my brother sitting behind his desk, looking like sin incarnate in his perfectly tailored suit, and the smile that curves his lips when he sees me makes my knees weak.

"Close the door." He waits until I comply, then gestures for me to come closer. "Lock it. I have a call in fifteen minutes."

"Sir?" I turn the lock with trembling fingers. "Wait, fifteen minutes?" I'm never privy to his calls or what he does for the company. "Why did you need me up here?"

"Because after watching you fall apart so prettily on my cock last night," he rises from his chair and crosses toward me, "I want to watch it again. And again. And again."

Heat floods my cheeks. "We—we can't do anything here."

"You forget whose name is on the building." He stops in front of me, close enough that I can feel the warmth radiating from his body. "You also forget that no one can see through those windows."

He kisses me before I can protest, demanding my submission, his tongue sweeping into my mouth with that barbell that makes me shudder every

time I feel it. I'm lost in seconds, drowning in the taste of him, the feel of him, and the overwhelming need that's been building all day.

He spins me around and bends me over his desk in one smooth motion, my hands brace against the polished wood as he yanks down my pants, exposing the base of the plug still nestled between my cheeks.

"The plug did its job." He sounds pleased. "You're still open for me. *Still ready,*" he purrs.

He pulls the plug free, and I whimper at the sudden emptiness. Then I hear his zipper, the blunt pressure of his cock suddenly against my entrance, and my brain short-circuits entirely.

"I don't have time to prep you properly, so this is going to be quick and dirty." He pushes inside, one short thrust that seats him partially, and I cry out at the stretch. It's nothing I can't handle, but some part of me wants him to drive in deeper, my body aching for all of him rather than just what he's giving me. I know better than to say anything. However, there is another problem.

"Malakai, sir, I still have the cage on."

"I know." He starts to move, shallow thrusts that hit every sensitive spot inside me. "Don't you remember the rules? Bad boys don't get to come."

I grit my teeth together, trying to hold myself together as pleasure and frustration war inside me. His hands grip my hips, pulling me back to meet each thrust as his mouth finds my ear.

"How does it feel to be my dirty little secret?" His voice comes out as a low rasp that makes me shiver. "My little brother, giving me what I want when I want it?"

I groan, not understanding why I like this so much or why the wrongness of it only makes it better.

"You're so perfect." His thrusts pick up pace. "Letting me use you like this. The idea of you stuffed with my come, walking around the office, sitting in meetings, knowing you're full of me—" He comes with a growl, pulsing inside me, the heat of his release flooding my insides. My own cock throbs painfully against the cage, desperate for relief that isn't coming.

He pulls out, and before I can even process the loss, the plug is pushing back inside me, trapping his release inside my body.

"What—" I can barely form words. "I can't— please—" He pulls up my pants before turning me around to face him. His hands cup my face with a tenderness that contrasts sharply with what we just did. "Give me a color." His eyes search mine. "Truthfully."

"I—"

Malakai places a soft kiss on my lips. "There's a bathroom just off to the side. You can clean up, but knowing you're stuffed with my come..." He trails off, a wild grin spreading across his lips.

God, I want his praise so bad but this is dangerous. I can't believe he just fucked me in the office. "Mala—sir, they're going to find out. I can feel you, feel it inside me. I need—"

He kisses me again, slower this time, his tongue dragging across my bottom lip. "I won't be mad, baby. Give me your color."

There it is again. Baby. I have to clear my thoughts, still trying to wrap my head around Malakai used me and how much I loved it. "Yellow," I finally say.

His expression softens further, all traces of the smug dom fading into something more like concern. "What do you need?"

"I don't know." I shake my head, frustrated with myself. "I just— I don't know."

He kisses me a third time, then pulls back with a thoughtful expression. "I did bring you up here for a reason, though." He guides me toward his chair, settling into it before looking up at me expectantly. "Kneel for me. Right beside my chair. If at any point this becomes too much, you tell me, okay? I won't be angry. Your comfort is just as much a priority as the rules."

I stare at the floor, then back at his face, before sinking to my knees. The position shifts the plug, some of his release slipping out around it, wet and warm against my skin. A soft whine escapes my throat before I can stop it.

"That's it." His fingers card through my hair, soothing my earlier panic. "I wanted you to hear something while you're fully claimed by me. Owned by me. While you know that you're completely mine."

"Sir?" I frown up at him, confused. None of this makes any sense and I don't know why we couldn't have done this in the safety of the study at home. Connor wasn't around me today. Nothing else happened, either. So why...

His computer chimes with an incoming call, and he turns to accept it. I look up from where I'm kneeling just as my mother's face fills the screen.

My eyes go wide, panic flooding through me. From this angle, she can only see Malakai. I'm hidden just below the frame, kneeling at my brother's feet with his come leaking out of me. This is insane. This is the most reckless thing we've ever done. If she looks too closely, if she notices something in his expression, if I make a single sound—

"Victoria." Malakai's voice is perfectly composed. "Thank you for making time for this call."

"Of course, darling." My mother's voice filters through the speakers, that familiar crisp tone that always made me feel about two inches tall. "I

wanted to discuss the Singapore expansion. Richard has concerns about the timeline."

They dive into business talk while I kneel there in silence, my body reacting in ways I don't understand. I'm terrified she'll find out. Terrified that one wrong move will expose everything. But this is also the most taboo thing I've ever done, completely claimed by my brother, kneeling in his office while our mother is inches away on a screen.

The fear and the arousal tangle together until I can't separate them anymore. But then the conversation shifts, bringing me back to reality.

"I must say," my mother's voice takes on a different quality, something almost warm, "I've heard excellent things about the financial presentation this morning. Sarah mentioned it was one of the most thorough quarterly reviews we've had in years."

"Elliot prepared most of it." Malakai's hand finds my hair, stroking gently where she can't see. "He's been an asset to the finance department. His analysis of the Eastern European markets was particularly impressive."

"Elliot?" She sounds genuinely surprised. "Really?"

"He has a natural talent for pattern recognition. And his attention to detail is exceptional." There's pride in Malakai's voice. "I think you'd be impressed if you saw his work firsthand."

"I had no idea he had it in him." For the first time in my memory, my mother sounds like she might actually be impressed by something I've done. "Perhaps I misjudged him. Richard always said he didn't have the head for business, but if he's producing results like that—"

"He is." Malakai cuts her off smoothly. "He's exceeded every expectation."

They wrap up the call a few minutes later, my mother actually saying she looks forward to seeing my next presentation, and then the laptop closes with a soft click, silence stretching through the room.

Malakai looks down at me with such genuine affection that my chest aches. I lean toward him instinctively, wanting to be closer, wanting to crawl into his lap and never leave. God, I love him. No one has ever stood up for me like that and I just... fuck, I need him inside of me again, telling me how proud he is of me.

Maybe he'll even call me baby again. Maybe he'll—

And then something shifts.

It starts as an unfamiliar warmth in my belly, a completely unexpected sensation considering the circumstances. My eyes widen as I realize what's happening, my body clenching around the plug as heat races through my veins.

"Sir, fuck, I'm—" The words come out laced with panic. "I'm gonna come."

Malakai raises an eyebrow.

I start whimpering, shifting on my knees as the sensation builds without my permission. My cock isn't even hard, still trapped in the cage, but something inside me is winding tighter and tighter, the fantasies of my brother pounding into my ass like he did last night making everything worse and when Malakai's grip in my hair tightens—

I groan as I spill into my pants, my ass clenching around the plug as more of Malakai's release leaks out around it. The orgasm isn't like anything I've felt before, more pressure than pleasure, but the release of tension is overwhelming.

"Well." Malakai's voice is amused. "Isn't that a pretty sight."

My face floods crimson, humiliation and relief warring inside me. I just came untouched, with a cage on, in my brother's office, with our mother's voice still ringing in my ears.

"It seems like you could use that bathroom after all, hmm?" He tips my chin up, forcing me to meet his eyes. "Look at me. I told you before that I love it when your pleasure comes because of me. However, I'll have to think of more creative punishments if you come untouched so easily."

I nod frantically, not trusting my voice.

"Go get cleaned up, doe." He releases my chin. "The staff's probably already made dinner in preparation for our arrival, and then I want to sleep inside you again."

My eyes widen at the promise, heat flooding through me despite everything. "Yes, sir." I scramble to my feet, wincing at the mess in my pants and the slickness between my cheeks.

I lock the door behind me and catch my reflection in the mirror. My face is flushed, my pupils fully dilated, my lips swollen from his kisses. I look wrecked and thoroughly used. Is this how I've basically looked all day? *Fuck.*

I look like someone in love.

"Don't even think about it, idiot." The words come out as a whisper, harsh with desperation. "This won't last forever, and if you confess, it'll all be over."

The face in the mirror doesn't look convinced.

Neither am I.

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Elliot

The next two days are pure bliss. There's no other word for it. Pure, unadulterated bliss wrapped in silk sheets and Malakai's arms. I still wore the cage to work on Friday, squirming through meetings and presentations with that constant reminder of who I belong to, but the relief that came when I got home, when Malakai finally unlocked me and took me apart with his hands and his mouth and his cock, made every moment of torment worth it.

And then he slept inside me again.

I don't know how to describe what it feels like to fall asleep with him buried deep inside me, his chest pressed against my back and his breath warm on my neck. It's ownership in its purest form. Possession that goes beyond anything I ever imagined wanting. Every time I shift in my sleep, I

feel him. Every time I wake in the night, he's there, a connection that never breaks.

It's *everything*.

By the time Saturday morning arrives, I'm warm and full and floating in that hazy space between sleep and wakefulness when I hear something that doesn't belong.

Voices downstairs break through the moment. There's Mrs. Callahan's familiar tone, but she's talking to someone else. Someone with a deeper voice, an impatience coating every word.

Fuck.

Before I can process the implications, Malakai's hips snap forward, one hard thrust that buries him deeper and sends pleasure crashing through my system. I feel him pulse inside me, the heat of his release flooding my insides. I try to hold back but I can't, I can't—

I fall apart seconds later, spilling onto the sheets with a choked-off moan that I barely manage to muffle against the pillow. Malakai laughs softly, pressing a kiss to my shoulder. "Good morning, little doe."

"I think Dad's home." The words come out a little panicky as I try to catch my breath. "I heard him downstairs."

Malakai's expression shifts, his gaze cutting toward the door with an irritation that makes me shiver. "He wasn't supposed to be here for hours." My brother sounds as annoyed as I am terrified. "Not show up early and disrupt my morning."

"We need to get up. We need to—"

He pulls out of me, and I gasp at the sudden emptiness. But before I can move or scramble toward the bathroom and some semblance of normalcy, he flips me onto my back and slides right back in.

"Malakai!" My voice comes out strangled. "You can't— we can't—"

"I'm not done yet." His eyes are dark, boring into mine with a possessiveness that makes my cock twitch despite the fact that I just came. "With him here, I won't be able to touch you for hours. So you're going to be a good boy and fall apart for me one more time."

"But what if he—"

"The door is locked." He starts to move again, my protest dying in my throat. "He won't come in here. But we've got about five minutes before he starts to wander, so I suggest you focus on being quiet."

"I can't— I don't know if I can—"

He drags his nose along my cheek, his lips brushing against my ear. "Color, baby. Give me a color."

The pet name sends warmth flooding through my chest, the same warmth I felt that first morning when he said it like it was the most natural thing in the world. "Green. But what if he hears—"

"Then you'll have to be very, very quiet." He picks up the pace, fucking me hard and fast, and I have to clamp my hand over my mouth to keep from crying out.

It doesn't take long. I'm already oversensitive from my first orgasm, and the desperate, frantic edge to his movements pushes me higher with every thrust. When I come the second time, it's silent, my whole body going rigid as I spill between us with nothing but a muffled whimper escaping past my fingers.

Malakai follows seconds later, groaning against my neck as he fills me again.

"Shower." He pulls out and practically shoves me toward the bathroom. "There's a small present on the counter. Get dressed quickly. We're running

late."

I stumble into the bathroom on shaky legs, my heart in my throat as my gaze falls on what he's left for me. It's a set of clothes, nicer than my usual work attire. Fitted charcoal pants, a pale blue dress shirt, and a slate gray vest. Beside them, though, nestled in a small velvet pouch, is a plug.

It's smaller than the ones I've worn before, sleek and silver with a tapered base. Nothing out of the ordinary, really. But something about knowing Malakai selected it, knowing he wants me to wear it while our father is in the house, makes heat pool in my belly.

I want to wear it.

The realization surprises me, but I don't fight it. Malakai can't touch me while we have company or pull me into his office and take me apart the way he usually does. But this way, some part of him will still be with me. Inside me. Claiming me even when we have to pretend we're nothing more than brothers.

I shower quickly, washing away the evidence of our morning while trying not to think too hard about what's happening. The plug slides in easily, my body still loose from Malakai's thorough attention, and then I dress, my fingers trembling as I try to do up the buttons.

There's no time to kneel. No time for the rituals that have become the foundation of my days. I just have to trust that Malakai understands and that he won't hold this against me.

I rush downstairs to find Malakai already in the kitchen, looking impeccable in a tailored navy suit that makes my mouth water. Our father stands beside him, equally polished, reviewing something on his phone with the kind of focused intensity that means he hasn't registered my presence at all.

"Here." Malakai presses a piece of toast and a mug of coffee into my hands. "We're running a little late for the event."

I look between him and our father, confusion creasing my brow. "What event?"

"Work function." Malakai's tone comes off casual. "It's a networking brunch that was set up late last night. A lot of important people will be here to see how things are run. You'll attend to observe and learn."

"Here?" I glance around the estate before settling my food on the kitchen table and straightening my vest. "People are coming here?"

"The Ashford estate has hosted business functions for three generations," our father says without looking up. "It's tradition."

Malakai catches my arm as our father moves toward the study to collect some documents. "I should have told you earlier, but it slipped my mind." His voice drops lower, meant only for me. "You're too fucking tempting, and I can't seem to focus when you're around."

He presses a small kiss to my lips, just as I catch Mrs. Callahan in my peripheral vision, her back turned as she arranges flowers in the foyer. My face flames crimson.

"Did you get dressed properly?" Malakai's eyes drop meaningfully to my pants. "Did you put in what I left for you?"

I nod, not trusting my voice.

"Good." A smile curves his lips that makes my stomach flip. "Because it's not just any plug, little doe. It's something I got specially for you."

He pulls out his phone and taps the screen. A few seconds of silence passes and then the plug comes alive inside me. I nearly collapse against him, my hand shooting out to grip his arm as vibrations pulse through my core. "Off," I gasp, trying to keep my voice down. "Off, off, off!"

He taps the screen again, and the vibrations cease. "I want to see how long you can be a good boy for me."

"But I'll be talking to people!" The words come out as a desperate whisper. "And Dad is here!"

"That's exactly why you'll have to be a good boy." His thumb strokes over my knuckles before he releases my hand. "The game ends when you can't hold on anymore. And then I'll come take care of you."

"What if I say I can't handle it right now?"

"I know some part of you is going to enjoy this." He leans closer, his breath warm against my ear. "You trying to fix your facial expressions as you imagine it's me inside of you rather than just that plug." His lips brush my earlobe. "You love being my dirty little secret, little doe. Don't pretend otherwise."

He straightens just as our father returns, and I'm left standing there slightly worried that this is one test I won't be able to handle.



Guests begin arriving around ten, a steady stream of executives and investors and old money contacts who all want to shake hands with Richard Ashford and his golden son. I recognize some of them, people I've seen in passing as a kid or when I'd come home during the holiday breaks from boarding school. However, I don't *know* any of them and seeing how nobody seems to notice my existence nor inquire about the second son pains me a little.

I hover at the edges, making small talk when required, and trying to focus on the conversations happening around me instead of the plug nestled deep

inside my body. Malakai waits until I'm mid-sentence with a silver-haired woman from the Singapore office before he turns it on.

The vibration is low, barely perceptible, but I stutter over my words and have to start my sentence over. The woman gives me a curious look, and I blame it on too much coffee, my laugh coming out a little too high.

I should have known before agreeing to this that Malakai would truly play into it. He loves to be in control but in the same vein, he loves when mine falls apart.

He increases the intensity while I'm explaining quarterly projections to a group of analysts.

My voice wavers. My hands shake. I grip my champagne flute so hard I'm afraid it might shatter.

"Are you feeling alright?" one of the analysts asks. "You look a bit flushed."

"Just warm in here." I tug at my collar. "If you'll excuse me."

I retreat to the corner of the room, trying to catch my breath, and that's when the plug starts pulsing in rhythmic waves that make my knees threaten to buckle. My gaze finds my brother across the room, Malakai deep in conversation with a Japanese investor, his expression perfectly neutral. His phone is nowhere in sight, probably in his pocket, and yet somehow he's controlling my pleasure with the casual ease of someone checking the weather.

The next hour is a blur of vibrations and desperate attempts at composure. Every time I start to relax, he increases the intensity. Every time I think I've adjusted, he changes the pattern. I'm sweating through my dress shirt, my cock straining against my pants so obscenely, I'm sure someone would

notice if my shirt wasn't long enough, my body wound so tight I feel like I might shatter at any moment.

I make it through a short presentation about the Asian market expansion, my voice only cracking twice. I even make it through a conversation with our father about the security division, nodding along while the plug pulses against my prostate. I make it through another glass of champagne and a plate of food I don't taste.

But when Malakai turns the vibration to its highest setting during a conversation with the CFO, I know I'm done.

"Excuse me." I set down my glass with trembling hands. "I need to use the restroom."

I make it down the hall and into the powder room just as the first wave hits me.

My orgasm crashes through me without warning, ripping a cry from my throat as I collapse against the sink. I come in my pants, my ass clenching around the still-vibrating plug as pleasure whites out my vision. I'm still shaking when the second one hits.

The plug won't stop vibrating or give me a moment to catch my breath, my oversensitive body responding without my permission. I fumble with my pants and boxers, shoving them down my legs, trying to reach the plug, trying to pull it out before I lose my mind entirely—

And then the door opens.

Malakai steps inside, his eyes dark with hunger, something in his expression making me freeze. "I couldn't wait." His voice is rough, almost feral. "Watching you fall apart out there, knowing you were seconds away from coming in your pants while talking to our CFO—"

He crosses the room in two strides, pulls the plug free with one smooth motion, before twisting me around hoisting me up against the wall.

I wrap my legs around his waist instinctively, my hands clutching at his shoulders as he works his zipper open. A whimper tears from my throat as he stripes off his jacket and shirt before wrapping a hand around my cock. He gathers up my release before stroking himself with it and then pushes inside me, filling me where the plug was just moments ago, and I have to bite down on his shoulder to keep from screaming.

He fucks me hard and fast, still mostly clothed, the waistband of his pants brushing against my bare thighs as he drives into me over and over. It's primal and deperate, nothing like the controlled way he usually takes me.

"Fuck, I love you." The words fall from his lips between thrusts. "I love you so fucking much."

My eyes go wide at the confession, but before I can respond, his mouth is on mine, swallowing whatever I might have said. He kisses me like he's drowning and I'm the only air as I kiss him back with everything I have. When he comes, it's with a groan that vibrates against my lips. I follow him over the edge seconds later, the orgasm of the morning leaving me boneless and trembling in his arms.

He holds me there for a long moment, pressed against the wall, both of us breathing hard. "I wish I could take you upstairs and take care of you properly." His forehead rests against mine, his voice rough with regret. "But I can't. Not with these people in my house."

"I know." My voice comes out hoarse.

"Clean up a little, then go get changed." He presses a soft kiss to my forehead. "If you want to come back down, you can. If not, wait for me upstairs, alright?"

I nod, once again not trusting myself to speak.

He lowers me to my feet gently, making sure I'm steady before he steps back. There's one last kiss before he grabs a warm cloth and wipes my release off his stomach before righting his clothes and redressing. He hands me another warm cloth to clean myself and while I know he would do it in any other circumstance, my brother's hands on me again would turn this into a very different ending.

I take it from him just as Malakai slips out the door and back to the brunch like nothing happened.

I stare at my reflection in the mirror, taking in the flushed cheeks, swollen lips, and wild eyes.

Fuck, I love you.

Did he even know he said it?

I clean up as best I can, changing into fresh clothes from the guest room attached to the bathroom, and make my way upstairs to Malakai's bedroom. The sheets still smell like him, like us, and I curl up in the center of the bed and let my eyes drift closed.

I love you too, I think as sleep pulls me under. Even if I can never say it out loud.

I love you too.



Malakai

I gave most of the staff Monday off, hoping for a quiet morning, a small reward for the successful brunch over the weekend and the quarterly numbers that exceeded projections. The office is a ghost town, just a skeleton crew handling essential operations, and I've been taking advantage of the silence to work through a backlog of correspondence that's been piling up for weeks.

My phone is pressed to my ear, some tedious call with our legal team about the Singapore expansion, when there's a soft knock at my door.

A frown takes over my face at the interruption. Sarah knows not to bother me when I'm on a call unless it's urgent, and I specifically told her I didn't want to be disturbed this morning. The knock comes again, softer this time, almost hesitant, something about the quality of it making me realize it's the one person who shouldn't be here.

"Hold on a moment," I say into the phone, then hit the mute button.

"Come in."

The door opens, and Elliot slips through.

Confusion takes over the frown on my face. I gave him the day off along with everyone else and told him to rest after the intensity of the weekend, telling him I'd handle the few residual tasks that needed attention. But here he is, standing in my doorway with his shoulders hunched and his eyes fixed on the floor, looking smaller than I've seen him in weeks. He looks like the broken boy who showed up at the house over a week ago with bruises on his arms and terror in his eyes.

Something is wrong. Something is very, very wrong.

I watch in silence as he closes the door behind him, his movements more delicate than usual, like he's trying not to shatter into a thousand pieces. He doesn't look at me or speak or even offer any explanation for why he's here when he should be home resting. Elliot just rounds the desk with that same fragile carefulness and slowly lowers himself to the floor.

And then, he crawls under my desk.

My heart stops beating. For one terrible moment, the world narrows to the sight of my brother folding himself into the small space beneath my desk, pressing his body against my legs like he's trying to disappear. This isn't a game. This isn't him being playful or needy or desperate for attention the way he sometimes gets when I've been working too long. This is something else entirely. This is survival instinct. This is Elliot seeking shelter in the only place he knows he's safe.

He kneels between my legs and places his head on my inner thigh, his cheek pressing against the expensive fabric. His breathing is labored,

shallow little gasps that I can feel trembling through his entire body, each exhale a shudder that reverberates through my own chest.

I card my fingers through his hair, the way I've learned calms him faster than words ever could. I've spent weeks perfecting and cataloging every response, memorizing every reaction, and building a vocabulary of touch that speaks louder than any language.

"What happened, doe?"

He doesn't answer, just presses closer, his fingers curling into the fabric of my pants like he's afraid I might disappear if he lets go. I keep stroking his hair, waiting for a response as I give him the space to find his voice while my mind races through every possible scenario that could have reduced him to this state.

The silence stretches between us and then wetness soaks through my pants, spreading against my thigh where his face is pressed. *He's crying?* There's no sobs or sniffles, just a silent cry for help as his whole body shakes with the effort of containing sounds that want to escape.

I end the call without a word, not caring how much we stand to lose due to my unprofessional behavior. None of it matters. Nothing matters except the trembling boy beneath my desk and the tears soaking through my pants.

I toss my phone onto the desk and reach down to cup Elliot's face, tilting his chin up and forcing him to look at me. What I see makes my blood run cold and then immediately, violently hot.

His eyes are red-rimmed and swollen, tears tracking down his cheeks. There's a flush across his face that could be from crying or something else, something I don't want to think about, and his lower lip is trembling in a way that makes me want to burn the entire world down to ash and salt the earth so nothing can ever grow there again.

"Hey." I keep my voice soft, even as rage begins to simmer beneath my skin. "What happened? Tell me."

"Connor." The name comes out broken, barely audible, a whisper that nonetheless hits me square in the chest. "He— I was downstairs, getting files from the archive, and he— he cornered me."

The rage flares hotter, but I tamp it down with every ounce of control I possess. Elliot needs me calm right now. He needs me steady and present and focused on him, not consumed by the fury that's threatening to undo me.

"What did he do?" My thumb strokes across his cheekbone, wiping away tears that are immediately replaced by fresh ones. "Tell me everything."

"He was— his hands—" Elliot's breath hitches, catches, and then breaks into a sob that tears through him. Fresh tears spill down his cheeks, and I watch them fall with a detachment that frightens me, because I know that detachment is the only thing standing between me and a violence that would end everything we've built. "He threatened me. Said things about— about us. Said I was a tease. Said I wanted it. And then he got angry when I tried to leave, and he—"

"Did he fucking touch you?"

The words come out sharper than I intended, Elliot flinching back at my tone. *Fuck*. I hate myself for that, for being the cause of even a moment's additional fear, and I force myself to soften, to gentle my grip on his face.

"He..." Elliot can't finish. His voice breaks as he just looks at me with those devastated eyes.

Somehow, I know what happened. I know what Connor did. And I know, with a certainty that settles into my bones, that Connor Webb will never draw another peaceful breath as long as I live.

I reach for my phone and dial security. "This is Malakai Ashford. I need the security footage from the main floor archive area for the past hour pulled and sent to my office immediately." My voice hardens. "Yes. *Now*. I don't care what you're doing. Drop it and send me that footage within the next two minutes or you'll be joining the unemployment line by end of business today."

I end the call and pull up my email, my fingers moving across the keyboard while my other hand continues to stroke through Elliot's hair. He's still kneeling between my legs, his head back on my thigh, his body trembling with silent sobs that I feel more than hear.

Three minutes later an email arrives. I click the attachment with a sense of dread settling into my stomach like a stone.

The footage is grainy but clear enough to see everything I need to see. I watch as Elliot enters the archive area, heading for the filing cabinets in the back. Connor appears moments later, and even from this angle, even through the grainy quality of the footage, I can see the predatory intent in his posture. He moves like he's been lying in wait, planning this, waiting for an opportunity, and biding his time until he could catch Elliot alone and unprotected.

He approaches Elliot from behind, saying something that makes Elliot stiffen, his whole body going rigid with fear. Then Connor's hands move to Elliot's shoulders, spinning him around, as the bastard crowds him against the filing cabinet with nowhere to escape.

I watch Connor's mouth move, and even without audio, even without being able to hear the words, I can read the accusation in his body language. The way he leans in too close, invading Elliot's space with aggression. The way his hands grip Elliot's arms, fingers digging in hard enough to leave

bruises. The way he's backing my brother into a corner with nowhere to go, trapping him the way Marcus used to trap him, the way everyone has always trapped him.

"You just like to tease me, huh?"

I don't need to hear the words to know what he's saying. I can read them on his lips and see the sneer that accompanies them. I can only imagine the entitled rage that must be coloring his voice. I've seen men like Connor before. Men who can't take no for an answer. Men who think persistence is the same as romance. Men who feel entitled to whatever they want, regardless of who gets hurt in the process.

Elliot tries to push past him. My brother's hands come up, pressing against Connor's chest, trying to create distance, but Connor grabs him harder, his fingers digging into Elliot's arms with a force that makes my vision go red. Then Elliot's mouth opens in what can only be a scream.

No one comes. The floor is empty. I gave everyone the day off.

This is my fault. I left him unprotected. I gave the staff a holiday without considering that it would leave Elliot vulnerable to the predator who's been circling him for weeks. Even though I told Elliot to stay home, some part of me knew he'd show up, needing to be close to me. *Fuck*. I knew Connor was a problem. I warned him. I threatened him. And I still left Elliot exposed.

I will never forgive myself for this.

I watch as Connor forces Elliot back against the cabinet, his hands moving from Elliot's arms to his face. My jaw tightens as I brace myself for this bastard trying to kiss my brother. This piece of shit is going to force his mouth on my brother, and there's nothing I can do but watch it happen on a screen because I wasn't there to stop it.

But Elliot fights back.

My beautiful, brave, terrified brother fights with everything he has. His knee comes up, connecting with Connor's shin hard enough to make the other man stumble backward with a howl I can almost hear through the silent footage. The moment Connor's grip loosens, Elliot runs. He sprints for the elevator, his speed born of pure terror, and I watch him disappear through the doors just as they close.

The video ends on a freeze frame of the empty archive room, Connor still hunched over his injured shin, and I sit there staring at it while something inside me cracks wide open.

Rage. Pure, undiluted rage, the kind I haven't felt since I beat Marcus bloody in that Hartford alley. The kind that makes my vision narrow and my hands shake and my heart pound with the primal need to destroy. It's the rage of a man watching someone touch what belongs to him. The rage of a brother seeing his twin violated and terrorized. The rage of a lover who would burn down the entire world if it meant keeping one person safe.

Connor Webb touched what belongs to me.

Connor Webb put his hands on my brother, tried to force himself on him, and made him cry and shake and crawl under my desk seeking safety.

Connor Webb is going to pay.

I'm already planning the destruction, mapping out the systematic dismantling of his career, his reputation, his entire fucking life, when Elliot's voice cuts through the red haze.

"Please don't leave me."

I look down at him, at his tear-stained face and his trembling body and his desperate, pleading eyes that are looking up at me from beneath my desk like I'm the only solid thing left in his world.

"I can't— I don't want—" He can't finish the sentence, the words fragmenting into nothing, but he doesn't need to. I understand. I always understand.

He needs me here. He needs me more than I need revenge. More than I need to feel Connor's bones crunch beneath my fists. More than I need to watch the light of understanding dawn in that bastard's eyes when he realizes exactly how badly he's fucked up.

At least for now. Connor can wait. He's not going anywhere. And when I finally get my hands on him, the anticipation will have made it so much sweeter.

I reach over and press the button that locks my office door, the soft click echoing in the silence. For however long Elliot needs, this room belongs to us and us alone. Then I push my chair back and reach for him, my hands sliding under his arms as I pull him up from the floor and into my lap.

He comes desperately, his arms wrapping around my neck as he buries his face against my shoulder. I can feel the wetness of his tears soaking through my shirt and the tremors still running through his body. I hold him tight, one hand splayed across his back and the other cradling the back of his head, and I let him shake apart in my arms while I put myself back together piece by piece.

"I've got you." The words come out rough, thick with the emotion I'm trying to contain. "I've got you, little doe. You're safe. He can't hurt you here. No one can hurt you here."

"I need you." Elliot's voice is muffled against my neck. "Please, Malakai. I need you. I need to feel you. I need to know I'm still yours."

The request cuts through me, though, I understand immediately what he's asking for. He's not asking for sex, not really. He's asking for reclamation.

He's asking me to erase Connor's touch with my own, to overwrite the violation with possession, to remind him that his body belongs to me and no one else. He's asking me to take him back from the brink, to pull him out of the dark place Connor's hands have sent him, to anchor him to something real and safe and mine.

How can I deny him that? How can I deny him anything?

"Okay." I press a kiss to his temple, to the curve of his cheek, and to the corner of his mouth. "Okay, baby. I've got you. I'll take care of you."

I help him out of his pants, taking my time despite the urgency thrumming through my veins. He lifts his hips to help, his fingers clutching at my shoulders for balance. He's already half-hard, his body responding to my proximity even in the midst of his distress, and the sight of him vulnerable and wanting in my lap makes something primal roar to life in my chest.

Mine. He's mine. And I will destroy anyone who tries to take him from me.

"I don't have anything," I whisper, an apology laced in my expression. I don't keep supplies here and never anticipated needing them or imagined a scenario where I'd be taking my brother apart in my office while the city sprawls beneath us. "We shouldn't—"

But Elliot's not listening. His hands are already scrambling at my pants, clumsy as he works my zipper down and frees my cock. His fingers wrap around me with a familiarity that still takes my breath away, and I'm hard in seconds, my body responding to his touch like it was designed for this, for him, for nothing else.

Well then.

I hold out my hand, palm up, and meet his eyes.

"Spit."

He does, gathering what he can and depositing it in my palm. I know it's not enough and that this is going to be rough and probably uncomfortable, but I also know that denying him this isn't an option. Not when he's looking at me like I'm the only thing standing between him and oblivion.

I coat my fingers with the slick warmth and reach between us, pressing one finger against his entrance. He's still loose from last night, my finger sliding in with minimal resistance. He gasps against my neck, his hips rolling down to take more, and I add a second finger before he can ask.

"Easy." I scissor my fingers gently, stretching him as quickly as I dare. "Let me take care of you, doe. Let me make it better."

"Please." The word is a sob. "Please, I need more. I need you inside me. I need to feel you everywhere."

I work him open as quickly as I dare, adding a third finger and stretching him until I'm satisfied he won't get hurt. My other hand strokes up and down his spine, keeping him tethered to me while I prepare him to take what he needs. Then, I position him over my cock, the head pressing against his entrance, and I look into his eyes.

"Take what you need from me. Use me, baby. Fall apart for me."

He sinks down in one slow, devastating slide, and the sound he makes is somewhere between a moan and a cry, his body taking me in until he's fully seated in my lap. I hold him there, buried to the hilt, feeling his walls clench around me as his body adjusts to the intrusion. He's so tight and so completely, utterly mine.

For a long moment, neither of us moves. We just breathe together, our foreheads pressed close, his tears still falling against my cheeks, my hands stroking up and down his back in steady, soothing patterns.

Then he starts to move. It's not graceful or coordinated. It's desperate and messy and raw, Elliot fucking himself on my cock with an abandon that speaks to the depth of his need. I hold him steady, my hands moving to grip his hips to guide his movements, and I let him use me. I let him take what he needs and rewrite Connor's violation with every roll of his hips, every clench of his body, and every desperate sound that falls from his lips.

"That's it." I start stroking my hand down his spine again, feeling the tension slowly drain from his muscles with each passing moment. "There you go, little doe. I've got you. You can fall apart for me. You're safe. You're mine. No one else will ever touch you."

"Malakai." My name falls from his lips like the only word he knows. "Malakai, please."

"I know." I start to move with him, thrusting up to meet his downward strokes, driving myself deeper with each movement. "I know, baby. I'm here. I'm not going anywhere. I'm never going anywhere."

The tears finally stop and his breathing evens out, the shallow gasps becoming deeper. When he comes, it's with a quiet gasp that sounds like relief, his body clenching around me as pleasure washes through him in waves. His release coats the front of my shirt as he sags against me.

I follow him over the edge moments later, spilling inside him with a groan I muffle against his shoulder. The orgasm is almost secondary to the intimacy of the moment, to the feeling of his body wrapped around mine, to the knowledge that I've given him what he needed.

We stay like that for a long time, tangled together in my office chair, his head resting on my shoulder and my cock softening inside him. I stroke his hair, his back, the curve of his spine, soothing him with touch the way words never could. Eventually, his breathing deepens further, evening out.

He's fallen asleep in my lap, still impaled on my cock, exhausted from the trauma and the release of what just happened. But his face is peaceful now, a mixture of that anger from before and a protectiveness swelling in my chest as I hold him while my mind works through the logistics of what comes next.

Connor Webb is finished.

Not just at this company. Everywhere. By the time I'm done with him, he won't be able to get a job as a janitor in any building that bears the Ashford name. And considering how many buildings that encompasses across this city, across this country, across every continent where we do business, that's going to be a significant limitation on his future employment prospects.

But the professional destruction is just the beginning. The personal destruction comes later, when Elliot is safe at home, when I can leave him without worrying that he'll fall apart in my absence.

I reach for my phone with my free hand, careful not to jostle Elliot, and dial security. "Has Connor Webb left the premises?"

A pause. Then: "Yes, sir. About twenty minutes ago."

"Revoke his access immediately. Badge, parking, all building systems. If he tries to enter any Ashford property again, I want him escorted out by police. Actually, no. I want him escorted out by my private security. Police are too gentle."

"Yes, sir. I'll handle it immediately."

I end the call and dial HR, my thumb moving across the screen with mechanical precision.

"This is Malakai Ashford. Connor Webb is terminated effective immediately for assaulting an employee. I want his desk cleared and his final paycheck processed by end of business today. No severance. No

references. If anyone asks, he's ineligible for rehire at any company where I have influence. Which, as you know, is most of them."

The HR director sputters something about process, documentation, procedures, and legal requirements, but I ignore all of that.

"I have security footage of him physically attacking my brother and attempting to force himself on him in the archive room. If you want, I can send it to legal instead and we can discuss the criminal charges that footage supports. I can also discuss how long you've been aware of the complaints about Connor's behavior and chose to do nothing. Your choice."

A long, terrified silence settles between us.

Then she speaks. "I'll handle it immediately, Mr. Ashford. My sincerest apologies for the delay."

"See that you do."

I make a few more calls, each one another nail in Connor's coffin. IT, to ensure his accounts are locked and his emails are archived for evidence. Legal, to start drafting the documentation in case he's foolish enough to sue. PR, to prepare a statement in case this goes public. My assistant, to clear my afternoon schedule so I can take Elliot home.

By the time I'm done, Connor Webb has been systematically erased from Ashford Holdings. His badge doesn't work. His parking pass has been deactivated. His computer login is locked. His desk is being cleared by security, his personal effects boxed up and ready to be mailed to whatever address he listed as his emergency contact.

It's like he never existed. And by the time I'm finished with the rest of his life, everyone will wish he hadn't.

But it's not enough. It will never be enough.

Nothing will be enough until I've looked him in the eye and made him understand exactly what he's done. I look down at my brother sleeping in my arms, at his tear-stained face and his fingers still curled into my shirt even in sleep.

I love him.

The thought doesn't surprise me anymore. I've known for weeks, maybe longer, that what I feel for Elliot goes beyond possession, obsession, or anything I've ever experienced or have words to describe. It's love in its purest form. The kind that makes me want to build someone a kingdom and burn down anyone who threatens it.

I will destroy anyone who hurts him. Connor. Marcus. Our parents, if they try to send him away. The board of directors, if they interfere. Anyone who looks at him wrong. Anyone who touches him without permission. Anyone who makes him feel small or scared or worthless.

I will burn the entire world down if that's what it takes to keep him safe.

Because he's mine and I will never, ever let him go.

I press a kiss to Elliot's hair and let him sleep a while longer, content to hold him while I plan the systematic destruction of everyone who's ever made him feel like he wasn't worth protecting. Connor Webb has no idea what's coming for him.

But he will. Soon. Very, very soon.

An hour passes, maybe more. I lose track of time, too focused on the man in my arms and the plans taking shape in my mind. Elliot stirs occasionally, making soft sounds against my neck, and each time I soothe him back to sleep with gentle touches and murmured words.

Finally, when the afternoon starts to switch to evening, I wake him with a gentle hand on his cheek. "Elliot." I stroke his face, watching his eyes

flutter open. "I'm going to take you home, alright? I just want you to rest."

He blinks at me, disoriented, still half-asleep and hazy from the emotional exhaustion of the day. "What time is it?"

"Late afternoon." I help him off my lap, wincing slightly at the loss of contact as my soft cock slips free of him. "Can you stand?"

He nods, but his legs are unsteady when he tries to rise, and I end up supporting most of his weight as I help him back into his clothes. His movements are almost mechanical, the movements of someone operating on autopilot while their mind is somewhere else entirely.

I guide him to the private elevator that leads directly to the parking garage, my arm wrapped around his waist, his head resting against my shoulder. He doesn't say much of anything during the ride down or the walk to the car or the drive home. He just stares out the window with that hollow look in his eyes, his fingers occasionally reaching over to touch my thigh like he needs to confirm I'm still there.

I get him inside the estate, up the stairs, and into the bedroom that's become as much his as mine. He curls up on his side the moment he hits the mattress, drawing his knees up to his chest. God, Elliot is breaking my heart. When I start to pull away, his hand shoots out and grabs my wrist.

"I need..." He can't finish the sentence, but his eyes say everything. Don't leave me. Don't go. I can't be alone right now.

I reach for the collar on the nightstand, the one he shed this morning when he decided to come into the office, the one that represents everything we've built together over these past weeks. I fasten it around his throat, watching the tension in his shoulders ease slightly at the familiar weight.

"I have a few more things to take care of." I press a kiss to his forehead, letting my lips linger against his skin. "But I'll be back. I promise."

His fingers tighten on my wrist for just a moment before releasing. "Okay." His voice comes out small and exhausted, but calmer than it was. "I trust you."

It's only three words but they cut right to the heart.

I watch him for a moment longer, this beautiful, broken man who's given me everything. His eyes are already drifting closed, exhaustion pulling him under.

Mine, I think. Forever mine.

Then I turn and walk out of the room, closing the door softly behind me.

I have a man to destroy.



Elliot

I wake up groggy and disoriented, my mind swimming through thick layers of fog as I try to remember where I am and how I got here. The bedroom comes into focus slowly, with its familiar dark furniture and heavy curtains and the faint scent of sandalwood that clings to everything my brother owns. The sheets are tangled around my legs, damp with sweat, a heaviness in my limbs that makes even the thought of moving feel exhausting.

My hand drifts to my throat. The collar is still there, a steady pressure that should be grounding me, but something feels wrong. Something feels off. The usual calm that settles over me when I touch it isn't coming.

I reach for my phone on the nightstand, squinting at the screen through bleary eyes. There's a text from Malakai, sent about an hour ago.

Take a bath. Relax. I'll be home soon. Don't push yourself.

Don't push yourself. The words should comfort me, but instead they make something twist in my chest. I don't want to relax. I don't want to take a bath. I want to kneel. I want to feel the floor beneath my knees and let my mind go quiet the way it does when I'm in position, waiting for him.

Maybe if I can just get into the right headspace, the shaking will stop and the memories will fade and I'll feel like myself again instead of this trembling, fractured thing that's taken up residence in my skin.

I push myself upright, my muscles protesting every movement, and swing my legs over the side of the bed. The floor is cool beneath my bare feet as I lower myself to my knees beside the bed, assuming the position that's become as natural as breathing over the past weeks. Spine straight. Hands palm-up on my thighs. Eyes forward. Breathe.

It doesn't work.

My head is too loud. The thoughts keep crashing into each other, fragments of memory and fear and shame that refuse to settle into anything coherent. Connor's hands on my arms, his fingers digging into my flesh, a sneer on his face when he calls me a tease, panic flooding through me when I realize no one was coming to help, that I'm alone with him in that empty archive room with nowhere to run.

I squeeze my eyes shut and try to focus on my breathing, counting the way Malakai taught me. In for four. Hold for four. Out for four. But the numbers keep slipping away, replaced by the echo of Connor's voice in my head.

You just like to tease me, huh?

A shudder runs through me, violent enough to break my posture. My whole body shakes, tremors running through me. The collar feels too tight suddenly, the leather pressing against my throat in a way that makes it hard

to breathe. “Why can’t I make this work?” I plead, reaching up to tug at the leather. The one thing that always helps, the one tool I have to quiet the chaos in my brain, and it's failing me when I need it most.

I open my eyes and look over my shoulder at the bathroom door. Malakai said to take a bath. Maybe he was right. I push myself to my feet on unsteady legs and make my way to the bathroom, each step requiring more effort than it should. Everything is already set up, a bottle of lavender and eucalyptus oil sitting on the ledge of the tub, a fresh towel draped over the stand just beside it.

He already knew what I needed, just like he always does. Stripping out of my clothes as fast as I can, I run the bath, relief soaking through me the moment I get into the warm water, the oil soothing my skin. I slide further down until the water reaches my chin, letting it lap against my collarbones, as I close my eyes.

For a few minutes, there's quiet.

Not silence, not the perfect stillness I find when I kneel at Malakai's feet, but something close to it. The water holds me, and I focus on the sensation of heat against my skin, the gentle pulse of my heartbeat, and the rhythm of my breath fogging in the steam.

But the quiet doesn't last. The memories start creeping back all over again, his vile touch ghosting across my flesh. The same fear Marcus trained into me over months of careful conditioning returns, clawing at me, trying to force me into submission.

I sit up abruptly, water sloshing over the sides of the tub, and wrap my arms around my knees. The shaking has started again, worse than before, tears pricking at the corners of my eyes.

I want Malakai. I want him here, holding me, and telling me I'm safe. I want his hands in my hair and his voice in my ear and the solid, steady presence of him blocking out everything else. I want to feel owned again, claimed, and protected.

I just have to hold on until he's back.

By the time I drain the tub and step out, wrapping myself in one of Malakai's oversized towels, I feel marginally more human, functional enough to put one foot in front of the other.

I dry off and move back into the bedroom, pulling open Malakai's closet to find something to wear. My own clothes are in my own room, but the thought of going there, of being surrounded by things that aren't his, makes my chest tight with anxiety. Instead, I reach for one of his sweatshirts, a soft gray thing that hangs past my thighs and smells like him, and pull it over my head. The fabric engulfs me, and I bring the collar up to my nose, breathing in deep.

Better.

I find a pair of my own pants in the drawer where I've started keeping some of my things and pull them on, then reach for my phone.

Can I get something to eat?

The response comes almost immediately.

Of course. There should be something in the fridge that the staff prepared.

Eat whatever you want. I'll be home within the hour.

Within the hour. I can survive an hour. I've survived worse.

I pocket my phone and head for the bedroom door. The hallway is quiet and I'm almost to the stairs when a voice stops me cold.

"Mr. Elliot?"

I turn to find Margaret, one of the housekeepers, standing outside the door to my bedroom with a stack of fresh linens in her arms. She's an older woman with kind eyes and dark, reddish hair pulled back in a neat bun, and she's looking at me with an expression I can't quite read.

"Margaret." I try to keep my voice steady. "I didn't realize you were working today."

"Just doing some tidying up." She tilts her head, her gaze traveling from my bare feet to Malakai's sweatshirt to the door I just emerged from. "Have you been sleeping in Mr. Malakai's room?"

My face heats suddenly, panic clawing at my throat, and I have to swallow twice before I can find my voice. "I— sometimes. When I have nightmares." The lie tastes sour on my tongue. "He lets me stay with him when I can't sleep."

Margaret's expression doesn't change, but something shifts in her eyes. "I went to fix up your room earlier, and it doesn't look like anything's been touched in quite a while. The sheets are still tucked the way I left them last week."

My heart is pounding so hard I'm sure she can hear it. "I've just— it's been easier to stay with Malakai. Since everything that happened before I came home."

She studies me for a long moment, and I can't tell if she believes me or not. Then she sighs, something that might be concern crossing her features. "You really should be sleeping in your own room, Mr. Elliot. It's not proper for two grown men to share a bed, even if they are brothers." She shifts the linens in her arms. "People might talk."

The words feel like ice water down my spine. People might talk. Does she suspect something? Does she know? Has she seen something or noticed

something? Maybe pieced together the truth from a hundred small details we thought we were hiding?

"I'll— I'll try to start using my room more." My voice comes out thin. "Thank you for your concern, Margaret."

She nods, still watching me with that unreadable expression, and I force myself to walk past her toward the stairs. I'm so caught up in the spiral of anxiety that I almost don't register the voices drifting up from the first floor until I'm halfway down the stairs. Then I freeze, my hand gripping the banister so hard my knuckles go white.

My parents are here.

I can hear my mother's voice, that particular cadence she uses when she's discussing something she considers important, and my father's lower tones rumbling beneath hers. They're in the sitting room, just off the foyer, and there's no way to get to the kitchen without passing by the open doorway.

My first inclination is to go back upstairs and hide out until Malakai comes home but I haven't eaten since the morning. I start down the stairs again, moving as silently as I can, keeping to the edges where the wood is less likely to creak. I'm almost to the foyer, when my mother's voice rings out.

"Elliot! I had no idea you were home."

I freeze, close my eyes, and then take a breath that doesn't do anything to calm the panic rising in my chest. When I turn around, my mother is standing in the doorway of the sitting room with a glass of wine in her hand and a smile on her face that doesn't quite reach her eyes.

"Mother." The word comes out flat. "I didn't know you and Father were here."

"We arrived about an hour ago. Something about the Singapore contracts, I think." She waves her hand dismissively, as if the details of multi-million dollar business deals are beneath her notice. "Come, darling. We were just talking about you."

The words make my stomach drop. Nothing good has ever followed my mother saying she was just talking about me.

She gestures toward the sitting room, and I have no choice but to follow, my feet carrying me forward even as every instinct screams at me to run. My father is seated in one of the armchairs, his reading glasses perched on his nose as he studies something spread across the coffee table. He doesn't look up when I enter.

"Sit, sit." My mother settles onto the sofa and pats the cushion beside her. "Richard, tell Elliot what we've been discussing."

My father finally glances up, his eyes flickering over me with a familiar dismissiveness before returning to the papers in front of him. "Your mother and I have been thinking about your future."

I lower myself onto the sofa beside my mother, keeping as much distance between us as I can without being obvious about it. "My future?" My voice sounds strange to my own ears.

"Malakai's been giving us updates on your work at the company." My mother takes a sip of her wine. "He says you've been doing quite well. Better than expected, really."

The praise should feel good. Instead, it just makes the anxiety worse, because I know there's a but coming. There's always a but.

"We're very pleased with your progress." My father pushes his glasses up his nose. "Which is why we think it's time to discuss the next step."

He gestures at the coffee table, and for the first time, I actually look at what's spread across it. Dozens of glossy brochures with photos of ivy-covered buildings and smiling students and promises of world-class education cover the surface. I see names I recognize, prestigious universities scattered across the country, each one at least a thousand miles from here.

"We think you should go back to school." My mother's voice is cheerful, like she's offering me a gift instead of a sentence. "Finish your degree properly. Malakai mentioned you never completed your business program, and really, Elliot, if you want a proper position at the company, you need the credentials to back it up."

They got mad I ran off to school the first time and now... they're sending me back? However, I can't really focus on my mother's words because all I can see are those pamphlets and all I can think is that every single one of those schools is hundreds or thousands of miles away.

They want to send me away.

They want to separate me from Malakai.

"There are some excellent programs here." My father taps one of the brochures. "Stanford has a top-tier business school. So does Wharton. Georgetown's not bad either."

California. Pennsylvania. Washington D.C. Each name just makes it worse, driving the air from my lungs.

"Of course, we'd want you home for holidays." My mother pats my knee. "And summers, if your coursework allows. But we really think this would be good for you, darling. Give you some independence. Let you stand on your own two feet for once."

I can't listen, because the panic is rising in my chest like a tide, drowning out everything except the one thought that keeps circling through my head on an endless loop.

They're going to take me away from him. I won't be able to kneel for him every morning or sleep in his bed every night or feel his hands on my skin or his voice in my ear.

I'll be alone, and the collar won't mean anything without him there to see it, and I'll fall apart the way I used to fall apart when he's not there to hold me together.

My hand drifts to my arm without conscious thought, rubbing at the spot where Connor grabbed me. The skin is tender, the memory of his fingers digging into my flesh making me flinch.

"Elliot?" My mother's voice cuts through the spiral. "Are you listening?"

"Yes." The word comes out automatically. "Of course."

"You seem distracted, darling. Is everything alright?"

No. Nothing is alright. I was assaulted at work this morning, and now you're telling me you want to send me away from the only person who makes me feel safe, and I can't breathe, I can't think, I can't do anything except sit here and nod while you plan my exile.

"I'm fine." The lie is bitter on my tongue. "Just tired."

"Well, look through these brochures when you have a chance." My father pushes a stack toward me. "We'll need to discuss application deadlines. Most of these programs have rolling admissions, but the best spots fill up quickly."

They're not even asking me if I want to go or if this is something I've ever considered. They're just telling me, the way they've always told me, making decisions about my life without ever bothering to consult me.

And the worst part is, they're not even really talking to me. They're talking *about* me, like I'm a piece of furniture they're considering moving to a different room. My mother starts listing the benefits of various programs while my father makes notes on a legal pad, and neither of them seems to notice that I've gone completely still, that my hands are trembling in my lap, or that I'm barely holding myself together.

I search for an excuse to leave. Something, anything, that will let me escape this room and these pamphlets and the casual destruction of everything I've built with Malakai.

"I should— I need to—" The words won't come, panic building until it threatens to undo, the edges of my vision starting to blur.

Not here. I can't fall apart here. Not in front of them.

I start counting my breaths. In for four. Hold for four. Out for four. The numbers give me something to focus on, something other than the pamphlets and my parents' voices and the crushing weight of impending separation.

I tune my parents out completely, letting their voices become white noise while I focus on my breathing. I just have to hold on until Malakai gets home. He won't let them take me away. He promised.

He'll fix this.

He has to.



Malakai

An hour ago.

The drive to Connor's apartment takes seventeen minutes and I spend every single one of them thinking about the security footage. About Elliot's face when he crawled under my desk. About the tears soaking through my pants and the way his body trembled against mine like he was trying to shake apart at the molecular level.

Connor Webb lives in a high-rise downtown, one of those sleek modern buildings with floor-to-ceiling windows and a rooftop pool that appeals to young professionals who want to project success without actually achieving it. I know the building well. Ashford Holdings developed the property three years ago, which means I know exactly which unit is his, which parking spot is assigned to him, and which security guard is working the front desk on Monday afternoons.

I pull into a space just off the side of the building, avoiding the main entrance and cameras before reaching for my phone. The bastard answers on the third ring.

"You fucking bastard." Connor's voice is tight with barely contained rage. "You revoked my access to everything! You—"

"Meet me outside." I cut him off, my voice flat. "Now."

"Are you insane? I'm not meeting you anywhere. You just destroyed my career over nothing."

"Over nothing." The words come out cold. "Is that what you're calling it? Nothing?"

"Your brother is a tease and a liar. Whatever he told you—"

"I have security footage, Connor. I watched you corner him. I watched you put your hands on him. I watched you try to force yourself on him." My grip tightens on the phone until the case creaks. "So here's what's going to happen. You're going to come outside, and we're going to have a conversation about what happens to men who touch things that don't belong to them."

Silence stretches across the line. I can hear Connor breathing and imagine him weighing his options, calculating whether defiance or compliance will serve him better. "Fine." He pushes out. "There's a small park two blocks east. I'll meet you there in—"

"I'm already at your building. Come outside or I'll come up."

I end the call before he can respond and step out of my car. I lean against the hood of my car and wait, watching the entrance of Connor's building with barely restrained patience. He emerges three minutes later, still wearing the same suit he had on this morning, though the jacket is gone and his tie hangs loose around his neck. His face is flushed with anger, his jaw

set in a hard line, and he stalks toward me with the confidence of a man who still doesn't understand how badly he's fucked up.

"This is harassment." He stops about six feet away, maintaining distance like he thinks it will protect him. "I could call the police right now and have you arrested."

"You could try." I push off the hood of my car and take a step toward him. "But I don't think that would go the way you're hoping."

"What do you want, Ashford? You've already fired me. You've already ruined my reputation. What more could you possibly take?"

"I haven't even started."

I take another step toward him. Connor holds his ground, but I can see the uncertainty flickering behind his eyes now, the dawning realization that this isn't going to be a conversation.

"You put your hands on my brother. You cornered him in an empty room. You grabbed him. You tried to force yourself on him."

"He wanted it." Connor's voice wavers slightly. "He's been flirting with me for the past week. Leading me on. Teasing me with those looks and then running back to you like a scared little—"

I move before he can finish the sentence. My fist connects with his jaw with a satisfying crack, sending him stumbling backward into the side of a parked car. He catches himself on the hood, shock and pain warring across his features as blood begins to trickle from his split lip.

"What the fuck—"

I don't give him time to recover. I grab the front of his shirt and haul him upright, then drive my fist into his stomach hard enough to double him over. He wheezes and tries to raise his hands in defense, but I'm faster, angrier,

and driven by a fury that's been building since I watched that security footage.

"He didn't want it." I land another punch, this one to his ribs. "He asked you to stop." Another punch. "He said no." Another. "And you didn't listen." Elliot's lips parted in a scream will haunt me every fucking day of my life.

I wasn't there to protect him.

Connor manages to get his arms up, blocking my next swing, and then his fist connects with my cheekbone hard enough to snap my head to the side. Pain blooms across my face, the world going white at the edges for a moment.

Good. I wanted him to fight back. I wanted an excuse to truly hurt him.

We trade blows in the parking lot, neither of us holding back. Connor is bigger than I expected, stronger than he looks in his tailored suits and carefully styled hair, and he manages to land several hits that I'll be feeling for days. But I'm fighting with something he doesn't have, something that makes me faster and meaner and willing to take damage if it means inflicting more.

I'm fighting for Elliot.

Every punch I throw carries the weight of my brother's tears. Every hit I take is a small price to pay for the privilege of making Connor bleed. When I finally get him on the ground, my knee pressed into his chest and my hand around his throat, we're both gasping and bleeding and covered in the debris of our violence.

"If you *ever* come near him again," I squeeze his throat just hard enough to make breathing difficult, "I will kill you. Do you understand? Not metaphorically. Not as a threat. As a promise. I will end your life and bury your body somewhere no one will ever find it."

Connor's eyes widen with genuine fear, his bravado stripped away by the recognition of what I am, what I'm capable of, and what I will do to protect what's mine.

"Do you understand?"

He nods frantically, his hands scrabbling at my wrist as he struggles to breathe.

"Say it."

"I understand." The words come out choked. "I understand. I'll stay away. I swear."

I hold him there for another moment, letting him feel the full weight of my control over his life, before releasing his throat and standing up. My knuckles are split and bleeding, my ribs ache where he landed a particularly vicious punch, and I can feel the edge of jaw starting to bruise.

Worth it, though. Every bit of it is worth it.

I straighten my jacket and start cataloging my injuries and planning my exit, when the sound of sirens cuts through the newest bout of silence. A chuckle rumbles through me. Someone called the police.

I glance around the parking lot and spot an elderly woman standing in the window of a ground-floor apartment, phone pressed to her ear, watching us with wide eyes. Of course. A witness. Connor probably planned this, probably hoped I would lose control so he could have me arrested for assault. Too bad for him that I have resources he can't imagine.

The squad car pulls into the lot less than two minutes later, lights flashing but sirens now silent. Two officers step out, hands resting on their belts, and I recognize one of them immediately.

Officer Daniels. He's been moonlighting as security for Ashford Holdings events for the past five years. His wife works in our accounting department.

His son received a scholarship from the Ashford Foundation last spring. He's mine to control, whether he knows it or not.

"Mr. Ashford." Daniels approaches with a careful neutrality that tells me he's already assessed the situation and made his calculations. "We received a report of a disturbance. Care to explain what happened here?"

"He attacked me." Connor staggers to his feet, blood dripping from his nose and a bruise already forming on his cheek. "Out of nowhere. I was just leaving my apartment, and he was waiting for me. He's insane."

Daniels looks at me, one eyebrow raised.

"Mr. Webb here sexually assaulted my brother at our corporate offices this morning." I keep my voice as level as I can. Were I anyone else, I would be in jail. "I have security footage that documents the entire incident. I was attempting to have a conversation with him about his behavior when he became violent."

"That's a lie!" Connor's voice rises to a near-shriek. "He came here to attack me! He threatened to kill me!"

"Did he?" Daniels turns back to Connor, his expression unreadable. "And I suppose you have witnesses to this threat?"

"I— no, but—" He gestures to the sidewalk, the lady standing there now gone. No doubt one of the security escorted her away and handed her a lump sum to stay quiet. God, if this ever gets back to my father, I'm dead.

"So it's your word against his." Daniels pulls out a notepad and flips it open. "Mr. Ashford, do you wish to press charges for the assault?"

Connor's face goes pale. "What? No, he assaulted me! I want to press charges against him!"

"You can certainly try." Daniels doesn't look up from his notepad. "But I should mention that I'm familiar with your reputation, Mr. Webb. We've

received several complaints about your behavior over the years, though none of the victims involved ever wanted to pursue formal charges." He finally meets Connor's eyes. "Something about being afraid of retaliation from a man with connections."

The color drains from Connor's face entirely.

"Keep this shit off the books, you asshole." Daniels' voice drops low enough that only the three of us can hear. "I know who you are, Webb. I know what you do. And I know that Mr. Ashford here has the resources to make your life very, very difficult if you push this."

"This is corruption." Connor's voice is shaking now, with rage or fear or some combination of both. "This is— you can't do this. I have rights."

"You have the right to file a complaint." Daniels tucks his notepad back into his pocket. "And I have the right to investigate that complaint thoroughly, which would include interviewing everyone at Ashford Holdings about your behavior, pulling your employment records, and possibly obtaining warrants for your personal devices to look for any evidence of harassment." He pauses. "Is that what you want?"

Connor stares at him for a long moment, calculations flickering behind his eyes. "You... this is about the assault right here! Isn't it?" I can see the exact moment he realizes he's lost, that there's no move he can make that doesn't result in his complete destruction. "No." The word comes out hollow. "That's not what I want."

"Then I suggest you go back inside and put some ice on those bruises." Daniels gestures toward the building. "And I suggest you stay far, far away from the Ashford family from now on. You might even want to find a place to live since the building is owned by the Ashford family."

Connor shoots me a look of pure hatred, but he's already retreating, accepting his defeat. He turns and walks back toward his building without another word, his shoulders hunched and his head bowed.

I wait until he's disappeared through the entrance before turning to Daniels. "Thank you."

"Don't thank me." Daniels' expression is hard. "I did this because what he did to your brother was wrong, and because I've seen the way he operates with other employees at your company events. But don't mistake this for loyalty, Mr. Ashford. I'm not your man."

"I understand."

"Do you?" He holds my gaze. "Because if you ever put me in a position like this again, I will do my job regardless of who you are or how much money you have. Are we clear?"

"*Crystal.*" I grit my teeth, hating that I still don't have the power my father has. He could ask Daniels to fucking crawl to him and the officer would. One day, I'll be able to properly protect my brother regardless of the consequences. Until then, I'll have to find other, less illegal ways.

He nods once, then turns and walks back to his squad car. His partner, who has been standing by silently through the entire exchange, follows without comment. They pull out of the lot a moment later.

I stand there for a long moment, letting the adrenaline drain from my system. Everything aches but Connor Webb will never touch my brother again. He will never work in this industry again. He will never feel safe again, always wondering when I might decide that letting him live was a mistake.

That's worth any amount of pain.

I pull out my phone and check my messages. There's several texts from Elliot, each one more anxious than the last.

Are you okay?

Malakai, please answer me.

Mom and Dad are here. I want you to come home.

I need you.

The last message twists something in my chest. He's alone with our parents, probably being subjected to whatever plans they've cooked up in my absence, and here I am bleeding in a parking lot instead of protecting him. *Again.*

On my way home now. Don't agree to anything. I'll handle it.

I speed back toward the estate, focused on getting to my brother. Traffic is a nightmare. What should be a twenty-minute drive stretches into thirty and by the time I finally pull into the garage, I'm on edge all over again. Voices spill into the the kitchen as I enter, my parents' familiar tones drifting from the sitting room along with the clink of silverware on porcelain.

Of course, they're having dinner. Victoria would never let something as trivial as an unexpected visit disrupt the sacred ritual of the evening meal. I pause in the hallway to check my reflection in a small mirror. The damage isn't as bad as I thought, though the bruise forming along the bottom of my chin is going to need a few layers of concealer to keep the office from asking any questions. My shirt has a few rips along the sides just beneath my jacket, my entire appearance screaming violence.

I can't let Elliot see me like this but I also can't leave him alone with our parents for another moment. I straighten my spine, arrange my features into something approximating composure, and walk into the dining room.

Unfortunately, my family isn't stupid and their reaction to me is immediate.

Victoria's wine glass freezes halfway to her lips, her eyes going wide as she takes in my appearance. Richard sets down his fork with a clatter, his expression shifting from surprise to concern to assessing in the space of a heartbeat.

And Elliot.

Elliot looks up from the plate he's been pushing food around, his face crumpling with something that's equal parts relief and horror. He's wearing my sweatshirt and even from across the room I can see the way his hands are trembling, the shadows under his eyes, and the pallor of his skin.

He's been holding himself together by sheer force of will, waiting for me to come home.

"Malakai." Victoria recovers first, setting down her wine glass with studied casualness. "What on earth happened to you?"

"Minor altercation." I wave off her concern. "Nothing to worry about."

"You look like you've been in a street fight." Richard's voice is jagged with disapproval. "This is hardly the image we want to project as a family."

"I'll keep that in mind for next time." I don't let my gaze leave Elliot, watching the way his shoulders have loosened slightly at my presence. "I had no idea you'd be here, but I've got a few things to finish up and then we can have a discussion about whatever you've been planning."

"We were just telling Elliot about the educational opportunities we've been researching." Victoria throws me a tight smile. "Some wonderful programs that could really help him advance his career."

"I'm sure." The words come out flat. "Can I borrow Elliot for a minute? I need to use his brain for one of the accounting spreadsheets."

Richard waves his hand dismissively. "Yes, yes, go. We can continue this conversation later."

Elliot is out of his chair before the words are fully out of our father's mouth, following me out of the dining room and down the hall toward my study. I open the door and usher him inside, before closing it behind us and locking it. He heads toward my desk, unsure of whether to stand or kneel before meeting my gaze.

The broken look in his eyes is all it takes as I cross the room in three strides and pull him into my arms. He comes willingly, almost desperately, his hands fisting in my ruined jacket as he buries his face against my chest. I wrap my arms around him and hold on tight, one hand cradling the back of his head and the other splayed across his lower back, pressing him as close as physics will allow.

"You know I would do anything to protect you, right?" The words come out rough, scraping against my throat. "Anything."

He makes a small sound against my chest, something between a sob and a laugh. "You hurt Connor, didn't you?"

"I had to."

"I know." His voice is muffled against my shirt. "It's okay. I know."

He starts to pull back, probably to look at my face and assess the damage but I'm not ready to let go yet. I'm not sure I'll ever be ready. "Let me just hold you a little longer."

He stills in my arms, then relaxes completely, melting against me like he's finally found the place he belongs. I bend my head and press my lips to his hair, breathing in the familiar scent of him. God, I need this.

I need to hold him for my own sanity, my own survival, my own desperate clinging to something real in a world that suddenly feels like it's

trying to tear us apart. This isn't just about Elliot's needs anymore. It hasn't been for a long time. Somewhere along the way, his comfort became my comfort. His peace became my peace. His safety became the only thing standing between me and the violent chaos that's always lurked beneath my carefully controlled surface.

I love him.

The thought crystallizes in my mind with perfect clarity. Not the obsessive, possessive love I've been calling it, though that's part of it. Not the protective, brotherly love that would be acceptable to the world, though that's part of it too. Something bigger than both of those things. Something that encompasses every part of him and every part of me and the strange, beautiful, impossible thing we've built together.

I love you, Elliot Aurelius.

The words stay locked behind my teeth, too precious to speak aloud, too fragile to survive in the air between us. But I feel them in every beat of my heart, every breath I take, and every moment I spend with his body pressed against mine.

Needing more, I tilt his head back and capture his mouth in a kiss.

It's soft at first, a question more than a statement. But he opens for me immediately, his lips parting on a sigh. My tongue sweeps against his, the barbell dragging across sensitive flesh as he whimpers into my mouth with a sound that goes straight to my cock.

This is different from the kisses we've shared before. Those were about power, about control, and about establishing the dynamic that governs everything between us. This is just about him and us. About the feelings I can't name and can't escape and don't want to.

"We should go back." His murmurs against my lips, his voice is barely a whisper. "They'll wonder what's taking so long."

"Let them wonder."

But I release him anyway, because he's right. I look at him, taking in the exhaustion in his eyes and the tremor in his hands and the way he's leaning toward me like I'm the only solid thing in his world.

I love you, Elliot Aurelius. I say to myself again.

One day, I'll find the courage to say it out loud.

But for now, I settle for taking his hand in mine and squeezing once before letting go.



Malakai

I'm awake, sir. Collar on. Kneeling now.

I can picture him perfectly, tucked away in his own bedroom down the hall because our parents decided to extend their visit for another day and brought back the full staff to accommodate their presence. He's probably kneeling beside his bed, the one he hasn't slept in for a while until last night, trying to find that quiet headspace.

I hate that he had to sleep alone. I hate that I couldn't hold him through the night and feel his heartbeat against my chest and couldn't wake up with him warm and pliant in my arms. But with Victoria and Richard wandering the halls at all hours and the household staff buzzing around like a hive of particularly observant bees, we can't risk it.

Good boy. How do you feel?

The three dots appear, disappear, appear again. Finally:

Wrong. Empty. I missed you.

Something in my chest clenches at the words. Three simple words that carry the weight of everything we've become to each other.

I missed you too. Tonight, I'm taking you somewhere. Leave your car, I'll drive.

Where are we going?

You'll see. Now finish your morning routine and get ready for work. I have plans for you today.

I set my phone down and push myself out of bed, rolling my shoulders to work out the stiffness that's settled into my muscles overnight. The bruises from my encounter with Connor have faded a little, but they still ache when I move wrong.

I shower, dress, and make my way downstairs to find Victoria already holding court at the breakfast table, regaling Mrs. Callahan with stories from her latest charity function. Richard is nowhere to be seen, probably already sequestered in the study with his phone and his spreadsheets, existing in his own universe that only occasionally intersects with the rest of ours.

"Malakai, darling." Victoria waves me over with the hand not holding her coffee cup. "You're up early."

"Work to do." I pour myself a cup from the carafe and take my usual seat. "The Singapore contracts won't finalize themselves."

"Always so dedicated." She beams at me with the particular pride she reserves for accomplishments she can brag about to her friends. "I was just telling Mrs. Callahan how impressed we are with the quarterly numbers. Richard says you've exceeded projections by nearly twenty percent."

"Eighteen point seven, but who's counting."

Elliot appears in the doorway a moment later, and I have to force myself not to stare. He's dressed in the clothes I laid out for him last night, his hair still slightly damp from the shower, curling at the ends the way it does when he doesn't have time to style it properly, and there's a flush on his cheeks that tells me he's hyperaware of my attention.

"Good morning." His voice is carefully neutral as he takes a seat across from me. "Mother."

"Elliot." Victoria's smile dims slightly, the way it always does when she's forced to acknowledge her younger son. "You look well. Did you sleep alright?"

"Fine, thank you."

He reaches for the coffee, and I watch his hands, looking for the tremor that's been present since Connor's assault. It's still faintly there, a reminder of everything he's been through and everything I still need to fix.

Soon. *Tonight*. I just need to get through the day.

We eat breakfast in relative silence, Victoria filling the gaps with chatter about her upcoming gala and the various social obligations she's juggling. Elliot pushes food around his plate without eating much of it, and I make a mental note to ensure he has a proper meal later.

The drive to work passes in charged silence. I keep one hand on the steering wheel and the other on Elliot's thigh, my thumb tracing idle patterns through the fabric of his pants. He doesn't speak, but I can feel the tension slowly draining from his body with each passing mile, the familiar comfort of my touch working its magic even without words.

At the office, we separate with a professional nod that gives nothing away. He heads to his desk while I take the elevator to my corner suite, and the distance between us feels like a physical ache in my chest. The worst part is

that the morning drags. I sit through meetings and review contracts and respond to emails, but my mind keeps wandering to Elliot, to the plans I've been making, to the evening that stretches ahead of us full of possibility.

Which is why I start texting him around eleven.

Are you being a good boy for me?

His response comes almost immediately.

Yes, sir. Trying to focus on work.

How does the cage feel?

A pause. Then:

Tight. Every time I think about you, I'm reminded that I can't get hard.

I smile at my phone, imagining his face flushing as he types the words and the way he probably glanced around to make sure no one was watching. He hasn't come again with the cage on and while I always give him the choice of what to wear to work, Elliot generally chooses the cage over the plug and sometimes both.

Good. That's exactly how I want you. Desperate and denied and thinking about me.

You're cruel.

You love it.

...yes.

I let him stew for an hour before sending the next message.

When we get home tonight, I'm going to take that cage off. I'm going to make you beg for permission to come. And then I'm going to deny you anyway, just because I can.

His reply takes longer this time, and I can picture him squirming in his desk chair, trying to compose himself while his body responds to my words. I'm thoroughly enjoying this but there's a deeper need beneath all of it. I

can't touch him at home, a place I regard as my own sanctuary and every since Elliot came home, I've had the ability to do whatever I wanted. *When* I wanted. Now, that I can't... I feel like I'm starving.

Sir, please. I can't concentrate.

That's the point, little doe. I want you thinking about me all day. I want you wet and wanting and ready to fall apart the moment I touch you.

I hate you.

No, you don't.

...no, I don't.

The afternoon passes in a haze of anticipation. I watch the clock, counting down the hours until I can have him to myself again, until I can strip away the professional distance and claim what's mine.

At five o'clock, I text him to meet me in the parking garage.

He's already waiting by my car when I arrive, his messenger bag slung across his shoulder and his hands shoved in his pockets. The nervous energy radiating from him is nearly contagious, a vibration in the air that I can feel from twenty feet away.

"Come on." I unlock the doors and gesture for him to get in. "I'm taking you somewhere."

"Where?" He slides into the passenger seat, his eyes wide with curiosity and a hint of apprehension.

"You'll see."

I pull out of the garage and navigate through downtown traffic, heading for a part of the city Elliot has probably never visited. The streets grow narrower, the buildings older, the neon signs advertising establishments that don't cater to the Ashford social circle more prominent here.

When I finally park in front of a nondescript storefront with blackened windows and a simple sign reading "Discretion," Elliot's eyebrows climb toward his hairline.

"What is this place?"

"A specialty store." I kill the engine and turn to face him. "For *supplies*."

His face goes through a fascinating series of expressions, from confusion to understanding to mortification, all in the space of about three seconds. The blush that spreads across his cheeks is spectacular, a deep crimson that extends down his neck and probably continues beneath his collar.

"You mean... supplies for..."

"For us." I reach over and squeeze his thigh. "Come on. I think you'll enjoy this."

The interior of the shop is nothing like the seedy sex shops that populate certain parts of the city. The walls are painted a deep burgundy, the soft lighting giving the place a certain laidback ambiance, and the merchandise is displayed with the care and attention usually reserved for high-end jewelry.

Which, in a way, is exactly what it is.

Elliot stops just inside the door, his eyes going wide as he takes in the array of items on display. Ropes in every color imaginable, coiled neatly on wooden pegs. Leather restraints lined with soft fabric for comfort. Blindfolds in silk and satin and velvet. Plugs of every size and material, from small training sets to elaborate designs that make even me raise an eyebrow.

And toys. So many toys. Vibrators and clamps and rings and things I'm not entirely sure how to use but would very much like to figure out.

"Malakai." His voice comes out strangled. "I can't— we can't—"

"We absolutely can." I place my hand on the small of his back and guide him further into the store. "And we will. Now, I want you to pick out a few things you'd like us to try." The beauty of being this far from the heart of the city means no one will recognize us, ask questions, or even try to pick at *who* we are. Here, we're just lovers looking for a bit of fun.

He turns to stare at me, his expression caught somewhere between panic and intrigue. "Me? You want me to choose?"

"I want to know what interests you. What catches your eye. What makes you curious." I lean closer, dropping my voice to a murmur meant only for him. "This is part of learning to ask for what you need, little doe. Show me what you want."

He swallows hard, his throat working visibly, and then he turns back to the displays with a determination that makes me proud.

For the next twenty minutes, I watch him wander through the store, picking up items and examining them with the careful attention he brings to everything. His blush never fully fades, but it dims to a soft pink as he grows more comfortable, his natural curiosity overriding his embarrassment.

He lingers longest over the ropes, running his fingers over the soft fibers with an expression that borders on awe.

"This one." He holds up a coil of midnight blue rope. "I like how it feels."

"Good choice." I take it from him and add it to the basket I've been carrying. "What else?"

He moves on to the blindfolds, eventually selecting one made of black silk with padding around the eyes for comfort. Then a small, discreet vibrating toy, that makes his face flame when he hands it over.

"Is this— I mean, I don't know if—"

"It's perfect." I cut off his stammering with a reassuring squeeze of his shoulder. "You're doing so well."

While he continues to browse, I make my own selections. A delicate chain designed to be worn across the chest, thin enough to hide beneath clothing but present enough to serve as a constant reminder. A set of plugs in graduated sizes, smaller than what he's used to but made of brushed metal that will warm to his body temperature and feel like an extension of himself.

When I add them to the basket, Elliot's eyes track the movement with a mixture of anticipation and nervousness.

"Where are we even going to use any of this?" His voice drops to a whisper, as if someone might overhear. "Our parents are staying at the house just until the gala, and the staff is everywhere, and—"

"Some of it tonight." I cut him off gently. "Some at our mother's gala tomorrow. You'll wear the chain under your tuxedo, and you'll think of me every time it shifts against your skin."

His breath catches in his throat.

"And once the quarter ends," I continue, watching his face intently, "I'm taking you up to one of the cabins for a weekend. Just us. No interruptions. No staff. No parents. No rules except mine."

The look he gives me is amazing, his pupils dilating visibly even in the soft lighting of the store. "A whole weekend?"

"Three days and two nights of nothing but you and me and all the things I've been wanting to do to you." I let my voice drop lower. "Three days of breaking you apart and putting you back together. Three days of making you scream so loud with no restrictions or need to care about others around."

He makes a small sound in the back of his throat, halfway between a whimper and a moan.

"Color?" I ask, because his consent is the foundation everything else is built on.

"Green." The word comes out breathless. "So green."

I pay for our purchases without batting an eye at the total, handing over my card and accepting the discreet black bag the shop owner provides. Elliot hovers at my elbow throughout the transaction, his face still flushed and his hands fidgeting at his sides.

"One more stop." I guide him back to the car with a hand on his lower back. "And then the real fun begins."

The hotel I've chosen is one of the most exclusive in the city, a boutique establishment that caters to clientele who value privacy above all else. The suite I reserved has soundproofed walls, a king-sized bed with restraint points discreetly built into the frame, and a bathroom with a shower large enough for two.

The shock is all over my brother's face when we step into the room, taking in the luxurious furnishings and the champagne chilling on the sideboard. It's nothing we don't have at home, but the palette here is... brighter.

"Malakai, this is..." He trails off, apparently unable to find words.

"This is what you deserve." I set down the bag from the shop and pull him into my arms. "This is me showing you how much you matter."

"But why? We could just go home. Why go to all this trouble?"

"Because I want to do nasty things to you." The words come out low and rough against his ear. "And I can't have the staff or our parents asking questions. Our mother brought back the full household for the next little

while, remember? Every maid and footman and cook, all of them watching and reporting back to her."

He shivers in my arms.

"So I told them we're working late. That we have contracts to review and spreadsheets to finalize." My teeth graze his earlobe. "And meanwhile, I'm going to take you apart piece by piece and put you back together again."

The scene that follows is unlike anything we've done before.

I start with the blindfold, sliding the soft silk over his eyes and securing it behind his head. The moment his sight is cut off, his other senses sharpen, his whole body tuning in to every touch, every sound, and every whisper of my breath against his skin.

"You're going to rely on me completely tonight." I guide him toward the bed, my hands steady on his hips. "You won't be able to see what's coming. You'll only feel and hear. Trust that I'm going to take care of you."

"Yes, sir." His voice comes out hushed.

I undress him slowly, cataloging every shiver and gasp as each layer of clothing falls away, his cock straining uselessly against the metal prison.

"You put this on yourself this morning." I trace my finger along the bars, watching him jerk at the sensation. "You chose this over the plug. Why?"

"Because—" He has to pause and gather his thoughts through the haze of arousal already clouding his brain. "Because I wanted to feel you controlling me. Even when you weren't there."

"Good boy." The praise makes him melt, his whole body going soft and pliant under my hands. "Such a good boy for me."

I spend hours exploring him with my hands, my mouth, and my voice. I describe everything I'm doing, painting pictures with words that he has to

translate into sensation, forcing him to trust my narration of his own pleasure.

"I'm touching your chest now." My fingers trail across his skin. "Tracing the line of your collarbone. Moving down to your nipple."

He gasps when I pinch it, his back arching off the bed.

"Now I'm going lower. Across your stomach. Down to your thighs."

Each touch is precise, designed to build sensation without providing release. I edge him three times, bringing him to the brink with my hands and my mouth and the new vibrating toy pressed against his ass, then pulling back just before he tips over.

By the fourth edge, he's crying, tears soaking into the blindfold as he begs. "Please, sir, please, I can't, I need—"

"You need what I give you." I press a kiss to his trembling thigh. "Nothing more. Nothing less."

When I finally let him come, it's with my cock buried deep inside him and my hand wrapped around his freed length. His orgasm seems to last forever, wave after wave of pleasure crashing through him until he's nothing but a shaking, sobbing mess in my arms.

The aftercare is just as important as what came before. I remove the blindfold, letting his eyes adjust to the light before I meet his gaze. I clean him with warm cloths and feed him bites of chocolate from the room service tray before tugging him against my chest and murmuring praise into his hair until his trembling stops and his breathing evens out.

"Thank you." His voice is hoarse, wrecked. "That was..."

"That was just the beginning." I press a kiss to his forehead. "Wait until we get to the cabin."

I keep him pressed against me for a while, his lips touching my chest in small, timid kisses. God, I could stay here forever. Just a little shuffling and I could slip inside of him again so that he'd be even closer. But there's only so much we can do without Victoria starting to ask questions.

The moment my phone buzzes on the table a few feet away, I know our time is up. We dress reluctantly, neither of us wanting to return to reality but both knowing we have to. Neither of us say much as we drive home, but once again our connection has strengthened, Elliot's fingers finding mine as he turns my palm over in his lap.

Some part of me knows that walking back into the house is going to ruin the little high we have but there's only so much I can do to claim my brother. This can never be public. I've entered into a dangerous game of loving a man I can never truly have even if my claim on him is obvious to the both of us.

I pull into the garage and cut the engine, and before I can stop myself, I lean over and capture his mouth in a kiss. It's soft and sweet, nothing like the intensity of what we just shared, but somehow it feels more intimate.

"I could kiss you forever," I murmur against his lips.

His fingers come up to curl into my collar, flesh brushing against my neck. "I'd let you."

A knock on my window shatters the moment. Elliot shrieks, jerking away from me. I place a steadying hand on his chest, feeling his heart hammering against my palm. "The windows are tinted, baby. They can't see anything."

I roll down the window to find our father standing there, his expression a mixture of a thousand different emotions.

"Both of my sons working so hard for the company." Richard's voice carries that particular edge it gets when he's trying to be paternal and not

quite succeeding. "It's a rare sight."

"Some of the contracts required some late-night attention. Elliot's analysis was invaluable."

"Hmm." Richard's gaze flickers to Elliot, then back to me. "Well, don't work too hard. Your mother has plans for the gala this week that apparently require everyone's participation."

"We'll be ready."

He nods once and turns, heading back toward the house with his phone already in his hand. I turn to Elliot, who looks like he might pass out at any moment. "Breathe for me." I take his hand in mine. "One... two... three..."

He follows my count, his chest rising and falling until some of the color returns to his face.

"Better?"

"I think I just lost ten years of my life."

I laugh softly, bringing his hand to my lips and pressing a kiss to his knuckles. "Go upstairs and wait for me. I need to say a few words to our father."

He nods, still shaky, and practically bolts from the car. I watch him disappear through the door before getting out and turning to follow our father. Richard is in the study, pouring himself a whiskey, when I enter. He glances up, then gestures toward the decanter in silent offering.

"I'm fine."

"Suit yourself." He settles into his chair, swirling the amber liquid in his glass. "I've noticed you've gotten quite close to your brother since he returned."

My spine stiffens, but I keep my expression neutral. "He needed support after what he went through. I provided it."

"Mmm." Richard takes a sip of his whiskey. "Just make sure his shortcomings don't pull you down as well. You've worked too hard to build your reputation to have it tarnished by association."

The words hit me like a slap, not because they're surprising but because they're so perfectly, predictably cruel. This is who our father has always been. This is who he'll always be. Our parents have never really accepted Elliot. We looked identical until almost into our teens, Elliot fading into the background while I was doted on.

I've hated every moment and every step that drove a wedge between our connection but I hadn't really known the depth of it until Elliot left for college. They treated our household like it was just the three of us, never once mentioning the son who had carved a place out in my heart.

"If you spent half as much attention on my brother," I push out, trying to bite back the anger rising to meet my words, "maybe he would flourish the way you wished he would. Elliot isn't lacking. He's been neglected. There's a difference."

Richard's eyebrows rise, but he doesn't respond. The old man takes another sip of his whiskey and waves his hand in dismissal. I leave before I say something I'll regret. I'm not surprised to see my door cracked and my room empty but it still hurts that we can't relax for the next few days.

Elliot is pacing the length of his bedroom when I cross the hallway, all that nervous energy I worked this evening to dispel back again. He whirls to face me when the door opens, his expression caught somewhere between anxiety and relief.

"Our parents are here!" The words come out in a rush. "What if they heard something? What if they—"

I twist the lock, cross the room, and pull him into my arms, cutting off his spiral mid-sentence. "The door is locked." I press my lips to his hair. "And while I can't take you apart the way I want to, not with the sounds you make, that doesn't mean I can't hold you."

He sags against me, the tension draining from his body as he accepts the comfort I'm offering.

"Where were we?" I murmur into his hair.

"Malakai." His voice is muffled against my chest. "Our parents will be right down the hall."

"And I locked the door. Besides," I tilt his chin up to meet my eyes, "I don't need to fuck you to make you feel owned. Sometimes it's enough just to hold you and know that you're mine."

The look he gives me is so full of trust and love that it steals my breath. I guide him to the bed and pull him down beside me, arranging us so that his head rests on my chest and my arms wrap around him like a shield against the world. We lie there in silence, listening to each other breathe, and I think about how far we've come since he showed up on the doorstep nearly two weeks ago.

"I love you," I whisper into the darkness.

But he's already asleep, his breath evening out further, the words disappearing into the silence between us.



Elliot

The past 48 hours have been eye opening. With Connor gone and our parents preparing to leave, the office has transformed into something almost pleasant. I can walk to the break room without checking over my shoulder. I can sit at my desk without flinching every time someone approaches. The constant knot of anxiety that lived in my chest has loosened, replaced by something that feels dangerously close to peace.

And Malakai has been stealing kisses.

Not just at home, where we have to be careful about the staff and our parents' wandering presence, but at work too. In the elevator when we're alone between floors. In the supply closet when I go to grab printer paper. In his office with the blinds drawn and the door locked, his mouth hot and demanding against mine before he sends me back to my desk with swollen lips and a warning to behave.

Yesterday, he caught me in the stairwell.

I'd been heading down to the archive room, a journey I now make with a combination of defiance and residual terror, when the door opened behind me and Malakai appeared on the landing. Before I could say anything, he had me pressed against the wall, his body caging mine as his mouth found that spot beneath my ear that makes me forget my own name.

That's when I saw it.

The bruise on his side, visible through the gap where his shirt had come untucked, a mottled purple and yellow bloom that spoke of violence and pain and things he hadn't told me about. He makes me forget who I am when we're in bed together that I've not properly seen him since the first time we had sex. I should have seen it. I should have been more attentive.

"What is that?" I'd pushed at his chest, trying to get a better look, my fingers tracing the edge of the discoloration. "Malakai, what happened?"

He'd tried to distract me with another kiss, but I'd turned my face away, demanding answers with my silence.

"Connor," he'd finally admitted. "He got in a few hits before I put him down."

The anger that surged through me was surprising, mostly directed at Connor for daring to hurt my brother. However, I was angry at Malakai for not telling me and then also angry at myself for being the reason any of it happened in the first place.

"You should have told me."

"It's nothing. Just a bruise."

"It's not nothing." I'd pressed my palm flat against his side, feeling him wince even as he tried to hide it. "You got hurt because of me."

"I got hurt because Connor Webb is a predator who couldn't take no for an answer." Malakai had captured my face in his hands, forcing me to meet his eyes. "I would take a thousand bruises if it meant keeping you safe. Do you understand?"

I'd wanted to argue or rage and cry and make him promise never to put himself in danger for me again. But the look in his eyes, that fierce, unwavering devotion that still takes my breath away, had silenced every protest before it could form.

He'd kissed me then, and I'd let myself melt into it, forgetting the bruise and the fear and everything except the feeling of his body against mine.

Now it's Wednesday evening, and everything is about to change again.

I'm standing in Malakai's bedroom, freshly showered and wrapped in one of his robes, watching him lay out options on the bed with the careful attention of an artist preparing his canvas. Our parents announced at breakfast that they'd officially be leaving tomorrow, cutting their visit short due to some emergency at the Monaco property, and I've been floating on a cloud of relief ever since.

But first, there's the gala.

Victoria's annual charity event, the crown jewel of her social calendar, has been the subject of her endless planning and micromanaging for over the last day and a half. The fact that she's leaving immediately afterward speaks to the severity of whatever's happening in Monaco, but she refuses to miss her moment in the spotlight.

Which means I have to attend. We all do.

"Before we get dressed," Malakai says, turning to face me. "I want to talk about something."

My stomach tightens with automatic anxiety. "Okay."

"The rules are changing. Slightly." He crosses to where I'm standing and takes my hands in his, his thumbs stroking across my knuckles in that soothing way he does when he's about to push me out of my comfort zone. "You still have your colors. That will never change. But I want you to start asking for what you want."

I swallow, trying to stuff the sudden bout of anxiety that spreads through my chest. "What do you mean?"

"I mean exactly what I said. When you want something, anything, I want you to ask for it. And when I ask you what you need, I want you to tell me truthfully." His eyes search mine, looking for understanding. "No more waiting for me to guess. No more hoping I'll read your mind. You have a voice, Elliot. I want you to use it."

"That's..." I trail off, trying to find the right words for the tangle of emotions knotting in my chest. "It's easier when you choose. I don't have to think. I just have to obey."

"I know." His grip on my hands tightens slightly. "And I'll still guide you. I'll still tell you yes or no. I'll still make the final decisions about what we do and how we do it. But I need to know what's happening inside your head. I need to know what you're craving, what you're afraid of, and what you're curious about."

"Why?"

"Because I want to give you everything you need." He brings one of my hands to his lips, pressing a kiss to my palm that makes warmth bloom through my entire body. "And I can't do that if you won't tell me what that is."

I consider his words, turning them over in my mind. Part of me rebels against the idea, that part that's spent weeks learning to surrender control

and finding peace in the absence of choices. But another part, a smaller, quieter part, understands what he's asking for. He doesn't want to take away my submission. He wants to deepen it by making it more intentional, more conscious, more *mine*.

"I'll try," I finally say. "I can't promise I'll be good at it, but I'll try."

"That's all I ask." His throws me a soft smile, and it makes something flutter in my chest. "Now, let's start with something simple. Choose what you want to wear tonight."

He gestures toward the bed, where three options are laid out. A classic black tuxedo with a white shirt and black bow tie. A midnight blue number with subtle sheen that seems to shimmer. And a deep burgundy jacket with black lapels that I've never seen before but that makes my fingers itch to touch the fabric.

"Any of these would be appropriate for the event," Malakai continues. "They're all perfectly tailored, all designed to make you look devastating. The choice is yours."

I move toward the bed, my hand reaching out almost of its own accord to stroke the midnight blue fabric. It's softer than I expected, and the color reminds me of the rope I chose at the shop yesterday, that same deep, rich blue that reminded me of the ocean at night.

"This one." I clear my throat, strengthening my voice. "I want to wear this one."

"Good choice." Malakai's voice is warm with approval. "Now, let's talk about what you'll be wearing underneath."

He produces a familiar velvet pouch and tips its contents onto the bed. There's the cage, along with a new plug, smaller than the others but made of brushed metal that warms in my palm when I pick it up. And the chain,

that delicate lattice of silver links designed to drape across my chest like a secret only we know about.

"The cage and the plug are mandatory." Malakai's tone shifts, taking on a commanding edge. "But I want you to tell me how you feel about wearing the chain."

I pick it up, letting the cool metal slide through my fingers. It's beautiful and intricate, clearly expensive. The kind of thing that would be invisible under clothes but present with every breath, every movement, and every moment of the evening. It intrigued me when Malakai first bought it but the fantasy of actually wearing it has pleasure shooting down my spine.

"I want to wear it." The words come easier this time, bolstered by Malakai's encouraging nod. "I want to feel it against my skin while I'm surrounded by all those people. I want to know that I'm yours even when no one else can see it." I finger the delicate chain, watching the way the bedroom lamp catches on each tiny link. Then I look up at him through my lashes. "Will you dress me?"

Something shifts in his expression, the hunger in his eyes barely contained. He takes my hand and guides me toward the full-length mirror in the corner of the room, positioning me so I'm facing my own reflection with him standing behind me.

"You'll have to be quiet." His lips brush against the shell of my ear, and I shiver. "Can you do that for me?"

"Yes, sir."

His hands come up to the collar of my robe, loosening the tie. The fabric parts as his palms slide beneath it, skimming across my chest and then he pushes the robe off my shoulders. It pools at my feet, leaving me bare before the mirror.

"Look at yourself." His voice is low against my neck. "Look how beautiful you are."

I watch in the mirror as his hands roam my chest, fingers tracing patterns across my skin before finding my nipples and rolling them gently. A breathless sigh escapes me, and I lean back against the solid warmth of his body.

He reaches for the chain on the bed and drapes it across my chest, securing the tiny clasps at my collarbones. The metal is cool at first, but it warms quickly against my skin. His fingers trace along the delicate links, following the path they make across my body.

"Perfect." The word is a murmur against my shoulder. "Now stay still."

I hear the click of the lube bottle, and then his slicked fingers are pressing between my cheeks, circling my entrance before one slides inside. I gasp, my hips jerking involuntarily, his free hand wrapping around my cock to hold me steady.

"Quiet, remember?" His teeth graze my earlobe. "You're doing so well."

He works me open slowly, adding a second finger while his other hand strokes my cock in a lazy rhythm that has me trembling. In the mirror, I can see everything. His clothed body behind my naked one. His hands on me, in me. The chain shifting across my chest with every shuddering breath.

"Look how pretty you are." His voice drops lower. "All mine. No one will ever see you like this. No one except me."

A third finger joins the first two, and I have to brace a hand against the mirror to keep from collapsing. The pleasure keeps building, coiling tight in my belly, and I'm so close I can taste it.

"Fall apart on my fingers, baby." His lips brush my neck. "Let me see you."

I shatter with a choked moan, my release spilling over his fist as my body clenches around his fingers. He works me through it, his hand milking every last pulse until I'm sagging against him.

In the mirror, I watch as he releases my cock and raises his hand, showing me the evidence of my pleasure coating his fingers.

"Do you want to taste yourself, little doe?"

My breath hitches in my throat at the idea. He brings his hand closer, and I hesitate for just a moment before leaning forward and taking a finger into my mouth. The taste is strange, but the sound Malakai makes against my neck, a low groan of approval, makes it worth it. I clean each finger thoroughly, my tongue swirling around the digits until there's nothing left.

"Good boy." He withdraws his fingers and presses a kiss to my temple. "Such a good boy for me."

He grabs a small cloth from the dresser and wipes me down gently, cleaning away the mess before reaching for the lube again. The plug slides in easily, my body still loose and relaxed, a whimper falling from my lips at the sensation of being filled again.

"Watching you taste yourself," he murmurs against my ear, "I almost want to fuck you right now." His hand smooths down my hip. "But we'll have time for that later."

The cage comes next, fitted around my soft cock, then my pants, my brother guiding my legs into them one at a time and pulling them up over my hips. The shirt follows, brushing against the chain with every breath. He buttons it slowly, his knuckles grazing my chest through the fabric.

By the time he's finished with the jacket and bow tie, I barely recognize myself in the mirror.

Malakai steps back to admire his handiwork, and the look in his eyes makes my breath catch.

"Devastating," he murmurs. "Absolutely devastating."

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Elliot

The gala is everything I expected and nothing I was prepared for. The ballroom of the Grand Marquis Hotel has been transformed into a winter wonderland, despite the September heat outside. Crystal chandeliers drip from the ceiling like frozen waterfalls, casting prismatic light across the hundreds of guests in their designer gowns and tailored tuxedos. A string quartet plays something classical in the corner, their music barely audible over the hum of conversation and the clink of champagne flutes.

Victoria sweeps through the crowd like a queen surveying her kingdom, her silver gown shimmering every time she moves. She greets guests by name, air-kisses cheeks, and laughs at jokes that probably aren't funny. In her element, she's almost a different person than the cold, dismissive mother who's spent my entire life making me feel invisible.

Richard is conspicuously absent, some business emergency pulling him away at the last minute, and I can't bring myself to be disappointed. Without his disapproving presence, the evening feels slightly more bearable.

Slightly.

I mingle as best I can, making small talk with people whose names I forget as soon as they introduce themselves. Every step shifts the plug inside me. Every breath presses the chain against my chest. Every moment reminds me that beneath this polished exterior, I belong to someone, and that someone is watching me from across the room.

Malakai looks amazing in his own tuxedo, a classic black number that fits his broad shoulders and narrow waist like it was painted on. His hair is swept back from his forehead, his jaw freshly shaved, and there's a confidence in his posture that draws eyes from every corner of the room. Women approach him in a steady stream, touching his arm, laughing at his comments, and leaning in close to whisper things I can't hear.

He's polite to all of them. Charming, even. But every few minutes, his gaze finds mine across the crowded ballroom, and his mouth twitches in that particular way that means he's thinking about everything hidden beneath my clothes.

I flush and look away, reaching for another glass of champagne to give my hands something to do.

An hour into the event, I can't take it anymore.

The constant stimulation is driving me insane. Every conversation requires monumental effort to maintain. Every smile feels like it's cracking my face in half. Every moment I spend surrounded by these people is a moment I could be alone with Malakai, letting him take me apart the way my body is screaming for.

I slip away during a lull in the conversation I'm pretending to follow, weaving through the crowd toward a quiet corridor I spotted earlier. The hallway is dim, lined with closed doors that probably lead to conference rooms or storage spaces, and blissfully, it's blessedly empty.

I lean against the wall and close my eyes, focusing on my breathing the way Malakai taught me. In for four. Hold for four. Out for four. The plug shifts with every breath, a constant reminder of his presence even in his absence.

"There you are."

My eyes fly open to find Malakai standing at the entrance to the corridor, his silhouette backlit by the golden glow of the ballroom behind him. He moves toward me with that predatory grace I've come to crave, until he's close enough that I can smell his cologne and feel the heat radiating from his body.

"You've been so good tonight." He purrs. "Smiling and nodding. Making small talk with people you don't care about. Wearing my chain like a good boy."

"I couldn't stop thinking about you." The confession spills out before I can censor it, bolstered by champagne and desperation. "I thought I was going to lose my mind."

"That's the point." He backs me against the wall, his hands bracing on either side of my head, caging me in. "I want you desperate and ready to fall apart at my touch."

"I am." My voice comes out breathless. "Please, Malakai. I need—"

"Tell me." His command cuts through my stammering. "Ask for what you want."

There's that new rule. The one I promised to try.

"I want you to touch me." The words feel foreign on my tongue. Being direct with Malakai feels almost wrong but the smile on his face gives me the courage to continue. "I want you to make me come. Right here. Where anyone could walk in and find us." If anyone found us, it would be over. Our family's name would be tarnished, our reputation trashed. Mom and Dad would no doubt blame me and kick me out of the house, the will, and their lives.

But in this moment, I find that I can't care. I find that I *need* this. And that scares me more than anything.

Malakai chuckles. "Are you jealous, little doe? Did you see all those women coming up to me, hoping I'd return their touch and get angry?"

I stutter over a 'no', shaking my head violently before whispering 'yes'.

His laughs boldens a little, his eyes darkening with the same hunger from our bedroom before his hand slides beneath my jacket and shirt, his fingers finding the chain and tracing its path across my chest.

"Such a brave little doe." His thumb brushes my nipple through the thin metal links, and I have to bite my lip to keep from moaning. "Asking for what you want like a good boy." His other hand moves to my pants, working the button and zipper before revealing the cage, my cock straining uselessly against its confines. Malakai makes a low sound of appreciation. "You've been so patient." He produces the key from his pocket and fits it into the lock. "Let's give you your reward."

The cage falls away, my cock springing free with a relief so intense it borders on pain. Malakai's hand wraps around me immediately, and I have to bury my face in his shoulder to muffle the moan that tears from my throat. "Elliot, you're going to have to clean yourself up, though." I merely

nod, a rumble of appreciation moving through his chest. "Quiet now." His breath is hot against my ear. "We wouldn't want anyone to hear."

He strokes me ruthlessly, building the pleasure with quick, tight movements that have me shaking within seconds. The plug shifts inside me with every thrust of my hips, adding another layer of sensation to the overwhelming tide that's threatening to pull me under.

"You're going to come for me." His voice is a growl against my neck. "You're going to spill all over my hand in this hallway where anyone could walk by. And then you're going to lick my hand clean before going back to that party and smile and mingle while the rest of your cum dries on your skin beneath your clothes."

The image pushes me over the edge. My orgasm crashes through me, and I have to sink my teeth into Malakai's shoulder to keep from screaming as I pulse hot and wet across his fingers. He strokes me through it, wringing every last drop of pleasure from my trembling body, until I'm sagging against him.

"Perfect." He presses a kiss to my temple while he watches me affix the cage back on and tuck myself back into my pants. "Absolutely perfect." Malakai holds up his hand and I take it in earnest, making sure to clean it thoroughly and leave no trace of what we just did.

Heat pours through at how inappropriate this is but it's not a bad heat. I'm turned on and ready for another round, wanting Malakai to make a mess of me as my eyes dip to the bulge between his thighs. *I shouldn't.*

"Sir, can I—" I stop myself and rephrase my words. "Sir, I'd like to make you come." Malakai raises an eyebrow, stepping a little closer as an invitation. I take it, quickly undoing his belt and zipper as well, adrenaline

rushing through me. My heart beats a little faster as I wrap my hands around his length, immediately realizing an issue.

When my brother comes, it's going to get all over me. Which is exactly what I want but we can't do that *here*. Malakai just stands perfectly still, his cock in my hands as I try to figure out a solution. It takes me a moment to realize he's laughing at me.

"Malakai—"

"It's fine, baby. We can do this later."

But I don't want to do this later. For some reason, I need to claim him even if I can't do it publicly. I need to know that he knows he's mine. And then an idea runs through my mind. I undo my buttons, revealing the chain beneath before grabbing his cock again, pointing it toward my stomach.

Malakai braces himself against the wall as I stroke him, hard and fast, trying to beat whoever might decide to walk down this hallway. God, this is the worst idea ever.

My brother doesn't think so. "Are you going to wear my cum, little doe? Are you going to walk around covered in my release like a claim?" He lets out a deep grunt, one of his hands sifting around the back of my neck. "So fucking perfect for me, aren't you?" He breaths out against my lips. He doesn't last long either, coating my chest and stomach, the hot mess making my cock thicken and then flag because of the cage.

But it's perfect.

Malakai looks down, rubbing his release into my skin. "God, I can't wait to take you apart tonight."

He lets me clean his hand off again, his lips finding my earlobe and then my jaw before releasing me completely. We return to the party separately, five minutes apart, and no one seems to notice that anything has changed. I

spend the rest of the evening floating on a cloud of post-orgasmic bliss, the evidence of Malakai's possession drying sticky against my stomach beneath my pristine white shirt.

The moment the party begins to die, Malakai drags me home, commanding me upstairs into his bedroom. Everything is dark and suspiciously quiet, not doubt my parents already heading out to Monaco and the staff relieved based on my brother's preferences.

What follows is hours of exquisite torture. He uses the new rope to bind my wrists to the headboard, leaving me spread and vulnerable on his bed. The blindfold comes next, plunging me into darkness where every touch becomes amplified, every sensation magnified beyond endurance.

He edges me four times with the vibrating toy, bringing me to the brink and pulling back just before I crest. By the third denial, I'm crying, tears soaking into the silk of the blindfold. By the fourth, I'm begging, promising anything, everything, just to let me come.

When he finally grants me release, it's with his cock buried deep inside me and his hand wrapped around my cock. The orgasm tears through me, leaving me shattered and remade in its wake. And for the first time, it feels like we made love rather than just fucked. Like he took his time with me, the love in his eyes more than words could ever say.

"So perfect for me, baby," he mutters against my hair as we settle.

I curl closer to him, pressing my face against his chest. *Perfect*. He thinks I'm perfect. And lying here in his arms, wrung out and worshipped, I'm starting to believe him.



Malakai

It feels like time is moving both too slow and too fast. It's been two days and something shifted between us after the gala, some invisible barrier that neither of us knew was there until it crumbled away. The dynamic is still present, the rules still in place, but there's a tenderness now that wasn't there before. A softness that weaves through even our most intense moments, transforming them into something deeper, something that feels less like control and more like love.

I'm not sure which version of us I prefer. The raw, primal possession that defined our first weeks together, or this new intimacy that makes my chest ache every time Elliot looks at me with those trusting eyes. Maybe I don't have to choose. Maybe we can have both, the control and the tenderness, the dominance and the devotion, woven together into something entirely our own.

Friday morning starts like any other. Elliot texts me when he wakes, puts on his collar, and kneels for his five minutes. I watch him from the doorway of his bedroom, admiring the line of his spine and the way the leather sits snugly around his throat. When his timer goes off, I cross to him and help him stand, pressing a kiss to his forehead before sending him to shower.

I'm in my study reviewing contracts when I hear his phone ring in the hallway.

"Hello?" His voice carries through the open door, and I half-listen while I scan the document in front of me. "Oh, Mother. I think you meant to call Malakai. Let me transfer—"

He goes quiet. *Too quiet.*

I set down my pen, something prickling at the back of my neck.

"I see." His voice has gone flat, hollow in a way I haven't heard since his first days home. "No, I understand. Yes, I'll let him know you called."

The phone beeps as he ends the call, and I wait for him to appear in the doorway, to explain what that conversation was about. Instead, I hear his footsteps retreating down the hall and up the stairs, followed by the soft click of his bedroom door closing.

I give him a few minutes. Then a few more. When he still doesn't emerge, I push back from my desk and go to find him. His door is closed but not locked. I knock once, softly. "Elliot?"

"I'm fine." The words come too quickly. "Just getting ready for work."

He's not fine. I can hear it in his voice, that brittle quality that means he's holding himself together by sheer force of will. But I also know better than to push when he's not ready to talk.

"Alright. I'll see you downstairs."

The drive to work is quiet. Elliot stares out the window, his hands folded in his lap, and he doesn't reach for me the way he usually does. When I rest my hand on his thigh, he doesn't lean into the touch. He just sits there, like he's retreated somewhere I can't follow. Mom called for me but whatever she said to him... God, if she wasn't our mother, I would wring her neck.

At the office, he disappears into the main area while I head up to my suite. I text him around ten.

How are you feeling?

The response takes almost twenty minutes.

Fine. Just tired.

I frown at my phone. Elliot never takes that long to respond, and his messages are usually warmer, peppered with "sir" and small expressions of affection.

Are you wearing the plug?

Another long pause.

No. I wasn't feeling up to it today.

The cage?

No.

Something cold settles in my stomach. In all the time we've been doing this, Elliot has never opted out of the physical reminders of our dynamic. Even on difficult days, he's clung to them like lifelines, drawing comfort from the constant presence of my claim on his body.

Talk to me. What's wrong?

Nothing. Just not feeling well. Can we talk later?

I want to push. I want to march downstairs and drag him into my office and demand he tell me what's happening inside his head. But that's not how this works. That's not what he needs from me right now.

Of course. I'm here when you're ready.

The rest of the day passes in a haze of distraction. I sit through meetings without hearing a word, sign documents without reading them, and check my phone every five minutes hoping for a message that doesn't come. By the time we leave the office, Elliot looks worse than he did this morning, his face pale and his eyes shadowed.

The drive home is just as silent and out of respect, I don't try to touch him this time. At the estate, he goes straight upstairs while I detour to the kitchen for a drink I don't really want. I give him thirty minutes to decompress before following. I find him in my bedroom, sitting on the edge of the bed in his collar and nothing else. He's staring at the floor, his hands clasped between his knees, and he doesn't look up when I enter.

"I thought we could try something new tonight." I keep my voice light, trying to gauge what he needs. I've watched him get testy with me. I've watched him cry and I've watched him fall apart. But this... I can't read him when he's like this. "Maybe we can use some of the items from the store we haven't explored yet."

He nods without meeting my eyes. "Okay."

The agreement is too quick and too automatic. There's no spark of interest, no flush of anticipation. Just hollow compliance. Some part of me knows I should stop and draw out whatever is bothering my brother. But the other part of me thinks that maybe this is what he needs, that if I can just get him deep enough into subspace, he'll let go of whatever's eating at him.

It's a mistake. I know it even as I reach for the blindfold. "On the bed. Hands above your head, little doe."

He obeys, moving into position but there's no life behind it. I bind his wrists to the headboard with the soft rope, not tight enough to hurt but

secure enough that he can't escape. The blindfold goes on next, plunging him into darkness. I start the way I always do, with long, slow strokes down his body, mapping the terrain of his skin with my fingertips. Usually, this is when he starts to melt, his tension draining away as he surrenders to sensation. Tonight, he just lies there, his body stiff and unresponsive.

I push harder and add more stimulation. The vibrating toy against his ass, my mouth on his nipples, my hand wrapped around his cock. He responds physically, his body going through the motions of arousal, but there's no connection behind it. No presence. He's somewhere else entirely, and nothing I'm doing is bringing him back.

"Color?" I murmur against his throat.

"Green." The word comes out flat.

It's a lie. I know it's a lie. But I want so badly to break through to him that I keep going anyway, pushing harder, touching more, and trying to overwhelm whatever walls he's built between us.

The sob that tears from his throat a few seconds later stops me cold.

It isn't the soft crying that sometimes accompanies deep subspace, the tears of release and surrender that I've learned to cherish. This is something else entirely. Gut-wrenching, body-shaking sobs that sound like they're being ripped from somewhere deep inside him.

I stop everything immediately. The blindfold comes off first. Then the rope, my fingers working the knots with frantic speed. I pull the toy away, grab the blanket from the foot of the bed, and wrap it around his shaking shoulders.

"I've got you." I gather him into my arms, pulling him against my chest.
"We're done. It's over. You're safe."

He can't stop crying. The sobs keep coming, wave after wave of grief that he's clearly been holding back all day. I don't ask what's wrong or demand explanations despite how much I want to. I just hold him and rock him and murmur reassurances into his hair while he falls apart in my arms.

It takes a long time for the crying to slow. Even longer for the trembling to stop. When he finally goes quiet, limp and exhausted against my chest, his voice comes out hoarse and broken. "Mother called this morning."

I go still. "I heard."

"She thought she was calling you. It was about Grandmother's estate." He swallows hard, his fingers curling into my shirt. "The will has been finalized. I'm not in it."

Rage flares in my chest. "What?"

"Everything goes to you. The house in the Hamptons, the art collection, the trust fund. All of it." His voice cracks. "She said Grandmother always felt I was unfocused. That you'd manage everything properly."

I close my eyes, fighting down the anger that's building behind my ribs. Of course our grandmother would do this. She was always the same as our parents, favoring me while dismissing Elliot, reinforcing the message that he was less than, not worthy, a disappointment.

"I'll split it with you." The words come out automatically. I don't even have to think about it. "Whatever she left me, half of it is yours."

"That's not the point." Elliot pulls back, his eyes red-rimmed and swollen. "The point is that everyone has always seen me as less. Our parents, grandma, *everyone*. It's like I'm not even their son. Like I don't even exist to them except as a reminder of everything they wish I was."

"Elliot—"

"I know it shouldn't matter." He smacks away the tears running down his face. "I know I shouldn't care what a dead woman thought of me." Fresh tears spill down his cheeks. "But I just feel so worthless. I don't even know why it hurt so much. I never expected to get anything, but just... having it confirmed like that..."

I pull him back against my chest, holding him tight while the anger churns inside me. Anger at our grandmother for her cruelty. Anger at our parents for creating the environment that made this possible. Anger at myself for not seeing sooner that something was wrong. "I need to know these things." I press my lips to his hair. "Before we scene. I need to know where your head is." Fuck, I'm an idiot. "And I should have never kept going."

There's a beat of silence.

"But I said green. I... thought it would help. I'm sorry." The words are muffled against my chest. "I didn't want to burden you with it. I thought I could handle it on my own."

"Don't apologize. Just tell me next time." I tilt his chin up, forcing him to meet my eyes. "I can't take care of you if I don't know you're hurting. You don't have to carry everything alone anymore. That's what I'm here for."

He nods, but I can see the exhaustion in his eyes, the emotional toll of the day finally catching up with him. I kiss him softly, just a brush of lips, and he responds with a desperation that makes my heart ache.

The kiss deepens, his hands fisting in my shirt as he pulls me closer. For a moment, I think he's trying to restart what we abandoned earlier, trying to lose himself in sensation to escape the pain. But then he pulls back, his breath shaky.

"I don't... I don't think I can do anything tonight." The admission comes out small, like he's afraid I'll be disappointed.

"Thank you for telling me." I stroke my thumb across his cheekbone.
"Can I just hold you?"

He nods, relief flooding his features. I rearrange us on the bed, pulling him against my chest with the blanket wrapped around both of us. He fits into the curve of my body perfectly, his head tucked beneath my chin, his hand resting over my heart.

"I made you a promise." I speak quietly into the darkness. "I promised to never hurt you. To never be the one that makes you break." I press a kiss to his hair. "But I need your help to keep that promise. I need your words. I need you to tell me when something's wrong, even when you don't want to. Can you do that for me?"

He's quiet for a long moment. Then, softly: "I can try."

"That's all I ask."

His breathing evens out gradually, the tension draining from his body as sleep begins to pull him under. I hold him through the transition, watching his face go slack with unconsciousness, and I make a silent vow.

The next time I can get my mother on the phone, I'm going to tell her exactly what I think of the way she delivered that news to Elliot. And then I'm going to make it very clear that if she ever makes him feel worthless again, she'll lose both her sons instead of just the one she never wanted.

But that's tomorrow.

Tonight, all that matters is the man in my arms, the steady rhythm of his breathing, and the knowledge that despite everything, he trusted me enough to fall apart. I'll keep earning that trust. Every day, for the rest of our lives.

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Elliot

Morning light filtering through the curtains wakes me up but I lie still for a long moment, cataloging the sensation of Malakai's body curved around mine. His chest rises and falls against my back, his breath warm on the nape of my neck, and his arm curled around my waist. The blanket is tangled around our legs, twisted from when I started tossing and turning before we finally settled into each other. Neither of us moved during the night after that. Neither of us needed to.

After everything that happened yesterday, I expected to wake up feeling fragile. Broken, even. Like the pieces of me that shattered last night would still be scattered across the floor, too many to put back together properly.

Instead, there's something almost peaceful settling in my chest, a quiet that has nothing to do with submission and everything to do with being held through the worst of it. Malakai didn't try to fix me or analyze me or

demand explanations I wasn't ready to give. He just held me until the shaking stopped and stayed wrapped around me through the night like a shield against everything waiting outside this room.

Malakai stirs behind me, his arm tightening briefly before relaxing again. His lips brush against my shoulder, not quite a kiss, more like a reflex of affection that happens before he's even fully awake.

"Morning." His voice is rough with sleep, the sound of it vibrating against my skin.

"Morning."

We don't move. Most days, I'd already be on my back by now, or on my knees, or bent over whatever surface Malakai decided to use. Most days, the morning starts with his hands on me, his commands in my ear, and the rules of our dynamic clicking into place like a lock sliding home.

Today, this is enough. Just lying here and breathing together, existing in the same space without needing anything more. The intimacy of it catches me off guard, how much comfort there is in simply being held, in the absence of expectation or demand.

I've spent so much of my life feeling like I needed to earn my place, earn affection, and earn the right to take up space. With Malakai, in this moment, I don't have to earn anything.

Eventually, my stomach growls loud enough to break the spell, a rumbling complaint that seems almost offensive given the weight of everything we've been through.

Malakai huffs a laugh against my neck, the sound vibrating through me. "Breakfast?"

"Please."

We untangle ourselves slowly as I pull on a pair of sweatpants from the pile on the floor while Malakai reaches for a t-shirt, stretching his arms above his head with a yawn that cracks his jaw.

The kitchen is quiet when we arrive, Malakai moving to the counter to pull out eggs and butter and a loaf of bread that looks like it was baked fresh yesterday. I settle onto one of the stools at the island, content to watch him.

"We need to talk about last night."

I tense automatically, my fingers curling around the edge of the counter hard enough that my knuckles go white. I knew this conversation was coming. I knew we'd have to address what happened and figure out how to make sure it never happens again. That doesn't make it any easier to face.

"I know."

He doesn't look up from the eggs he's whisking. "Why didn't you safeword?"

I stare at the marble countertop, tracing the gray veins with my eyes, trying to find the right words for something I barely understand myself. "I told you last night that I thought I should be able to handle it." I manage a small shrug, trying to play off my feelings. "I've handled worse before. I've gone deeper into subspace and taken more intense scenes. I didn't want to seem weak, or like I was backsliding, or like all the progress we've made didn't matter. I didn't want to disappoint you." The other truth is that I thought the scene would help.

It didn't. It made things worse.

The whisk goes still. Malakai sets down the bowl and rounds the island, coming to stand in front of me. His expression is controlled, but I've learned to read him over these weeks, and I can see the tension in his jaw, the

tightness around his eyes, and the slight flare of his nostrils that means he's fighting to keep his composure.

"Elliot." He reaches out and cups my face in his hands, tilting my head back so I can't escape his gaze. "Look at me."

I force myself to hold his stare, even though every instinct is screaming at me to look away.

"Your safeword is not optional. It's not a suggestion or something you use only when things become unbearable. It's the foundation of everything we do together. Without it, nothing else works."

"I know—"

"No, I don't think you do." His grip on my face tightens slightly. "When you don't safeword, when you push through something you can't handle because you're afraid of disappointing me, you're not protecting our dynamic. You're destroying it. You're taking away my ability to trust your responses, to know that when you say green, you actually mean green."

The words hit harder than I expected. My throat tightens, and I have to blink against the sudden sting in my eyes.

"I trusted you to tell me when something was wrong." His voice drops lower, becoming rougher around the edges. "I trusted that green meant green and that you'd use yellow or red when you needed to. I should have listened to my gut and that's on me but I want to know that *you* want it or that you don't, Elliot. I need to know that, babe." His voice wobbles at the end and the realization that he's scared surprises me.

"I didn't mean to lie. I just thought I could push through it, thought if I just held on a little longer—"

"I know you didn't mean to." His thumbs stroke across my cheekbones, catching the tears that have started to fall without my permission. "But the

impact is the same. I pushed you when you needed me to stop. I hurt you because I didn't have the information I needed to take care of you properly. Do you understand how that feels? Knowing I caused you pain when my entire purpose is to protect you?"

The guilt in his voice cracks something open in my chest. "That's not your fault. I'm the one who didn't safeword. I'm the one who lied."

"It's both our faults." He pulls me forward, pressing his forehead to mine, and I can feel his breath warm against my lips. "Which is why we're going to fix it. Together. We're going to put systems in place to make sure this never happens again, and you're going to trust me enough to be honest, even when you think the truth will disappoint me."

He releases me and steps back, returning to the abandoned eggs with a determined set to his shoulders. I watch him work, relaxing a little bit as my body finally catches up with my brain. *He's not mad.*

"New rules," he says, pouring the whisked eggs into a heated pan where butter is already sizzling. "First, during intense scenes, I'm going to pause and check in more frequently. Not just at the beginning or when I think something might be wrong, but throughout, regularly. And I need you to answer honestly, even if you think you're ruining the mood."

I nod, wiping at my damp cheeks. "Okay."

"Second, if you've had any difficult interactions with our parents, or anyone else that might be affecting your headspace, you tell me before we scene. No exceptions. Even if you think you can handle it, even if you're sure it won't affect anything."

"Even if I think I'm fine?"

"*Especiall*y then." He shoots me a look over his shoulder, his expression softening slightly. "Your judgment about what you can handle is

compromised when you're already struggling. That's not a criticism of you. That's just how it works for everyone, including me."

I consider this, turning it over in my head. Yesterday proved that beyond any doubt. I thought I could push through the pain of my grandmother's rejection and bury it beneath submission and pleasure, and instead I shattered in his arms.

"Okay," I say again. "I can do that."

"Third." He turns off the burner and plates the eggs and toast, bringing everything to the island and slides one portion in front of me before settling onto the stool across from mine. "I want you to start asking for more. Not just accepting what I give you, not just following orders and hoping I'll know what you need. I said it before but tell me what you need." His eyes hold mine, an intensity there that makes my breath catch in my throat. "I want to hear your voice, Elliot. Not just your obedience."

This one is harder than the others. Asking for things and voicing desires has never come naturally to me. Growing up in this family taught me that wanting was dangerous, that expressing needs only gave people ammunition to use against you later. And the dynamic we've built has been a relief partly because it removes that burden, letting me surrender the responsibility of wanting to someone I trust to know better than I do.

But I understand what he's asking, and I understand why. If I can't tell him what's happening inside my head, he can't take care of me the way he wants to, the way I need him to.

"I'll try." The words come out steadier than I feel. "I can't promise I'll be good at it right away, but I'll try."

"That's all I'm asking." He reaches across the island and squeezes my hand, his thumb rubbing circles across my knuckles. "Now eat. You barely

touched dinner last night, and your body needs fuel to recover from everything it went through."

We eat in comfortable silence, the tension from earlier fully dissolving into something softer, something that feels almost like peace. By the time I'm scraping the last bite from my plate, the heaviness in my chest has lifted enough that I can breathe fully again. "Can I ask for something now?"

Malakai looks up from his coffee, a flicker of surprise crossing his features before he smooths it away. "Of course."

"I want to shower together." The request feels almost insignificant after everything we've discussed, but it's a start. "I want to take care of you the way you take care of me."

"I'd like that."

The bathroom fills with steam as Malakai adjusts the water temperature, testing it against his wrist before stepping back to undress. I follow suit, peeling off my sweatpants and leaving them in a heap on the tile floor, though the collar stays on. I like how it feels.

Malakai steps in first, tilting his face up into the spray, and I follow close behind, letting the heat soak into muscles I didn't realize were still tense until they begin to release. "Let me." I reach past him for the body wash, squeezing a generous amount into my palm. "Just relax."

He lets out a breath and drops his head forward as I start at his shoulders, working the lather across his skin in slow circles. The knots beneath my fingers are stubborn, evidence of the stress he carries for both of us, and I take my time working them loose, pressing my thumbs into the tight muscles until I feel them give way.

My hands travel down his back, tracing the planes of muscle, the dip of his spine, and the curve of his hips. I take my time with every inch,

mapping his body the way he's mapped mine so many times before. This is different from being the one receiving, different from lying back and letting sensation wash over me. There's power in this too, I realize, power in giving pleasure rather than just receiving it.

When I reach around to wash his chest, he leans back against me, his head resting on my shoulder. The intimacy of the position makes something flutter in my chest. I've never felt closer to him than I do right now, standing here in the steam with his body relaxed against mine.

He twists around as my hands drift lower, soaping across his stomach, his cock filling where it presses against my hip, and I smile as I deliberately avoid touching it, washing down his thighs instead.

"Tease."

"Maybe." I press a kiss to his shoulder blade. "Or maybe I'm just being thorough."

I finish washing his legs, guiding him to lift each foot so I can soap between his toes, then ease him under the spray to rinse. The suds fall away as I stare at my brother, admiring every muscle, every firm line, every beautiful inch of him.

Then I sink to my knees. His eyes fly open, finding mine through the cascade of water. I hold his gaze as I lean forward and take him into my mouth.

The sound he makes is heavenly, one hand bracing against the tile wall while the other comes to rest on my head. I work him slowly at first, learning his responses all over again, noting what makes his breath hitch and his fingers tighten.

But today I want something different, something more. I pull back, looking up at him through wet lashes. "I want you to use me for your

pleasure, sir."

Something shifts in his expression, a wildness flooding into his eyes that makes heat pool low in my belly. His hand moves from resting on my head to fisting in my hair. "You sure?"

"Yes, sir. Please."

His hips snap forward, and I open my throat to take him deeper, letting him set the pace. It's rougher than before, and I have to focus on breathing through my nose as he uses my mouth exactly the way I asked him to.

My own cock is hard between my thighs, but I don't reach for it. This isn't about me. This is about him, about showing him that I can give as well as receive, that this dynamic goes both ways even when he's the one in control.

His rhythm stutters, his grip tightening to the edge of pain.

"You have two seconds to tell me where you want it."

I pull off just long enough to answer. "On me. Please, on me."

He groans and strokes himself twice, three times, and then he's coming across my face and chest, hot pulses that the water immediately begins to wash away. I close my eyes and tilt my face up into it, letting myself feel the primal satisfaction of being used exactly the way I wanted.

My own orgasm crashes through me without warning. One moment I'm kneeling there, basking in the aftermath, and the next pleasure is ripping through my body with no warning at all. I gasp, my cock pulsing against my thigh, spilling untouched as my muscles clench and release in waves.

When I can think again, I swipe a hand through the mess on my chest and bring my fingers to my lips. Malakai watches with dark eyes as I clean my hand thoroughly, tasting him on my tongue, and then he's hauling me to my feet and kissing me hard enough to steal whatever breath I have left.

"God, you're such a good boy." The words are murmured against my lips between kisses. "Such a perfect, filthy, beautiful boy."

The kiss deepens, his tongue sweeping into my mouth as his piercing pushes past my lips and I melt against him. The water continues to rain down on us as his hands roam my body, pulling me closer, and I can feel him starting to stir again against my hip.

A knock on the bedroom door makes us both freeze. We pull apart, our eyes meeting in a moment of pure panic. The knock comes again, followed by a muffled voice.

"Mr. Ashford? Is everything alright? I thought I heard something."

"Who's that?" I whisper, my heart hammering so hard I can feel it in my throat.

"Lingering staff." Malakai's jaw tightens, a muscle jumping in his cheek. "Fuck. I thought they'd all left yesterday."

Another knock. "Sir?"

"I'm fine," Malakai calls out, his voice impressively steady despite the tension radiating from his body. "Just dropped something. I'll be down shortly."

Footsteps retreat down the hall, and we both let out shaky breaths.

"Get dressed." Malakai reaches past me to turn off the water. "Come downstairs whenever you're ready. Lunch will be in a few hours."



Elliot

By the time lunch is ready, I still can't shake the encounter with the staff member outside Malakai's bedroom. The incident keeps replaying in my mind. Did they hear something? Did they suspect something? Are they going to tell Mom and Dad?

Malakai, by contrast, seems completely unbothered. This is the second meal he's made for me, or at least put together, sandwiches and fruit and a pitcher of iced tea being set on the table like the morning's near-discovery never happened. There's a looseness to his shoulders I don't often see, a softness around his eyes that makes him look younger, less burdened by the weight of everything he carries.

"Come here."

The command pulls me out of my spiral, and I look up to find him settled at the small table in the breakfast nook, one leg extended slightly, an

invitation clear in his posture. I cross to him, unsure of what he's asking for until his hands find my hips and guide me down onto his thigh.

My legs end up on either side of his, straddling his thigh in a position that feels impossibly intimate for the middle of the day, in the middle of the kitchen, where anyone could walk in at any moment. The hard muscle of his leg presses against my ass, the slight pressure making my face heat in response.

"Malakai, what if someone—"

"The staff are gone, remember? I sent them away before you came down. No more unnecessary interruptions." His hands settle on my waist, thumbs stroking idle patterns through my shirt. "It's just us. And I want to try something."

I swallow hard. "What kind of something?"

"I want you to ask for your food." He twists me around a little, his eyes meeting mine. "Not request permission, not phrase it as a question about whether you're allowed. Just tell me what you want, and it will be given."

The distinction seems small, almost meaningless, but I understand what he's doing. This is practice. This is him teaching me to voice my desires without the safety net of submission, without the framework of permission that's become my comfort zone.

"I..." I look at the spread of food on the table, suddenly uncertain. "I would like a sandwich. Please."

He offers me a smile, before his hands tighten briefly on my waist. "Good boy. Here."

He reaches for one of the sandwiches and brings it to my lips, tearing off a small piece and feeding it to me with his fingers. The intimacy of the gesture makes my breath catch in my throat, and I have to focus on chewing

and swallowing rather than the way his eyes track the movement of my throat.

"What else?"

"I would like some water."

"Perfect." He reaches for the pitcher and pours a glass, holding it to my lips so I can drink. "You're doing so well."

We continue like this, Malakai feeding me bites of food between sips of water, his praise warming me from the inside out every time I manage to voice a want without hedging or apologizing. It feels strange at first, almost uncomfortable, but gradually I start to relax into it, start to find a rhythm.

"I would like a strawberry."

"Here you go." He holds one to my lips, and I bite into it, juice running down my chin. He catches it with his thumb and brings it to his own mouth, licking it clean while holding my gaze, and the heat in my belly flares into something more.

"I would like you to kiss me."

The words slip out before I can stop them, and for a moment I'm terrified I've pushed too far. But Malakai's smile widens as he leans in to press his lips to mine.

The kiss is soft at first, almost tentative, like he's giving me the chance to pull away. But I want this. I lean into him instead, my hands finding his shoulders as I twist around completely, curling up in his lap. He deepens the kiss, a low sound in the back of his throat rumbling through his chest that makes my toes curl. He tastes like strawberries and coffee and something uniquely him, and I want to drown in it. I want to stay here forever, curled up against him in the breakfast nook, kissing my brother like it's the most natural thing in the world.

When we break apart, I'm breathless and grinning like an idiot. A laugh bubbles up from somewhere deep in my chest, my brother joining me, his own laughter rumbling through his body and into mine where we're pressed together. I can't remember the last time I laughed like this. I can't remember the last time anything felt this right, even if it's so very, *very* wrong.

"See?" He kisses the tip of my nose. "That wasn't so hard, was it?"

"It was a little scary," I admit, but I'm still smiling. "But I... I liked it." Knowing that what I asked for would be given isn't something I'm used to. My words are always skimmed over, my desires brushed away but with Malakai, I'm heard. *Always*.

"You're amazing." He gives me another kiss, this one to my forehead. "My brave little doe, learning to use his voice."

The moment stretches between us, and I think that maybe everything will be okay. Maybe we can navigate this impossible situation after all. That is, until I hear footsteps in the hallway.

I scramble off Malakai's lap so fast I nearly knock over the pitcher of water, grabbing our plates and turning toward the sink just as Mrs. Callahan appears in the doorway. My heart is pounding so hard I'm sure she can hear it and can see the guilt written all over my face, but I force myself to keep moving and pretend I wasn't just straddling my brother's thigh in the breakfast nook.

What is she doing here?

"Don't stop on my account." There's a hint of amusement to her voice, and when I risk a glance over my shoulder, her smile makes my heart drop into my stomach. "I was merely tidying up the last of everything before I left. You two aren't subtle, Elliot. Your parents are just unobservant."

The plate nearly slips from my fingers. I catch it at the last second, setting it down in the sink with a clatter that seems to echo through the suddenly silent kitchen.

"However," she continues, moving to the counter to fill the kettle, "the other staff *have* started asking questions. Your brother sent everyone away this morning, so you shouldn't have to worry about anyone walking in on anything." She pauses, her back still to us. "At least for now."

It's a good thing but not soon enough. One of the staff already knocked on the door this morning. I'm assuming it was Margaret. Once she locks onto something, she can be incredibly nosy.

I can't breathe. The air has turned solid in my lungs, my vision starting to blur at the edges. I'm going to pass out right here in the kitchen with Mrs. Callahan talking about how everyone knows about me and my brother. Malakai's arm wraps around my waist from behind, pulling me back against his chest. I can feel the tension in his body, but his voice comes out steady when he speaks.

"And you'd understand?"

Mrs. Callahan turns to face us, but there's no judgment in her expression. No disgust. No horror. Just a quiet acceptance that somehow makes the whole situation feel more surreal.

"I understand that love happens in unexpected places and between unexpected people." Her gaze moves between us, taking in Malakai's protective stance and my obvious panic. "And I haven't seen Elliot this relaxed and happy in years. So yes, I'll turn a blind eye. I'll pretend I don't know anything should someone ask." She pauses, something flickering in her eyes. "However, it's only a matter of time. Ashford secrets never stay secrets for long."

The kettle clicks off, and she pours herself a cup of tea with the same calm she brings to everything. She nods once at us, a gesture that feels almost like a blessing, and then she's gone, her footsteps fading down the hall toward the staff's quarters.

Malakai's arms tighten around me. "Breathe."

I try. The air comes in shallow gasps that don't seem to reach my lungs, and my hands are shaking where they grip the edge of the counter.

"She's not going to tell anyone." His lips brush my ear. "She's been with this family for thirty years. She's kept worse secrets than this."

"What secrets could possibly be worse than this?"

He doesn't answer, which is somehow more terrifying than any response he could have given.

We stand there for a long moment, wrapped around each other in the kitchen where I grew up. The kitchen where I learned to walk and burned my first batch of cookies and sat at the table doing homework while Mrs. Callahan made dinner. Everything feels different now, tainted by the knowledge that our secret isn't as secret as we thought, that at least one person knows what we are to each other.

"It's okay." Malakai presses a kiss to my temple. "We're okay."

I want to believe him but it's hard when every time I try to build my world, it crumbles. Tears cloud my vision as Malakai tugs me toward the couch in the lounge with a blanket and a cup of tea. He kisses my forehead and promises that everything will be fine. But the anxiety doesn't fade. If anything, it grows, feeding on itself until I feel like I'm going to crawl out of my skin.

However, Malakai has work to do, calls to make, and emails to send. I watch him settle into the armchair across the room, phone pressed to his ear,

and I try to focus on the book in my lap and try to lose myself in fiction the way I used to before my life became stranger than any story I could imagine.

It doesn't work.

It feels like everyone is watching me, even though there's no one here but us. The weight of imaginary gazes presses down on my chest until I can't sit still anymore, until I have to move or scream or both.

I slide off the couch and cross to where Malakai is sitting, lowering myself to the floor at his feet without thinking. This is what I do when the world gets too loud, when my thoughts spiral out of control. I kneel at his feet and let his presence anchor me, the familiar position quieting the chaos in my brain.

Today, it doesn't work.

I shift my weight from one knee to the other, trying to find comfort that refuses to come. Malakai's hand finds my hair, stroking absently while he continues his call, but even that doesn't help. The anxiety is still there, writhing beneath my skin, and no amount of submission is making it go away.

Without really deciding to, I crawl up into his lap.

He makes a small sound of surprise but adjusts easily, shifting his legs to accommodate my weight while continuing his conversation. I burrow against his chest, pressing my face into the warm curve of his neck, and try to breathe.

It's not working. Nothing is working.

I shift again, pulling my legs up, trying to find a position that feels safe. Malakai's free hand comes up to steady me, but I can't stop moving or find any way to exist in my own body that doesn't feel like torture.

"I need to go to my room." The words come out small, fractured. "Please."
Malakai ends his call without hesitation. "Of course. Let me—"

"No, I just—I need a minute. Please."

I extract myself from his lap and practically flee the room, my feet carrying me up the stairs and down the hall to my bedroom. The one I haven't slept in for weeks. I close the door behind me and lean against it, trying to figure out what's going on in my head.

This room feels foreign now, like it belongs to someone else. The bed is made with crisp corners, the desk is clear, and everything is exactly where the staff left it because I haven't touched any of it. I've been living in Malakai's room, sleeping in Malakai's bed, and existing in Malakai's space like it's the only place I belong.

And now someone knows about us. Someone has seen through the facade and recognized what we are to each other, and even though Mrs. Callahan says she won't tell, even though she promised to keep our secret, I can't stop thinking about what happens when someone else figures it out.

What happens when the secret spreads, the way she said Ashford secrets always do? What happens when our parents find out, when the staff starts talking, when the whole world discovers that Malakai Ashford is fucking his brother?

Margaret's words start running through my head.

"You really should be sleeping in your own room, Mr. Elliot. It's not proper for two grown men to share a bed, even if they are brothers. People might talk."

I pace the length of the room, my thoughts spiraling faster and faster. My hands start shaking and not even wringing them together is giving me any

peace. I can't catch my breath, can't slow down, and can't find any way to make the panic stop.

The collar. Maybe the collar will help.

I took it off after the shower this morning in the panic of the staff knocking on the door. Rushing across the hall, I snatch it and buckle it around my neck with shaky fingers, but even that doesn't calm me. The leather feels like it's choking me instead of grounding me, and I have to fight the urge to tear it off.

Nothing is working. I tried kneeling, I tried Malakai's lap, I tried the collar, and nothing is working. The tools that always bring me peace are failing me, and I don't know what to do. I don't know how to exist in this body, in this moment, in this life that's spinning out of control.

A silent scream tears from my throat as a tear runs down my cheek, the door creaking open only slightly pulling me out of my spiral. I spin around, my heart leaping into my throat, but it's just Malakai. He steps inside and closes the door behind him, his expression shifting from concern to something more focused as he takes in my state.

"I tried everything." The words tumble out of me in a rush. "I knelt, I sat in your lap, I even put on the collar. Nothing is working. I can't stop thinking about Mrs. Callahan and what she said and what Margaret said and what happens if someone else finds out and I can't breathe and I can't—"

"Elliot." His voice cuts through my spiral. "Look at me."

I force myself to meet his eyes.

He crosses to me in three strides and reaches for my throat, his fingers finding the buckle of the collar. I expect him to tighten it, to use it to ground me the way he usually does, but instead he loosens it, sliding the leather free from my neck.

"What are you doing?" My voice comes out a little squeaky.

He doesn't answer. Instead, he lifts the collar to his own throat and begins to fasten it around his neck.

A shocked gasp falls from my lips.

"Malakai, what—"

"Sometimes giving up control and being in control coincide." His fingers work the buckle, securing the collar in place. It looks different on him, darker against his tanned skin, the leather that's molded itself to my throat now circling his. "You've always needed to let go, to let someone else take over, to make the decisions, and to tell you what to do. But that only works in a world where the control is too much. There are times when you feel so out of control that being in control is the only thing that fixes it. I keep telling you that I'm yours. But maybe it's time to show you what that means."



Malakai

Elliot stands frozen in front of me, his eyes fixed on the collar around my throat. The leather sits heavy against my pulse point, warm from his skin already, foreign in a way that makes something twist in my chest. I've never worn a collar before. I've never submitted to anyone. I've never even considered the possibility of giving up the control I've spent my entire life cultivating.

But for Elliot, I would do anything.

"Come here." I reach for his hand and guide him toward the bed, walking backward until we're standing beside the mattress. "Undress me."

His hands shake as they reach for the hem of my shirt. I watch his face as he works, the way his eyes keep darting to the collar, and the way his breath comes in short, uneven bursts. He's overwhelmed, caught somewhere

between confusion and arousal, and I want to smooth the furrow from his brow and tell him everything will be okay.

Instead, I stand still and let him undress me at his own pace. Giving him control in this moment when his mind is a mess is the only thing I can think of to fix everything.

The shirt comes off first, lifted over my head with trembling fingers that brush against my ribs on the way up. Then his hands move to my pants, fumbling with the button for a long moment before finally working it free. The zipper follows, and then he pushes the fabric down my hips, taking my underwear with it, until I'm standing naked before him, only the collar around my throat.

He steps back to look at me, and the expression on his face makes my cock twitch. Wonder. Hunger. Something that looks almost like reverence.

"Get undressed." I let a hint of command creep back into my voice. Old habits. "And get on the bed."

He strips quickly, shedding his clothes in a pile on the floor, and climbs onto the mattress. His back hits the headboard and he scrambles up against it, already hard and leaking against his stomach.

"What are you doing?" His voice comes out breathless.

"I think it's time I give you a little more control. Give you all of me."

His eyes go wide. "You mean..."

"I mean exactly what you think I mean."

I reach for the nightstand and pull open the drawer, finding the bottle of lube. I've used this to open Elliot up more times than I can count, watching him fall apart on my fingers before I ever gave him my cock. Now I'm going to do the same thing to myself while he watches.

I've only bottomed once before. Back in high school, I was still figuring out what I wanted. It wasn't my thing, but for the right person, I'd do it. The biggest thing was that some part of me wanted to give Elliot everything. Not just submission but my body. All of it. To let him truly understand that he was all of mine.

I pour a generous amount into my palm. God, this is going to be a stretch. It's been over a decade. Blowing out a deep breath, I crawl onto the bed and settle myself over his stomach, my thighs bracketing his hips. His cock twitches against my ass. "You're going to fuck me, little brother."

"I don't..." He swallows hard, his hands hovering at his sides. "I've never... I mean, I have, but only once, and it was a long time ago—"

"I'm going to take such good care of you, okay?" I lean down and press a kiss to his forehead. "Just trust me." He nods, some of the tension draining from his shoulders. "But if at any point this becomes too much, you have your colors. This doesn't work without communication."

"Yes, sir."

The title sends a shiver through me. For a moment, I consider what it would be like to truly switch roles. But no, I like being called sir. I like the way it sounds on his lips.

I lean back on one hand, spreading my thighs wider, and reach between my cheeks with my slicked fingers. The first touch makes me hiss. It's been so long since anyone has touched me here, and even longer since I've touched myself. I circle the entrance slowly, letting myself adjust to the sensation, and then press one finger inside.

Elliot makes a sound like all the air has been punched out of him.

I keep my eyes on his face as I work myself open, watching every flicker of emotion that crosses his features. Shock first, his eyes going wide as he

processes what he's seeing. Then fascination, his gaze fixed on where my hand disappears between my thighs. Then desperate, aching need, his pupils blown so wide his eyes look almost black.

His hand moves down to grip the base of his cock, squeezing hard, his whole body trembling with the effort of holding back his orgasm. The sight of him like this, flushed and desperate and fighting against his own pleasure just because, makes me want this moment even more.

This is what I wanted to give him. Not just the physical act, but the knowledge that I trust him enough to be vulnerable. That I want him enough to let go of the control I've held onto my entire life.

"Sir, I'm going to come." Panic bleeds through his voice. "Fuck, I can't—I'm watching you and I can't—"

"No, you're not." I add a second finger and scissor them apart, stretching myself wider. "Not until I have you inside me. You can hold on for me, can't you, baby?"

He whimpers, his hand tightening around his cock as he fights against the pleasure threatening to overwhelm him. I watch him struggle. My precious little doe trying to obey, Elliot choosing me over his own release, and the love I feel for him in this moment is so intense it steals my breath.

I've had lovers before. Men and women who warmed my bed and satisfied my needs and left before morning without leaving a mark. But none of them ever looked at me the way Elliot is looking at me right now. None of them ever made me want to crack myself open and let them see every dark, twisted thing that lives inside me.

I add a third finger, working myself faster now, the stretch burning in a way that borders on pain. My body remembers this, even after all these years. It remembers how to relax, how to open, and how to accept. By the

time I'm satisfied that I'm stretched enough, I'm breathing hard and my cock is leaking against my stomach.

I pull my fingers free and position myself over Elliot's cock, the head pressing against my entrance. He's so hard it looks painful, his length flushed dark and glistening with precum, and the thought that all of that is about to be inside me makes my head spin.

"Ready?"

He nods frantically, beyond words.

I sink down.

The stretch is intense, more than I remembered. My body resists for a moment before giving way, and I have to pause halfway down to let myself adjust to the intrusion. Elliot's hands fly to my hips, fingers digging in hard enough to bruise, and the sound he makes is broken and beautiful and utterly wrecked.

"Oh god." His voice cracks on the words. "Oh god, Malakai, you feel—I can't—you're so—"

"Breathe." I stroke my hands down his chest, feeling his heart hammer against my palm. "Just breathe, baby. We've got time. I've got you."

The words are as much for me as they are for him. I give myself a moment to adjust, to let my body relax around him, and then I sink the rest of the way down, taking him to the hilt.

We both groan.

He's inside me. My little brother is inside me, filling me up, stretching me open in ways I haven't felt in over a decade. And it's not just good. It's right. It's everything I didn't know I was missing until this exact moment.

I plant my hands on his chest and lean down to kiss him. The angle is different from this position, deeper and more intimate, our bodies connected

in every way possible. I pour everything I'm feeling into the press of my lips against his. All the love I've been too afraid to say out loud. All the devotion I can only show behind closed doors. All the fierce, burning need to make him understand that he is everything to me.

His hips jerk upward, a reflexive thrust that drives him deeper inside me, and we both gasp into each other's mouths.

"There you go, baby." I break the kiss and rock my hips, encouraging him. "Again. Make me feel good. Show me what you can do."

He finds a stuttering rhythm, his movements uncoordinated but eager, each thrust pushing a sound from my throat that I don't try to contain. I want him to hear what he does to me. This is something I need just as desperately as he does.

I let him set the pace for a while, content to ride the waves of pleasure he's creating, adjusting my angle until he's hitting that spot inside me that makes my vision blur. But eventually I want more. I want to see his face when he falls apart.

I roll us over, Elliot gasping as his back hits the mattress, his eyes flying wide at the sudden change in position. But he doesn't stop moving. If anything, he picks up a better rhythm now that he has leverage, his hips snapping up into me with increasing confidence. Each thrust drives him deeper, as I brace my hands on his chest and let myself feel all of it.

I reach between us and wrap my hand around my own cock, stroking in time with his thrusts.

"You feel so good." His voice comes out breathless, awed. "Oh my god, I can't—sir, please—I'm not going to last—"

"Then don't." I squeeze my cock and roll my hips up to meet his next thrust. "Come for me, Elliot. Fill me up. I want to feel it."

He cries out and slams into me one last time, his whole body going rigid as his orgasm crashes through him. I can feel him pulsing inside me, the hot rush of his release flooding my insides, and the sensation tips me over the edge right behind him. I come with a groan, spilling across his stomach and chest, pleasure whiting out my vision until the only thing that exists is him beneath me and inside me and all around me.

For a long moment, neither of us moves as Elliot collapses to my chest. We just lie there, tangled together, breathing hard as the aftershocks ripple through our bodies. Elliot is still inside me, softening slowly, but I don't make any move to separate us. I want to stay like this forever.

Eventually, I find the strength to move. I pull him tighter into my arms and roll us onto our sides, keeping him close as he slowly slips out of me. The sensation makes us both shiver, a small aftershock of intimacy.

"How do you feel, doe?"

He takes a moment to consider, his brow furrowing the way it does when he's thinking hard about something. "It's quiet again." His voice is soft, full of wonder. "I don't understand. I really like kneeling. I thought that was the only thing that made the noise stop."

I smile and press a kiss to his forehead, pulling him closer until his head is tucked beneath my chin. "Because it was never about the kneeling." I stroke my hand down his spine, feeling him melt against me. "It was about controlling the peace in your head, about taking charge of it. Sometimes that looks like kneeling. Sometimes it looks like wearing the collar." I press another kiss to his hair. "Sometimes it looks like being the one in control instead of the one surrendering."

His fingers reach up, tracing along the leather still circling my throat.

"Sometimes it's just holding the one you love." I tighten my arms around him, letting him see the one piece of my heart that will ruin us both. "Knowing that no one outside this room can know your dirtiest secret."

He gasps softly against my chest, his heart rate spiking where our bodies are pressed together. The word hangs between us, the confession that should never be revealed. He doesn't say it back, but I don't expect him to. The way he curls closer, the way his fingers keep tracing the collar on my throat, and the way his whole body relaxes into mine like I'm the only safe place in the world—it tells me everything.

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Elliot

The weekend was ours.

I didn't fuck Malakai again after that first time, and I didn't want to. Not because it wasn't incredible, but because I didn't need it. For the first time in as long as I can remember, I was happy in my own skin, content with my place in the world. Something fundamental had shifted between us when he put on that collar, when he let me inside him, when he showed me that this thing we have isn't just about my needs. It's about both of us. It goes both ways.

The rules loosened after that night. I still wore my collar most of the time at home, but the kneeling was no longer a requirement. Malakai didn't demand it, didn't schedule it, and didn't make it part of the structure that had governed my days since I came home. I did it when I wanted to, when the

world got too loud and I needed the quiet that only came from surrendering to his presence.

But most of the time, I didn't need it.

Most of the time, I'd curl up on the chair beside Malakai's desk while he worked, my legs tucked beneath me and a book in my lap that I rarely actually read. I'd watch him instead, cataloging the way his brow furrowed when he was concentrating, the way his fingers flew across the keyboard, and the way he'd glance up every few minutes like he needed to confirm I was still there.

Or we'd stay in bed for hours, wrapped around each other while he answered emails on his phone and I dozed against his chest. His free hand would card through my hair absently, and sometimes he'd press kisses to my forehead between messages, and I'd drift in a haze of warmth and safety that I never wanted to end.

It wasn't perfect. We still had to be careful and maintain the facade whenever staff was around. But behind closed doors, in the spaces that belonged only to us, we were something more. Something real. Something that made all the pretending worthwhile.

Monday morning arrived too soon, pulling us back into the real world of spreadsheets and meetings and the careful distance we had to maintain in public. I didn't wear the cage or the plug today. Neither of us felt the need for that level of intensity, not after the weekend we'd shared. But the chain was there, hidden beneath my shirt, cool metal links resting against my skin like a secret only we shared.

I caught myself stealing glances at Malakai every time he came down to the bullpen. My heart did a stupid little flip whenever our eyes met across

the crowded floor, and I had to look away quickly before anyone noticed the color rising in my cheeks.

He was so good at keeping his expression neutral, but I saw the way his mouth twitched when he looked at me and the heat that flickered in his eyes before he turned away.

At lunch, I made up some excuse about needing to discuss the quarterly reports and practically ran up to his office. He was waiting for me, standing by the window with his jacket off and his sleeves rolled up, and the moment I stepped inside, he crossed the room in a few strides and pulled me into his arms.

"Took you long enough." His mouth found mine before I could respond, kissing me with a hunger that made my knees go weak.

I melted into him, my hands fisting in his shirt as he walked me backward until my shoulders hit the door. He kissed me until my lips were swollen and tingling and I couldn't remember my own name, let alone the quarterly reports I was supposedly there to discuss.

"You're going to get us caught," I mumbled against his mouth, not pulling away.

"Don't care." He kissed me again, deeper this time, his tongue sweeping into my mouth like he was trying to taste every part of me. "Needed to taste you. Been thinking about it all morning."

"We have jobs."

"I'm the CEO. I can take a long lunch if I want to."

I laughed, the sound muffled against his lips, and he swallowed it down like it was something precious. We stayed like that for far too long, pressed against the door of his office, kissing like teenagers who'd just discovered what their mouths were for.

By the time I stumbled back to my desk, I was dazed and grinning and completely useless for the rest of the afternoon. My lips felt bruised in the best way, and every time I touched them, I could still feel the ghost of his mouth on mine. Paulina gave me a knowing look when I sat down, but she didn't say anything. She just smiled and went back to her spreadsheet.

The drive home was comfortable enough. Malakai kept one hand on my thigh the whole way, his thumb tracing idle patterns through my pants while he navigated traffic with the other. I leaned my head against the window and watched the city blur past, already thinking about what we'd do when we got home. Maybe another bath. Maybe just bed. Maybe I'd kneel at his feet while he read, not because he told me to but because I wanted to.

Then we pulled into the garage and I saw Mom's car parked in its usual spot. I sat up straight, every muscle in my body going rigid. "I thought they were in Milan."

"They were." Malakai's jaw tightens, a muscle jumping beneath his skin. "Plans must have changed."

"What do we do?"

"We go inside and act normal." He squeezes my thigh once, before releasing it. "They're probably just passing through. They never stay long."

I want to believe him. I nod and climb out of the car, following him through the side entrance that leads into the mudroom. The house is rather quiet, which means the day staff has been dismissed for the evening, a few lingering to ensure everything is prepared for tomorrow. But muffled voices drifting down the hallway from the direction of my father's study catch my attention.

"Fuck," Malakai murmurs, his hand brushing the small of my back. "I forgot something at work. I'll be right back to take care of this. Go upstairs,

Elliot." He presses a chaste kiss to my head and rushes back to the garage.

I should listen to my brother and trust him to deal with whatever this is. Instead, I find myself drifting down the hallway toward the study, drawn by an odd curiosity to know what they're talking about.

The door is slightly ajar, light spilling through the gap along with my parents' voices.

"—think it's for the best." My mother's voice hits my ears. "He needs structure, Richard. Direction. He's been drifting since he came home, and frankly, it's starting to reflect poorly on the family."

"Malakai's been handling him." My father pushes out, sounding bored, like this conversation is keeping him from something more important.

"Malakai's been coddling him." The sharpness in her tone makes me flinch. "He needs to stand on his own two feet. Learn some independence. This position at the company was supposed to be temporary, remember? A way to ease him back in while we figured out a more permanent solution."

"And you think sending him back to school is the answer?"

"I think finishing his degree is the answer. An official credential. Something he can point to that proves he's more than just the family disappointment who couldn't hack it the first time around."

I press my back against the wall beside the door, my heart pounding so hard I can hear it in my ears. Family disappointment. Couldn't hack it. Is that really all I am to them?

"I've already looked into programs." My mother continues, oblivious to the damage she's inflicting. "Stanford has an accelerated track. So does Wharton. Georgetown. Columbia. Any of them would be suitable."

Stanford. Wharton. Georgetown. Columbia.

All of them hundreds of miles away. All of them on the other side of the country. All of them would separate me from Malakai.

"Those are all excellent schools," my father says. "But getting him admitted on such short notice—"

"I've made some calls. His previous university is willing to take him back for the spring semester. He could start the preparatory program as early as next week."

Previous university.

The place where Marcus found me. The place where Marcus broke me. The place I ran from with nothing but a duffel bag and a face full of bruises and the desperate hope that I'd never have to see it again.

"That seems fast." My father actually sounds surprised. "Does Elliot know about any of this?"

"Not yet. We'll tell him tonight, once Malakai gets home. Present it as a family decision. I've already arranged for a car to be delivered tomorrow, and I have a new wardrobe coming in as well. Everything he'll need to start fresh."

"And Malakai? What does he think about this plan?"

"Malakai will understand." Her voice hardens. "He has the company to run. He can't be babysitting his brother forever. It's not healthy, the way Elliot depends on him. The sooner we separate them, the better."

I can't breathe.

The hallway shrinks around me, the walls pressing in as I try to suck in a breath and fail. I stumble backward, my hand catching the edge of a side table to keep myself upright as stars burst at the edges of my vision.

They want to send me back. Back to that school. Back to the place where Marcus's friends are waiting for me with fists and fake promises of what

they'll do if I ever show my face again.

I never told Malakai everything. I told him about Marcus, about the bruises and the control and the fear that lived in my bones for the months I dated that bastard. But I didn't tell him about the others. Marcus' friends. The ones who watched and laughed and sometimes joined in when they were drunk enough. The ones who made it clear that if Marcus ever got tired of me, they'd be happy to take his place.

If I go back, they'll be waiting. Either to get revenge for what happened to Marcus after Malakai took care of him, or to collect on the debt Marcus always said I owed.

I can't go back. I won't.

My feet carry me up the stairs, my mind spiraling into panic so thick I can barely see where I'm going. The hallway stretches out before me, my vision distorting as I pace the length of it with my hands shaking at my sides and my breath coming in short, ragged gasps.

Text Malakai. I need to text Malakai.

I fumble for my phone, my fingers clumsily jotting at the screen as I type out a message.

I need you. Please. I need you now.

His response comes almost immediately.

Where are you?

A soft sob tears from my throat as a tear splashes onto the screen.

Upstairs.

The three little typing dots ebb and flow for a few seconds before I get his response.

Breathe for me. In for four, out for four.

Go to my room. Strip. Get the collar on. Get into bed. I'll be there as soon as I can.

I stare at the words, trying to make them make sense through the fog of panic. Strip. Collar. Bed. I can do that. I can follow instructions. That's what I'm good at, the only thing I'm good at. I start toward Malakai's room, my hand reaching for the door, when a voice stops me cold.

"Mr. Elliot." Margaret's voice stops me cold. She's standing at the end of the hallway with a stack of fresh towels, something in her expression that makes my stomach clench. "I was hoping to run into you."

"I'm in a bit of a hurry, actually—" I smack at the tears running down my face but it does nothing to dull the panic.

"This will only take a moment." She sets the towels down on a side table and moves closer. "I've been meaning to follow up on our last conversation. About your... sleeping arrangements." She waves her hand dismissively

My mouth goes dry as my gaze darts into Malakai's room and then back to Margaret. "I told you, I have nightmares sometimes. Malakai lets me—"

"You've been here for a while now." She cuts me off, her tone sharpening. "And your room still has been barely touched. The sheets have only been changed once or twice since you showed up here because they haven't been slept in. Your clothes are exactly where I put them after laundering, too." She pauses. "You're not occasionally sleeping in your brother's room, Mr. Elliot. You're living in it."

"That's not—"

"And then there was the other morning." She glances down the hallway, checking that we're alone. "When I knocked on Mr. Malakai's door because I thought I heard someone in distress. He said he dropped something, but

the sounds I heard before he answered weren't the sounds of someone dropping something."

The blood drains from my face. She's talking about the shower, when Malakai had me pressed against the tile and I couldn't keep quiet.

"I don't know what you think you heard," I manage, "but you're wrong."

"I heard *two* voices, Mr. Elliot. And neither of them sounded like they were in pain, if you understand my meaning."

I understand. God help me, I understand exactly what she's implying. The panic spreads outward, my limbs feeling heavier as I try to keep my wits about me. I take in a small breath but that just makes everything worse, a sob sitting at the back of my throat.

"Whatever you're imagining, it's not happening." The words come out steadier than I feel as I shove them out, desperately trying to protect our secret. "Malakai is my brother. He's been helping me through a difficult time, that's all."

"I've known your brother since he was a boy." Margaret's voice softens slightly, but her eyes remain full of distrust. "He's always been intense. Possessive of the things he considers his. And the way he looks at you, the way he's always finding excuses to touch you when he thinks no one's watching..." She shakes her head. "I'm not blind, Mr. Elliot. And I'm not the only one who's noticed."

Panic claws at my throat. "There's nothing to notice."

"If he's pressuring you into something, if this isn't something you want—"

"He's not pressuring me into anything!" The denial comes out too fast but I don't want anyone questioning what I have with him. He's everything I want and need and right now, knowing my parents are about to ship me off back to hell, I really, *really* just want to crawl up into a ball and disappear.

"Malakai would never hurt me. He's the only person in this house who actually gives a damn about me." My breath catches on the last word and the sob I was holding back makes an appearance.

Margaret frowns, suddenly concerned as a fresh wave of tears roll down my cheeks. "That may be true. But whatever is going on between you two, it's not something the rest of the staff will overlook forever. People talk. Questions get asked. And your parents are home now." She picks up her towels again. "I'd be very careful, if I were you." She walks past me without another word, disappearing around the corner toward the service stairs.

Her words feel like a threat as I clutch at my chest, another sob falling from my lips. I dash into Malakai's room and grab my collar before retreating to my space, refusing to chance another encounter with someone else. The moment I get the door shut, I pull out the piece of leather and wrap it around my neck, but it doesn't calm me the way it usually does.

Strip. Malakai said to strip.

I tear off my clothes, leaving them in a pile on the floor, and crawl into bed. The sheets are cold and unfamiliar. This isn't Malakai's bed. Nothing here smells like him. This isn't where I belong. But I pull the blankets up over my head anyway, curling into the smallest shape I can manage, trying to make myself disappear.

"Fuck, I need you," I mumble as I dial my brother again.

Voicemail.

"No, no, no." The word comes out as a whimper. I call again.

This time, he picks up on the second ring. "Elliot? What's wrong?"

"They know." The words tumble out in a rush, tripping over each other. "I think they know. Margaret was asking questions and she saw me going into your room and she asked if you were forcing me into something and Mom

wants to send me away and they're talking about schools and they want to send me back to California, Malakai, they want to send me back to where Marcus was and I can't go back there, I can't, I can't—"

"Elliot. Breathe."

"I can't breathe. I can't—"

"Yes, you can. Listen to my voice. In through your nose. Hold it. Out through your mouth. Do it with me. In... hold... out."

I try to follow his instructions, trying to match my breathing to the steady rhythm of his voice, but the panic is too big, taking over all my rational sense.

"Good. Keep breathing. I'm coming home."

"How long?" My voice cracks on the words.

"Ten minutes. Maybe less." There's a pause, and when he speaks again, his voice is edged with barely contained fury. "I need to figure out why our parents are here and what they're planning. But I need you to stay in your room and wait for me. Can you do that?"

"Yes."

"Good boy." His voice softens slightly. "I'm going to fix this, Elliot. Do you hear me? Whatever they're planning, whatever they think they've decided, it's not going to happen. You're not going anywhere."

I want to believe him. I want to trust that he can make this right, that he has the power to stop our parents from ripping us apart. But the fear is too strong, too deeply rooted in every terrible thing that has ever happened to me.

"Malakai?"

"Yes?"

"I didn't tell you everything." The confession scrapes its way out of my throat. "About California. About Marcus. There were others. His friends. They..." I can't finish that statement or put words to the things they did and the things they threatened to do.

Silence on the other end of the line meets my ears before I hear my brother's voice again. "I'm going to kill them."

"Malakai—"

"Ten minutes, Elliot. Stay where you are. Don't talk to anyone. Don't open your door for anyone except me."

The line goes dead.

I curl tighter under the blankets and count my breaths, waiting for the sound of his footsteps in the hallway.



Malakai

I should have never fucking left. I didn't absolutely need that file but I wanted to get a headstart on tomorrow's presentation and now... my brother... I cut off that line of thinking, trying to focus on the fact that I'm navigating a 2000 lb steel machine.

The drive home takes eight minutes on a normal day. I make it in five, running two red lights and cutting off a delivery truck that lays on its horn as I swerve past. My hands are white-knuckled on the steering wheel and my jaw is clenched so tight my teeth ache, but the only thing keeping me from losing my mind completely is the knowledge that Elliot is waiting for me. He needs me. I can fall apart later, after I've fixed this.

Others. He said there were others. Marcus's friends. People who hurt him and threatened him and made his life a living hell while he was trapped in that school thousands of miles from anyone who gave a damn about him.

And now our parents want to send him back to that place, back to those people, like the last few weeks never happened. Like he hasn't finally started to heal. Like he's nothing more than a problem to be shipped off and forgotten.

I pull into the garage and kill the engine, sitting there for a moment in the sudden silence. My blood is rushing in my ears and I can feel the rage building in my chest, a pressure that's going to explode the moment I see my mother's perfectly composed face and my father's dismissive indifference. They have no idea what they're about to get from me. They have no idea what I'm willing to do to protect my brother.

This isn't even the first time they've done this. Elliot was thirteen, quiet and anxious and desperate for approval that never came. Our parents sat in the study with brochures spread across the table, discussing boarding schools like they were choosing a new car or deciding which charity gala to attend.

They never asked Elliot what he wanted. They never considered that sending him away might break something in him that couldn't be fixed. They just made the decision and expected everyone to fall in line.

I tried to stop them then. I was thirteen too, just a kid with no power and no leverage, and when I begged them to let Elliot stay, my father looked at me with that cold, calculating expression and said, "This is what's best for everyone, Malakai. Your brother is holding you back."

Fucking *asshole*. Elliot is not a problem to be solved or a weight around my neck. He's the other half of my soul.

I've never forgotten everything my parents said about my twin brother. I've never forgiven them for it either.

I get out of the car and walk into the house, frowning at the celebratory murmurs coming from the study. I can hear the clink of glasses and the self-satisfied tone in my mother's voice. They think they've solved the Elliot problem once again. *Fuck that.*

Marching toward their voices, I catch them sitting at the table with papers spread out in front of them, a bottle of expensive champagne chilling in a bucket beside my father's whiskey glass. Brochures and application forms and credit card statements cover every inch of the polished wood surface.

I thought it was just a mention here or there about *possibly* sending Elliot to school. I should have fucking known that Mom was already laying out the groundwork so they could snap their fingers and send Elliot off.

"Malakai!" My mother looks up with a smile that doesn't reach her eyes. "There you are, darling. We were just about to send for you. Come sit down, we have wonderful news."

"I know what you were discussing." My voice comes out flat and cold.

My father sets down his whiskey and gestures at the chair across from him. "Good, that saves time. Then you understand why this is the best solution for everyone involved. We've found an excellent program for Elliot at his old university. They're willing to take him back for the spring semester, and with a few calls, we can have him enrolled in their accelerated track by next week." He shuffles through some papers and pulls out a glossy brochure. "It's really quite impressive what they're offering. A fresh start, a real credential, and most importantly, some distance so he can learn to stand on his own two feet."

I walk toward the table, my gaze dropping to the papers spread across the surface. Brochures from Stanford, Wharton, Georgetown, Columbia. Application forms already half-filled out in my mother's precise

handwriting. A credit card statement showing purchases for a new wardrobe, a new car, a lease on a new apartment, and everything else Elliot would need to start his new life hundreds of miles away from me. They've thought of everything. They've planned every detail of how to tear my brother out of my life, and they're sitting here drinking champagne like they've just closed a particularly profitable business deal.

Fuck. That.

I sweep my arm across the table and send all of it crashing to the floor.

The whiskey glass shatters against the hardwood, spraying amber liquid across the Persian rug my mother had imported from Morocco. The champagne bottle hits the ground and explodes, sending glass and foam spraying across her designer shoes and the hem of her cream-colored dress. Papers scatter everywhere, fluttering down to land in the spreading puddle of alcohol and broken glass.

My mother screams and lurches back from the table, staring at the mess on her shoes in horror. My father surges to his feet, his face going red with fury.

"What the hell do you think you're doing?" He slams his palm on the table. "Have you lost your mind?"

"For once in your life, I would like you to remember that you have *two* sons." My voice shakes with barely contained rage. "Not one son and an obstacle. Not one heir and one disappointment. Two sons. Identical, in case you've forgotten what we looked like before you decided one of us wasn't worth keeping around. Two sons who deserve love and attention and affection in equal measure."

"Malakai, calm down." My mother recovers her composure, though her voice is strained. "This is about Elliot's future. We're trying to help him."

"Bullshit." The word cracks through the room. "This has never been about Elliot's future. This has always been about mine. About making sure the golden child doesn't get dragged down by his defective twin. Do you have any idea what it was like, growing up watching you treat my brother like he was worthless? You were my heroes. Both of you. I wanted to be just like you when I grew up. I wanted to make you proud and to live up to the Ashford name. And Elliot was at my side through all of it. We were going to rule the world together. That's what we promised each other when we were kids. We were going to take over the company and make it bigger and better and we were going to do it side by side, the way twins are supposed to."

My father opens his mouth to interrupt, but I don't let him.

"But then you broke everything. You decided that Elliot wasn't good enough, that he was holding me back, that the best thing for everyone would be to ship him off to some school on the other side of the country where you wouldn't have to look at him anymore. You took my brother from me. My best friend. The person who understood me better than anyone else in the world. And for what?" My voice rises, echoing off the walls of the study. "Because he's quiet? Because he's different than me? Because he doesn't fit your narrow definition of what an Ashford should be? So what? So fucking what?"

"This is about giving him opportunities." My father's voice has gone hard and cold, the tone he uses in boardroom negotiations when he's trying to intimidate his opponents into submission. "He needs credentials if he's ever going to stand beside you as an equal. A degree from a respected institution, connections, a foundation to build on. We're doing this for his benefit."

"He was already standing beside me!" I slam both hands on the table hard enough to make the remaining glasses rattle. "He was working at the

company. He was learning. He was healing from everything you put him through, and he was finally starting to believe that he might actually be worth something. And now you want to rip all of that away and send him back to the place that nearly destroyed him."

"You're being dramatic." My mother smooths her hands down her ruined dress, her expression shifting into something that's probably meant to be sympathetic. "Elliot had some difficulties at school, yes, but that was years ago. He's older now. More mature. A fresh start in a familiar environment might be exactly what he needs."

"A familiar environment?" I laugh, but there's no humor in it. "You mean the environment where his boyfriend beat him for months? The environment where he came home with bruises he had to hide and a flinch reflex that still hasn't gone away? That's the fresh start you want to give him?"

My mother's face goes pale. "We didn't know it was that serious. He never said anything."

"Of course he didn't say anything. When has Elliot ever been able to say anything to either of you? When have you ever actually listened to him? You don't see anything other than dollar signs and the Ashford image. Half the time you don't even see me, and I'm the one you actually approve of."

"That's not true." She reaches for me, her hand extended like she's trying to comfort a child throwing a tantrum. "Malakai, darling, we love you. We love both of you. Everything we do is for your benefit."

I step back before she can touch me. "Really? You've been here three or four times in the last few weeks. And every single conversation has been about contracts and galas and business deals and which politician needs schmoozing at the next fundraiser. Not once have you asked how I'm doing.

Not once have you asked what I do in my free time, or whether I've thought about taking a vacation, or if there's anyone in my life who matters to me."

"We assumed you would tell us if there was anything important—"

"Do you even know that someone at work touched your son without his consent?"

The words land like a bomb in the middle of the room. My mother's hand drops to her side and my father goes very still, his expression shifting from anger to something that might almost be concern if I didn't know better.

"What?" My mother's voice comes out barely above a whisper. "Malakai, what are you talking about? When did this happen? Why didn't you tell us?"

"It wasn't me." I watch the confusion ripple across her face as she tries to process information that doesn't fit into her carefully constructed worldview. "It wasn't me who was assaulted. It was Elliot. A coworker cornered him in the archives a few weeks ago. He put his hands on my brother and tried to force himself on him while Elliot begged him to stop."

"Oh my god." My mother's hand flies to her mouth. "Is he alright? Did you call the police? We should press charges, we should—"

"I handled it. I fired the guy and made sure he'll never work in this city again." I keep my voice flat, even though I want to scream. "But that's not the point. The point is that you didn't know. You had no idea that your son was assaulted at work, because you never asked. You never ask about Elliot. You come back when it's convenient, talk about whatever business needs discussing, and then leave again without sparing a single thought for the son you shipped off to boarding school when he was thirteen years old."

"We check in," my father says, but even he sounds uncertain now. "We ask how things are going."

"You ask how the company is going. You ask about quarterly projections and profit margins and whether the Singapore deal is going to close on schedule. You don't ask about us. When Elliot was off at school, I used to beg you for updates. I'd ask how he was doing, whether he was happy, whether he'd made friends, and you never had answers. You didn't know because you didn't care enough to find out."

"We thought he was fine." My mother's voice softens to nearly a whisper as she twists her hands in front of her. "He seemed fine when he came home for the holidays. He never mentioned any problems."

"He seemed fine because he learned a long time ago that showing you his pain only makes things worse." I take a step back from the table, suddenly exhausted by the weight of all the things I've been holding back for years. "He cries when you're not looking. He has nightmares about the things that happened to him at that school. He flinches when people move too fast around him because he's been conditioned to expect violence. But you don't know any of that, because you never bothered to look past the surface."

"He's seemed so happy since he's been home." My mother sounds genuinely bewildered now, like the idea that Elliot might be suffering has never once occurred to her. "More relaxed. More confident. I thought things were finally turning around for him."

"That's only because he refuses to show you the tears."

The words hang in the air between us, damning everything they've been doing since we were born. My mother's face crumples for just a moment before she smooths it back into her usual composed mask. My father hasn't moved from his position behind the table, his expression unreadable.

But I'm done. I'm done trying to make them understand, done begging for scraps of attention on my brother's behalf, and done pretending that

anything I say will actually change the way they see him.

"Elliot isn't going anywhere." I meet my father's eyes, letting him see the steel in my own. "Not back to that school. Not to Stanford or Georgetown or anywhere else. He's staying here, with me, where I can actually protect him from the people who want to hurt him. And if you try to force him to leave, I will make your lives very difficult."

"Are you threatening us?" My father's voice drops a few octaves, a dangerous edge to it.

"I'm stating facts. I run the company now. I control the money. I have relationships with every board member, every major investor, and every politician you've spent the last twenty years cultivating. If you want to turn this into a war, I will win. And I will enjoy every second of watching you realize that you've finally pushed me too far."

I turn and walk out of the study before either of them can respond, my heart pounding as I take the stairs two at a time.

Margaret is waiting in the hallway just outside Elliot's room, her arms crossed over her chest and her expression troubled. She steps into my path as I approach, something in her eyes telling me she's been waiting for this conversation.

"Mr. Ashford. I heard everything you said down there and I need you to think about what you're doing."

"Excuse me?"

"Whatever is going on between you and your brother." She glances toward Elliot's door, then back to me. "I've seen things and heard things."

"Is that so?" I stop in front of her, close enough that she has to tilt her head back to meet my eyes. "Then let me make something *very* clear. You

get paid extremely well to work in this house. Well enough to keep your mouth shut and your opinions to yourself."

"Mr. Ashford—"

"Whatever you think is going on isn't. And whatever you're thinking about telling my parents, you're not going to because Elliot's safety and happiness mean more to me than anything else in this world, and I will do *whatever* it takes to protect him." I lean in closer, letting her see exactly how serious I am. "Do you understand?"

She holds my gaze for a long moment, something flickering in her expression. Then she nods once. For as nosy as she is, I'm very aware she's seen me return from both Marcus' *and* Connor's beatings.

"If you want to keep your job," I continue, "you'll keep your mouth shut. Because as your luck would have it, *I* pay your salary, not my parents. They've kind of forgotten some of the bills over the years that I gracefully picked up. So, whatever you've seen, whatever you think you know, it stays between us. Nod if you understand."

She nods again, her face paling slightly.

"Good. Now if you'll excuse me, my brother needs me."

She practically runs down the hallway toward the service stairs, disappearing around the corner without looking back. I turn and walk to Elliot's door, trying the handle and finding it locked. "Elliot, baby." I keep my voice as soft as I can, a stark contrast to the fury that was pouring out of me moments ago. "It's me. Open the door."

There's a long pause and then silence. I let out a small sigh, fishing in my pocket for the key I always keep attached to my ring. Getting locked out of rooms because we accidentally engaged the mechanism gave me a reason to keep it with me.

I quickly unlock the door, step inside and close it behind me, turning the lock again and leaning back against the wood for just a moment. The room is dim, the curtains drawn, and it takes my eyes a moment to adjust to the darkness. Elliot is in bed, buried under a mound of blankets, his body curled into the smallest possible shape. Even from here, I can see his entire body shaking, little sobs heating my ears.

God, he's going to break my fucking heart.

I strip off my jacket and let it fall to the floor. My tie follows, then my shirt, my pants, and my shoes. I don't stop until I'm down to my boxers, the cool air running across my newly exposed skin. Then I climb into bed beside him and pull him into my arms.

The moment my body curves around his, Elliot latches onto me. His arms wrap around my chest and his face presses into my neck as his whole body curls into mine like he's trying to crawl inside me and hide from the world. He's shaking so hard the bed trembles with it, his breath coming in ragged gasps that dampen my skin with tears.

"I've got you." I fold him tighter against my chest, one hand splayed across his back and the other cradling the back of his head. "I'm here, baby. I'm not going anywhere."

"Please." The word comes out broken, barely audible, muffled against my throat. "Please, Malakai. Please don't let them take me."

"I'm not letting them take you from me." I press my lips to his hair. "Do you hear me, Elliot? I'm not letting them send you anywhere. You're staying right here, with me, where you belong. Now and forever."

"Please." He keeps saying it, the word tumbling from his lips over and over again like a prayer. "Please. Please. Please."

Each repetition breaks my heart a little more. I hold him tighter and whisper promises into his hair, promises I will burn the entire world down to keep.

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Elliot

Malakai holds me through the night, his arms wrapped around me and his breath warm against my hair, but every time I close my eyes, I see Marcus' friends waiting for me on the other side of my eyelids. I see the university campus where I spent three years learning how to make myself invisible. I see the apartment where Marcus taught me that love and pain are the same thing, and I can't stop shaking no matter how tightly Malakai holds me.

Even so, my brother whispers promises into the darkness. He tells me he won't let them take me, that he'll burn the entire family to the ground before he lets anyone hurt me again. I want to believe him. I want to trust that he has the power to stop this, that his love is enough to shield me from everything waiting in California.

But promises never served me before and by the time the first gray light of dawn creeps through the curtains, I feel hollowed out and raw.

Malakai's alarm goes off at six. He reaches over to silence it, then pulls me closer and presses his lips to my forehead. "How are you feeling?"

I don't know how to answer that question. I feel like I've been scraped clean from the inside, like there's nothing left of me but fear and exhaustion and a desperate, clinging need for the man holding me. I feel like I'm standing on the edge of a cliff and the ground is crumbling beneath my feet. "I don't know," I admit. "Scared. Tired. Like everything is falling apart."

"Nothing is falling apart." He cups my face in his hands and tilts my head up so I have to meet his eyes. "I meant what I said last night. You're not going anywhere. I don't care what our parents have planned. I don't care how many brochures they've printed or how many phone calls they've made. You're staying here, with me."

"What if you can't stop them?"

"I can stop them." His voice rumbles through his chest. "I have leverage they don't know about. I have options. And I will use every single one of them if that's what it takes to keep you safe."

I want to believe him. God, I want to believe him so badly it hurts.

"We should get ready for breakfast, though," he says, pressing one more kiss to my forehead before pulling away. "We need to face them together and show them that we're a united front."

The thought of sitting across the table from my parents, pretending everything is fine while they discuss shipping me off to the place that nearly destroyed me, makes my stomach turn. But Malakai is right. If I hide in this room, I'm letting them win. I'm proving that I'm exactly what they've always thought I was: weak, pathetic, and incapable of standing up for myself.

I force myself out of bed and into the shower. The hot water helps a little, loosening some of the tension in my muscles, but it can't touch the knot of dread that's taken up permanent residence in my chest.

I dress in clothes that Malakai lays out for me, appreciate the turtleneck which offers an option for me to keep on my collar. After last night, I feel like I need it.

Malakai is waiting for me in the hallway when I emerge. He's dressed in one of his perfectly tailored suits, but his eyes are soft when they land on me. "Ready?"

"No." I manage a weak smile, looking to see if Margaret is somewhere but the upstairs is suspiciously absent.

My brother chuckles, turning my attention back to him. "The staff won't be bothering us, not anymore."

That gives me a little confidence but not much as we walk downstairs together. My parents are already seated at the dining table, my mother sipping coffee and my father scrolling through something on his tablet. They look up when we enter, and my mother's expression shifts into something that's probably meant to be warm and welcoming but just makes my skin crawl.

"Good morning, boys." She gestures at the empty chairs. "Sit down. I had Mrs. Callahan make your favorites."

I take my usual seat, the one farthest from my father, and stare at the plate of food in front of me. Eggs, bacon, fresh fruit. Right, "my favorites", just like she said. As if a nice breakfast could make up for the fact that they're planning to tear my life apart.

The first few minutes pass in tense silence. Malakai actually starts eating, his eyes fixed on his plate, while I push food around without actually

putting any of it in my mouth. My mother keeps glancing between us like she's waiting for someone to break the ice. Finally, she clears her throat.

"I've been thinking about what you said last night, Malakai. About Elliot's experience at his previous university. I had no idea things were so difficult for him there."

I go very still.

"That's why I made some calls this morning," she continues. "Stanford has an excellent program, and they're willing to expedite Elliot's application given our family's history with the institution. It'd be a little different but still a wonderful environment. Somewhere he can thrive without any of the baggage from his past."

"I don't want to go to Stanford," I push out.

"Darling, I know change is scary, but—"

"It's not about change." I set down my fork and force myself to meet her eyes. "I don't want to leave. I have a job here. I have a life here. I have—" I cut myself off before I can say something I'll regret. "I'm not going anywhere."

"Elliot." My father's voice cuts through the conversation like a knife. "This isn't a discussion. Your mother and I have made our decision. You need a proper education, a proper credential, something that will allow you to contribute to this family in a meaningful way. The position Malakai gave you was always meant to be temporary."

"Richard." Malakai's voice carries a warning that makes my father's eyes narrow.

"This is family business, son. I know you have a soft spot for your brother, but coddling him isn't doing him any favors. He needs to learn to stand on his own two feet."

Something snaps inside me. I push back from the table and stand up so abruptly my chair scrapes against the hardwood floor. Everyone goes silent, staring at me, but I'm past the point of caring what they think.

"If you feel the need to send me away, so be it." My voice comes out a little wobbly, my hands shaking at my sides. "But not there. Anywhere but there. I'm not going to that school. I'm not going anywhere near California. If you want to ship me off to some program on the other side of the world, fine. I can't stop you. But I will not go back to the state where—"

My voice breaks. I can't finish the sentence or put words to the things that happened in that apartment, in that city, or at that school. The memories claw at my throat, threatening to drag me under, and I have to get out of this room before I fall apart completely.

I turn and walk out of the dining room without another word. Behind me, I hear my mother calling my name and the scrape of Malakai's chair as he stands, but I don't stop. I push through the door into the kitchen and keep walking until I reach the far counter, bracing my hands against the marble as I try to remember how to breathe.

"Elliot." Malakai's voice hits my ears as the door swings open. I hear his footsteps crossing the tile, and then his hand is on my back. "What happened back there?" He moves to stand beside me, ducking his head to try to catch my eyes. "Talk to me, babe,"

"They're not going to stop." I shake my head, my voice coming out rough and broken. "Whatever you told them last night only made them change their trajectory, not their decision."

"I told you, I'm not going to let that happen."

"You can't stop them, Malakai." I finally look up at him, the rawness in my own voice surprising me. "They're our parents. They control everything."

The money, the house, well most of it I guess, the family name. If they decide to cut me off and force me out, there's nothing either of us can do."

"They don't control everything." His jaw tightens. "I run the company now. I have my own money and my own resources. They control a lot less than they think they do. If they want to play hardball, I can play harder."

"And then what? You go to war with our parents over me? You destroy your relationship with them, your position in the family, and everything you've worked for, just to keep me here?" I laugh, but there's no humor in it. Last night I loved the idea of Malakai telling me he would burn the world down for me but hours later, I realize that's not practical. "I'm not worth that. I've never been worth that."

"Don't." His hand moves from my back to my chin, gripping firmly and forcing me to meet his eyes. "Don't you dare say that. You are worth everything. You are worth more than this house, more than the company, more than every cent the Ashford name has ever been worth. I meant it when I said I would burn it all down for you, Elliot. I would walk away from everything without a second thought if that's what it took to keep you safe and at my side."

The tears I've been fighting finally spill over, tracking down my cheeks in hot streams. Malakai's expression softens further and he pulls me into his arms, holding me tight against his chest while I shake and sob into the expensive fabric of his suit.

"I'm so scared." The confession comes out muffled against his shoulder. "I can't go back there, Malakai. If I go back, they'll—" I cut myself off, refusing to rehash those memories again.

"You're not going back." His arms tighten around me. "I don't care what I have to do. I don't care who I have to threaten or how much money I have

to throw at this problem. You are not going back to that school or anywhere near there, and those people are never going to touch you again."

"You promise?"

"I promise." He pulls back just enough to cup my face in his hands, wiping away my tears with his thumbs. "We'll figure this out, okay? Together. I'm not going to let anyone take you from me."

I nod, trying to believe him, but there's something else clawing at my chest, something I've been holding back for weeks, maybe longer. Something that's been building and building until it feels like it's going to tear me apart if I don't let it out.

"There's something else." My voice comes out barely above a whisper. "Something I haven't told you."

Malakai's brow furrows. "What is it?"

"The will." The words tumble out before I can stop them.

His brow furrows. "Babe, I thought we talked about."

"We did!" I whisper-yell, searching for the right way to explain this. "It's just more proof, isn't it? That I've never been enough. That no matter how hard I try, no matter what I do, I'm always going to be the disappointment. The afterthought. The twin who wasn't worth remembering in a will or fighting for or keeping around." I'm spiraling. I know it. We already discussed this and the money doesn't even matter. I know Malakai will take care of me or try to, at least.

It's just...

"That's not true." He pushes back.

"Then why does everyone want me gone?" The words rip out of me. "Our parents, our grandmother, everyone. The only person who's ever wanted me

around is you, and I don't understand why. I don't understand what you see in me that's worth all of this trouble."

"Elliot—"

"I'm in love with you."

The confession spills out before I can stop it, before I can think about what I'm saying or the consequences of saying it out loud. The words hang in the air between us, my heart in my throat because I can't take them back.

"I'm in love with you," I repeat, my voice cracking. "I'm in love with my twin brother and I don't know what to do. I don't know how to stop feeling this way. I don't know if I even want to stop, and I'm so scared that you don't feel the same, that this whole thing has just been you taking care of me because you feel obligated, and I—"

I break off, a sob tearing from my throat. The tears come faster, streaming down my face, and I can't breathe or think or do anything but stand there trembling while I wait for Malakai to say something.

Except, my brother doesn't respond the way I hoped he would.

His hands are still on my face, his thumbs still resting on my cheekbones, but his expression has shuttered into something I can't read. The seconds stretch out between us, each one an eternity, the silence worse than any rejection could be.

"Malakai." His name comes out as a plea. "Please say something. Please."

He opens his mouth and that's when I hear my father's voice from the doorway.

"Malakai. I need to speak with you about the Singapore contracts. Now."

Malakai's hands drop from my face. His expression closes off completely, becoming the cold, professional mask he wears at work. When he speaks, his voice is flat and distant. "We'll talk about this later."

I search his face for some sign of what he's feeling, some indication that my confession meant anything to him at all, but there's nothing there. Just the blank, shuttered expression of a man who has already moved on to more important things.

He turns and walks out of the kitchen without looking back. I manage to twist around, my brother's shoulders squared up as another whisper hits my ears.

"What the fuck were you doing?"

There's a hard chuckle that's most definitely from Malakai. "Nothing. What's so important?"

I stand there for a long moment, frozen in place, trying to process what just happened as their voices taper off. I told my brother I loved him. I laid myself bare, confessed the most terrifying truth I've ever spoken aloud, and his response was "we'll talk about this later." Like I'd just mentioned a scheduling conflict. Like my heart wasn't bleeding out on the kitchen floor in front of him.

Last night, he held me in his arms and promised to burn the world down for me. He said I was worth everything, that he would never let anyone take me away. He whispered that he loved me while he thought I was asleep.

But now, faced with the reality of my feelings spoken aloud, he couldn't get away from me fast enough. The panic from earlier takes root, twisting my thoughts and making everything worse.

Does he not feel the same? Has he never felt the same? Everything we've shared, the collar and the kneeling and the way he looked at me like I was the only thing in the world that mattered, was it all just him taking care of his broken little brother? Pity dressed up as passion? Obligation masquerading as love?

Was I a fool to think it could ever be anything more?

I force myself to move, pushing off from the counter and walking on numb legs toward the back stairs. I can't face my parents right now. I can't face anyone. I need to get out of this house before I shatter into pieces that can never be put back together.

Some part of me wonders if I read the situation wrong as I drag my phone out and shoot him a text.

Malakai, do you not feel the same way?

Silence. No response. Nothing.

My heart kicks up a notch as I send another text.

Sir?

Just that one word. Maybe it'll mean something.

We can speak at the office. I have an opening at 9 am. Does that work?

None of that makes any sense. No 'little doe'. No flirting. *Nothing*. Why would he text me like that after I told him I loved him?

I try one more time, my heart already breaking into a million pieces.

I told you I loved you.

More silence. Not even the three little bouncing dots.

The messages shows that he read it but a response never comes. A sob tears from my throat as I shove my phone back into my pocket. So, he'll protect me but he won't love me? I'm his but only to a point?

Fine. I'll go to work. I'll sit at my desk and stare at spreadsheets and pretend everything is fine. I'll be the good little Ashford everyone expects me to be, quiet and compliant and invisible.

And tonight, when Malakai wants to "talk about this later," I'll tell him there's nothing left to talk about. I got my answer. The silence told me everything I needed to know.

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Malakai

Ten Minutes Earlier

I was going to say it back. The words were right there on my tongue, ready to spill out, ready to give Elliot everything he was asking for. *I love you too. I've loved you since before I knew what love meant. I've loved you so long it feels like breathing, like something I couldn't stop even if I wanted to.*

And then I heard our father's voice from the doorway, our father standing just inches from the front of the kitchen.

The look on Elliot's face when I pulled away will haunt me for the rest of my life. The hope draining out of his eyes, replaced by something hollow and broken. The way his hands dropped to his sides and the way he didn't even try to stop me when I walked out of the kitchen.

I had to. I had no choice. Father was standing right there, watching us with that sharp, calculating expression that meant he was filing away information for later use. If I had said what I wanted to say, if I had pulled Elliot into my arms and kissed him the way every cell in my body was screaming at me to do, everything would have been over. Our parents would have known. The secret we've been building together, the life we've been creating in stolen moments and locked rooms, all of it would have crumbled to dust.

So I walked away. I let my brother think I was rejecting him, and I followed my father into his study to discuss fucking Singapore contracts like my heart wasn't shattering in my chest.

"What the fuck were you doing in there?" Father's voice sharpens as he closes the study door behind us.

"Nothing." I force my expression into something neutral. "What's so important?"

He studies me for a long moment, his eyes narrowing slightly, but whatever he's looking for, he doesn't seem to find it. "The Singapore deal. Stasi is getting cold feet about the timeline. I need you to call him and smooth things over."

"Fine." I pull out my phone to check my calendar, hooking it up to my screen so that I can explain to our father I already have this shit handled when a text from Elliot pops up.

Malakai, do you not feel the same way?

My chest constricts. I want to respond and type out everything I couldn't say in the kitchen, but Father is standing three feet away, his eyes flicking to my screen with idle curiosity.

"Something important?" he asks.

"Just work." I dismiss the message, about to continue on about this Singapore bullshit when another text comes through.

Sir?

Just that one word. The title he uses when he's vulnerable, when he's reaching for the dynamic that's become our lifeline. It takes everything in me not to type back *I love you, little doe. I'm so sorry. Please wait for me.*

Instead, with my father's eyes on me, I type something that makes me want to vomit.

We can speak at the office. I have an opening at 9 am. Does that work?

Cold. Professional. Everything I'm not when it comes to Elliot.

I watch the message deliver, the little indicator that shows he's read it turn green, and I can almost feel his heart breaking from here. Father starts talking, something about quarterly projections and Stasi's concerns about the manufacturing timeline, but I'm not listening. I'm watching my screen, waiting for Elliot's response, dreading what he must be thinking.

I told you I loved you.

The words hit me like a punch to the stomach. I stare at them for a long moment, trying to figure out how to respond, how to fix this without giving everything away. But Dad moves closer, peering at my screen with undisguised interest.

"What sweet little thing do you have pining for you?" He chuckles, clearly amused by what he assumes is some woman I'm stringing along.

I swipe the notification away without responding. "No one important."

The lie tastes like poison on my tongue. And just like that, the rest of the morning is a disaster. I ran upstairs to find Elliot and ask him to ride with me but he had already headed into the office. From there? Every thing just went from bad to worse.

I can't focus on anything. I make mistakes I haven't made since I was an intern, transposing numbers on a report and forgetting the name of a client I've worked with for three years. My assistant keeps shooting me concerned looks, and twice I catch myself staring at my phone, willing Elliot to respond to the texts I've been sending since Father finally left me alone.

Elliot, please let me explain.

Delivered. No response.

I'm sorry. That wasn't what I wanted to say.

Delivered. No response.

Please talk to me.

Delivered. Nothing.

He's shutting me out. I don't blame him. After everything I said last night, all the promises I made, I couldn't even tell him I loved him back when he finally found the courage to say it first. I told him I would burn the world down for him, and then I walked away because my father wanted to discuss a business deal.

What kind of protector does that make me? What kind of partner?

I try to find moments throughout the morning to get him alone. I walk down to the main area twice, making up excuses about needing to check on reports or discuss project timelines, but every time I get close, someone intercepts me. A department head with urgent questions. An assistant with papers that need signing. My mother calling to discuss dinner arrangements for the evening.

It's like they know something is off. Like they can sense that there's a crack in the foundation and they're determined to wedge themselves into it.

The third time I make it to the main area, I spot Elliot at his desk. He's staring at his computer screen, but his fingers aren't moving on the

keyboard. His posture is rigid, like he's just a shell of himself, his eyes red rimmed. When I approach, he looks up, and the emptiness in his eyes makes my stomach drop.

"Elliot. Can we talk?"

"Of course, Mr. Ashford." His voice comes out flat. The voice he uses with strangers. "What do you need?"

Mr. Ashford. Not Malakai. Not sir. Mr. Ashford, like I'm just his boss and nothing more.

"I need to explain about this morning—"

"Malakai!" My mother's voice cuts through the hallway, turning heads. She's standing by the elevator, waving at me with that brittle smile she wears when she wants something. "There you are. I've been looking everywhere for you. We need to discuss the seating arrangements for the charity gala next month."

I close my eyes for a brief moment, fighting the urge to scream. When I open them, Elliot has already turned back to his computer, his shoulders hunched like he's trying to make himself smaller.

"We'll talk later," I tell him, hating the words even as they leave my mouth.

He doesn't respond. He doesn't even look at me.

The rest of the morning is more of the same. Every time I try to get Elliot alone, someone appears. My father with questions about the Singapore call. My mother with updates about Elliot's new wardrobe arriving. Department heads, assistants, interns with coffee orders, an endless parade of people who seem determined to keep me from the one person I need to reach.

And through it all, Elliot withdraws further and further.

He responds when spoken to, follows instructions, and completes his work with mechanical precision. But there's no warmth in him. No life. The spark that I've spent weeks coaxing back to the surface has been extinguished, and I'm the one who snuffed it out.

I keep texting him.

I need you to know the truth. Please give me a chance to explain.

No response.

What I said this morning wasn't what I meant. Father was right there. I couldn't risk us.

No response.

Elliot, please. Don't shut me out.

Nothing.

By early afternoon, I'm desperate. I send one more text, pouring everything I have into the words.

I love you. I was going to say it back. I've loved you for so long I don't remember what it felt like before. Please, just give me five minutes. That's all I'm asking.

I watch the message deliver. It sits there, unread just like all the others for five minutes. Ten. Fifteen.

He's not even looking at his phone anymore.

I'm about to give up and march down Elliot's desk and drag him into a conference room regardless of who's watching, when my assistant appears in my doorway.

"Mr. Ashford? There's a situation downstairs. Your brother collapsed at the copier."

My entire world stops.

I'm out of my chair and running before she finishes the sentence, taking the stairs because the elevator is too slow, my heart pounding so hard I can feel it in my throat. *Elliot collapsed*. What if something is seriously wrong? What if the stress of the morning, the sleepless night, the emotional devastation I caused, what if it broke something inside him that can't be fixed?

I find him in the small clinic on the first floor, lying on a narrow bed with his eyes closed. He's white as a sheet, trembling slightly, and one of the nurses is checking his vitals with a concerned expression.

"What happened?" I demand, pushing past her to get to his side.

"He fainted at the copier," she explains. "His blood pressure dropped suddenly. It happens sometimes with acute stress or emotional shock. He'll be fine with rest, but he should take it easy for the next few days."

Emotional shock. Acute stress. I did this to him.

"Give us a minute," I tell her, my voice rough.

She hesitates, glancing between us, but something in my expression must convince her not to argue. She nods and slips out of the room, closing the door behind her. I sink into the chair beside Elliot's bed and take his hand in mine. His fingers are cold, and he doesn't grip back the way he usually does.

"Elliot." I keep my voice soft. "Can you hear me?"

His eyes flutter open. For a moment, there's confusion, like he's not sure where he is or how he got here. Then his gaze lands on me, and his expression hardens into something that makes my chest ache.

"You don't have to pretend anymore, okay?" His voice comes out hoarse, barely above a whisper. "I get it. I'm just your stupid little brother. The one

you have to take care of because no one else will. You don't have to act like you actually—"

"Elliot, that's not—"

The door opens and the nurse walks back in, chart in hand. I pull back my hand, knowing that I won't be able to explain the tender touch. "I just need to go over a few things before I can discharge him. Nothing strenuous for the next forty-eight hours, plenty of fluids, and if the dizziness returns—"

I stop listening. I can't do this anymore. I can't keep letting the universe interrupt us, while I watch Elliot believe the worst, me standing helplessly by him.

"We're leaving," I announce, cutting off the nurse mid-sentence. "I'm taking him home."

"Mr. Ashford, I really think—"

"I'll make sure he rests." I'm already helping Elliot to his feet, supporting his weight against my side. "Send any discharge paperwork to my assistant."

I half-carry him to the elevator, ignoring the stares from employees we pass. Let them think what they want. Let them gossip and speculate. I don't care anymore. The only thing that matters is getting Elliot somewhere private, somewhere I can finally say everything I should have said this morning.

I defer my attention to my phone long enough to tell my assistant I'm taking emergency leave to care for my brother. She doesn't question it, merely mentioning that she'll rearrange my calendar. I guide Elliot through the parking garage and into the car, buckling him in like he's something fragile that might shatter if I'm not careful.

"I just want to go home," he mumbles, his head falling back against the seat.

I don't respond. I just start the car and pull out of the garage, heading not toward the estate but toward the cabin I've been planning on taking him to since we truly became something. It's thirty minutes outside the city, tucked away in the woods where no one will find us. Where no one will interrupt us. Where I can finally give Elliot the truth he deserves.

Elliot stares out the window, and every few minutes he asks another question that I can't answer. Not yet. Not while I'm driving. Not while the words are still tangled up inside me, fighting to get out.

"Where are we going? This isn't the way home."

"Somewhere private."

"Why? So you can let me down gently without an audience?"

"Elliot—"

"I don't want to keep doing this." His voice cracks. "I can't keep hoping for something you're never going to give me. If you don't feel the same way, just tell me. I'm a big boy. I can handle it."

I tighten my grip on the steering wheel until my knuckles go white. My control is shot, the need to tell him in the comfort of the cabin switching out for the need to fall apart right here, to give Elliot every fucking thing he's been asking for. When I hear his breath hitch a little, I can't take it anymore.

I swerve off into an empty parking lot, still twenty minutes away from a place I used to call *paradise* and twist just enough to look at Elliot. "I need you to listen to me." His face turns up as I soften my voice, hoping and praying I'm not about to ruin everything we just built together. "All of it. Don't interrupt."

He falls silent, his eyes widening with a mixture of confusion and disappointment.

"I've loved you since we were fifteen." The words come out in a rush, like a dam breaking. "I've loved you since before I understood what it meant to love someone like this. I watched you date other people, and I hated every single one of them. Not because they weren't good enough for you, but because they got to have you in ways I thought I never could."

His lips part, but he doesn't say anything which I'm grateful for because I'm not done yet.

"When you left for college, I couldn't sleep for weeks. I kept thinking about all the things I should have said, all the chances I missed. And when you came back broken, when I saw what Marcus did to you, part of me was glad." My voice catches. "Because it meant you were home. It meant I could have you again. It meant I could break those who broke you. And I've never forgiven myself for that."

Tears are sliding down his cheeks now, but I can't stop. I've held this in for too long.

"I pulled away sometimes because you deserve better. Better than shadows and secrets. Better than a brother so obsessed with you he'd burn the entire world just to keep you close." I reach out and cup his face in my hands, wiping away his tears with my thumbs. "But then you came back, and I couldn't stop myself. I tried. God, I tried. But you're everything, Elliot. You've always been everything."

"This morning—" he starts.

"When you said you loved me, I was about to say it back. The words were right there. And then I heard Father's voice, and I panicked. I couldn't risk us. I couldn't let him see." I press my forehead to his, grabbing his face in

my hands as I all but tug him over the console. He weakly comes, straddling my thighs as I pull him closer. "Baby, the texts, fuck... they were coming through on my screen while he was standing right there. I had to respond like you were nobody. Like you didn't matter. And when you said you loved me, he saw it before I could hide it. He made some comment about a sweet little thing pining for me, and I had to swipe it away like it was nothing. Like you were nothing."

"I thought—" His fingers dig into my shoulders as I run my hands around his back and up beneath his shirt, needing to feel his skin against mine.

"I know what you thought doe and fuck, I'm so sorry. I'm so sorry I let you believe that for even a second."

His breath hitches. "You love me?"

"God, Elliot." I pull back just enough to look into his eyes. "I love you. I've always loved you. I will never stop loving you."

A small gasp falls from his lips, a sound that's half sob and half laugh. "Say it again. Tell me again."

"I'm in love with you, Elliot Aurelius Ashford." I brush my lips against his forehead, his cheeks, and then the corner of his mouth. "I shouldn't feel this way, and the rest of the world will never truly understand, but I am so completely in love with my twin brother. And if I had the chance to do it all over again, I wouldn't change a single thing."

"Malakai." He breathes my name like a prayer, and then he leans down to kiss me.

The kiss is soft at first, like he's still not quite sure this is real. But then I press him closer to me, his arms wrapping around, and the kiss deepens into something desperate and relieved and full of all the words we've been too afraid to say.

When we finally break apart, Elliot's eyes are still wet, but he's smiling now, a real smile that reaches all the way to his eyes. "I love you too," he whispers. "So fucking much, Kai."

"God, you haven't called me that since we were five." And I love that name. It's his and only his. No one else has *ever* called me that and some part of me always wished Elliot still would. Hearing it now, I want to hear it again. And again. And again. "It feels so fucking good to say it. I love you, little doe." I raise an eyebrow, and his smile widens.

"Too much?"

"Never." I pull him back in for another kiss. "Nothing about you could ever be too much."



Elliot

The parking lot is empty, the engine ticking as it cools, and the only sounds are our breathing and the soft, wet noises of our mouths finding each other again and again. I'm still straddling Malakai's lap, my knees wedged awkwardly against the center console and the driver side door, but I don't care. I don't care about anything except the way his hands feel pressed against my back, the way his lips feel against mine, and the way he keeps whispering "I love you" between kisses like he's making up for all the times he couldn't say it.

"I love you," he murmurs against my mouth. "I love you, little doe."

"I love you too, Kai." The nickname feels strange on my tongue after so many years of not using it, but the way his breath catches every time I say it makes me want to say it forever. "I love you so much."

He pulls back just enough to look at me, his eyes soft and warm in a way I've never seen them before. Not when we're in the middle of a scene, not when he's taking care of me after, not even when he's holding me through a nightmare. This is something new. Something unguarded. Something that makes my chest ache with how much I want to protect it.

"We should probably head back," he muses, though his hands don't stop moving against my skin. "Before someone sends out a search party."

"Probably." I don't move either. "Where were you taking me?"

"There's a cabin about twenty minutes from here. I've been wanting to take you there since this started." His thumb traces circles on my hip. "Somewhere private. Somewhere we don't have to hide."

"That sounds perfect."

"We'll go soon. Maybe this weekend, if I can clear my schedule." He presses one more kiss to my lips. "But right now, we need to go home and deal with our parents."

The mention of our parents brings reality crashing back. I climb off his lap and settle back into the passenger seat, my body already missing the warmth of his. The drive back to the estate is quiet, but it's a different kind of quiet than before. It's not heavy with misunderstanding and hurt, but peaceful. His hand finds mine on the console, our fingers intertwining, and I spend the next several minutes watching the way his thumb strokes across my knuckles.

I can't believe even for a moment that I thought he didn't love me. The moment is dashed when we pull into the garage. Mom and Dad's car is still there.

"They're still here," I say, stating the obvious.

"They were probably waiting to throw more fuel into the fire." Malakai squeezes my hand before releasing it. "Let me do the talking if things get tense."

We walk into the house together, and I barely make it three steps into the foyer before my mother appears from the direction of the sitting room. Her face is pinched with something that might be concern if I didn't know better, and my father is right behind her but have no idea what he's thinking.

"Elliot." My mother crosses to me, her hands fluttering like she wants to touch me but isn't sure if she's allowed. "I had no idea it was bothering you that much. Why didn't you say something?"

I blink at her, confused. "What?"

"One of the investors reached out to me when they couldn't get a hold of Malakai," my father explains. "We called the company and found out you'd collapsed. The nurse said it was acute stress." He crosses his arms over his chest. "You should have told us you were struggling."

I almost laugh. *Almost*. The irony of my parents suddenly caring about my wellbeing after spending the last twenty-four hours trying to ship me off to the other side of the country is almost too much to process. Malakai's hand presses against the small of my back, a silent encouragement.

Speak up. Tell them.

I take a breath, forcing myself to pour everything I've been feeling into words. "Every time I say something, you just gloss over it. My opinions and choices don't matter to you. They never have. The only time you've ever praised me was because Malakai told you I was doing well at the company. Not because you saw it yourself. Not because you asked. Because he told you."

My mother's face falls. "Elliot, that's not—"

"It's true." I cut her off before she can finish the denial. "You've spent my entire life treating me like an afterthought. Like a problem to be managed instead of a son to be loved. And now you're surprised that the stress of you trying to send me away made me collapse?"

Silence stretches between us. Dad's jaw tightens, but he doesn't say anything. Mom's eyes glisten with tears, though I've never actually seen her cry. "I'm sorry," she finally says. "I didn't realize... I thought we were doing what was best for you."

"It's a little too late for all of that." I swallow back a nervous laugh. Malakai told them their planning was bullshit this morning and most likely last night, too. Mom's words are just lies. "But I appreciate the apology. I guess."

My father clears his throat. "About the school plans. We've been reconsidering, given the circumstances."

"Actually," Malakai steps forward, cutting in, "I've been thinking about Elliot's education as well. There's an excellent program closer to home that would allow him to finish his degree while continuing to contribute to the company. He'd be far more useful during the leadership transition if he's nearby."

I glance at him, surprised. We haven't discussed this, but he's handling it like we've rehearsed it a dozen times.

My mother considers this for a moment. "That does make sense from a practical standpoint."

"I'll have my assistant send over the program details," Malakai continues. "The admissions process is competitive, but I have contacts who can expedite things."

"We'll look into it," my father says, which is about as close to agreement as he ever gets.

I feel like I should say something or thank Malakai for the save or push back against my parents for still trying to control my future. But I'm tired. So incredibly tired. The emotional whiplash of the last twenty-four hours has drained everything out of me, and all I want is to go upstairs and collapse into my brother's arms.

"We need to go change," I say, already turning toward the stairs. "It's been a long day."

"Of course." My mother takes a step toward me, then stops herself. "Do you think you're well enough? The nurse said you should rest."

"Don't force the mom stuff." The words come out pretty harsh, but I don't take them back. "You're not good at it."

She flinches like I've slapped her, Dad's expression darkening a little, but neither of them says anything as I walk away. Malakai falls into step beside me as we climb the stairs. We're almost to his bedroom door when his hand closes around my wrist.

Before I can react, he pulls me inside and shuts the door behind us. The lock clicks into place, and then his mouth is on mine, his hands already working at the buttons of my shirt.

"Kai!" I gasp against his lips. "Our parents are downstairs."

A dark laugh bubbles up from his throat, his fingers making quick work of my shirt and pushing it off my shoulders. "I don't really fucking care. Do you?"

"We're going to be late for... something. Dinner, probably."

"And I need to be inside the man I love." He spins me around and presses me against the door, his chest warm against my back. "I've been thinking

about this all day. About how I almost lost you because I couldn't say three fucking words."

"We've got fifteen minutes at most before Mom sends someone up to check on us."

"Then I'll make it count."

I hear the nightstand drawer open, the click of a cap, and then his slicked fingers pressing between my cheeks. I let out a moan that's probably too loud, and immediately his free hand clamps over my mouth.

"Now be a good boy and stay quiet." His voice is a low growl against my ear, his fingers working me open. "We wouldn't want our parents to know what their boys get up to behind closed doors, do we?"

A laugh bubbles up in my throat, muffled by his palm. The absurdity of the situation hits me all at once. Our parents are downstairs, probably still processing the conversation we just had, and Malakai has me pressed against his bedroom door with his fingers in my ass and his hand over my mouth.

Then I feel the head of his cock pressing against my entrance, and the laughter dies in my throat.

"Fuck," I whimper against his palm. "Kai, please."

"Please what?" He pushes in slowly, giving me time to adjust to the stretch. "Tell me what you want, baby."

"I want you to fuck me." The words come out muffled but clear enough. "I want you to make me feel how much you love me."

He groans against the back of my neck, his hips snapping forward until he's fully seated inside me. The sensation knocks the breath out of my lungs. He's so deep, filling me up completely, and I have to bite down on his palm to keep from crying out.

"I love you," he breathes against my ear, starting to move. "I love you so fucking much, Elliot. I'm sorry I didn't say it sooner. I'm sorry I made you think I didn't feel the same."

"You can make it up to me," I manage between his thrusts as I brace myself against the door. The rattle of wood against its hinges would alert anyone with a brain to what's going on in this room. But that just kind of adds to the thrill. "Say it again."

"I love you." He punctuates each word with a roll of his hips. "I love you. I love you. I'll never stop saying it. I'll never stop showing you."

His hand slides from my mouth to my throat, wrapping around the collar that's still hidden beneath my turtleneck. I had forgotten about it all day, too lost in my thoughts to remember I was still wearing my brother's claim.

Malakai uses it as leverage, pulling me back against him as he drives into me harder. The new angle has him hitting that spot inside me that makes my vision blur, and I have to stuff my fist in my mouth to muffle the sounds I'm making.

"That's it, baby." His voice is ragged now, his control slipping. "Take me. Take all of me. You're so fucking perfect, Elliot. So perfect and beautiful and mine."

"Yours," I agree, mouthing the word around my fist. "Always yours, Kai. Only yours."

He pulls out suddenly, spinning me around and lifting me up like I weigh nothing. My back hits the door and my legs wrap around his waist instinctively, before he pushes back inside me, this new angle even deeper than before.

I can see his face now. His eyes are dark with desire, his jaw tight with concentration, but underneath all of that is something softer. Something that

looks like wonder. Like he can't quite believe this is real, that we're here together, that we finally get to have this.

"I love you," I whisper, reaching up to cup his face in my hands. "I love you, Malakai Ashford. I've loved you my whole life."

His rhythm stutters, his eyes squeezing shut like the words are too much to bear. "Say it again."

"I love you."

"Again."

"I love you, Kai. I love you. I love you."

He kisses me, swallowing the words as they spill from my lips. His thrusts grow faster and more desperate, my own orgasm building at the base of my spine. I'm not going to last much longer. Neither is he.

"Come for me," he growls against my mouth. "Come on my cock, little doe. Let me feel you."

That's all it takes as my orgasm crashes through me, whiting out my vision and tearing a moan from my throat that Malakai catches with his mouth. I clench around him, feeling the hot splash of my release between our bodies, and then he follows me over the edge with a groan that vibrates through both of us.

We stay like that for a long moment, pressed together against the door, as his forehead drops to my shoulder, and I card my fingers through his hair, marveling at how different everything feels now.

"We made a mess," I finally say, glancing down at the state of our clothes.

Malakai laughs. "Worth it." He presses another kiss to my lips, lingering there before he speaks again. "You did so well, you know that?" His hips rock forward, pulling a moan from the back of my throat. God, we don't have time for this. "I'm proud of you."

"For what?"

"For standing up for yourself. For not letting them steamroll you." He pulls back to look at me, his expression turning a little serious. "You've come so far, Elliot. I hope you can see that."

I think about the person I was when I first came home. Broken and scared and unable to meet anyone's eyes or ask for what I needed. And I think about who I am now. Still healing, still learning, but stronger. More confident. More sure of my place in the world. Even after that little panic when I thought Malakai didn't love me.

"I see it," I admit. "It's because of you."

"It's because of *us*." He corrects gently. "We built this together." He slowly pulls out of me before lowering me to my feet, cum slipping down my thighs. Malakai stares for a long moment before chuckling. "I think it's time for a shower before we go downstairs and I'm stealing you to bed. We have a cabin to visit this weekend, and I want you well-rested for all the things I'm planning to do to you."

I laugh, letting him pull me toward the bathroom. For the first time in my life, the future doesn't feel like something to dread. It feels like something to look forward to.

And I can't wait to see what comes next.



Elliot

Two months later, I wake up in my own space for the first time feeling like it actually belongs to me.

The extension took six weeks to build, a small but perfect addition off the east wing of the estate with its own entrance, a kitchen I'm slowly learning to use, a bedroom with windows that overlook the gardens, and a study where Malakai has claimed the leather armchair as his own. It's not an apartment in the city like I originally wanted, but it's mine. No staff with prying eyes. No parents wandering in unannounced. Just my space, my rules, my life.

Well. My rules and Malakai's.

I stretch beneath the sheets, savoring the quiet, then reach for the collar on my nightstand. The leather has softened from months of wear, molded perfectly to the shape of my throat, and I fasten it around my neck. The

weight settles against my pulse point, something in my chest loosening at the familiar comfort.

I grab my phone and type out the message I've sent almost every morning for the past two months, falling back into the routine we first started. I don't need it but I like it.

I'm awake, sir.

The response comes within seconds.

Good boy. Kneel. I'll be there in ten.

I smile at the screen, then set the phone aside and slide out of bed before padding to the spot beside my bed, the same spot I've claimed for this ritual since I moved in. I sink to my knees, settling into the position that's become as natural as breathing.

Knees apart, hands on thighs, palms up, spine straight.

Then I close my eyes and let my mind go quiet. We don't do this every day anymore. The rigid structure of those first weeks has softened into something more flexible, more sustainable. I kneel when I need it, wear the collar when I want to, and ask permission when the asking itself brings me peace.

Some days I'm entirely in charge of myself, making decisions and navigating the world without checking in. Other days, the noise gets too loud and I need Malakai to take the reins, to tell me what to do and how to do it and remind me that I'm safe.

The balance works. We figured it out together, through trial and error and endless conversations about what we each need. Some things stayed from those early days. The morning texts. The collar. The way he feeds me sometimes, not because I can't feed myself but because the intimacy of it makes us both feel connected. Other things fell away. The constant check-

ins, the rigid schedules, the rules that existed more for structure than for genuine need.

What we have now is ours. Imperfect and unconventional and completely, utterly ours.

My timer goes off after five minutes, and I rise from my knees just as I hear the knock at my door. I cross the small living area, and pull it open to find Malakai on the other side.

He's holding a bag of takeout from the café I like, dressed in jeans and a soft gray henley that makes him look five years younger and devastatingly handsome. His eyes sweep over me, taking in the collar around my throat and the loose sleep pants hanging low on my hips, his mouth curving into a smile that makes heat pool in my belly.

"Good morning, little doe."

"Good morning, sir."

He steps inside, closing the door behind him, as his gaze travels around the room. Textbooks are scattered across the coffee table. A half-empty mug of cold tea sits beside my laptop. Clothes are draped over the back of the couch, and there's a pile of papers on the kitchen counter that I've been meaning to sort for three days.

"It's looking a little messy in here, doe."

I grin, unrepentant. "Sir, I was busy with schoolwork. The program doesn't leave much time for housekeeping." I tilt my head, feeling bold. "But you can spank me for it if you like."

Malakai's eyebrows shoot up, surprise flickering across his face before it melts into something darker. He sets the food on the counter and closes the distance between us, one hand coming up to wrap around my throat just

above the collar. "Is that something you're into now?" His voice drops low, and a shiver runs down my spine.

I shrug, trying to look casual even though my heart is nearly beating out of my chest. "I learn new things every day. The program is very educational."

A warm laugh rumbles through his chest as he tugs me a little closer, his lips slotting over mine. The kiss is deep and thorough, his tongue sweeping into my mouth while his hand stays firm against my throat. I melt into him, loving the way his barbell runs across my tongue, my hands fisting in the soft fabric of his shirt, and when he finally pulls back, I'm a little dazed.

"We'll explore that later," he promises, his thumb stroking along my jaw. "But first, breakfast."

He releases me and moves to the kitchen, unpacking the food onto the small table I picked out myself. It's all of my favorites, croissants, fresh fruit, and some kind of egg dish that smells incredible. My stomach growls, and I realize I skipped dinner last night, too absorbed in a research paper to remember to eat.

I watch him arrange everything, struck suddenly by how domestic this is. How *normal*. If anyone looked through the window right now, they'd see two brothers having breakfast together. They wouldn't see the collar around my throat or the dynamic that shapes every interaction between us. They wouldn't understand that the man plating fruit for me is also the man who owns me in every way that matters.

That's the thing about secrets. They can be isolating and suffocating. Or they can be precious. Sacred. A world that belongs only to you and the person you share it with.

Ours is the second kind.

Malakai pulls out a chair and looks at me expectantly. I don't move toward the food, even though I'm starving. Instead, I look at him, then at the plate, then back at him.

"If you want something, you have to ask for it." His voice carries that gentle challenge I've come to love. The reminder that using my voice is part of this too.

I smile. "Sir, would you please feed me?"

His face lights up with the same delight it always does when I ask for what I want. "It would be my pleasure, doe."

I settle into the chair beside him rather than across from him, close enough that our knees touch beneath the table. He tears off a piece of croissant and brings it to my lips, and I take it from his fingers, my eyes never leaving his face. We've done this dozens of times now, but it never gets old, especially when his fingers linger just between my lips and I drag my tongue along his digits.

"How's the program going?" he asks, feeding me a slice of strawberry next.

"Good. Hard, but good." I chew and swallow before continuing. "Professor Martinez says my analysis on market volatility was one of the best in the class."

"That's because you're brilliant." He says it matter-of-factly, like it's an obvious truth rather than a compliment.

"I had a good tutor." I lean into him, resting my head against his shoulder for a moment. "Thank you. For making this happen. For convincing them to let me stay close."

"You convinced them. I just provided supporting arguments."

That's not entirely true, and we both know it. When my parents first agreed to the local program, they wanted me to stay in the main house, under their watchful eyes. It was Malakai who suggested the extension, who framed it as a compromise between independence and proximity. He argued that I needed my own space to focus on my studies, that having staff underfoot would be distracting, and that a separate entrance would allow me to come and go without disrupting the household.

What he didn't say was that he needed a place where he could visit me without anyone questioning why the CEO was spending so much time in his brother's bedroom.

The extension isn't perfect. Our parents still have access to the main estate, and there's always the risk of someone noticing Malakai's car in the side drive at odd hours. But it's ours. A tiny piece of the world where we can be ourselves without hiding.

"What are you thinking about?" Malakai's voice pulls me from my thoughts.

I look up at him, taking in the strong line of his jaw, the softness in his eyes, and the tattoos peeking out just above his collar. He's the most beautiful thing I've ever seen. The most complicated person I've ever known. The love of my life, even though the world would call what we have wrong.

"Nothing," I say. "Just... I love you."

His expression shifts, the playful warmth giving way to something deeper. He sets down the piece of fruit he was about to feed me and cups my face in his hands, tilting my head up so our eyes meet.

"I love you too." He kisses me again, soft and sweet this time, and when he pulls back, we're both smiling like idiots. "Finish your breakfast,"

Malakai says, picking up another piece of croissant. "Then I'm going to bend you over that couch and show you exactly what happens to messy boys who can't keep their apartments clean."

I snort. "I thought we were exploring the spanking thing later."

"I changed my mind." He throws me a wicked grin. "Unless you have objections?"

I open my mouth to accept the food he's offering, chewing slowly while I pretend to consider. "No objections, sir. But I should warn you, I might make messes on purpose from now on."

"I'm counting on it, little doe."

He feeds me the rest of breakfast with that promise hanging in the air between us. And when the plates are empty and he pulls me toward the couch with a fire in his eyes, I go willingly.

This is my life now. Complicated and secret and absolutely perfect.

I wouldn't change a single thing.



Thank You!

Thank you so much for coming along on Elliot and Malakai's journey!

Stay tuned for future installments of the ***Forbidden*** series:

Toxic Temptation An MMF Twincest x Cousin Dark Romance *Fight Club*.

Submission. Touch them and die.

Bruise Me An MM Incest Dark Romance *Older/Larger Sub. Accountant x Enforcer.*

Toxic Love An MM Cousin Dark Romance *Kidnapping. Stockholm Syndrome. If I can't have you, no one will.*

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